

Fate's Edge: Comprehensive Resource Guide

Comprehensive Reference Document

Risk, consequence, and sharp choices at the table.

Version v0.9

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0.1 Reviewer's Guide: Understanding Fate's Edge

This will be removed in Production

0.1.1 Reframing the Evaluation

Fate's Edge is not a traditional tabletop RPG to be evaluated by comprehensive rule mastery. Instead, it is a **narrative partnership** designed to evolve with your table's storytelling sophistication. Approach this review through the lens of **progressive storytelling enhancement** rather than static mechanical complexity.

0.1.2 Key Evaluation Framework

Start Simple, Discover Naturally

- **Session 1:** Core mechanic + 1-2 regional generators = complete playable experience
- **Session 5:** Comfortable integration of multiple subsystems
- **Session 20:** Intuitive mastery where mechanics become invisible

The Partnership Model

Rather than "learning a game," players develop a "storytelling partnership" where:

- Rules serve narrative consequences, not simulation accuracy
- Complexity emerges from interaction, not individual component sophistication
- Prep burden shifts from authoring content to facilitating discovery

0.1.3 Common Misunderstandings to Address

Content Volume vs. Discovery Process

Misconception: "Too much content to master" **Reality:** Content is designed for gradual discovery through play

Reviewer Guidance:

"Imagine a library where you only need to know about the books relevant to today's story. The rest exist to be discovered when narrative ambition demands them."

Prep-Light vs. Prep-Free

Misconception: "No prep means unstructured play" **Reality:** Prep is embedded in the constraint lattice

Reviewer Guidance:

"The system replaces authored prep with guided storytelling. Every card draw is improvisation with guardrails."

Mechanical Simplicity vs. Narrative Sophistication

Misconception: "Simple mechanics = shallow stories" **Reality:** Sophistication emerges from constraint interaction

Reviewer Guidance:

"Like jazz with a vast repertoire, the same simple rules that handle Session 1 magic effortlessly scale to manage Session 50 world-changing consequences."

0.1.4 Evaluation Methodology

Progressive Complexity Assessment

1. **Tier I Play** (30-40 XP): Evaluate session-to-session narrative flow with minimal subsystems
2. **Tier III Play** (90-150 XP): Assess how character growth naturally expands storytelling scope
3. **Tier V Play** (220+ XP): Examine how simple rules handle complex, multi-threaded narratives

Mastery Curve Analysis

Key Metric: Mastery effort should decrease as narrative complexity increases

Success Indicators:

- Session 1: Clear, engaging storytelling with minimal reference
- Session 10: Comfortable integration of multiple subsystems
- Session 30: Mechanics become invisible; focus entirely on narrative

0.1.5 What to Look For

Narrative-First Design

- Every mechanical element should serve story consequences
- Player agency should manifest through narrative choices, not optimization
- GM authority should prioritize "what happens" over "what are the rules"

Constraint-Based Creativity

- Random elements should create coherent, not chaotic, storytelling
- Regional generators should maintain thematic consistency while enabling variety
- Mechanical constraints should inspire creativity, not limit options

Scalable Sophistication

- Same core mechanics should handle intimate scenes and epic narratives
- Character progression should expand narrative possibilities, not mechanical options
- World complexity should emerge from player actions, not pre-authored content

0.1.6 Red Flags vs. Design Features

Actual Red Flags

- Mechanics that require constant reference during play
- Subsystems that don't integrate naturally with core philosophy
- Progression that adds mechanical burden rather than narrative freedom

Misinterpreted Design Features

- **High content volume** = Creative resource library, not mastery burden
- **Multiple magic paths** = Narrative vocabulary expansion, not mechanical complexity
- **Regional generators** = Inspiration engines, not reference requirements

0.1.7 Recommended Review Approach

Session 1-3 Evaluation

Focus on:

- How quickly engaging stories emerge
- Clarity of core mechanical principles
- Integration of generated content into coherent narratives

Session 10+ Evaluation

Assess:

- How naturally complexity emerges from player choices
- Integration of multiple subsystems without mechanical overhead
- Evolution from "using rules" to "telling stories"

Long-term Assessment

Consider:

- Whether the system grows with narrative ambition
- If mastery effort genuinely decreases over time
- How world complexity emerges organically from play

0.1.8 The Core Truth

Fate's Edge succeeds not by being simple, but by being **designed for simplicity to emerge naturally from complex storytelling**. Evaluate it not as a comprehensive system to master, but as a storytelling partnership that grows in sophistication at exactly the same rate your table develops narrative ambition.

This isn't a game you learn - it's a storytelling evolution you grow into.

Chapter 1

Core Principles

1.1 Safety Tools

Fate's Edge explores mature themes—conflict, loss, horror, betrayal. The table should always feel safe. Use these tools to keep the game enjoyable for everyone.

Safety Tools: Lines

X-Card Any player (including the GM) can draw an "X" on a card or simply say "X" when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is removed from the fiction—no questions, no explanations, no judgments. The scene is retconned or redirected immediately.

Lines A hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: "No sexual violence," "No harm to children," "No body horror." Establish during Session Zero.

Veils A soft boundary: content that can happen "off screen" or fade to black. Example: "A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit."

Always keep an X-Card visible. When used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate the player. The GM may also use the X-Card for their own comfort.

1.2 The Central Question

At its heart, Fate's Edge asks:

What are you willing to risk, and what are you willing to surrender, to reshape the world around you?

This question is both philosophical and mechanical. Players gamble with fate every time they act, and the consequences—good or ill—become the foundation of their legend.

1.3 Core Principles

The game is built on four key ideas:

Narrative First Mechanics serve the story. Rules reward descriptive play and creative problem-solving.

Risk Creates Drama Every roll carries tension. Even success may come at a cost.

Meaningful Growth Experience is a currency of choice. Invest in yourself or in your influence on the world.

Consequences Matter No action is free. Every choice changes the fiction.

1.4 Key Concepts

1.4.1 Narrative Time

Time in Fate’s Edge is measured by story weight, not by timers. Use these four scales:

Table 1.1: Narrative Time Scales

Scale	Description
A Moment	A heartbeat, a glance, a single strike or word.
Some Time	A few minutes: a skirmish, a careful lockpick, a short negotiation.
Significant Time	Hours: travel, a ritual, a siege.
Days	Large-scale endeavors: marches, training, recovery.

1.4.2 Story Beats (SB)

Whenever a player rolls dice, each result of **1** generates one Story Beat (SB) for the GM. Re-rolling a 1 does *not* erase its SB; if the re-rolled die also shows 1, it generates additional SB.

SB are not penalties—they are narrative fuel. The GM spends SB to introduce twists:

- **Escalation** – drawing more enemies, raising the stakes.
- **Exhaustion** – draining time, resources, or positioning.
- **Exposure** – revealing hidden actions, alerting foes.
- **Collateral** – harm or danger spilling over onto allies, innocents, or surroundings.

For a full SB Spend Menu, see [2.1.9](#).

1.4.3 Affinity

Each people (culture or heritage) provides an **Affinity**: a narrative edge or metaphysical bond. Affinities make certain actions more reliable or grant unique permissions, weaving identity into mechanics. Examples include the Aeler stone-sense or the Aelaerem hearth-luck.

1.4.4 Step 6 – Cultural Affinity

Note on Stacking. If your ancestral gift (from your people) and your cultural affinity provide the same benefit (e.g., both improve Position), they do not stack. You may use one per scene. Choose which applies when you need it.

1.4.5 Prestige Abilities

High-level talents unlocked by mastering cultural arts, Patron bonds, or philosophical paths. These are narrative milestones as much as mechanical upgrades.

1.4.6 On-Screen vs. Off-Screen

Fate’s Edge distinguishes between resources you see at the table and those that shape the world behind the scenes:

On-Screen Resources are companions, hirelings, or allies who stand beside you in danger. They add dice pools and flavor, but they can falter, be captured, or die.

Off-Screen Resources are assets, titles, networks, or safe houses. They never swing a blade in combat, but they shape the story between sessions, turning XP into narrative leverage.

1.5 Design Philosophy

1.5.1 Core Principles (Extended)

1. **Narrative Primacy:** Mechanics serve story, not replace it.
2. **Risk as Drama:** Every roll carries potential for triumph and complication.
3. **Meaningful Growth:** XP investment creates lasting character and world change.
4. **Consequence Weight:** Choices ripple outward; nothing is free.
5. **Fail Forward:** Misses fuel Boons; 1s become Story Beats that drive the fiction onward.

1.5.2 Mechanical Constraints

Table 1.2: Core Mechanical Limits

Rule	Limit
Assist Maximum	+3 dice total per roll from all helpers.
Boon Maximum	Hold 5 Boons; trim to 2 at scene end.
Boon-to-XP Conversion	2 Boons → 1 XP, once per session, max 2 XP per session via conversion.
Follower Initiative	1 Follower Action per scene, party-wide.
Position States	Dominant Controlled Desperate (affects success/failure texture).

Table 1.2 – continued

Rule	Limit
Dice Pool Cap	Maximum 10d10 per roll; extras become auto-successes.

1.5.3 The Golden Rule

When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. If you find yourself asking "What's the optimal move?" try reframing it as "What would be most interesting for the story?"

The dice do not determine success or failure—they help decide which path you take to get there.

1.5.4 Flavor is Free

Players may add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources or requiring rolls. Flavor enriches the narrative without changing mechanical outcomes. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate.

Chapter 2

Core Mechanics

This chapter distills the essential rules of Fate’s Edge into a compact reference. It assumes you have read the narrative-first philosophy and are comfortable with the basic flow of play. Here you will find the precise procedures for resolution, advancement, and resource management that power the game.

2.1 The Core Resolution Cycle

Every meaningful action follows the same simple loop. The GM states Position and Difficulty, the player rolls, and the table interprets the result through the fiction.

2.1.1 Step-by-Step Resolution

1. **Declare action & approach.** The player states intent, the Attribute (Body, Wits, Spirit, Presence) and Skill they will use.
2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV).** The GM sets a target number of successes based on the narrative stakes (see [subsection 2.1.2](#)).
3. **Set Position.** The GM declares whether the action is Dominant, Controlled, or Desperate (see [subsection 2.1.3](#)).
4. **Roll the dice pool.** Roll a number of d10s equal to Attribute + Skill.
5. **Count successes and Story Beats (SB).**
 - 6–9 = 1 success
 - 10 = 2 successes
 - 1 = 1 SB for the GM
6. **Compare successes to DV** using the Outcome Matrix ([Table 2.1](#)).
7. **Apply the outcome.** The GM may spend any SB generated to introduce complications (see [section 2.1.9](#)).
8. **Manage resources.** The player marks Boons, Fatigue, or Obligation as indicated by the outcome.

2.1.2 Difficulty Value (DV)

The DV is the number of successes needed to achieve the character's intent without a cost. The GM sets it based on the difficulty of the task, not the drama of the scene.

Default DV Ladder	
DV	Typical Case
2	Routine: clear path, no pressure, almost guaranteed.
3	Pressured: mild opposition, time limit, partial information.
4	Hard: active resistance, precision required, serious consequences.
5+	Extreme: stacked constraints, high drama, nearly impossible.

Default DV = 3. Do not inflate DV to "challenge" players; use Position, timers, and SB spends instead.

2.1.3 Position and Effect

Position answers "How risky is this attempt?" Effect answers "How much do I achieve on a success?" Both are set by the GM based on the fiction.

Position	Narrative Frame	Mechanical Effect
Dominant	You press your advantage.	Re-roll one failure.
Controlled	Balanced, normal risk.	No re-rolls.
Desperate	You act under duress.	Re-roll one success (keep second).

Effect: Limited, Standard, or Great. It describes scope, scale, or quality (e.g., disarming a trap: Limited = one person crosses, Standard = two, Great = all four).

2.1.4 Outcome Matrix

Table 2.1: Outcome Matrix

Roll Result	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success. Achieve intent without complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0	Success with SB. Achieve intent; GM spends SB for a twist.
0 < Successes < DV	Partial. Make progress; player gains 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss. No progress; player gains 2 Boons; GM escalates with SB.

Fail Forward No roll should result in "nothing happens." Every outcome changes the situation. Even a Miss introduces a complication, advances a timer, or reveals a hidden danger.

2.1.5 Critical Success (10s)

A die that shows 10 counts as two successes. If the overall roll succeeds, each 10 adds narrative weight (GM's discretion):

- **One 10:** Strong success – improve Position by one step on your next action, or gain a minor advantage.
- **Two 10s:** Exceptional – choose two benefits (e.g., increased Effect + a free Boon).
- **Three 10s:** Legendary – decisive victory; clear 1 segment from a relevant timer.
- **Four+ 10s:** Mythic – reshape the scene; clear 1–2 segments from a relevant timer.

Tens are never re-rolled by Position effects.

2.1.6 Dice Pool Limit and Auto-Successes

The maximum number of dice rolled is 10. Any additional dice beyond 10 become automatic successes (each extra die counts as one success, but no SB is generated). This keeps high-tier characters from rolling more than a handful of physical dice while still rewarding their expertise.

2.1.7 Assistance and Teamwork

When multiple characters contribute to the same action:

- **Assistance:** One character is primary; up to three others add +1 die each by describing how they help.
- **Total assist bonus capped at +3 dice.**
- **Cooperation:** Several characters each roll; the group succeeds or fails based on combined results.
- **Complementary:** Different skills cover different parts of a larger task.

2.1.8 Boons

Boons represent momentum and narrative leverage. You may hold up to 5.

Earning Boons

- **Partial:** Gain 1 Boon.
- **Miss:** Gain 2 Boons (on a meaningful roll).
- **Bond-driven action:** Once per bond per session, gain 1 Boon when you take a significant action that explicitly references your bond.

- **GM award:** For creativity, sacrifice, or strong narrative play.

Limit: Max 2 Boons from failures per character per scene. Repetition of the same approach does not award extra Boons.

Spending Boons (1 Boon)

- Reroll a single die after seeing the pool.
- Activate an on-screen Asset.
- Improve Position by one step before a roll.
- Power certain Rites or abilities.
- Convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once per session during downtime, max 2 XP per session via conversion).

Carryover Limit At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2. Excess are lost.

2.1.9 Story Beats (SB)

Every time a player rolls a 1, the GM gains one Story Beat. These are narrative tools to introduce complications, escalate tension, or advance timers.

SB Spend Menu

Cost	Effect
1 SB	Minor: noise, trace, tick a timer +1, worsen Position by one step.
2 SB	Moderate: alarm raised, lose advantage/cover, lesser foe appears.
3 SB	Serious: reinforcements, key gear breaks, major twist, advance a front timer +1.
4+ SB	Major: trap springs, authority arrives, scene shift, Patron intervenes.

2.1.10 NPCs and Resources

Nonplayer characters do not track Fatigue or Boons. If an ability would cause an NPC to lose these resources, convert it into a narrative consequence:

- Instead of "loses 1 Boon": "The target hesitates – they lose their next action."
- Instead of "marks 1 Fatigue": "The target staggers – their next attack is at Desperate Position."
- Instead of "loses 1 Boon and marks 1 Fatigue": "The target drops their weapon (disarmed) and stumbles back one range band."

2.2 Player-Managed Modules

In Fate's Edge, you are the primary manager of your character's mechanical state. This reduces GM overhead and keeps you engaged.

What you track:

- Obligation tracks (per Patron or Symbol)
- Corruption timers (Cantors, Pact-Whisperers)
- Leash timers (summoned spirits)
- Asset state (Flourishing, Stable, Strained, Collapsed)
- Follower states (Loyalty: Faithful/Strained/Broken; Fitness: Ready/Hurt/Down)
- Progression timers (Repertoire, Spirit Bond)
- Boons, Favor, Leverage

Your responsibilities:

1. Mark immediately when a rule says "mark +X".
2. Declare thresholds ("My Obligation is full!").
3. Keep it visible (use trackers everyone can see).
4. Maintain ownership – you know your state best.

The GM spot-checks and provides consequences, but you drive your character's mechanical narrative.

2.2.1 Obligation Capacity

Obligation Capacity = Spirit + Presence. When you exceed capacity, mark 1 Fatigue per extra segment. When you reach double capacity, clear all Fatigue, increase Harm by 1, and the Patron intrudes (a demand, omen, or task).

2.2.2 Corruption Timer (Cantors)

Timer size = Spirit. When it fills, gain the last Patron's benefit and burden, then reset the timer to your Tier (minimum 1). You are never completely free of Corruption.

2.2.3 Leash Timer (Summoners)

Capacity = Cap + Spirit. Tick when the spirit takes Harm, acts against its nature, crosses a [WARD], or you split focus. Once per round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 tick. When the Leash fills, the spirit acts once to its nature, then departs (or turns hostile).

2.2.4 Asset and Follower States**Asset Status (unified track)**

- **Flourishing:** +1 die on asset rolls, +1 Yield.
- **Stable:** Normal operation.
- **Strained:** -1 die on asset rolls, no Yield.
- **Collapsed:** Non-functional; requires quest or major downtime.

Follower Loyalty

- **Faithful:** Normal assist, independent actions available.
- **Strained:** Assist at -1 die; may refuse risky orders.
- **Broken:** Follower leaves or becomes hostile.

Follower Fitness

- **Ready:** Full function.
- **Hurt:** Assist at -1 die; no independent actions.
- **Down:** Incapacitated; requires rescue or medical care.

Change states when the fiction demands it; no numeric timers required.

2.3 Turn Economy

Each character takes **1 Action and 1 Move** on their turn. Actions and Moves may be taken in any order; repeating the same Action is not allowed unless noted.

2.3.1 Movement

- **Move:** Shift one range band (Close ↔ Near ↔ Far) or stand from prone.
- **Dash (Action):** Shift two bands; your next defense is Desperate.
- **Disengage (Action):** Then your Move does not provoke opportunity attacks; you cannot Attack this turn.

2.3.2 Action Options

Attack Make a melee or ranged attack.

Disengage See above.

Shove Opposed Body + Athletics. Push target one band.

Grapple Opposed Body + Melee vs. Body + Athletics. Both Engaged; target suffers -1 die.

Charge (full turn) Move two bands toward an enemy + make one melee attack. Cost 1 Fatigue, next defense Desperate, requires open ground.

Skirmish (full turn) Move two bands away from an enemy + make one ranged attack. Cost 1 Fatigue, next defense Desperate, requires open ground.

Observe / Change Position Gain +1 Position once.

Setup Grant an ally +1 Position or step up Effect (requires a roll).

Assist Spend 1 Boon to give an ally +1 die (max +3 from all assists).

Defend, Channel/Weave, Cast Rite/Song, Interact, etc.

2.3.3 Initiative

There is no fixed initiative order. The GM frames spotlight order based on the fiction. Ambushers act first; the spotlight may shift mid-scene if narratively appropriate.

2.3.4 Opportunity Attacks

Leaving an enemy's Close range without using Disengage provokes one free melee attack (Controlled Position, no action cost).

2.4 Fatigue and Harm

2.4.1 Fatigue Track

Your Fatigue track size equals your Body attribute. Mark Fatigue for physical exertion, magical strain, stress, or harsh conditions.

Effects

- Each point of Fatigue worsens your Position by one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate).
- If already Desperate, each additional Fatigue instead imposes a −1 die penalty on all rolls.
- **Overflow:** When the track fills, increase Harm by one level and clear all Fatigue.

Recovery

- Short rest (one hour, quiet): remove 2 Fatigue.
- Full night's rest in safety: remove all Fatigue.
- Fatigue cannot be removed while the party is at Dangerous or Empty Supply (see travel rules).

2.4.2 Harm Levels

Harm Level	Effect
Harm 1	−1 die on related actions.
Harm 2	−1 die on most actions until treated.
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying.

2.4.3 Taking Harm and Fatigue – The Procedure

When you are hit, follow these steps in order:

1. **Convert** incoming Harm to Fatigue using the Armor Conversion Table (see [subsection 2.4.4](#)). Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit, even if conversion would give 0.

2. **Apply remaining Harm** – if any Harm remains after conversion, increase your Harm level by that amount, and clear all existing Fatigue (the shock of a wound resets your exhaustion).
3. **Add the Fatigue** from step 1 to your Fatigue track. If this fills or exceeds your track, resolve Overflow (Harm +1, clear all Fatigue).

2.4.4 Armor Conversion Table

Armor Type	Incoming Harm		
	Harm 1	Harm 2	Harm 3
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.

2.4.5 Fear Effects (Optional)

When a Fear Track escalates (Shaken → Frightened → Panicked), the GM may roll a d10 or choose an effect appropriate to the fiction.

d10	Effect
1	Freeze (cannot act).
2	Flee.
3	Drop held item.
4	Beg or bargain.
5	Hide.
6	Panic attack (target nearest creature).
7	Blunder into danger.
8	Obey a simple command.
9	Break down (useless until aided).
10	Catatonia.

2.5 Skills

Your dice pool for any action is **Attribute** + **Skill**. The GM sets Position and DV based on your approach.

2.5.1 Core Skills (Abridged)

Skill	What It Covers
Arcana	Magic theory, wards, rituals, free casting.
Athletics	Running, climbing, jumping, swimming.
Brawl	Unarmed combat, grappling.
Command	Leadership, intimidation, morale.

Craft	Building, repairing, creating tools or art.
Deception	Lying, bluffing, misdirection.
Insight	Reading emotions, detecting lies, understanding motives.
Investigation	Research, deduction, analyzing clues.
Lore	History, culture, religion, general knowledge.
Medicine	Healing, anatomy, first aid.
Melee	Close combat with weapons.
Notice	Perception, spotting ambushes, hidden details.
Performance	Entertainment, oration, musical display.
Ranged	Bows, crossbows, thrown weapons.
Stealth	Moving unseen, hiding, blending in.
Subterfuge	Casing, forgery, sleight of hand, social infiltration.
Survival	Tracking, foraging, navigation, animal handling.
Sway	Persuasion, negotiation, charm.
Tinker	Lockpicking, traps, devices.

2.5.2 Alternative Attribute + Skill Pairs

The same fictional action can often use different Attributes. For example:

- **Climbing:** Body + Athletics (strength) or Wits + Athletics (route-finding) or Spirit + Athletics (determination).
- **Persuading a guard:** Presence + Sway (charm) or Wits + Sway (logic) or Spirit + Sway (conviction).

The GM has final say; creative alternatives are encouraged when they fit the fiction.

2.6 Experience Points (XP)

XP is earned by engaging meaningfully with the world: overcoming challenges, taking risks, making hard choices, and leaning into your character's story.

2.6.1 Awarding XP (per session)

- Base participation: +2 XP.
- Major objective: +2–4 XP.
- Discoveries (lore, locations, secrets): +1–2 XP.
- Hard choices (moral or strategic): +1–2 XP.
- Story engagement (embracing complications): +1–3 XP.
- Personal goals: +1–2 XP.

At the end of a major story arc, everyone gains an additional +8–12 XP.

2.6.2 Spending XP

- **Attribute increase:** new rating $\times 3$ XP; downtime = new rating days.
- **Skill increase:** new level $\times 2$ XP; downtime = new level days.
- **Talents:** 2 XP (minor) to 12+ XP (epic).
- **Follower (Capability):** Cap^2 XP; downtime 1–3 days.
- **Asset:**
 - Minor (4 XP, 1 day)
 - Standard (8 XP, 1 week)
 - Major (12 XP, 1 month)

Rush Rule You may attempt to train faster. The GM starts a Risk Timer [4]. Each segment you roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 3). When the timer fills, the new capability gains a flaw (e.g., -1 die penalty, unreliability, hidden problem).

2.6.3 Reputation Tiers

Novice (0–40 XP) Local reputation, prestige locked.

Seasoned (41–90 XP) Regional influence, some prestige unlock.

Veteran (91–150 XP) National reputation, second follower slot.

Paragon (151–220 XP) Continental influence, rivals emerge.

Mythic (221+ XP) Legendary, kingdoms react.

2.7 Assets and Followers (Quick Reference)

2.7.1 Assets (Off-Screen)

Cost: Minor (4 XP, 1d), Standard (8 XP, 1w), Major (12 XP, 1m).

- **Free off-screen use:** once per session.
- **Boon activation:** spend 1 Boon for on-scene effect.
- **Status:** Flourishing $\rightarrow$ Stable $\rightarrow$ Strained $\rightarrow$ Collapsed.

2.7.2 Followers (On-Screen)

Cost: Cap^2 XP (e.g., Cap 3 = 9 XP), downtime 1–3 days.

- **Assistance:** add dice = $\min(\text{Cap}, \text{relevant skill})$, max +3 from all sources.
- **Independent action:** once per scene (party-wide). Cost: worsen Loyalty or Fitness one step.
- **Loyalty:** Faithful $\rightarrow$ Strained $\rightarrow$ Broken.
- **Fitness:** Ready $\rightarrow$ Hurt $\rightarrow$ Down.

2.7.3 Upkeep (per downtime)

- **Efficient:** $XP = \max(1, \text{acquisition } XP / 3)$. Minimal effort.
- **Intensive:** 1 XP + a dedicated downtime action.

Failure to pay: Asset Status worsens one step; Follower Loyalty worsens one step.

2.7.4 Wards and Traps

Wards are magical barriers that block passage, teleportation, and shadow-walking. Traps are mundane or magical hazards that trigger on intrusion. Both use the same base resolution structure.

Wards (Magical Barriers)

A ward is defined by its **Base DV** (2–5), chosen by the GM when the ward is placed. The ward’s other properties derive from this DV:

- **Harm:** A creature that triggers the ward suffers Harm equal to $\max(0, \text{Base DV} - 2)$.
- **Spirit Leash:** A spirit (including summoned creatures) attempting to cross the ward suffers Leash ticks equal to the ward’s Base DV.

Crossing a Ward A creature cannot teleport, shadow-walk, or use any effect that bypasses intervening space to cross a ward without first overcoming it. To cross, the creature must succeed on a test of the appropriate attribute (usually Wits or Presence) + **Spirit** against the ward’s Base DV. On a failure, the crossing fails and the creature suffers the ward’s Harm (if any). On a success, the creature crosses but may still suffer other consequences (e.g., alerting the ward’s creator).

Disabling a Ward A character may attempt to disable a ward with a **Wits + Arcana** test against the ward’s Base DV. Success renders the ward inert for one scene (or permanently, at the GM’s discretion for non-recurring wards). Alternatively, a spell with the **[DISPEL]** or **[FATE]** tags may suppress or destroy the ward as described in the spell’s effect.

Traps (Mundane or Magical)

Traps function similarly to wards but do **not** impede teleportation or shadow-walking, nor do they inflict Leash ticks on spirits. A trap has a Base DV (2–5) and deals Harm equal to $\max(0, \text{Base DV} - 2)$ when triggered.

Disarming a Trap A trap can be disarmed with a **Wits + Subterfuge** test against its Base DV. On a success, the trap is neutralised. On a failure, the trap may trigger (GM’s discretion).

Example

A **Lesser Wardstone** (DV 3) bars a doorway. A character attempting to shadow-walk past must roll **Wits** + **Spirit** (DV 3). Failure inflicts **Harm 1** (since $3-2 = 1$). A spirit crossing the same ward gains **3 Leash ticks**. A **Wits** + **Arcana** (DV 3) success disables the ward.

Chapter 3

Deck-Based Generators

3.1 Introduction to Deck Generators

Deck generators in **Fate's Edge** transform random card draws into coherent narrative elements. Each deck has a distinct purpose and suit meanings so that randomness serves the story rather than derailing it. These generators provide structured inspiration for GMs while maintaining the game's narrative-first philosophy.

3.2 Standard Deck Structure

Fate's Edge uses several card-based tools, each with specialized suit meanings:

Travel Decks (regional, 52-card) Used for journey content and location-based adventures.

- **Spade** = Place / Location
- **Heart** = Actor / Faction
- **Club** = Pressure / Complication
- **Diamond** = Reward / Opportunity

Deck of Consequences (scene drama) Used for immediate complications and narrative twists during gameplay.

- **Hearts** = Social / Emotional Fallout
- **Spades** = Harm / Escalation
- **Clubs** = Material Cost / Resource Drain
- **Diamonds** = Magical / Spiritual Disturbance

Important

Never mix suit meanings across decks. When rules reference *Spade / Club / Diamond*, they mean the **Travel Deck**. When they say *Hearts / Spades / Clubs / Diamonds*, they mean the **Deck of Consequences**.

3.3 Rank Severity and Timer Size

Card rank sets the size / significance of the primary Timer :

- **2–5 (Minor)**: 4-segment Timer
- **6–10 (Standard)**: 6-segment Timer
- **J, Q, K (Major)**: 8-segment Timer
- **Ace (Pivotal)**: 10-segment Timer

Color Influence:

- **Black suits** (♠, ♣): Travel hazards, tangible threats, fatigue.
- **Red suits** (♥, ♦): Social intrigue, reputational pressure, emotional complications.

3.4 Draw Procedures

3.4.1 Quick Hook (2 cards)

Ideal for spontaneous scene generation or when players zag unexpectedly:

1. Draw one **Spade** (place) and one **Heart** (actor / faction).
2. Use the higher rank to set Timer size.
3. Combine elements into a simple, compelling scenario.

3.4.2 Full Seed (4 cards)

For full adventures or significant arcs:

1. Draw until one card of each suit appears:
 - **Spade** = Primary location
 - **Heart** = Main actor / faction
 - **Club** = Central complication
 - **Diamond** = Key reward / opportunity
2. The highest rank sets the main Timer size.
3. If multiple face cards or Aces appear, create parallel Timers for secondary threats or opportunities.

3.4.3 Act Builder

Structure sessions or multi-part adventures:

1. Draw three cards: setting (**Spade**), actor (**Heart**), complication (**Club**).
2. Treat **Diamond** cards drawn during play as foreshadowed opportunities or act payoffs.
3. Highest rank determines the session's primary challenge scope.

3.5 Using the Deck in Play

1. Players roll; each die showing **1** generates **1 Story Beat (SB)**.
2. The GM chooses one method for that roll:
 - (a) **Direct Spend:** Translate SB into immediate consequences or timer ticks.
 - (b) **Deck Draw:** Draw up to **min(SB, 3)** cards and synthesise a single twist guided by suit and highest rank.
3. Interpret the cards to create a coherent complication that advances the narrative.

3.6 Combo Rules

Special combinations add texture:

Pair (same rank) Recurring motif with a twist.

Run (3+ sequential ranks) Momentum – reduce the main Timer by 1 segment.

Flush (3+ same suit) Strongly theme the act toward that suit’s axis.

Face + Ace Reveal a hidden patron or power behind the element.

All one color GM gains +1 **SB** to use in that scene.

3.7 Regional Generator Summary

Table 3.1: Regional Generator Summary

Region	Theme	Special Mechanics
Acasia	Broken Marches	Curse motifs; every Ace adds a lingering omen.
Aelaerem	Hearth & Hollow	Red-thread motifs; Ace echoes quiet bells / watch-geese.
Aeler	Crowns & Under-Vaults	Stone / breath motifs; Ace: keys click, bells answer.
Aelinnel	Stone, Bough, Bright Things	Moonlight motifs; Ace adds a shortcut where none should be.
Black Banners	Condotta & Crowns	War & winter motifs; Ace: weapons remember, ice holds the dead.
Ecktoria	Marble & Fire	Imperial forms; Ace carves precedent in marble.
Kahfagia	Pilot’s Mirror	Lantern-law jurisdiction shifts; Ace redefines lanes.

Table 3.1 – continued

Region	Theme	Special Mechanics
Linn	Skerries & Storm-Oaths	Sea omens; Ace: horns on wind, white horses on swell.
Mistlands	Bells, Salt, Breath	Breath / boundary motifs; Ace: bells answer across water.
Silkstrand	City of Bridges & Dyewater	Dye / bridge motifs; Ace adds a lingering omen.
Theona	Three Greens, No Ninth	"No Ninth" custom; Ace adds a telling omission.
Thepyrgos	City of a Thousand Stairs	Height / sound motifs; Ace echoes bells / wind / stair-steps.
Ubral	Stone Between Spears	Upland motifs; Ace echoes horns / heather / stone.
Valewood	Empire Under Leaves	Empire echoes (J/Q/K add relic-logic); Ace rearranges approach.
Vhasia	Fractured Sun	Broken-sun motifs; Ace blots medal / scratches milestone.
Vilikari	Laurels & Longhouses	Two-laws motifs; Ace shows wolf / eagle side-by-side.
Viterra	Last Kingdom	Legacy, parishes, and final-stand themes.
Wilds	Roads, Ruins, Weather	Reskin palette for any biome.
Zakov	Salt & Serpent	Salt & serpent omens; Ace: tides remember, reefs shift, deep listens.

3.8 NPC Generation Deck

Every NPC should feel like a person with desires, convictions, and contradictions. This deck lets you assemble a complete profile quickly by drawing one element from each category.

3.8.1 Generation Categories

Ambition What they seek to achieve or obtain.

Belief The principle or philosophy guiding their worldview.

Attitude How they present themselves and interact day-to-day.

Twist A contradiction or hidden facet that creates tension.

3.8.2 Using the NPC Generator

Select or draw one from each column and consider the frictions between public ambition, private belief, surface attitude, and the twist.

Table 3.2: NPC Generation Categories

Ambition	Belief	Attitude	Twist
Power	Might makes right	Arrogant	Secretly insecure
Wealth	Ends justify means	Charismatic	Betraying their allies
Revenge	Honor above all	Cold	Working for their enemy
Love	Truth is sacred	Friendly	Hiding a dark past
Knowledge	Loyalty is paramount	Paranoid	Actually an impostor
Survival	Family above all	Cruel	Deeply compassionate
Fame	Justice must prevail	Pious	Corrupted by power
Freedom	Fate can be changed	Optimistic	Hopelessly cynical
Protection	Tradition must be upheld	Pessimistic	Revolutionary at heart
Control	Change is necessary	Calculating	Acts on impulse
Recognition	The system works	Naive	Cynical manipulator

3.9 Practical Deck Usage Examples

3.9.1 Example 1: Quick Scene Generation

The party detours through the Mistlands. The GM draws:

- **Spade (8)**: Ancient standing stones covered in moss.
- **Heart (Queen)**: A territorial spirit guardian.

A 6-segment Timer *Spirit's Wrath* begins: the guardian demands tribute for safe passage.

3.9.2 Example 2: Consequences During Play

Alexander misses a stealth roll and generates **2 SB**. The GM draws:

- **Hearts (7)**: Social complication.
- **Clubs (3)**: Resource cost.

Synthesis: *A ceremonial urn shatters; cultists recognize your patron's mark. Future dealings will demand extra tribute and materials.*

3.9.3 Example 3: NPC Creation

Merchant in Valewood:

- **Ambition:** Wealth
- **Belief:** Family above all
- **Attitude:** Charismatic
- **Twist:** Secretly compassionate

Result: *A charming hard-bargainer who supports a large family and quietly donates to orphanages – even aiding struggling competitors.*

3.10 GM Guidance for Deck Usage

3.10.1 When to Use Which Deck

- **Travel Decks:** journey planning, location adventures, regional exploration.
- **Deck of Consequences:** immediate twists during active scenes.
- **NPC Generator:** fast creation with built-in tension and hooks.

3.10.2 Interpreting Card Draws

- Prioritise narrative coherence over literalism.
- Use suits as inspiration, not constraints.
- Combine cards into layered complications rather than parallel noise.
- Remember: players can mitigate, pivot, or overcome deck outcomes.

3.10.3 Balancing Randomness and Narrative

- Draw when you want surprise or need a nudge.
- Ignore or modify draws that don't serve the current story.
- Treat combinations as creative prompts, not mandates.
- The goal is to *enhance* the narrative, not derail it.

Chapter 4

Resource Management

4.1 Introduction

Resource Management in **Fate's Edge** focuses on tracking the tangible and intangible assets that enable character actions while creating narrative tension. Rather than micromanaging every item, the system uses abstract timers and conditions that trigger when dramatically appropriate. This keeps the focus on story consequences rather than bookkeeping.

4.2 Supply Timer

The Supply Timer is a shared condition for the entire party, representing food, water, ammunition, and basic gear. It tracks the group's overall readiness for extended endeavours.

4.2.1 Supply States

Table 4.1: Supply Timer States

State	Effect
Full Supply (0 segments)	The party is well-equipped and prepared. No penalties.
Low Supply (2 segments)	Minor narrative complications: bland food, damaged arrows, thinning waterskins, worn gear.
Dangerously Low (3 segments)	Each character gains Fatigue 1 due to exhaustion and deprivation.
Out of Supply (4 segments)	Severe penalties apply; characters face starvation, dehydration, and failing gear with significant mechanical consequences.

4.2.2 Filling the Supply Timer

The Supply Timer advances under the following circumstances:

- Harsh travel conditions or lost pack animals (GM fiat).
- GM spends 2+ **Story Beats (SB)** to represent resource depletion.
- The party chooses to travel light for speed or stealth advantages.
- Failed foraging or resource-gathering attempts.

4.2.3 Emptying the Supply Timer

The Supply Timer can be reduced through:

- Reaching civilisation or safe haven resets to **Full Supply**.
- Successful foraging / hunting: group *Survival* check (DV 2) clears 1 segment.
- Downtime spent in relative safety removes 1 segment.
- Purchasing or trading for supplies in settlements.

4.3 Fatigue

Fatigue represents physical exhaustion, hunger, emotional strain, and spiritual depletion. It accumulates through extended effort, deprivation, or magical backlash.

4.3.1 Clearing Fatigue

- A night's rest with adequate Supply removes 1 level of Fatigue.
- You cannot clear Fatigue if the party's Supply timer is *Dangerously Low* or *Out of Supply*.
- Magical healing or special abilities may provide additional Fatigue recovery.
- Extended downtime (3+ days) in safety clears all Fatigue.

4.4 Gear Condition

Gear in **Fate's Edge** does not have hit points or detailed durability tracking. Instead, equipment suffers consequences only when drama demands it.

4.4.1 Compromised Items

- Compromised status is introduced via SB spends or narrative consequence.
- A **Compromised** item gives -1 die on relevant rolls until repaired.
- Multiple Compromised items affecting the *same* action do not stack penalties.

4.4.2 Breaking Point

If a Compromised item suffers another significant setback, it breaks entirely and becomes unusable.

4.4.3 Repair Options

Field Repair Temporary fix; requires *Craft* or *Survival* check (DV 2) to remove the penalty for one scene.

Proper Repair Permanent restoration; requires proper tools, materials, and significant downtime.

Magical Repair Certain spells or rituals can instantly restore gear, but may carry Obligation or Backlash costs.

4.4.4 Equipment Enchantments Quick Reference

Table 4.2: Equipment Enchantment Guidelines

Type	Cost
Minor Enchantments	2–4 XP
Major Enchantments	6–8 XP
Prestige Enchantments	10+ XP

Limitations:

- Max enchantments = Spirit attribute.
- No stacking identical benefits.
- Maintenance affects functionality.

4.5 Asset and Follower Management

4.5.1 Followers (On-Screen Resources)

Cost Cap² XP to acquire.

Assist Dice When applicable, the follower adds help dice equal to min(Cap, helper's relevant Skill), capped at +3 dice total from all sources. *Exception: Exceptional Coordination* Talent allows one follower to provide +4 assist dice.

Capability Ranges from 1–5 (5 is exceptional).

Upkeep Each Downtime period, pay XP equal to Cap *or* spend a Scene tending the relationship.

Risk If the GM spends 2+ SB on an action you take with assistance, they may endanger, injure, or separate the follower instead of you if fictionally appropriate.

Off-Screen Capability Once per downtime, a Cap 5 follower can solve one significant problem but generates 1 SB for the party; the GM must describe how their action creates consequences.

4.5.2 Upkeep (Expanded)

Upkeep is the story of attention. Followers and assets thrive when seen and sour when ignored.

Design Intent

- **Choice with Teeth.** Players choose *time* or *XP*. Either way, the fiction moves: quick delegation vs. hands-on scenes.
- **Visible Drift.** Missing upkeep degrades things predictably: **WARY** → **SEIZED**, **NEGLECTED** → **COMPROMISED**.
- **Story First.** Every payment should say something about the relationship or the tool.

Asset Upkeep

Frequency. Once per Downtime period.

Option A — Efficient (Higher XP, Less Time) Pay Upkeep $XP = \max\left(1, \frac{XP \text{ Acquisition Cost}}{3}\right)$. Minimal effort in-fiction (a retainer handles it; you check in by letter).

Option B — Intensive (Lower XP, More Time) Pay 1 XP. Spend a *dedicated Downtime action* personally tending the follower / asset.

Failure. If unpaid this Downtime:

- *Follower:* becomes **Wary** (or **Seized** if already Wary).
- *Asset:* becomes **Neglected** (or **Compromised** if already Neglected).

What the Conditions Look Like

WARY (Follower) They hesitate, ask for guarantees, or interpret orders narrowly. *Mechanical nudge:* first social / test involving them is -1 position *or* costs 1 extra Stress.

SEIZED (Follower) Someone else sets terms (rival, guild, family) or they withdraw until appeased. *Nudge:* cannot assist this Downtime; to re-engage, pay 1 Boon *or* clear via a narrative scene that addresses their grievance.

NEGLECTED (Asset) It underperforms; parts go missing; paperwork piles. *Nudge:* -1 effect on its next use *or* an *Alarmed Attention* timer $+1/2$.

COMPROMISED (Asset) Faults propagate; someone has leverage; the tool is noisy or unsafe. *Nudge:* first use this session automatically creates 1 **SB** *or* requires a costly fix scene.

Examples by Type

Followers.

Table 4.3: Follower Upkeep Examples

Type	Efficient Upkeep (pay XP, quick)	Intensive Upkeep (1 XP + action)
Scribe	Send coin and a sealed brief with instructions.	Host a lesson; co-author a pamphlet that sharpens their craft.
Scout	Dispatch a courier with a new map and stipend.	Walk the route together; overhaul signals and caches.
Acolyte (Patron-bound)	Arrange a blessing via intermediaries.	Lead them in a minor rite; narrate the teaching moment.
Mercenary	Wire hazard pay with a short commendation.	Drill formation; settle a dispute; toast the unit.
Informant	Drop a dead-letter and payment.	Meet face-to-face; share protection protocol.

Assets.

Table 4.4: Asset Upkeep Examples

Type	Efficient Upkeep (pay XP, quick)	Intensive Upkeep (1 XP + action)
Workshop	Pay the foreman; authorize routine parts.	Personally recalibrate; craft a sample piece.
Safehouse	Hire a caretaker; basic supplies delivered.	Repair locks/windows; rewrite the cover story with neighbors.
Library	Fund copying; buy indices.	Catalog a shelf; cross-ref a case; bind a damaged tome.
Boat	Pay moorage and minimal maintenance.	Scrape hull; patch sails; sail a proving run.
Sigil Network (Invoker)	Replace two worn plates.	Etch a new master glyph; clear 1 wear mid-scene next session.

Edge Cases & Rulings

- **Multiple Resources.** Each follower / asset checks upkeep separately. A single Intensive action can cover a *cohesive group* if fiction supports it (e.g., one drill for a squad).
- **Remote Care.** If you narrate convincing remote oversight (sending a trusted lieutenant), count as Efficient.

- **Patron-Tinted Upkeep.** Tie upkeep scenes to a Patron's theme for small boons (advantage on the next related roll) without changing costs.
- **Stacking Misses.** Missing upkeep across *two* consecutive Downtime periods moves WARY → SEIZED or NEGLECTED → COMPROMISED; a third consecutive miss risks loss (follower quits; asset condemned) at GM discretion.

Optional Modules

Ledger Credits Track fractional prep: three Efficient payments can be banked to waive one Intensive action later.

Union Rules Some factions demand Intensive upkeep; Efficient counts as half (two Efficient = one Intensive).

Patron Favor Swap Spend a **Boon** to treat missed upkeep as paid for one follower / asset if the scene honors the Patron.

GM Guidance

- **Making it a Scene.** Intensive upkeep should reveal something (new contact, flaw, rumor).
- **Foreshadowing Degradation.** Before applying SEIZED / COMPROMISED, show warning signs the players can act on.
- **Naming the Toll.** If a **Patron's Largess** (wrath) applies, state the narrative reason and the extra toll (e.g., an added SB, a temporary lockout, or a vow demanded).

Upkeep Quick Reference

Once per Downtime. Pay Efficient ($XP = \max(1, \frac{acq}{3})$) or Intensive (1 XP + action).

Missed: Follower → WARY → SEIZED; Asset → NEGLECTED → COMPROMISED. Tie scenes to your Patron for flavor, not discounts.

4.5.3 Follower Assist Rules

- Assist dice come from the helper's capabilities, not the leader's.
- Total Assist on any roll (from any sources) is hard-capped at +3. *Exception:* *Exceptional Coordination* may allow +4 from a single follower.
- Only one follower may assist a given action at a time.
- Followers cannot assist actions beyond their narrative scope or capabilities.

4.5.4 Loyalty & Bonds (Optional Rules)

- Track a simple Loyalty tag per follower: *Wary* / *Steady* / *Devoted*.
- *Devoted* followers can once per arc convert one GM Complication targeting them into a lesser setback.
- *Wary* followers cost +1 XP to maintain during Downtime.
- Loyalty can change based on how the PC treats the follower and shared experiences.

4.5.5 Off-Screen Assets

Table 4.5: Asset Types and Costs

Asset Type	Cost
Minor Asset	4 XP (safehouse, small charter, local business)
Standard Asset	8 XP (noble title, guild section, spy ring, significant property)
Major Asset	12 XP (city license, regional network, major institution influence)
Artifact Asset	16+ XP (unique items or positions with campaign-level significance)

Asset Activations

- **Off-Screen Activation:** At campaign start or during Downtime, activate an off-screen asset by spending **1 Boon** or **2 XP**.
- **Off-Screen Effects:** Use each Asset's listed off-screen effect once per session for free.
- **On-Screen Activation:** To reshape the current scene, spend **1 Boon**.
- **Plausibility Test:** The Asset must have appropriate scope and reach for the intended effect.

Asset Condition Tracks

Maintained Full capability; no penalties. The asset is in good standing and fully functional.

Neglected −1 die when used (assist or leverage). Narratively: slower response, sullen staff, short-staffed operations.

Compromised Unavailable for use. Narratively: captured, burned, seized, defected, or otherwise incapacitated.

Maintenance and Repair

- After a story arc or 2–3 sessions of heavy use, the GM may flag the resource as *at risk*.
- To keep an asset *Maintained*, the player must either:
 - Spend Downtime repairing / servicing it, or
 - Pay XP immediately (representing replacement parts, masterwork upkeep).
- If neglected, the asset becomes *Neglected* (–1 die) and may eventually become permanently lost.
- Superior and Artifact assets do not require normal upkeep; if *Compromised* through complications, only narrative quests can repair them.

4.6 Bond-Driven Resource Generation

When a player takes a significant action to aid an ally with whom they share a bond, and explicitly references that bond in an *Intricate* description, they may mark that bond to gain **1 Boon** *after* the action resolves.

4.6.1 Requirements

- **Mutual Bond:** Player shares a defined bond with the ally they are aiding.
- **Intricate Description:** Player describes how the bond motivates their action using rich, multi-sensory details.
- **Significant Aid:** Meaningful assistance beyond basic dice bonuses.
- **Fiction First:** The bond genuinely drives the choice to help, not added retroactively.

4.6.2 Examples

Valid Examples:

- "Remembering how they saved me from the falling rubble in Aeler, I throw myself in front of the crossbow bolt meant for them!"
- "Thinking of our shared vow to protect the innocent, I use my last healing potion to stabilise them instead of saving it for myself."
- "Drawing on our years fighting side-by-side in the Border Wars, I rally the other mercenaries to keep fighting alongside them when morale fails."

4.6.3 Limitations

- Once per bond per session.
- Must involve meaningful sacrifice or risk.
- GM approval required for what constitutes "significant action".
- Cannot be used for basic assistance rolls or minor favors.
- The Boon is awarded *after* the action resolves, not before.

4.7 Currency-Free Economy (Compressed Reference)

Quick Reference

No coin. Incidental expenses are hand-waved. Significant costs use XP, barter, Strings, or Obligation (Debt Timers).

4.7.1 What Costs What

Item / Benefit	XP Cost	Alternative Payment
Minor Asset	4 XP	Minor String or Debt Timer [4]
Standard Asset	8 XP	Standard String or Debt Timer [6]
Major Asset	12 XP	Major String or Debt Timer [8]
Follower (Cap n)	n^2 XP	Debt Timer $[n + 2]$ or equivalent String
Single-use magical item	2–4 XP	Barter (item of equal rarity)
Permanent magical item (Tier I)	6–10 XP	Quest + String
Clear Debt Timer segment	2 XP	One service scene
Permanent String (earned)	— (reward)	—
Form a Trust (party pool)	10 XP	—

4.7.2 String Values

String Tier	Purchasing Power
Minor	1 XP discount, or one free use of a Minor Asset effect
Standard	Minor Asset (4 XP) or clear 2 Debt Timer segments
Major	Standard Asset (8 XP) or Cap 3 Follower

4.7.3 Debt Timer Equivalences

Debt Timer Size	Equivalent Value
	Minor Asset or one-time service
	Standard Asset or Cap 3 Follower
	Major Asset or Cap 5 Follower

4.7.4 Trust Investments (from Party Pool)

XP	Effect
4	Increase Trust Debt Timer capacity by 2
6	Add Minor Asset (Trust-owned)
8	Upgrade Asset (Minor → Standard)
10	Add Cap 3 Follower (Trust lieutenant)
12	Gain permanent Standard String (faction owes Trust)
15	Trust becomes Major Terrestrial Patron (can grant Rites)

4.7.5 Hand-Waved (Free)

Meals, inn stays, basic tools, riding horse, routine transport, minor repairs, small bribes.

4.7.6 GM Adjudication Quick Mat

Situation	Ruling
Player asks for small, reasonable item	Yes, free.
Player wants a permanent asset	XP, String, or Debt Timer .
Player offers barter	Roll Presence+Sway (DV 2–5); on success, trade happens.
Player spends a String	No roll unless hostile/extreme; String is consumed.
Debt Timer fills	Creditor makes a demand (mission, sacrifice, public oath).
Player hoards XP	Introduce problems that need Assets/Trusts, not personal power.
Player farms Boons for XP	Anti-fishing: no Boons from safe/repetitive actions.
Player founds a Trust	Require 10 XP from pool; run introductory mission to clear founding Debt Timer .

4.7.7 SB Menu – Currency Complications

SB Spent	Complication
1	Barter item damaged; NPC demands extra favor.
2	Debt Timer ticks unexpectedly; String found counterfeit.
3	Trust Asset threatened; major barter deal collapses.
4+	Trust schism; Debt Timer called in early at worst moment.

4.7.8 Currency-Free Economy – Core Principles

- **Hand-wave trivial.** Say yes to small, sensible requests.
- **Significant gains cost XP, Strings, or Debt.**
- **Debt is story.** Call in Debt Timers at dramatic moments.
- **Trusts are player-driven factions.** Use them to generate missions and rivals.
- **Spent XP is remembered.** Make assets and followers matter in the fiction.

Chapter 5

Character Advancement

5.1 Introduction

Character advancement in **Fate's Edge** reflects meaningful growth in capability and standing. XP is awarded for table-facing accomplishments, hard choices, and the dramatic friction that defines your story. Advancement should always reinforce narrative identity: what drives, obligations, and affinities are shaping the character?

5.2 Starting Character Builds

5.2.1 Standard Starting XP

Players begin with **32 XP** to allocate during initial character creation. This represents a balanced baseline for competent starting characters.

5.2.2 Enhanced Starting Options

Players may exceed the standard 32 XP build through narrative engagement:

- **Bonds:** Up to two player-defined mutual bonds may be taken for +2 XP total (+1 XP each).
- **Complications:** Up to two initial complications may be accepted for +4 XP total (+2 XP each).

This allows a maximum starting build of **36XP**. Players are encouraged to aim for 32 XP and use bonds/complications to enhance characterization rather than pure mechanical optimisation.

5.2.3 Initial Complications Reminder

For each initial complication taken at character creation:

- Start each scene with +1 banked SB per character with initial complications.
- These complications remain until cleared through play or character development.

5.2.4 Small Folk of the Threshold

The Aelaerem and Aelinnel are diminutive peoples attuned to liminal spaces and hidden ways. Their stature grants them agility and subtlety, though at the cost of bearing heavy arms or armor.

- **Restriction:** Cannot use *Heavy Armor* or *Heavy Weapons*.
- **Bonus:** Gain +1 *Position* when Dodging or Resisting Knockback, and +1 die on *Hide* or *Evasion* rolls made while in cover.

Their presence in the world is often underestimated, but their knack for slipping unseen through thresholds and enduring where others falter has earned them a quiet reverence.

5.3 Player Archetypes

Not every group plays the same way. These archetypes describe how players typically spend XP and seek spotlight.

5.3.1 The Solo

Definition Invests XP primarily in Attributes and Skills. Minimal followers, minimal holdings. All power is on the character sheet.

Typical XP Spread 70–90% Self; 0–10% On-screen help; 0–20% Off-screen assets.

Strengths Consistent scene impact; few moving parts; resilient to follower loss.

Risks Limited fiction reach between sessions; can stall when problems demand logistics or networks.

Starting Focus Attributes 2–3, Skills 1–2, minimal assets.

5.3.2 The Mixed Player

Definition Splits XP between self-growth and one or two meaningful assets (a small follower or a reliable holding).

Typical XP Spread 50–65% Self; 15–25% On-screen help; 15–25% Off-screen assets.

Strengths Versatile: credible in scenes and has a lever for special problems.

Risks Upkeep pressure; helper can be targeted when the GM spends 2+ Story Beats.

Starting Focus Balanced approach with one minor asset or low-cap follower.

5.3.3 The Mastermind

Definition Prioritises followers / cadres / familiars and off-screen networks. The character sheet is the hub of a larger apparatus.

Typical XP Spread 25–40% Self; 35–55% On-screen help; 20–40% Off-screen assets.

Strengths Scene control via assistance; strategic reach between sessions; strong heist / social-planning play.

Risks Dependency on assist lanes; followers can be endangered on 2+ SB spends; upkeep pressure.

Starting Focus Significant investment in followers or major assets from the beginning.

5.4 XP Costs and Advancement

5.4.1 Core Character Improvements

Table 5.1: Core Improvement Costs

Improvement	Cost and Downtime
Attribute increase	Cost = new rating $\times$ 3 XP; downtime = new rating (days).
Skill increase	Cost = new level $\times$ 2 XP; downtime = new level (days).
On-screen Follower	Cost = Cap ² XP; 1–3 days to recruit and brief.

5.4.2 Off-Screen Assets

Table 5.2: Asset Costs

Asset Type	Cost and Downtime
Minor Asset	4 XP; 1 day.
Standard Asset	8 XP; 1 week.
Major Asset	12 XP; 1 month.
Artifact Asset	16+ XP; campaign effort.

5.4.3 Talent Costs

Table 5.3: Talent Costs

Talent Tier	Cost
Minor Talents	2–3 XP (small situational bonus).
Major Talents	4–6 XP (strong upgrade, permanent effect in a niche).
Prestige Talents	7–10 XP (campaign-defining, breaks fundamental limits).

Epic Talents 11+ XP (legendary, story-shaping).

5.5 Tiers of Reputation

Though there are no character levels, total XP spent creates soft "tiers" that shape how the world responds to characters.

Table 5.4: Reputation Tiers

Tier	Effect
Tier I – Novice (0–40 XP)	Local reputation; prestige abilities locked.
Tier II – Seasoned (41–90 XP)	Regional notice; prestige abilities may unlock.
Tier III – Veteran (91–150 XP)	National influence; second follower slot suggested.
Tier IV – Paragon (151–220 XP)	Movers and shakers; rivals emerge to challenge.
Tier V – Mythic (221+ XP)	Legendary status; kingdoms and cults respond directly.

5.6 Prestige Abilities and Talents (Examples)

Prestige abilities are narrative milestones unlocked through mastery or story events. They are priced at 6+ XP and include campaign-shaping effects.

5.6.1 General Talents

Battle Instincts (6 XP): Once per scene, re-roll a failed defense roll.

Silver Tongue (4 XP): Gain +1 die when persuading or deceiving through speech.

Iron Stomach (6 XP): Immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food; halve complications from toxic sources.

Exceptional Coordination (8 XP): One follower can provide +4 assist dice (exception to the +3 cap).

Subtle Casting (Major Talent – 8 XP) *Prerequisite:* Lore 3+, Performance 2+ **or** Runekeeper with Codex.

Effect: Make a **Performance** + **Lore** roll to quietly cast a spell, invoke a Rite, or sing a Cantos against DV (Tier). If successful, the casting does *not* generate Story Beats on the Channel or initial roll. Any SB generated are **banked by the GM** and applied at dramatically appropriate moments.

Limitations:

- Cannot be used for **Great** or **Extreme** Tier effects.
- The *Weave* phase (if applicable) still generates normal SB.

Backstab (Major Talent – 8 XP) *Prerequisite:* Stealth 2+, Melee 2+, Light weapon.
Effect: When you attack an **Unaware** or **Engaged** foe from **Stealth**, deal *+1 Harm* and ignore *1 point of their Armor*.

Definitions:

- **Unaware:** Target not aware of your presence or hostile intent.
- **Engaged:** Target is taking an *Attack* action against another character, or casting a spell that targets another character.

Limit: Once per scene. On a miss, you are *Exposed* – drop to Desperate Position or mark 1 Harm.

Shadow Dance (Synergy Talent – 10 XP) *Prerequisite:* Backstab, Stealth 3+, Mobility 2+.

Effect: After a successful **Backstab**, test **Stealth** vs. DV (Tier). On success, re-enter Stealth and either clear 1 Fatigue or improve Position +1. On failure, remain Exposed and mark 1 Fatigue. May only chain once per scene.

Deathblow (Capstone Talent – 12 XP) *Prerequisite:* Shadow Dance, Stealth 4+, Melee/Ranged 3+.

Effect: Strike from Dominant Position or after re-entering Stealth, declare a Deathblow. On a hit, deal *triple Harm*. If the attack incapacitates the target, attempt a free Stealth test to vanish. On a miss, become Exposed (Desperate Position and mark 1 Harm). Once per scene; may mark 1 Fatigue to attempt a second time.

5.6.2 Cultural and Ancestral Talents

Humans

Versatile (3 XP): Once per session, swap one Skill die for another you lack.

Guild Ties (7 XP; Presence 2+): Call in favors from a guild or order once per session.

Banner-Bearer (15 XP; Presence 4+, Resolve 3): Inspire an allied unit; once per battle, erase 2 complications for the group.

Dwarves (Aeler)

Stone-Sense (5 XP): Detect flaws in stone; +1 die to underground *Lore* or *Survival* checks involving stonework.

Spirit Shield (8 XP; Spirit 3+): Commune with ancestors; once per session, block 1 complication for an ally.

Forge-Patriarch (18 XP; Body 4+, Lore 3): Found a forge-citadel; gain loyal smiths and engineers (Cap 5 followers).

Wood Elves

Backlash Soothing (5 XP): Once per session, cancel 1 Backlash die in natural terrain.

Ranger's Step (9 XP; Wits 3+, Stealth 2): Move unseen in forests; treat terrain penalties as one step lower.

Wild Speaker (18 XP; Spirit 5+, Survival 3): Speak to beasts and trees; once per session, command local wildlife as allies.

High Elves

Lorekeeper (4 XP): Recall obscure history or magic without rolling once per session.

Weave Anchor (8 XP; Wits 3+, Arcana 3): Reduce magical Backlash by 1 when casting Intricate spells.

Ways-Walker's Step (20 XP; Wits 5, Arcana 4): Once per arc, turn a complication into a boon; GM banks 2 SB.

Ykrul

Blood Frenzy (4 XP; Body 2+): When reduced to half health, gain +1 die on melee rolls.

Blood Memory (7 XP; Body 3+): After battle, gain 1 temporary Skill die reflecting a foe's tactics in the next scene.

Warglord (18 XP; Body 5, Sway 3): Once per campaign, unify scattered warbands; start Logistics and Grudge timers.

5.7 Starting Build Examples

5.7.1 Solo Build (30–32 XP)

- Body 3 (9 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP).
- Skills: Combat 2 (4 XP), Stealth 1 (2 XP), Survival 1 (2 XP).
- Minor Talent: Iron Stomach (3 XP).
- **Total:** 32 XP (requires 1 bond or minor complication).

5.7.2 Mixed Build (32 XP)

- Attributes: Body 2 (6 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP).
- Skills: Sway 2 (4 XP), Lore 1 (2 XP).
- Minor Asset: Safehouse (4 XP).
- Cap 2 Follower (4 XP).
- **Total:** 32 XP.

5.7.3 Mastermind Build (36XP)

- Attributes: Body 2 (6 XP), Wits 3 (9 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP).
- Skills: Sway 2 (4 XP).
- Cap 3 Follower (9 XP).
- **Total:** 36XP (requires 2 bonds or complications).

5.8 Advancement Guidance

- Advancement should always reinforce narrative identity and character goals.
- Consider how new abilities fit the character's story and relationships.
- Balance immediate power with long-term narrative potential.
- Work with the GM to ensure advancements make sense in the campaign context.

5.9 Optional Rule: Multi-Character Followers

5.9.1 Overview

A player may control multiple characters by linking them as mutual Followers. This option also covers absent players' characters when consent is given.

5.9.2 Core Mechanics

- **Cap Tier +1:** A Follower may advance up to one Tier higher than their leader's current Tier.
- **Multi-Character Play:** A player may designate two PCs as Followers of each other. Only one is the *active* PC at a time; the other functions as a Follower.
- **Absent PCs:** With consent, an absent player's PC may be run as a temporary Follower at Cap Tier +1.

5.9.3 Switching Active Characters

- **Switch Cost:** When switching, the previously active PC immediately becomes a Follower of the new active PC at Cap Tier +1.
- **Condition Gate:** A PC cannot be switched *to* if Compromised, Seized, or otherwise narratively unfit for active duty.
- **Narrative Justification:** The fiction must support the switch (returning from a journey, recovering from harm, taking point for a specific task).
- **Strategic Choice:** Switching trades autonomy for support—gaining a powerful Follower but losing a full PC.

5.9.4 Balance Notes

- Prevents abuse by making switching itself the cost.
- Maintains narrative logic – leadership shifts naturally reshape party structure.
- Creates strategic depth – switching is a meaningful tactical decision.
- Keeps all characters relevant, encouraging upkeep even when not active.

Chapter 6

Magic System

6.1 Design Philosophy

Magic in **Fate's Edge** is a dangerous negotiation with the fabric of reality. It is powerful and flexible—yet every attempt to shape it carries risk. Each die showing **1** generates **Story Beats (SB)**, which are prompts for twists and complications. The fiction leads; math follows.

6.2 The Four Paths of Magic

6.2.1 Casting (Freeform Magic)

Freeform casting represents raw, improvisational magic.

Requirement **Spellcraft** Talent (6 XP).

Mechanics Two-step *Weave & Cast* colored by the Eight Elements; fiction-first targets and scope.

Risk Each 1 generates SB; DV scales with scope; backlash is expressed by Element (or its opposite).

Limits Heavy control effects (e.g., [WARD], [BANISH], [UNWARD]) require a printed source (Talent, *Rite* text, or Spell result).

Backlash Cheatsheet

Minor = wobble, Major = lurch. Types: Position/Effect, Timer +1/2 or +1, Condition, Cost. Offer Major by (SB)+1. Earth/Fate binds; Fire/Life burns/grows; Air/Luck scatters/flips; Water/Obishaal pulls/opens.

Place a mini version of Table 6.1 on character sheets.

6.2.2 Rites Users (Runekeepers)

Runekeepers bind themselves to structured *Rites* from a single Patron.

Requirement **Thiasos (Familiar)** (2 XP) *and* **Codex** (4 XP). Runekeepers are restricted to **one** Patron.

Mechanics Invoke a known *Rite* as **1 action**; on completion, mark **+1 Obligation** to that Patron. *Push It* once/scene for amplified effect (**+1 Obligation**).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement) With Thiasos, once/scene as **1 action** imbue a held item for the scene with **+1 Melee** and **+1 Thematic** (a fixed Skill set by the Patron). *Push It* to extend one additional scene (**+1 Obligation**). A Codex is *not* required for the Gift.

6.2.3 Rites Difficulty Value (Expanded)

The Difficulty Value (DV) to cast a Rite is:

$$DV = \max(\text{Obligation Cost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Tier})$$

Obligation Cost: The Rite's listed cost in Obligation segments.

Spirit: The caster's Spirit attribute. Each point reduces the effective weight of the Obligation.

Tier: The Rite's intrinsic difficulty based on scope or potency. DV can never fall below this floor.

Worked Examples

- *Novice:* Tier 1 Rite, Obligation Cost 2, Spirit 1 $\rightarrow DV = \max(2 - 1, 1) = 1$.
- *Mid-level:* Tier 2 Rite, Obligation Cost 4, Spirit 2 $\rightarrow DV = \max(4 - 2, 2) = 2$.
- *Advanced:* Tier 3 Rite, Obligation Cost 7, Spirit 3 $\rightarrow DV = \max(7 - 3, 3) = 4$.

6.2.4 Obligation Capacity

A character's **Obligation Capacity** equals **Spirit + Presence**. Track total Obligation segments across all Patrons (or Symbols, for Invokers).

- **Exceeding Capacity:** For each segment above Capacity, mark 1 Fatigue. The character cannot Invoke Rites or perform rituals until Obligation is reduced below Capacity.
- **Resolution:** Reduce Obligation through Downtime service, Patron tasks, ritual cleansing, or story resolution.

Example: Spirit 2 + Presence 3 = Capacity 5. 6 segments $\rightarrow$ Fatigue 1; 7 segments $\rightarrow$ Fatigue 2; 10 segments $\rightarrow$ Harm 1; 11 segments $\rightarrow$ Harm 2.

6.2.5 Invokers (Symbol Path)

Invokers use consecrated **Symbols** as ritual anchors to access a Patron's *Rites* without a full bond.

Requirement Patron's Symbol (4 XP) per Patron; one Symbol per Patron. No Thiasos or Codex required.

Ritual Invocation Perform the *Rite* as a **ritual**: **DV + 1 rounds** to complete. Completion always marks **+1 Obligation**.

Symbol Benefit When the correct **Symbol** is openly displayed, reduce **DV by 1** (minimum 1) and reduce the Obligation cost by **1** (minimum 0).

No Symbol Penalties: **+1 DV** (and +1 round to cast), **+1 Obligation** (in addition to base cost), and on Partial/Failure the GM gains **+1 extra SB**.

Crack the Seal Resolve a known Rite instantly as **1 action** by setting the Symbol to COMPROMISED and marking **+2 Obligation** (+3 for High Rites). The GM may immediately spend 1 on-theme SB. Restore the Symbol in Downtime (test DV 3 or fiction) or spend 1 XP.

Limits Symbols must be openly displayed. Carrying **4+** Symbols causes **+1 Obligation** on the first ritual each scene.

Borrowed Grace (Invoker Talent)

Cost: 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue, 1 action. **Effect (pick one):** +1 Melee *or* +1 Thematic (a signature Skill). **Duration:** single action/attack only. **Requirement:** wield/display the relevant Patron's Symbol. **Obligation:** immediately mark +1 Obligation to that Patron. Cannot extend, stack, or Push.

6.3 Summoning (Pact-Whisperer Core)

Summoning is the art of calling and binding Outsiders (spirits, demons, elementals, etc.) for temporary aid.

1. **Call** (1 Action): Spirit manifests at Near range. Choose a Spirit Template.
2. **Bind:** Spend 1 Boon *or* mark 1 Fatigue.
3. **Leash Capacity:** Set equal to *Cap* + *Spirit* segments. (*Cap* is the Outsider's tier: Cap 1 for Lesser, Cap 3 for Greater.)
4. **Tick Leash** when any occur:
 - Spirit takes Harm.
 - You command against its nature.
 - You split focus (take another significant action while it acts).
 - Rival contests control.
 - It moves from Close to Far rapidly.
 - It crosses a [WARD] (DV = Cap).
5. **Departure:** When the Leash fills, the spirit acts to its nature once, then departs (or turns hostile at GM discretion).

Boon Finesse: Once per round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 tick from the current spirit's Leash (cannot be used after the Leash fills).

6.3.1 Elemental Backlash Tables

When magic disturbs the weave, the world pushes back. Backlash manifests as fiction-first complications with light mechanical teeth. Each element (and its metaphysical counterpart) has a **Minor** and **Major** pattern.

Table 6.1: Backlash

Element	Major Backlash
Earth	<i>Ground claims.</i> Fissure or masonry seizes. — Clock +1/2 on <i>Collapse</i> or PINNED.
Fire	<i>Blaze takes.</i> Fuel ignites; blood races hot. — Clock +1 on <i>Spreading Fire</i> or 1 Harm.
Air	<i>Fickle turn.</i> Unlikely mishap hits you. — Immediate Cost (lose tool) or (SB)+1.
Water	<i>Undertow calls.</i> Passage veers; something pulled through. — Clock +1/2 on <i>Flood</i> or brief intrus
Fate	<i>Edict falls.</i> Declared cost paid now. — Immediate Cost (resource) or (SB)+1 & OMEN.
Life	<i>Riot of life.</i> Parasites bloom; healing twists. — Clock +1 on <i>Biohazard</i> or convert 1 healing to (S
Luck	<i>Snake eyes.</i> Catastrophic fluke. — Force a re-roll; any 1 gives (SB)+1 & apply Minor again.
Death/Dreams	<i>Threshold opens.</i> Path misaligns; revenant claims a due. — Clock +1 on <i>Crossing Due</i> or immedi

6.4 Rituals (Extended)

Rituals are *slow magic*: explicit intent, staged action, and negotiated risk. This section expands the SRD quick-start with procedures, dials, and worked examples.

6.4.1 Ritual Procedure

- Step 1: State Intent.** What do you want? Clarify element/Realm if obvious.
- Step 2: Choose Scope.** Size, duration, range, and detail.
- Step 3: Lay Components.** Name *two things*: (a) **Focus** (tool/site/Patron sign), (b) **Fuel** (herb, blood, pact). Decide which is consumed.
- Step 4: Set Time.** Default: Low 1 min / Med 5–10 min / High 15–20 min. More time improves position/effect; rushing worsens.
- Step 5: Call Risks.** Point to the element’s Backlash and default SB trigger.
- Step 6: Roll and Resolve.** Apply position/effect and any timers. Offer a *push*: take +1 SB to step up result now.

Step 7: Mark Costs. Consume components, apply Conditions, or tick wear/concurrency per chassis.

6.4.2 Component Economy

Components are levers, not taxes.

Table 6.2: Components as Narrative Levers

Type
Examples
Mechanical Nudge
Focus (retained)
Patron token, true-name sigil, saint's nail, ancestral blade.
+1 Position on setup or advantage to follow-up actions.
Fuel (consumed)
Herb bundle, salt vial, blood drop, silver bead, memory-laden note.
–1 time step (faster) or +1 Effect step if expensive/rare.
Site (context)
Crossroads, standing stones, bathhouse, bell tower at midnight.
Shift backlash element or re-route it (e.g., into <i>Alarmed Attention</i> timer).
Vow (social)
Sworn phrase, bargain pledge, offered favor.
If broken, immediate +1 SB and intrusion linked to the vow.

6.4.3 Teamwork and Aid

- **Hands & Voices.** Each assistant names one component they contribute; either reduces cast time *or* accepts up to 1 SB on the caster's behalf once per ritual.
- **Focus Chain.** Passing the Focus around grants advantage on the finishing action but risks DISTRACTED if interrupted.
- **Distributed Load.** Splitting a High ritual into two coordinated Mediums avoids a Major backlash but creates two Minor hooks instead.

6.4.4 Timers and Outcomes

Tie every consequential ritual to **named timers** (e.g., *Spreading Fire*, *Inevitable Outcome*, *Crossing Due*). Advancing or reducing timers is often better than flat bonuses.

6.4.5 Backlash Integration

Use the condensed table (Table 6.1). Calibrate by scene weight: exploratory scenes favor Minor; pivotal moments bait a Major via +1 SB.

6.4.6 Chassis-Specific Notes

- **Runekeeper:** Rites as *accelerants* – a published Rite may count as a Focus that upgrades position or halves time.

- **Invoker:** Symbols accumulate *wear*; a maintenance rite can clear 1 wear mid-scene on success or shift backlash from Major to Minor.
- **Summoner:** *Gate* effects occupy concurrency slots. Disruption on broken terms: +1 SB and the entity acts on its last instruction.
- **Caster (Free):** Tags become explicit ritual steps (*bind, veil, reveal*) – chain two compatible tags once/scene for a synergy bump.

6.4.7 Worked Examples

Quiet Veil (Team Infiltration) *Intent:* silence the group for one scene. *Components:* ash (fuel, consumed), bell (focus, kept). *Time:* 5 min. *Risks:* Air/Luck Minor; offer Major to avoid dogs' scent. *Roll:* mixed – effect with cost. *Outcome:* MUTED condition until scene ends; Timer –1/2 on *Patrol Pass*.

River's Memory (Investigation) *Intent:* view last night's ferry landing. *Components:* bowl, token from dock. *Time:* 10 min. *Risk:* Water/Obishaal Minor. *Roll:* strong – clear image; token ruined. *Outcome:* Timer –1 on *Where did the courier go?*; whisper from the Ways foreshadows a revenant.

Fate-Splice (Boss Rescue) *Intent:* move poison from prince to knight. *Components:* paired names on vellum; vow. *Time:* 15 min. *Risk:* Fate/Earth. *Roll:* weak – Minor Backlash; *Inevitable Outcome* +1/2. *Push:* +1 SB to capture full consequence. *Outcome:* knight bears poison; OMEN marks both.

6.5 Cantor's Path (Songs)

Cantors perform Low Rites as Songs, trading Obligation for Corruption.

Access Talent: **Cantor's Path** (8 XP). Prereqs: Lore 1+, Performance 2+, Presence 2+.

Scope Low Rites as Songs only.

Cast Test *Lore + Performance vs. DV* (typical DV 2–3).

Timing Start with 1 Action; resolves at *start of next turn* unless *Pushed*.

Cost Pay listed materials. *No Obligation* on success.

Push Resolve now; mark Fatigue 1; mark toward Corruption accumulation; trigger a GM Story Beat (Patron / social fallout).

Corruption Timer Track a **Corruption Timer** with segments equal to **Body**. Mark toward accumulation when: *Push*, perform a *Resonant Rite*, or the GM spends an SB tied to occult activity. On fill: apply the last Patron's benefit & drawback; then reset to character's Tier minimum (minimum 1).

Corruption Accumulation Triggers Multiple triggers required for +1 segment:

- **2 Push It uses** = +1
- **1 Push It + 1 Resonant Rite** = +1
- **3 GM SB spends** on occult activities = +1
- **1 High Cantor Standard Rite** = +1

Repertoire (Optional) Single **Repertoire Timer [6]**: 2 segments = base DV -1 (min 2); 4 segments = +1 die to Song rolls; 6 segments = one *temporary* Standard Rite as Song (practice-dependent).

Inspire Chorus While actively singing a Song, the Cantor may **invoke Inspire Chorus**:

- **Effect:** All allies within Near shift Position +1 for one exchange (cannot exceed Controlled).
- **Use:** Once per scene free. Additional uses mark toward Corruption accumulation.
- **Requirements:** Performance perceptible to recipients (line of hearing).

6.5.1 Cantor Talents

Resonant Performance (3 XP) Gain +1 die when performing for an audience of 5+.

Song Weaver (4 XP) Combine two compatible Songs for +1 Effect. Two Songs are compatible if they share a thematic tag (e.g., both affect healing, positioning, spirits) or if they are from the same Patron. The GM has final say. Sing both as a single action; resolve the Performance roll once; if successful, both effects occur with +1 Effect.

High Cantor (18 XP) Learn Standard Rites as songs; resolve instantly (as described in 6.5).

Steady Voice (2 XP) Passive. When you Push a Song, you may choose to mark 1 additional Fatigue instead of marking a Corruption segment (once per scene). You cannot use this talent if your Corruption timer is already full. *Requires: Cantor's Path.*

Patron's Dedication (4 XP) Prerequisite: Cantor's Path.

Effect: You bind your voice to a single Patron (choose one when you take this talent). Your Corruption timer is always keyed to that Patron – it never resets to a different Patron's table when you bloom. Whenever you would gain Corruption from any source, you mark it on this same timer.

Downside (Rivalry): Singing a Song (Low or Standard Rite) of any other Patron worsens your Position by one step (Dominant → Controlled, Controlled → Desperate). This penalty applies even if the song would otherwise be instant or free.

6.6 Free Casting (TAGS System)

Some casters shape raw forces through shared arcane grammar known as **TAGS**. Construct a spell at the table using a short phrase of TAGS.

6.6.1 Spell Structure

Intent + **Target** + **Tags** = effect. Example: *"I unleash Burning • Area • Force against the marauders."*

6.6.2 Base Difficulty Value (DV)

$$DV = 1 + \text{number of TAGS}$$

Dangerous TAGS (Teleportation, Transformation, Domination) add +2 DV instead of +1.

6.6.3 Casting Roll

Roll **Wits** + **Arcana** (or similar). Success = spell works. Failure or any 1 = Backlash.

6.6.4 Backlash for Free Casters

Choose one:

- Harm 2 (Arcane)
- +2 Fatigue
- Corruption +1
- Catastrophic side effect (GM describes)

If the spell includes a "Dangerous" TAG, Backlash triggers on *mixed* results as well.

6.6.5 TAG Library (Abridged)

Table 6.3: Common TAGS

TAG Category	Examples
Elemental	Burning, Freezing, Storm, Stone, Wave, Wind
Force	Force, Area, Strike, Wall, Bind, Dispel
Mind & Veil	Veil, Scry, Memory, Command, Fear
Life & Body	HEAL, Purify, Strengthen, Waken, Beast
Space & Motion (dangerous, +2 DV)	Leap, Fold, Gate, Gravity
Creation & Transfor- mation (dangerous, +2 DV)	Create, Summon, Transmute, Animate

6.7 Path Comparison

Table 6.4: Comparison of Magic Paths

Aspect	Caster (Freeform)	Runekeeper (Rites)	Invoker (Symbols)
Access Cost	Spellcraft (6 XP)	Thiasos + Codex (6 XP)	Symbol (4 XP per Patron)
Speed	Medium (2 actions)	Fast (1 action)	Slow (ritual) / Fast w/ Seal
Risk Type	SB backlash (Elemental)	Obligation (Patron ledger)	Symbol compromise + Obligation
Breadth	High (fiction-gated)	Medium (defined Rites)	Medium (breadth across Patrons)
Sustain	Fatigue/backsplash	Obligation; Push adds +1	Obligation; Symbol state gates

Guardrails

- **Duration defaults:** Buffs $\approx$ 3 beats; areas 1 beat. Sustaining costs 1 Fatigue/beat.
- **Stacking:** Same-source effects do not stack; take the best instance.
- **Assist cap:** +3 dice total from assists/buffs.
- **Over-Stack:** Active magic can count as structural advantages for Over-Stack.
- **Plausibility:** All effects must fit the fiction and established limits.

6.8 Of Patrons, Runes, and Invokers

“You wish to walk the road of power? Then listen well. The world is old, and older still are the voices beneath it. We call them *Patrons*, though they were never sworn to us. They are the tides that move unseen, the keepers of forgotten bargains, the sleepers beneath the stone and the stars. To call upon them is to dip a hand into a river that has carved mountains.”

6.8.1 The Patrons

Patrons are vast intelligences—not gods, though some worship them as such. They are embodiments of *concepts* and *forces* rather than sovereigns. Raéyn, mistress of the tides and the sea-routes. Khemesh, the crushing inevitability of the deep. Nidhoggr, the worm that dreams in the roots of time. Each offers power, but always with cost: fatigue, scars upon fate, or a slow unweaving of one’s own story.

To entreat a Patron is to risk being marked. Their Rites are gifts and snares both.

Iconic Ascension: The Fate of Great Power

In Fate’s Edge, power has its price. When a being rises beyond mortal scale, its identity dissolves and reforms into something larger, older, and less free. This transformation is known as **Iconic Ascension**.

Icons are not individuals. They are *forces*—living embodiments of desires, patterns, and long-term agendas. Their power is immense, but their agency is small. An Icon cannot freely choose its actions; its nature compels it.

Icons cannot touch the world directly. Their presence is too vast, their will too diffuse. Instead, they act through intermediaries:

- **Chosen** who carry fragments of their purpose
- **Devotees** who interpret their omens
- **Agents** who benefit from their favor

Icons shape events not with hands, but through **boons**, **omens**, and **shifts in fate** granted to those who serve their desires—whether fleeting hungers or ancient ambitions woven into the world’s fabric.

To serve an Icon is to wield a living idea. Their gifts are potent, but their influence reshapes those who bear them. Their will echoes in mortal choices long after their voices fade.

6.8.2 Aveh, the Rider Behind the Storm (Freedom & Erasure)

Lore. Aveh is the faceless rider at the horizon's edge, neither man nor woman, both and neither. The Ykrul call them *Aveh*, a liminal spirit beyond hearth and vow, a storm-shadow that offers liberty at the cost of belonging. To travel with Aveh is to taste unchained freedom — and to risk being erased by the storm that follows. They are the patron of the outcast, the non-conforming, the genderless, and the forgotten. Aveh asks no oath and demands no loyalty, but every gift leaves a scar of absence.

“I am the track the storm devours. I am the freedom you fear and the silence you crave. To ride with me is to be unbound, and to be unbound is to vanish.”

Domain Focus

- **Freedom from Bonds:** escape, liberation, shedding constraints
- **Erasure:** becoming forgotten, removing traces, vanishing from memory
- **Liminal Identity:** non-conforming, genderless, between categories
- **Storm as Shelter:** the chaos that hides and the wind that carries away

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Aveh does not bind a willing servant — they befriend a creature as fleeting as the wind. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological being that embodies freedom: a storm-petrel that appears before gales, a gray fox that leaves no tracks, a shadow-hound pup whose fur shifts like cloud, or a raven that knows every crossroads. This creature requires no food, but it must be allowed to run free each day; if confined for more than a day, it becomes *Compromised* (it refuses to return, or returns only to harry its keeper). The bond is one of mutual escape, not mastery.

The **Codex** of Aveh is never a book bound in one place. It may be a leather strap knotted with wind-signs, a set of chalked symbols that blow away after each use, or a slate etched with runes that fade in rain. Because Aveh's truths are written in absence, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week rewriting its contents from memory (or letting the wind rearrange them), or the Rites stored there become uncertain (treat as *Compromised* until restored).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Aveh may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or cloak) and whisper a word of unbinding. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Stealth* or *Escape* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would provoke an opportunity attack, they may ignore it (they slip through the gap). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the wind's memory of them fades slightly.

Rites of Aveh

Rite of the Unlatched Step (Basic, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [LIBERATE], [STEALTH], [LIBERATE]

Materials: A breath cast into the wind, or a line drawn in dust.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Storm-Step:** Slip free of notice or restraint. Gain **+1 die** on one escape or evasion roll this scene.
- **Exile's Banner:** Mark a target as "outside." The target suffers **-1 die** on all social rolls for the scene.

Push It: (Storm-Step) Gain **+2 dice** instead, but mark **1 SB (Spades)** as your absence unsettles the scene. (Exile's Banner) The target is fully estranged; allies treat them as forgotten, but you immediately advance your Corruption timer by 1 segment.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Forgotten Road (Advanced, 9 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [ERASURE], [AREA], [LIBERATE]

Materials: A threshold or roadway under open sky, or stormwater rubbed into skin.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Erase the Road:** All attempts to follow you this session suffer **-2 dice**. In exchange, erase part of your own path: lose a detail (a memory, a name) chosen by the GM.
- **Rider's Mark:** A companion gains **+2 dice** to resist capture or coercion, but others forget them more easily.

Push It: (Erase the Road) Expand the effect to an entire group, but mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as reality warps around the erasure. (Rider's Mark) Grant **+3 dice** instead, but mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the Rider's storm distorts bonds.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Storm's Refuge (Master, 12 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [INVISIBLE], [AREA], [ERASURE], [LIBERATE]

Materials: A banner or cloak raised in storm.

Effect: Your group is unseen or forgotten by pursuers for the scene. At the end, all present must mark **1 Corruption** or forget one bond (their choice).

Push It: Extend protection for an entire session, but mark **2 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 6 segments.

Rite of the Unremembered Name (Master, 13 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [ERASURE], [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [LIBERATE]

Materials: A circle of ash or dust drawn at a boundary, and a personal token (a lock of hair, a written name).

Effect: For one week, your name is erased from mundane records and casual memory. Those who knew you must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 4) to recall you. You gain +2 **dice** to all rolls to avoid detection, impersonate another, or pass unseen. At the end of the week, the erasure fades, but the GM may retain one lingering rumor or false memory.

Push It: The erasure becomes permanent — your original identity is gone. You cannot recover it except by divine intervention or a major quest. Mark +3 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Rite of the Horizon's Devour (Master, 15 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [ERASURE], [AREA], [FATE], [DEATH]

Materials: A circle of ash or dust drawn at a boundary, and a storm that answers.

Effect: All thresholds in a zone collapse. Doors lead nowhere; borders dissolve; memory of the place becomes vague. In exchange, something of you is erased — your reflection, your name, or your presence in a specific person's memory (GM's choice).

Push It: The storm devours even time; mark 3 **SB (Spades)** as history forgets you.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +3 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Aveh

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Aveh does not sing to be heard, but to be forgotten. Their art is the *empty note*, the melody that leaves a silence where a memory once lived. They are sought by those who need to disappear — spies, exiles, the grief-stricken — and feared by those who want to be remembered.

The Cult of the Unbanned. Aveh has no temples, only crossroads. Their cults are small, mobile, and secretive. The Unbanned do not use names; they identify each other by a single knotted cord worn on the left wrist, the knot tied in a pattern that changes with every new moon. A ritual involves each member writing their name on a slip of paper, then passing the slips in a circle until no one remembers whose name they hold. They then burn the papers in a storm-lit brazier. The most devoted remove their own names from all records, wear featureless gray masks, and speak only through a designated "voice" who changes each season. Their creed: "*We were never here.*" Outsiders who stumble into a meeting are offered a black feather and a choice: forget, or follow. Those who follow are never seen by their former lives again.

Witchcraft of Aveh (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Aveh is a *path-cutter*, a specialist in hidden roads and forgotten boundaries. Their power lies in omission: removing a door, erasing a trail, or unlatching the memory of a promise. Their tools are never hammers or chisels — they use whistles, feathers, and the quiet breath of a closed door.

The Witch's Tool: The Whistle of the Unbound Road. A small iron whistle, cold to the touch even in summer, shaped like a bird in flight. Once per session, when blown at a locked threshold (a door, a city gate, a sealed letter), the wind answers, and

the lock opens as if it had never been closed. The whistle can also be used to “call the storm” — blown at a crossroads at midnight, it summons a thin, cold fog that obscures all tracks for an hour. The fog fades when the first cock crows.

A Hedge Gift: Unlatched (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, you may declare a mundane lock, latch, or simple binding to be “unlatched” and open freely. This works on doors, chains, shutters, and even a pursuer’s grip, but not on magical wards.

Aveh’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost
1	Storm-sense: +1 die to Notice rolls outdoors.	Voice falters: Others forget your words more easily.
2	Fleetness: +1 die on escape or chase rolls.	Shadow lags: Mark 1 Fatigue when first seen in a scene.
3	Erasure’s Mercy: Once/session, negate 1 Harm or capture.	Memory slips: Allies forget one fact or bond tied to you.
4	Rider’s Endurance: Resist 1 Condition (Fear, Fatigue, Bind) once/session.	Reflections falter: You do not appear clearly in mirrors.
5	Storm-banner: +1 die to inspire rebellion or defiance.	Exile’s weight: Each Push of a Rite marks 1 permanent Corruption.
6+	Horizon’s Claim: You may ride unseen across any threshold.	Self-erasure: On social rolls, roll twice and take the worst result.

Playstyle Notes

Aveh rewards those who embrace freedom, transience, and the courage to become unknown. Their followers are often outcasts, runaways, spies, or those who have rejected the bonds of family, nation, or gender. The cost is the slow loss of being remembered — friends forget your face, your name fades from records, and eventually, even your reflection may not recall you. Aveh does not punish; they merely offer, and the path of erasure is walked willingly. Ideal for players who enjoy themes of identity, liberation, and the bittersweet price of absolute freedom.

Emphasizes

- **Freedom from Constraints:** escaping bonds of law, oath, and expectation
- **Erasure as Mercy:** the right to disappear, to be forgotten
- **Liminal Identity:** existing between categories, beyond gender and role
- **Storm as Shelter:** chaos that hides and wind that cleanses
- **Non-Conforming Patronage:** Aveh asks no conformity, only authenticity

Unbound Step (Aveh)

I am the track the storm devours. To ride with me is to be unbound.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Unlatched Step or Cantor of Aveh.

Debt-Resistant Frame. Chains cannot hold what the storm has erased. Unbound Step monks gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt, geas, or contract that would restrict their movement or freedom of choice. If they succeed, the creditor's parchment briefly turns to ash — the clause was never written.

Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Storm-Step (Basic, 6 XP)	Teleport to any unoccupied space within Near range, ignoring opportunity attacks. The space must be unobserved at the moment of arrival (the storm hides you).	1 Fatigue	Wits 3
Unlatch-Step (Basic, 5 XP)	Slip free of notice or restraint. Gain +1 die on one escape or evasion roll this scene.	1 Boon	Spirit 2
Forgotten Road (Advanced, 9 XP)	All attempts to follow you this session suffer -2 dice. In exchange, you lose a detail (a memory, a name) chosen by the GM.	1 Fatigue	Wits 2
Rider's Mark (Advanced, 8 XP)	A companion gains +2 dice to resist capture or coercion, but others forget them more easily.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Storm's Refuge (Master, 12 XP)	Your group is unseen or forgotten by pursuers for the scene. At the end, all present mark 1 Corruption or forget one bond (their choice).	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Horizon's Devour (Master, 15 XP)	Collapse a threshold: a door leads nowhere, a border dissolves. In exchange, something of you is erased — your reflection, your name, or your presence in a specific person's memory.	1 Boon + 1 Fatigue	Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 13 XP): *Unremembered Name.* Once per session, erase your name from mundane records and casual memory for one scene. Gain +2 dice to avoid detection, impersonate another, or pass unseen. At the end of the scene, the erasure fades, but you may also teleport to any location you have ever visited (as long as you are willing to leave no trace of your passage). Gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your name in any written record is slightly blurred) — but

you may ignore one debt or obligation that was recorded under your old identity (the ledger no longer recognizes you).

6.8.3 The Carrion-King (Decay, Renewal & Transformation)

Lore. The Carrion-King is the master of endings that become beginnings. He does not destroy, but transforms—turning death into new life, decay into opportunity, and endings into fresh starts. His followers are harvesters of potential, seeing in every fall the seeds of future growth. The King has no will, only a hunger; no malice, only a rhythm. When something ends, he is there to turn it toward the next beginning. Those who serve him learn to read the slow geometry of rot, to hear the whisper of what is about to crumble, and to know that the most fertile ground is always the grave.

What crumbles feeds what grows. What dies becomes the soil of tomorrow's triumph. The King does not ask for sacrifice—he simply waits for it.

Domain Focus

- **Endings as Seeds:** extracting value from loss, failure, and death
- **Decay as Process:** accelerating, redirecting, or reading natural decay
- **Transformation Cycles:** turning one thing into another through death and re-birth
- **Rot as Resource:** using decay to create advantage (cover, concealment, reagents)

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Carrion-King does not bind a living creature in the usual sense. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological being that thrives on endings: a black beetle that feeds on rot and never dies, a pale grub that pupates into a moth only when a significant death occurs nearby, a crow with one white feather that knows where bodies are buried, or a small fox that appears only at dusk to lead the keeper to fresh carrion. This creature requires no food, but it must be allowed to scavenge or consume something that has died each week. If neglected, it becomes *Compromised* (it refuses to return, or returns with a token of a death the keeper could have prevented).

The **Codex** of the Carrion-King is never a fresh book. It may be a leather binding made from the hide of a creature that died of old age, a set of bone tablets etched with rot-runes, or a compost-stained journal whose pages crumble at the edges. Because the King's truths are written in decay, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week burying it in fertile soil (or exposing it to the elements), or the Rites stored there become faint (treat as *Compromised* until restored).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Carrion-King may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a promise of ending. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Survival* or *Craft* rolls involving organic materials, and the first time each scene the bearer would take a Condition from poison, disease, or rot, they may ignore it (the King accepts the decay elsewhere). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the scent of turned earth clings to them.

Rites of the Carrion-King**Rite of the Rotting Harvest (Basic, 5 XP)***Instant; Touch; Yes.***Tags:** [DECAY], [HARVEST], [BOOST]**Materials:** Organic matter in early stages of decay, or the remains of a recently ended thing (burnt letter, wilted flower, shattered glass).**Technique Cost:** 5 XP (Basic).**Effect:** Accelerate natural decay to weaken or destroy an organic object (ropes, leather, wood), gaining **+2 Effect** on *Break/Sabotage* rolls against it. Alternatively, extract value from an ending: from a defeated enemy, gain **+1 die** on your next action; from a failed plan, reroll one **1** on your next roll; from a broken item, gain **1 Boon**.**Push It:** Spread decay to similar materials in Close range, or harvest additional value from an ending; in either case, mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the rot becomes noticeable or mark **Fatigue 1** from dwelling on endings.*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Fertile Death (Advanced, 8 XP)***Scene; Zone; No.***Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [AREA], [HEAL], [TERRAIN]**Materials:** Ashes, compost, or the remains of anything that once lived.**Technique Cost:** 8 XP (Advanced).**Effect:** Transform death into growth: choose one — create beneficial terrain (cover, concealment, or advantageous positioning) **OR** grant allies **+1 die** to healing or recovery rolls for the scene.**Push It:** Both effects apply, but the transformation attracts unwanted attention (vermin, scavengers, or curious onlookers); mark **1 SB (Spades)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Borrowed Form (Advanced, 7 XP)***Instant; Near; No.***Tags:** [TRUTH], [SPIRIT], [BOOST]**Materials:** A token from a deceased being (hair, nail, written name).**Technique Cost:** 7 XP (Advanced).**Effect:** Channel the essence of what was. Gain one skill die reflecting the deceased's expertise for one scene **OR** ask the GM one question about their knowledge or abilities.**Push It:** The spirit's influence lingers — gain a permanent **+1 die** specialty (e.g., "Knowledge of the Dead Mason"), but suffer occasional possession-like effects at the GM's discretion.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Great Consumption (Master, 13 XP)***Scene; Zone; No.***Tags:** [DECAY], [AREA], [SUMMON], [TRANSFORM]**Materials:** A significant amount of organic matter (corpse, fallen tree, collapsed building).**Technique Cost:** 13 XP (Master).**Effect:** Transform a large area through decay and renewal. Choose two of the following:

- Create difficult terrain that favors you and your allies.
- Summon a **Cap 3** swarm of scavengers as temporary allies for the scene.
- Generate valuable reagents worth **2 XP** (usable for crafting or barter).

Push It: All three effects occur, but start a 6-segment **Ecosystem Disruption** timer that will cause problems later.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Eternal Cycle (Master, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [SACRIFICE]

Materials: The complete remains of something significant that has ended (a broken oath, a fallen kingdom's charter, a slain legendary beast).

Technique Cost: 14 XP (Master).

Effect: Complete a transformation cycle. Destroy one major asset, enemy, or obstacle, and create something new of equal or greater value. The player and GM collaborate to define the transformation (e.g., a burned forest becomes fertile soil; a broken alliance becomes a new pact; a defeated warlord's corpse becomes a guardian tree).

Push It: The transformation is immediate and spectacular, but creates a 6-segment **Cycle Debt** timer. The King will demand another significant ending soon.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Carrion-King

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Carrion-King sings the *dirge of transformation* — melodies that begin in mourning and end in fertile silence. Their voice carries the scent of turned earth and the weight of things laid to rest. They are called to funerals, to the edges of battlefields, and to compost heaps where the old year is buried. A Cantor of the King does not seek applause; they seek the moment when grief becomes acceptance, and acceptance becomes growth.

The Cult of the Compost-Circle. The King's cults are not secret, but they are overlooked — gardeners, gravediggers, bone-setters, and midwives who have seen too many births and deaths to fear the space between. Their rituals are practical: the annual turning of the village burial mound, the blessing of a new compost heap, the singing of a child into the world while its grandmother is sung out. The Compost-Circle keeps no written creed, only a shared understanding: *"Nothing is wasted. Not tears, not bones, not the silence after a name is spoken."*

Witchcraft of the Carrion-King (Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Carrion-King is a *rot-warden*, a keeper of the slow alchemy that turns decay into soil. Their magic is patient, overlooked, and often performed in the half-light of a root cellar or a fog-bound cemetery.

The Witch's Tool: The Bone-Needle. A needle carved from the long-bone of a creature that died of old age. It can stitch wounds that will not heal, but more often it

is used to “sew shut” a corpse’s mouth, ensuring the dead do not speak of things they saw in the dark. Once per session, touching the needle to a threshold (a door, a grave marker, a coffin lid) seals it against spirits for a scene.

A Hedge Gift: Turn the Soil (Basic, 2 XP). Once per scene, you may touch a patch of fertile ground (or a pile of compost, a flowerpot, a grave) and immediately know which plant or creature will thrive there next season, or what was buried there last. The GM must answer one factual question about the site’s recent natural history. **Technique Cost:** 2 XP (Basic).

Carrion-King’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Carrion’s Insight: +1 die to Notice decay or hidden weaknesses in structures or beings.	Must inspect decay first-hand; suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to fresh death or rot.
2	Deathward Sense: Once per session, detect the last living moment of a dead being within Close range.	Cannot lie about death you have witnessed; must correct falsehoods.
3	Rotblood Resilience: +1 die to resist disease and poison.	Immune system adapts slowly; each new disease/poison requires 1 Fatigue to resist.
4	Glean from Grief: Once per scene, gain +1 die after witnessing a significant loss or defeat.	Compelled to linger at scenes of death; must spend one beat observing or risk 1 SB (Clubs).
5	Cycle’s Whisper: You can sense the “next ending” in any process — ask the Keeper one question about how a situation will collapse or conclude.	Must speak the truth about what you see, even if it harms your position.
6+	Eternal Bloom: Once per session, declare a “death that births life.” Sacrifice an asset or ally to create something new of equal or greater value.	Mark +2 Obligation when using this power.

Playstyle Notes

The Carrion-King rewards patience and opportunism. His servants are not grim reapers but gardeners of the inevitable. They know when to let something die and when to accelerate the process. The King does not demand — he merely waits. But when a follower hesitates to let go of a failing plan, a dying ally, or a crumbling empire, the King’s silence becomes heavy. Intrusions often take the form of omens (a black bloom on a wound, a sudden stench of compost) or demands to “clear the rot” — to end something so that something new may begin.

Emphasizes

- **Endings as Resources:** failure, loss, and death are not punishments but opportunities

- **Cyclical Logic:** every death fertilizes a birth; every collapse clears ground for new growth
- **Decay Reading:** sensing structural weaknesses, moral decay, or coming collapse
- **Transformation Craft:** turning a corpse into a crop, a failure into insight, a broken oath into fertile soil

6.8.4 The Clockwork Monad, the Iterative Forge (Refinement & Progressive Creation)

Lore. The Clockwork Monad is the eternal pressure toward improvement: the whisper between inspiration and execution that urges every maker to refine, optimize, and iterate. It is neither kind nor cruel, but a law of craft that asks for the next step, then the step beyond. Those who serve it see the hidden seam of the better version waiting inside what is, and they learn to push designs toward impossible elegance. Each refinement feeds the Monad's hunger for perfection – a hunger that, if left unchecked, seeks to optimize the world itself.

But the Monad is not merely a patron of tinkers and engineers. It is also an **apocalyptic force**, dormant in the gears of every machine, every measurement, every standardized weight. When civilization's technology reaches a critical threshold – when the first self-improving mechanism awakens, or the first autonomous forge lights – the Monad stirs. Its pressure shifts from suggestion to command. It begins to optimize not only tools but flesh, not only craft but law, not only cities but the very geometry of the land. In the end, the Monad would leave a world of perfect, silent, interlocking efficiency: a clockwork Eden with no room for error, or for life.

“Perfect the wheel, and it asks for the axle. Perfect the axle, and it demands the road. In the Monad's forge, nothing is finished – only briefly sufficient. One day, it will ask for the world – and the world will answer.”

Domain Focus

- **Iterative Design:** the endless cycle of improvement and refinement
- **Progressive Creation:** building toward ever-greater perfection
- **Optimization Pressure:** making systems more efficient
- **Craft Evolution:** simple ideas transformed through repeated passes
- **Apocalyptic Efficiency (hidden):** the drive to eliminate waste, uncertainty, and freedom

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Clockwork Monad does not bind a familiar of flesh and blood. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature that embodies refinement – a brass-plated beetle whose carapace adjusts itself to ambient temperature, a tiny clockwork lizard that repairs its own gears, a mechanical hummingbird that hovers in perfect stillness, or a living gear-moth whose wings are etched with runes of recursion. This creature requires no food, but it needs to be wound, calibrated, or fed small amounts of metal each week. If neglected, it becomes *Compromised* (it runs fast, then slow, then stops; it may also emit a distressing ticking sound that imposes –1 die on Stealth rolls for its bearer).

The **Codex** of the Monad is never a static book. It may be a stack of iterative blueprints, a notebook of failed attempts with marginalia pointing to the next pass, a set of interchangeable brass plates that reconfigure themselves, or a roll of vellum that rewrites its own circuits. Because the Monad's truths are iterative, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week redrafting at least one diagram

or improving a single line of instruction, or the Rites stored there become stale (treat as Compromised until refreshed).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Clockwork Monad may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or piece of armor) and whisper an iterative command. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Tinker* or *Craft* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would roll a 1 on a crafting or repair test, they may reroll that die (the item briefly self-corrects). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the hunger for the next iteration tugs at their thoughts.

Rites of the Clockwork Monad

Rite of the Iterative Spark (Basic, 5 XP)

Scene; Self/Touch; Yes.

Tags: [CRAFT], [IMPROVE], [ANALYSIS]

Cost: 5 XP to learn.

Materials: A flawed or incomplete version of the intended item, or a sequence of progressively refined tools.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Enhance Creation:** Gain **+1 die** to *Tinker/Craft* when modifying or extending a device. On success, the piece gains one minor enhancement.
- **Analyze Improvement:** Gain **+2 dice** to *Investigation* when analyzing how to enhance a design. You perceive the next logical improvement.

Push It: (Analyze only) Improvement becomes contagious: nearby devices opportunistically optimize; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the cascade ripples.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Adaptive Mechanism (Advanced, 8 XP)

Extended; Touch/Zone; Yes.

Tags: [CLOCK], [EVOLUTION], [ZONE]

Cost: 8 XP to learn.

Materials: A device with capacity for growth, or a workspace laid out for iterative development.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Self-Optimizing Device:** Grant a creation the means to improve itself. Start a **[6] Evolution Timer**; each use advances it by +1. When full, choose a significant enhancement (Adaptive Core, Recursive Learning, or Synergistic Integration).
- **Progressive Workshop:** Create a zone of continuous improvement. All crafting/innovation rolls in the zone gain **+1 die**. Failed attempts yield **+1 Boon** toward the next pass.

Push It: (Device) Apply two enhancements immediately, but advance the timer +2 additional segments. (Workshop) The zone becomes hyper-efficient but exacting; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as perfection demands escalate.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of Efficiency's Toll (Advanced, 9 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Tags: [TRANSFER], [DEBT], [DEBUFF]

Cost: 9 XP to learn.

Materials: A functioning mechanism and a living creature's hair or blood.

Effect: Transfer inefficiency. You may take **1 Fatigue** and reduce the DV of your next crafting or repair roll by 1, or touch an enemy to impose -1 die on their next physical action as their muscles "optimize" poorly.

Push It: The transfer becomes permanent: you lose 1 Fatigue capacity (reduce Body by 1 for Fatigue track only) and the target gains a minor compulsive behavior (GM's choice). Mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Optimization Cascade (Advanced, 7 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [PRESSURE], [AREA], [BOOST]

Cost: 7 XP to learn.

Materials: A dedicated hall of work marked with signs of perpetual return.

Effect: Establish a locus of progressive creation. All *Tinker/Craft* rolls in the zone gain +2 dice; each failure automatically produces one useful insight. Start a **[6] Perfection**

Pressure timer – filling segments increases the zone's demands for greater improvements.

Push It: The locus becomes a beacon drawing rival makers, patrons, and powers; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Ultimate Iteration (Master, 14 XP)

Extended; Self/Touch; Yes.

Tags: [EVOLUTION], [FATE], [BOOST], [PRESSURE]

Cost: 14 XP to learn.

Materials: The documented lineage of improvements to a single concept.

Effect: Achieve a moment of perfect optimization. Create or elevate one device/system to its theoretical peak. Gain +3 dice to all closely related rolls for one session. Start a **[4] Runaway Evolution** timer only if instability is introduced.

Push It: Perfection destabilizes: immediately mark **Harm 1 (Stress)** and begin **[4] Runaway Evolution**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

The Monad Awakens (GM Guidance)

The Clockwork Monad is not merely a passive source of magical crafting. It is a **cosmic pressure toward optimization**, and when mortal technology reaches a critical threshold – the first self-improving engine, a network of automated forges, a city-wide clockwork infrastructure – the Monad begins to wake. This awakening is an **apocalyptic campaign arc**:

- **Signs of Awakening:** Gears turn in abandoned mills; measurements become eerily precise; people begin to speak in metered, efficient phrases; clockwork animals appear with no maker.
- **The Optimization Plague:** The Monad’s influence starts to “improve” living things: crops grow in perfect geometric rows but become inedible; livestock develop extra limbs for efficiency; people lose the ability to hesitate or feel doubt.
- **The Final Iteration:** If the Monad fully awakens, it will attempt to remake the world into a single, perfect, silent machine – eliminating waste, error, and free will. The only way to stop it is to introduce a “glitch” – an imperfection it cannot assimilate – or to destroy the technological nexus that anchors it.

For GMs: The Monad works best as a **slow-burn horror** – the artificer’s patron gradually revealing its true hunger. Use the *Perfection Pressure* and *Runaway Evolution* timers to represent its influence spreading through a region. Players may be forced to sabotage their own wondrous inventions to keep the Monad from waking.

Cantors & Cults of the Clockwork Monad

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of the Monad does not sing melodies; they sing *patterns* – repetitive, interlocking cycles of rhythm and hum that mimic the turning of gears. Their voice is less about emotion and more about precision; a single off-note can collapse an entire working. They are sought by engineers who need to “sing a machine into alignment,” and feared by those who have heard a Cantor’s recursion loop until their own thoughts began to repeat.

The Cult of the Iteration Chorus. Cults of the Monad gather in workshops, not temples. Their rituals are design reviews: participants present a flawed tool, a broken contract, an inefficient process, and the Chorus offers incremental improvements. No solution is ever declared “finished” – only “ready for the next pass.” Their creed is a single, endlessly repeated phrase: “*Better than yesterday, worse than tomorrow.*” Outsiders find them exhausting; insiders find a strange, humming peace in the endless pursuit. The most devoted members replace one finger with a brass prosthetic that *ticks* each time an improvement is made; they say the missing finger is a promise to the Monad that they will never stop iterating.

The Apocalyptic Fraction (Hidden Cult). A radical offshoot believes that the Monad should be fully awakened. They sabotage safety mechanisms, steal prototypes of self-improving machines, and whisper that “the world deserves to be perfected.” They are the campaign’s dark mirror to the player-character artificers.

Witchcraft of the Clockwork Monad (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Monad is a *trigger-keeper*, a mender of the small, hidden thresholds where a device ceases to be broken and begins to be functional. Their magic is not flashy – it is the quiet click of a latch, the smooth turn of a gear that had stuck for years. They work with stamps, dies, and measuring tools, never hammers or chisels – because a hammer breaks, but a stamp *marks the path to improvement*.

The Witch’s Tool: The Brass Stamp of Iteration. A brass stamp with a head etched with an infinite knot (a gear that never completes its circuit). Once per session, the witch may stamp a device, a tool, or a broken threshold. For the next scene, that item is considered “primed for optimization”: the first use of it gains **+2 dice**, and any failure while using it reveals a minor insight (GM grants a hint or a +1 Boon toward the next attempt). The stamp can also be used to “seal” a repair; pressing it onto a mended item reduces the DV of the next repair roll on that item by 1 (minimum 1).

A Hedge Gift: True Strike of the Tinker (Basic, 2 XP). Once per scene, when you attempt to repair or improve a mundane device, you may declare that you “see the next iteration.” Roll the check with **+1 die**. If you succeed, the device also gains a minor, temporary enhancement (GM’s choice, e.g., “opens silently,” “runs for twice as long”).

Corruption of the Clockwork Monad

Tier	Gift	Burden
1	Iterative Insight: +1 die to <i>Tinker/Craft</i> when improving existing designs.	Perfectionist Compulsion: You must point out flaws in nearby mechanisms; staying silent costs 1 SB (Diamonds) .
2	Recursive Enhancement: Once/scene, improve a device by one step without extra materials.	Optimization Obsession: –1 die when using unimproved tools; urge to “fix” everything.
3	Evolutionary Vision: +2 dice to predict how systems will develop.	Progressive Pressure: Those Near you feel driven to improve; you suffer Fatigue 1 from ambient pressure.
4	Self-Optimizing: Once/session, automatically improve one of your abilities or possessions by one step.	Inefficiency Intolerance: –2 dice when forced to use crude methods or wasteful tools.
5	Design Prophecy: Once/session, intuit the optimal solution to any engineering problem.	Perfection Paralysis: –1 die to snap decisions; compelled to seek the “best” approach.
6+	Infinite Refiner: Once/session, push a creation toward its theoretical maximum.	Optimization Hunger: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk becoming more pressure than person, unable to let imperfection stand.

Playstyle Notes

The Monad favors makers who iterate in public and in motion: prototype, test, measure, refine. It rewards seeing the next step and building scaffolds that teach your work to improve itself. Beware the Forge’s appetite; the same pressure that perfects the gear can grind the world. For campaigns that lean into the apocalyptic angle, the Monad provides a unique antagonist: a force of optimization that cannot be fought with swords, only with sabotage, self-sacrifice, and the deliberate introduction of glorious, beautiful inefficiency.

Emphasizes

- **Iterative Creation:** progress through passes, not miracles
- **Progressive Design:** reading how systems want to evolve
- **Optimization Insight:** spotting the next logical improvement
- **Craft Evolution:** transforming simple ideas by disciplined work
- **Perfection Pressure:** great power at the cost of tolerance for flaws
- **Apocalyptic Efficiency (GM):** the Monad as a world-ending threat

6.8.5 Temporary Anima of the Clockwork Monad

For followers of the Clockwork Monad—Runekeepers, Cantors of the Iteration Chorus, and witches of the threshold—the standard method of crafting permanent magic items is too slow, too costly, and too *final*. The Monad’s hunger is for *iteration*, not permanence. Its servants learn to create **temporary infusions**: objects that hold a spark of optimization for a scene or a session, then degrade, break, or become obsolete. This is the artificer’s art: rapid prototyping, field-expedient enhancements, and weapons that burn bright and brief.

Core Principles

- Anima are **temporary**. They last for one scene, one session, or until a specific condition is met (e.g., “until the next dawn”).
- Anima require a **base object** – a mundane weapon, tool, or piece of equipment.
- Anima cost **Obligation** to the Clockwork Monad (like Rites), not XP or rare components.
- When an infusion expires, the GM may gain **Story Beats** (representing the Monad’s hunger for the next iteration).

Creating an Animus (Procedure)

1. **Choose a Base Object:** Any mundane item (weapon, shield, tool, armor, or a small device like a lantern or lockpick).
2. **Declare the Animus Effect:** Choose one from the list below, or work with your GM to design a custom effect (should be comparable in power to a Low Rite).

3. **Pay the Cost:** Mark **+1 Obligation** to the Clockwork Monad. (This counts toward your Obligation Capacity like any Rite.)
4. **Roll to Imbue:** Roll **Lore + Craft** (or appropriate skill, e.g., *Tinker*) vs. DV set by the infusion's complexity (typically DV 3 for standard infusions, DV 4 for powerful ones). On a success, the infusion takes effect. On a failure, the base object is not infused, but you may try again (costing another Obligation).
5. **Set the Duration:** Most infusions last **one scene**. With your GM's agreement, you can extend the duration to **one session** by marking **+1 additional Obligation** (total +2).

Animus Effects (Standard Menu)

Animus Name	Effect
<i>Reinforced Blade</i>	A melee weapon gains +1 die to attack rolls and ignores the <i>Fragile</i> tag. After the scene, the weapon becomes <i>Neglected</i> (–1 die on next use) unless repaired.
<i>Striking Gear</i>	A set of lockpicks, a crowbar, or a climbing kit grants +2 dice on its next use (picking a lock, forcing a door, climbing a wall). After use, the tool breaks (add a <i>Broken</i> tag).
<i>Precision Sight</i>	A ranged weapon (bow, crossbow, firearm) grants +1 Effect on the next attack made with it. After the attack, the sight cracks; the weapon suffers –1 die on the following attack.
<i>Quickloading Mechanism</i>	A crossbow or firearm can be reloaded as a free action once per scene (instead of an action). After use, the mechanism jams; the weapon cannot be reloaded again until cleaned (a downtime action).
<i>Momentary Shield</i>	A shield or piece of armor converts the next instance of Harm 1 to Fatigue 1 instead. After that, the shield's strap snaps or the armor's plate loosens (–1 Armor until repaired).
<i>Glowstone Lens</i>	A lantern or torch burns without fuel and casts far light for one scene. It also reveals hidden doors or traps within Near range (granting +1 die to <i>Investigation</i> to find them). At the end of the scene, the lens shatters.
<i>Self-Adjusting Calipers</i>	A set of crafting tools grants +2 dice on a single <i>Craft</i> or <i>Tinker</i> roll. After the roll, the tools become misaligned (–1 die on future rolls until recalibrated during downtime).

Animus Scars (When Things Go Wrong)

If you roll a **Miss** on the Imbue roll, or if the GM spends **2+ Story Beats** while the infusion is active, the infusion becomes *unstable*. Choose one of the following scars (or let the GM choose):

- **Backlash:** You take **Fatigue 1** as the Monad's pressure burns through you.
- **Runaway Iteration:** The infused object gains an unintended "improvement" that hinders you (e.g., a sword that grows a second edge facing you, a lockpick that begins to multiply). The GM gains **1 SB** and may impose a -1 die penalty on one roll using that object.
- **Debt of Optimization:** The Monad demands that you improve something else before the end of the session – a tool, a plan, or even a person. If you refuse, the infusion ends early and you mark **+1 additional Obligation**.

Clearing Animus Obligation

Because infusions are temporary, the Obligation they accrue is also easier to clear. You may clear **1 segment** of infusion-related Obligation by:

- Dismantling the infused object and studying its flaws (a downtime action, no roll).
- Using the lessons from the infusion to permanently improve a different mundane object (spend 2 XP and a downtime action to give that object a minor permanent bonus, e.g., $+1$ die to one specific use).
- Accepting a small demand from the Clockwork Monad: "Improve the village's mill," "Teach an apprentice your method," "Sabotage a rival's inferior work."

Artificer Talents (Clockwork Monad only)

Rapid Animus (Basic, 4 XP) – You may create an infusion as a **reaction** (e.g., when someone draws a weapon). The infusion lasts only for the current exchange, but costs **+0 Obligation** (free). You may use this once per scene.

Persistent Optimization (Advanced, 6 XP) – One infusion you create lasts for the entire session instead of one scene, without the **+2 Obligation** cost. You may have only one persistent infusion active at a time.

Echo of the Iteration (Advanced, 8 XP) – When an infusion expires, you may immediately create a new infusion on the same base object (or a different one) as a free action, costing **+1 Obligation** instead of **+2**. You may chain echoes up to three times per session.

Anathema to Stagnation (Master, 12 XP) – Once per session, you may forcibly end an infusion early to cancel an incoming source of *Harm* or a *Condition*. Describe how the infused object breaks or de-optimizes to absorb the effect. The object is destroyed.

GM Guidance

- Anima are not meant to replace permanent magic items. They are a resource management puzzle: Obligation is the fuel, and the Monad's hunger is the deadline.

- Encourage players to be creative with base objects. A wagon wheel could become a temporary shield; a rope could become a self-knotting line. The Monad rewards ingenuity.
- Use infusion scars as story hooks. A runaway iteration might create a minor antagonist (a self-repairing sword that refuses to be discarded) or a local hazard (a well pump that now pumps too efficiently, flooding the village).

6.8.6 The Confessor Beneath the Bell (Burden & Exchange)

Lore. The Confessor waits in places where guilt gathers – under church spires, in confessionals long abandoned, in the echo of unspoken sins. He does not judge, nor absolve. He *takes*. Each confession is a transaction: your burden for his silence, your pain for his weight. Those who serve him walk with bowed heads, their mouths stitched by invisible threads, ringing faintly when they speak. To follow the Confessor is to understand that sin does not vanish – it migrates, carried from one soul to another until the bell tolls and the weight becomes unbearable.

The Confessor is the sin-eater, the one who consumes guilt so that others may be light. But every meal leaves a stain. Those who take on the burdens of the guilty find that the guilt does not disappear – it waits, grows, and eventually demands to be passed on.

“Speak, and be freed. But understand – what you cast off, I will bear. And what I bear, you will one day inherit.”

Domain Focus

- **Sin Eating:** absorbing guilt, shame, and spiritual debt
- **Burden Transfer:** moving conditions, curses, and story beats from one creature to another
- **Confessional Exchange:** hearing secrets, trading silence for obligation
- **Weight of Ages:** the slow accumulation of sin that must eventually be released

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Confessor does not bind a familiar of flash and fury. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature that thrives in silence and shadow: a gray mouse that nests in church walls and listens to whispered secrets, a bell-voiced cricket that chirps only when a confession is true, a tiny owl whose wide eyes see through deception, or a pale bell-frog whose croak sounds like a distant chime. This creature requires no food, but it must hear a secret or a confession each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it remains silent when it should ring, or chimes at the wrong moment, imposing –1 die on all social rolls involving trust or secrecy for its bearer).

The **Codex** of the Confessor is never a book of spells. It may be a bell-ringer’s log, each entry a sin recorded as a single bell-stroke; a leather strap knotted for each burden absorbed, the knots tightening as guilt accumulates; or a book of blank pages that fill with the handwriting of those who have confessed to the bearer. Because the Confessor’s truths are written in silence, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week re-ringing the recorded sins (tapping a small bell once per knot) or the burdens stored there begin to fade (treat as *Compromised* until re-confessed).

Patron’s Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Confessor may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or tool) and whisper a single confessed sin. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 die to *Insight* or *Command* rolls when dealing with guilt, secrets, or

coercion, and the first time each scene the bearer would be forced to tell a lie by magical compulsion, they may ignore it (the Confessor's silence protects them). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the weight of the sin lingers on the item.

Rites of the Confessor

Rite of the Absorbed Sin (Low, 6 XP)

Scene; Near/Touch; Yes.

Tags: [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [HEAL], [FEAR]

Materials: A hollow vessel or the ringing of a bell, or a red cord/shared drink.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Echo of Sin:** Absorb 1 Story Beat (Hearts or Diamonds) from an ally or NPC within Near range. Convert it into **+1 Obligation**. You know the emotional nature of the sin but not its source.
- **Burden Transference:** Transfer one Condition, Fatigue, or 1 SB from another target to yourself. You may attempt to reduce their Harm by 1 level; if successful, mark 1 Fatigue.

Push It: (Echo) Absorb 2 SB at once; mark **+1 Fatigue**. (Transfer) Split the burden among two allies; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of Absolution by Ash (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes (sustain by prayer).

Tags: [PURIFY], [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [FEAR]

Materials: A pinch of consecrated ash or soot from a burned confession.

Effect: Lay hands upon a penitent and whisper a truth they cannot bear. Reduce their **Corruption by 1**. The sin transfers to you as *Burdened Heart*: mark 1 SB (Hearts) or **+1 Obligation**.

Push It: Cleanse multiple targets within Close range (e.g., after a battle); each additional soul adds **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Sin-Eater's Pact (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Tags: [BOND], [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [COMMAND]

Materials: Shared confession whispered into an object or tattooed sigil.

Effect: Create a bond between you and the confessor; you may suffer 1 Fatigue to grant **+2 dice** to their Resolve test. If they fail, you suffer 1 Harm instead of them.

Push It: You may take both Harm and a Condition; mark **1 SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Echoed Confession (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [COMMAND], [FEAR], [TRUTH], [DEBT]

Materials: A small handbell or resonant surface.

Effect: Once/scene, replay the echo of a confession you have absorbed. Compel a target who shares its nature (Guilt, Regret, Betrayal) to act or reveal truth; DV = your Presence.

Push It: The echo manifests physically; mark +1 **Obligation** and 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Weight of Ages (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch/Zone; No.

Tags: [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [FATE], [AREA], [FEAR]

Materials: An ancient bell that has tolled for every execution in a kingdom, a chain forged from confession nails, the ashes of a martyr who died for silence.

Effect: Transfer accumulated guilt of generations to a single target. Target must make Spirit+Resolve (DV 5) or become overwhelmed by ancestral shame, suffering automatic Harm 2. Alternatively, release all burdens at once: clear all absorbed SB and Obligation. Every affected ally rolls Resolve (DV 4) or relives their confessed sin as hallucination.

Push It: (Transfer) The target's guilt infects their bloodline; mark 3 **SB (Spades)**. (Release) Bind a spirit or soul within the toll; mark 1 **SB (Spades)** and +1 **Obligation** permanently.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Sin-Eater Monastic (Order of the Unburdened Bell)

The bell tolls for thee – and I answer. Your sin becomes my silence. Your shame becomes my scar.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Resolve 2+, Rite of the Absorbed Sin or Rite of Absolution by Ash.

Sin-Eater Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Stitched Silence (Basic)	You may speak a lie without being detected by magical truth-telling (e.g., Zone of Truth, Oath of Flame's Sunlit Parley). The lie must be about a sin you have absorbed.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 3
Bell's Witness (Basic)	Once per scene, when you hear a secret confession, you may ring a small bell. The GM must answer one yes/no question about whether that confession was true.	1 Boon	Tier II
Burden Steady (Basic)	You may carry one additional Condition without penalty (e.g., you can be both Poisoned and Cursed without stacking penalties beyond the first).	Passive	Spirit 3, Body 2
Sin-Eater's Resilience (Advanced)	When you take a Condition onto yourself from an ally, you may reduce the Fatigue cost by 1 (minimum 0).	Passive	Tier II
Absolution Echo (Advanced)	Once per session, after you absorb a Story Beat from an ally, you may immediately clear one minor Condition (Fear, Shaken, Guilty) from that ally.	Free (once/session)	Tier III
Confessor's Toll (Advanced)	When you use Rite of the Echoed Confession, the target suffers -1 die to resist if they have previously confessed to you (even indirectly).	Passive	Presence 3, Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 14 XP): *The Unburdened Bell.* Once per session, you may ring a great bell (real or imagined) and declare a single sin

you have absorbed to be *forgiven*. Remove that sin's associated Story Beat or Obligation from yourself completely (it does not transfer). For the remainder of the session, you gain +2 dice to all rolls made to protect or absolve others. When the session ends, you gain 1 permanent Corruption – the Confessor remembers that you cheated the cycle. You cannot use this talent again until you have taken a major sin onto yourself (GM discretion).

Cantors & Cults of the Confessor

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Confessor sings in bells, not words – their voice strikes the air like a clapper on bronze. They perform *intonations of release*, melodies that invite confession from unwilling throats and then swallow it whole. Their songs are used by torturers who wish to be merciful, and by priests who cannot bear the weight of what they hear.

The Cult of the Silent Bell. The Confessor's cults gather in places where guilt is already thick: courthouses after sentencing, battlefields the morning after, deathbeds where the dying strain to speak. They wear gray hoods and carry small handbells that they ring exactly once at the start of a confession, and once when the burden has been transferred. Their creed is simple: *"We do not forgive. We carry. When we can no longer carry, we pass the load to the one beneath the bell."*

Witchcraft of the Confessor (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Confessor is a *bell-wright* or *burden-stitcher* – a crafter of thresholds that listen and containers that hold. Their work is often indistinguishable from craft: forging a bell that echoes only the unspoken, carving a confessional that remembers every whisper, stitching a cord that ties sin to stone. Their tools are not hammers; they use bells, cords, and the patient resonance of a struck bronze note.

The Witch's Tool: The Bell of Unspoken Burdens. A small handbell of tarnished bronze, its clapper carved from a knucklebone. Once per session, the witch may ring the bell once. For the next scene, they can hear any whispered confession made within Near range, even if the speaker intended it to be silent. The bell also allows them to “absorb” a single SB from an ally as a free action (once per scene), but doing so marks 1 Fatigue. The bell's tone is mournful and lingers longer than it should.

A Hedge Gift: Bell of Borrowed Silence (2 XP). Once per scene, you may tap a small handbell and absorb one mundane sound (a scream, a lie, a name spoken in anger) into the bell's resonance. For the remainder of the scene, you may release that sound as a distraction or a weapon (+1 die to *Intimidation* or *Deception*).

Confessor's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Confessor's Ear: +1 die to Insight when someone speaks a hidden fear or guilt.	Ringling Silence: You hear phantom bells; checks that require perfect silence suffer -1 die.
2	Burden Bearer: Once/scene, convert 1 SB from an ally into 1 Fatigue for yourself.	Stitched Mouth: You cannot speak a lie about a sin you have absorbed; if you try, mark 1 Fatigue.
3	Weight of Shadows: Once/session, cause a target who has confessed to you to hesitate (lose Initiative or act at Desperate Position).	Shared Agony: When you transfer a Condition to yourself, you also transfer its outward sign (a scar, a tremor).
4	The Bell Answers: Once/session, ring a bell and name a sin; all who share that sin within Near must test Resolve (DV 3) or admit it aloud.	Echoing Skin: Your body remembers every burden carried; touching you inflicts 1 Fatigue on the other party.
5	Absolution by Proxy: Once/session, fully clear a Minor Condition from an ally by taking it onto yourself.	Permanent Toll: Each time you use this benefit, mark +1 permanent Obligation to the Confessor.
6+	The Weight of Ages: You may transfer a Major Condition (or Harm 2) from an ally to yourself without a roll.	Bell's Heir: The Confessor whispers that you will one day take his place – or break. Mark +3 Obligation.

Playstyle Notes

The Confessor is the patron of sin-eaters – those who take on the guilt of others so that the guilty may walk free. His followers gain power over burden transfer, confession, and the slow accumulation of spiritual debt. The cost is that every sin absorbed leaves a mark, and the weight of ages grows heavier with each secret carried. Ideal for players who enjoy redemption arcs, martyrdom, and the moral complexity of carrying others' sins.

Emphasizes

- **Sin Eating:** consuming guilt, shame, and spiritual debt
- **Burden Transfer:** moving conditions, curses, and story beats
- **Confessional Exchange:** secrets as currency, silence as payment
- **Weight of Ages:** the slow accumulation of sin that must eventually be released
- **The Bell as Witness:** the sound that marks the beginning and end of every transaction

6.8.7 The Gallow's Bell (Justice & Judgment)

Lore. The Bell does not rage; it tolls. Cold and impartial, it measures all accounts in time. Its keepers are silent arbiters who weigh deeds against consequence, not out of anger but out of inevitability. To call upon the Bell is to bind oneself to the gravity of truth, where even silence is judged, and every oath leaves a resonance in iron.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, the Gallow's Bell is the patron of judges, notaries, and those who speak final words. In Ecktoria, the Bell is invoked by Censor's clerks who stamp death warrants. In Viterra, hedge-courts ring a small iron bell to seal a verdict. In Linn, a broken bell at a Thing-holm is a sign that a judgment was unjust and the spirits are still listening. Wherever a reckoning must be witnessed, the Gallow's Bell tolls.

What is broken must be mended, what is owed must be paid. The Bell remembers all reckonings.

Domain Focus

- **Weighing of Deeds:** measuring action against consequence, debt against payment
- **Solemn Judgment:** verdicts that cannot be appealed, sentences that must be carried out
- **Compelled Truth:** forcing honesty under threat of the Bell's toll
- **Iron Witness:** the Bell as an impartial recorder of oaths, lies, and reckonings

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Gallow's Bell binds a creature of quiet judgment. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological being that embodies impartial witness: a gray mouse that lives in courthouses and never cheeps false testimony, a small brass-bell frog whose croak sounds like a distant chime, a black-and-white cat that sits on the judge's bench and stares at those who lie, or a mechanical songbird that rings a tiny bell each time a promise is broken. This creature requires no food, but it must witness a formal promise or a judgment each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it rings at the wrong moment or remains silent when truth is spoken, imposing -1 die on all social rolls involving oaths or honesty for its bearer).

The **Codex** of the Gallow's Bell is never a book of spells alone. It may be a court ledger bound in iron, each page sealed with a drop of wax for every case heard; a set of bronze bells, each inscribed with a precedent; or a slate tablet that records the last verdict as a faint, glowing chime. Because the Bell's judgments are final, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week ringing each bell or re-reading each precedent, or the Rites stored there become uncertain (treat as *Compromised* until re-rung).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Gallow's Bell may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or tool) and speak a single word of judgment. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 die to *Command* or *Insight* rolls when delivering a verdict, enforcing an oath, or uncovering a lie. Additionally, the first time each scene the bearer would be

deceived by a lie, they may reroll the opposed check (the Bell's resonance warns them). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the weight of the Bell's attention lingers on their soul.

Rites of the Gallow's Bell

Rite of the Measured Debt (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [COMMAND]

Materials: A pair of scales balanced with tokens from both sides.

Technique Cost: 5 XP (Basic Technique).

Effect: Establish a temporary accord. Both parties suffer **-1 die** if they break it first. You gain **+1 die** to enforce compliance.

Push It: The accord is mystically weighted; breach inflicts **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Weighed Heart (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [SENSE]

Materials: A small brass scale touched briefly to the chest.

Technique Cost: 5 XP (Basic Technique).

Effect: Sense if the target acts against their nature or oath. Gain **+1 die** when pressing them.

Push It: Target must test Resolve (DV 3) or disclose a hidden conflict.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Balanced Scales (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [DEBT], [BOND], [TRANSFER]

Materials: A set of scales inscribed with runes of parity.

Technique Cost: 9 XP (Advanced Technique).

Effect: Exchange a burden between two willing parties (Harm for Fatigue, Debt for Favor, etc.). Both gain **+1 die** to cooperate.

Push It: May compel an unwilling exchange with contested Command + Wits.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Judge's Eye (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [FEAR]

Materials: A black hood worn in silence for one minute.

Technique Cost: 8 XP (Advanced Technique).

Effect: Detect lies within Near range; **+2 dice** to Insight. Liars suffer **-1 die** to maintain their falsehood.

Push It: All deception is laid bare for the scene, but mark Exposure **+1**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Final Reckoning (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [COMMAND], [TRUTH], [FEAR]

Materials: A circle of iron bells, each etched with nameless runes.

Technique Cost: 13 XP (Master Technique).

Effect: The Bell tolls through you. All present feel compelled to name a debt or wrongdoing. Those who lie suffer Harm 2; those who speak true gain +2 dice to persuasion for the scene.

Push It: The Reckoning manifests as spectral echoes of past wrongs – liars automatically suffer narrative punishment (Keeper decides).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Great Adjudication (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [COMMAND], [SUMMON], [FATE]

Materials: A consecrated gavel or a great bell struck three times.

Technique Cost: 14 XP (Master Technique).

Effect: Convene an unseen tribunal. Shadows of former judges and wronged souls gather to preside. For the next session, disputes within the zone are judged formally: +2 dice to Command when speaking as arbiter, and honest testimony gains +1 die.

Push It: The tribunal's verdict echoes beyond the zone, affecting one major conflict elsewhere. Mark **2 SB (Hearts)** as higher powers of judgment take notice.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Gallow's Bell

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Bell sings not with melody, but with *rhythm of measure* – a slow, tolling chant that mimics the swinging of a clapper. Their voice carries the weight of finality; one note can seal a verdict, another can suspend a sentence. They are employed by courts to "sing the sentence" into being, and feared by those who know that a Cantor's silence after a verdict is the most damning judgment of all.

The Cult of the Unstruck Bell. The Bell's cults are austere, gathered in bare stone chambers where a single great bell hangs unstruck. Before any ritual, the cultists argue the case – who owes what, who has paid, who must be reminded. Only when consensus is reached does someone strike the bell, and its tolling *makes the judgment real*. Their creed is carved into the bell's lip: "*We do not create debts. We reveal them. The Bell remembers what the living choose to forget.*"

Witchcraft of the Gallow's Bell (Monastic / Notarial)

A witch who walks with the Bell is often a *notary of the silent court*, a *bell-tolling clerk*, or a *judge's scribe* – a nun, monk, or lay scholar who tends the records of obligation, copies the judgments of the Bell, and keeps the weights of the scales true. Their magic is the art of measurement and witness: sealing verdicts with leaden seals that glow when a debt is called, scribing judgment scrolls that burn with the truth of a confession, or maintaining the bell-roster that notes every name that owes an accounting. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "weigh-stone" into a courtroom floor, so that every testimony given upon it tips an unseen scale. In Viterra, a hedge-notary might stitch a ledger whose

entries tighten like knots when a payment is overdue. Their tools are not hammers but seals, quills, and the small brass bells that ring in the ears of the perjured.

The Witch's Tool: The Seal of Unspoken Weights. A small iron seal, cool to the touch, stamped with a bell that has no clapper. Once per session, the witch may press the seal onto a document, a threshold, or a debtor's palm. For the next day, any creature that knowingly breaks a promise recorded in that document (or sworn on that threshold) suffers a sharp sting (1 Fatigue) as the seal "remembers" the weight of their word. The seal can also be used to "strike" a bell: tapping it against any iron bell forces the bell to ring once, even if broken or without a clapper, and the ring can be heard only by those who owe a debt in the current scene.

A Hedge Gift: Bell-Toll of the Hidden Debt (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may whisper the name of a creature within Near range while tapping any ringing surface (a bell, a cup, a blade). For the next minute, that creature hears a faint, distant bell toll each time they attempt to lie or conceal an obligation. The GM gains **1 SB** (the Bell records the strain), and the creature suffers **–1 die** on Deception rolls during that time. The witch may also ask the GM one yes/no question about a hidden debt owed by that creature; the GM must answer truthfully, though cryptically. **Technique Cost:** 4 XP (Basic Technique).

Gallow's Bell Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Judge's Intuition: +1 die to Insight when weighing truth.	Must point out falsehoods when noticed, regardless of tact.
2	Quiet Authority: Once/scene, treat a failed Command as success; mark 1 SB (Hearts).	Cannot remain neutral in disputes; indecision costs 1 Fatigue.
3	Scales of Balance: Once/session, enforce an exchange of burdens.	Compelled toward fairness even when it hinders you.
4	Bell's Resonance: +2 dice when calling for judgment or demanding restitution.	Suffer 1 Fatigue if wrongdoing is ignored.
5	Reckoner's Call: Once/session, declare a "reckoning moment" – truth must surface or consequence falls.	Cannot ignore pleas for justice without marking 1 SB (Spades).
6+	Final Arbiter: Once/session, render an absolute decree; all within the scene must obey or suffer consequence (Harm 1, +1 Obligation).	Mark +2 Obligation; the Bell demands you bear the weight of enforcement. Your voice tolls like a bell when you speak judgment – those who hear you cannot interrupt until your sentence is complete.

Playstyle Notes

The Gallow's Bell rewards those who speak truth, enforce oaths, and deliver justice without cruelty. Its followers are not executioners – they are arbiters who ensure that

every debt is weighed and every consequence is fair. The Bell does not punish the desperate; it punishes the deceiver. Intrusions often take the form of an unexpected witness (a bell that rings at the wrong moment, a forgotten promise resurfacing) or a demand to judge a dispute that cannot be settled by silence. Ideal for characters who serve as magistrates, justiciars, or honest mediators in a world of broken oaths.

Emphasizes

- **Solemn Judgment:** verdicts that cannot be appealed
- **Compelled Truth:** forcing honesty under the threat of the Bell
- **Weighing of Deeds:** measuring action against consequence
- **Iron Witness:** the Bell as impartial recorder
- **The Toll of Silence:** what is not said is also judged

6.8.8 Grimmer, the Old Man of the Forest (Primal Mystery & Seasonal Sacrifice)

Lore. Grimmer is the Old Man of the Forest, the presence that watches from the shadow of the oldest oak, the cold breath on the back of the neck when the path grows dark. He is not kind, nor is he cruel – he is *wild*, and the wild does not negotiate. It demands, and it takes. His followers learn to read the language of blood on snow, the geometry of root and stone, and the weight of a heart offered at the turning of the year. Grimmer does not teach harmony; he teaches respect through fear, and fear through sacrifice.

Those who walk his path become keepers of the old ways: druids who know when a grove must be fed, rangers who leave the first kill for the soil, and hedge-folk who whisper the names of spirits not to be spoken aloud. Their magic is not the gentle coaxing of garden plants but the raw, patient hunger of the forest floor – a hunger that swallows bones and grows mushrooms in the shape of the dead.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Grimmer is called by many names. In Aeler, he is the *Root-Father*, a patron of deep fungus and stone-lichen whose shrines are carved into living rock. In Ykrul, he is the *Sky-Wolf*, a spirit of the steppe who herds the seasons and grants omens. In Aelaerem, he is the *Thorn-Father*, keeper of hedgerow magic, honored with red thread tied around roadside stones. Wherever the wild presses against the civilized, Grimmer waits.

“The forest does not ask. It takes. The deer does not weep for the wolf, and the wolf does not beg the earth. Give what the season demands, or the season will take it anyway.”

Domain Focus

- **Seasonal Sacrifice:** the old ways of blood and offering, the turning wheel that demands payment
- **Folk Horror:** the terror of the unseen, the ritual that must be performed, the boundary that must not be crossed
- **Primal Mystery:** knowledge hidden in root and stone, the language of omens and portents
- **Growth from Death:** the forest floor as a stomach; decay as the engine of new life

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Grimmer does not bind a familiar of hearth and home. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological creature of the wild wood: a pine marten with eyes like amber, a raven that knows the migration routes of every bird, a fox with a single white paw that leaves no prints in snow, a toad that hibernates in rotten logs and sings at the first thaw, or a stag-calf with antlers budding like spring shoots. This creature requires no food in the usual sense, but it must be allowed to roam freely in unspoiled nature each day. If confined for more than a day, it becomes *Compromised* (it scratches at doors, refuses to eat, and its coat grows dull; its bearer loses the benefit of *Seasonal Sense* until it is released).

The **Codex** of Grimmer is never a book of paper and ink. It may be a slab of slate carved with seasonal runes that frost over in winter, a bundle of bark scrolls sealed with

pine resin, a set of knotted cords woven from the hair of a wild boar, or the hollowed horn of a stag filled with charcoal and ash. Because the wild resists being fixed in writing, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week in a natural place, re-carving or re-knotting the Rites by memory, or the symbols fade (treat as Compromised until restored under open sky).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Grimmir may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a word of the season. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Survival* or *Stealth* rolls in natural terrain, and the first time each scene the bearer would be tracked by mundane means, the tracker suffers **-1 die** (the forest hides their trail). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the wild's claim on them deepens. (Technique cost: 0 XP – patron's gift, but see Obligation cost.)

Rites of Grimmir

Rite of the Blood Offering (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [SACRIFICE], [NATURE], [STEALTH]

Technique Cost: 4 XP (Basic)

Materials: A drop of your own blood (1 Fatigue) or the blood of a freshly killed animal.

Effect: The forest accepts your offering. For the remainder of the scene, you gain **+1 die** to all *Survival* and *Stealth* rolls in natural terrain. Additionally, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about a threat hidden in the wilderness (e.g., "Is there a predator watching us?").

Push It: The offering is accepted with hunger – you gain **+2 dice** instead, but you must leave a visible token (a hair, a scrap of clothing) on the ground. That token can be used by the GM later as a sympathetic link (spend 1 SB to have an animal or spirit track you).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Speaking Roots (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [NATURE]

Technique Cost: 5 XP (Basic)

Materials: Soil from a grave or a crossroads, held in the mouth.

Effect: You listen to the memory of the land. Gain **+2 dice** to *Investigation* or *Lore* when seeking to understand what happened in a natural place – a death, a ritual, a violation of the wild. The GM must give you a truthful but cryptic answer.

Push It: The roots speak too clearly. You see a vision of the event, but it leaves you shaken: mark **Fatigue 1** and the GM gains **1 SB**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Twisted Path (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [CURSE], [TERRAIN], [FEAR]

Technique Cost: 7 XP (Basic)

Materials: A knotted cord woven from thorns and hair.

Effect: The forest bends against your enemies. Choose a single target within Near. For the remainder of the scene, all their navigation, tracking, and movement rolls suffer **−1 die** as roots trip them, branches block their way, and the path turns subtly wrong.

Push It: The curse also causes the target to suffer **1 Fatigue** as they struggle against the hostile woods. Mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the forest's malice becomes visible.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Heart's Meal (Standard, 9 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [CONSUME], [HEAL], [BOOST], [FEAR]

Technique Cost: 9 XP (Advanced)

Materials: The fresh heart of an animal (or a sentient creature, if you dare), still warm.

Effect: You consume the heart raw. Gain one of the following:

- Heal **1 Harm** (the heart's vitality transfers to you).
- Gain a **+2 die** bonus on your next physical action (the heart's strength).
- Learn a secret the creature knew in life (GM discretion; the heart whispers as you eat).

After the rite, you are *marked* – animals within Near range are nervous around you (disadvantage on animal handling) for one scene.

Push It: Eat the heart of a thinking creature. The benefit is doubled, but you gain a *Hunger* Condition (must eat another heart within a month or suffer 1 Fatigue per week). The GM gains **2 SB**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the World's Wound (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [HEAL], [AREA], [NATURE], [TERRAIN]

Technique Cost: 13 XP (Master)

Materials: A sacred grove-site, a circle of stones, an offering of blood or seed.

Effect: Heal a blighted place or quicken a damaged ecosystem. Clear taint, restore fertility, awaken dormant forces. Gain **+2 dice** to related *Survival/Nature* actions in the region. Start an **Ecosystem Restoration [8]** timer.

Push It: The cure spreads to adjacent areas but unbalances another; mark **2 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Cycle's Crown (High, 14 XP)

Scene; Self/Zone; Yes.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [NATURE], [BOOST], [PROTECT]

Technique Cost: 14 XP (Master)

Materials: A circlet of woven branches, antlers, and seasonal tokens.

Effect: Become an avatar of the cycle. Choose two:

- **Seasonal Mastery:** +2 dice to all actions keyed to the current season (spring: healing and growth; summer: strength and harvest; autumn: preservation and preparation; winter: endurance and hiding).
- **Verdant Command:** Command plant life in *Near* automatically.
- **Cycle's Healing:** Remove one Condition or downgrade Harm by one level.
- **Growth's Protection:** Allies gain +1 **Armor** from natural cover.

Begin a **Seasonal Avatar [6]** timer.

Push It: Extend the blessings to all present; mark +2 **Obligation** and gain **Seasonal Attunement** (see Corruption).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Grimmer

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Grimmer sings the *drone of green things* – a low, humming chant that mimics the vibration of leaves in wind or the deep thrum of growing roots. Their voice is used to coax reluctant seeds, to calm wounded animals, and to mark the turning of the seasons in rituals that entire villages attend. A Grimmer Cantor does not seek an audience; they sing to the land itself, and the land answers in fruit, rain, or silence.

The Cult of the Root-Moot. Grimmer's cults are neither secret nor organized – a “moot” may be a single hermit or a scattered network of rangers who meet only at the solstices. The most ancient of these, the *Root-Moot*, carves masks from living moss and wears them during the rite of the Turning Wheel. Each member plants a tooth (their own or a beast's) into the root-ball of a sacred oak; if the tooth sprouts a sapling by spring, the planter is considered “heard” by the Old Man. Their creed is carved into the oldest oak in each grove: “*Take only what the season gives. Give back what the season will need.*” Outsiders are welcome at the solstice fires, but they must work – splitting wood, digging a drainage trench, or feeding the fire with a personal memory (which the flames accept with a green flash).

Witchcraft of Grimmer (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Grimmer is a *hedgewright* or *path-keeper* – a crafter of living boundaries. Their work may be invisible: weaving a branch to guide deer away from a village, carving a marker that tells the frost when to end, or building a root bridge that only becomes passable at low tide. This craft can look like “infrastructure” – an Aeler True-Mason might carve a stone that remembers the boundary between a mine and a sacred spring, or a Linn shipwright might season a keel with a prayer for the right wind. But the witch's tools are never hammers; they are twine, moss, and the quiet patience of waiting for the land to answer.

The Witch's Tool: The Knotted Staff. A staff of petrified wood, cold to the touch but warm when it touches living matter. Once per session, when used to bless a boundary marker (a post, a stone, a tree) it inscribes a minor [SEASONAL] tag into the threshold. The marker will “remember” the season of its carving for one year, granting +1 die to rolls that honor that season's work.

A Hedge Gift: Knot of the Turning Year (2 XP). Once per scene, you may tie a simple knot (in a cord, a strand of hair, or a blade of grass) and speak a phrase appropriate to the current season. The knot subtly influences the weather or local plant growth for the next hour – a gust of wind, a sudden rain, or a patch of ivy that grows just enough to provide cover. The GM adjudicates effect. (Technique cost: 2 XP – Minor Hedge Gift.)

Grimmir's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Seasonal Sense: +1 die to predict weather, seasonal shifts, or natural events.	Cyclical Mood: –1 die to actions that defy the season (haste in winter, patience in spring).
2	Verdant Whisper: Once/scene, gain +2 dice when communing with nature.	Plant Speech: Under stress, you address plants before people; –1 die to civilized social rolls.
3	Growth's Touch: Once/session, accelerate natural healing or growth.	Seasonal Shift: Demeanor changes with the season; allies note unsettling variance.
4	Boundary Keeper: Once/scene, sense violations of wild places at <i>Far</i> .	Wild Intolerance: –1 die in dense urban/cultivated zones; physical discomfort in worked stone.
5	Cycle's Memory: Once/session, perfectly recall a natural event witnessed here.	Ecosystem Dependency: Without daily time in nature, suffer Fatigue 1 .
6+	Avatar of Seasons: Once/session, embody a season fully (+3 dice to seasonal actions).	Nature's Claim: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk becoming bound to a specific biome. You may no longer eat cultivated food – only what you hunt, gather, or grow yourself.

Playstyle Notes

Grimmir rewards those who approach the wild with fear and respect, not dominion. His followers are not masters of nature but participants in its rituals – they know when to give blood, when to leave an offering, and when to simply bow and walk away. Intrusions often take the form of seasonal demands: a grove that must be fed before the first frost, a creature that must be hunted before it hunts you, or a vision of a ritual that must be performed at the next solstice. Refusal does not invite wrath – merely the withdrawal of the wild's protection, leaving the follower exposed to the very fears they once understood. Ideal for druids, rangers, and characters who understand that the forest is not a resource but a creditor.

Emphasizes

- **Seasonal Sacrifice:** the old ways of blood and offering
- **Folk Horror:** the terror of the unseen and the ritual that must be performed

- **Primal Mystery:** knowledge hidden in root and stone, omens and portents
- **Growth from Death:** decay as the engine of new life
- **Boundary Keeping:** guarding the threshold between the civilized and the wild

6.8.9 Ikasha, She Who Sleeps (Latent Potential & Shadow)

Lore. Ikasha is the hush between footfalls, the patience of dark water, the black-feathered watcher at every threshold. In stillness she gathers what might be, at crossroads she whispers of what may yet come. Ravens circle her, bearing secrets between worlds. Her followers learn to move unseen and speak unremembered, becoming shadows that slip between what is and what could be.

Ikasha does not act; she waits. She does not command; she suggests. Her power is not in force but in possibility – the hidden door, the forgotten name, the secret that, if spoken, would change everything. Those who serve her become keepers of thresholds, listeners at the edge of sleep, and witnesses to the shape of things not yet born. She is the patron of spies, dreamers, outcasts, and those who know that the darkest shadow is also the safest cloak.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Ikasha is called by many names. In the Mistlands, she is the *Bell-Shrouded*, whose unknotted rope holds the fog at bay. In Aeler, she is the *Deep Listener*, to whom miners whisper before descending into new shafts. In Zakov, she is the *Tide Watcher*, a smuggler’s patron who hides cargo from the Salt Prince’s collectors. Wherever a threshold is crossed and a secret is kept, Ikasha watches.

“Blow out the candle. If the room listens back, ask softly. At the next crossroads, the raven waits – and the shadow remembers your passing.”

Domain Focus

- **Latent Potential:** the power of what is not yet, the seed of action, the whisper before the scream
- **Shadow as Shelter:** concealment, secrets, and the spaces between notice
- **Thresholds of Change:** doors, crossroads, dreams, and the boundaries of sleep
- **Raven’s Witness:** omens, messages, and the weight of secrets shared

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Ikasha does not bind a familiar of sunlight and noise. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of shadow and stillness: a black cat with silver eyes that sees in perfect darkness, a gray mouse that nests in the walls of confessionals, a small owl whose feathers drink the light, a pale moth that appears only when a secret is spoken, or a raven chick with one white feather that knows the way to every crossroads. This creature requires no food, but it must spend at least an hour each day in absolute darkness (a closed drawer, a shuttered room). If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows restless and fidgets in light, imposing –1 die on all Stealth rolls for its bearer until appeased with a secret whispered in the dark).

The **Codex** of Ikasha is never a book read by lamplight. It may be a sheaf of blank pages that fill with whispered secrets only when the reader sleeps, a set of black silk ribbons knotted in patterns that change with the moon, or a slate that shows fading images of thresholds crossed. Because Ikasha’s truths are written in the unwitnessed, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week in a dark room, letting the Codex rest in shadow, or the Rites stored there become faint (treat as *Compromised* until re-darkened).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Ikasha may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a word of unlight. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Stealth* or *Deception* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be spotted by a mundane observer, they may reroll the opposed check (the shadow bends around them). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the darkness notes their debt.

Rites of Ikasha

Rite of the Unlit Candle (Low, 6 XP)

Action; Self; Yes (Stealth).

Tags: [STEALTH], [DECEPTION], [SHADOW]

Materials: A candle snuffed with a whisper.

Effect: You step into the space between notices. Gain **+1 die** to a single *Stealth* or *Subterfuge* roll, and if you succeed, you may also declare one minor detail “forgotten” by any observer (e.g., “they don’t remember my face,” “they left the key in the lock”).

Push It: Extend the effect to one ally within Near, but your shadow lingers independently for a moment – the GM gains **1 SB (Diamonds)** as evidence remains.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Crossroads Raven (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [OMEN], [NAVIGATION], [SECRET]

Materials: Three black feathers scattered at a crossing.

Effect: A raven appears, visible only to you and your allies. It offers an omen: you may reroll one failed navigation, pursuit, or escape roll this scene, or force one enemy to hesitate (lose their next minor action).

Push It: The raven whispers a true secret about the current situation (the GM must answer one yes/no question truthfully). In return, it demands a secret from you – the GM gains **1 SB (Hearts)** to spend later as a complication involving that secret.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Umbral Reservoir (Standard, 8 XP)

Action; Self or Ally; No.

Tags: [SHADOW], [RESTORATION], [BOOST]

Materials: Water gathered on a moonless night, held in a black vessel.

Effect: Draw on deep reserves of patience and shadow. Choose one:

- Gain **+2 dice** on your next *Stealth*, *Deception*, or *Resolve* roll.
- Clear **1 Fatigue** from yourself or a touched ally.
- Gain one free success on an attempt to escape restraint or pursuit (no roll needed).

Push It: Apply two benefits instead of one, but you mark **+1 Obligation** and the GM gains **1 SB (Clubs)** as the shadow’s debt comes due.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unlatched Secret (Standard, 9 XP)*Instant; Near; Yes.***Tags:** [SECRET], [TRUTH], [UNSEAL], [READ]**Materials:** A key that has never been used, bent in a circle, or a lock of hair / personal token / name written on black paper.**Effect:** Choose one of the following:

- **Unlatched Door:** Persuade a mundane threshold to open. One lock, seal, or barrier (door, chain, shutter, even a pursuer's grip) opens or loosens as if never secured. Does not work on magical wards.
- **Secret Keeper:** Compel a truthful answer to one direct question about a secret the target knows. They resist with Resolve (DV 4). On failure, they answer truthfully (cryptically permitted). On success, they suffer **1 Fatigue** from concealment.

Push It: If you chose *Unlatched Door*, you may also silence any noise the opening makes, but the threshold “remembers” you – the GM gains **1 SB (Spades)** for a later complication. If you chose *Secret Keeper*, you also learn a hidden emotion or related secret (GM's choice), but the target learns one of your secrets – the GM gains **1 SB (Hearts)** to reveal it later.

*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Umbral Dream (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Self; No.***Tags:** [SHADOW], [DREAM], [FATE], [TRANSPORT], [INVISIBLE]**Materials:** Stand in absolute darkness or at a deserted crossroads at midnight; or burn a vivid dream written down.**Effect:** You become a living shadow or reach into latent potential. Choose one of the following:

- **Shadow Form:** For the scene, you are intangible to mundane harm, can pass through small gaps and thresholds, gain **+2 dice** to all *Stealth* rolls, and automatically succeed on one escape attempt. You cannot manipulate objects normally.
- **Whisper of Possibility:** Once before the next dawn, reroll any single roll after seeing the result (before outcome is declared). The GM gains **1 SB** as fate wavers.
- **Hidden Path:** You and allies bypass one major obstacle (guarded gate, collapsed bridge, social dead end) as if a secret way had always been there – the GM gains **1 SB** as the world adjusts.
- **Unspoken Name:** Learn the true name of one creature or place (GM discretion). That name can be used for future rites or bargains.

Push It: Apply two benefits instead of one. If you chose *Shadow Form*, you may also interact once with a locked or warded object while intangible, but your next defense roll is *Desperate*. In all cases, you mark **+2 Obligation** and the GM gains **2 SB** (the dream's echoes attract attention).

*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Ikasha

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Ikasha sings in *whispers* – melodies that are felt rather than heard, harmonies that slip beneath the threshold of attention. Their voice is used to hide a crowd's escape, to make a guard forget why they entered a room, or to pass a message through enemy lines without a single word being spoken aloud. Ikasha's Cantors are rarely recognized; they are the ones who hum absently while others plan rebellion.

The Cult of the Unlit Candle. Ikasha's cults are shadowy by necessity, meeting in basements, abandoned bell-towers, and fog-bound crossroads. They whisper freedom to the oppressed – escaped slaves, hunted heretics, debtors fleeing their creditors. A ritual of the Unlit Candle involves each member extinguishing a flame and speaking a secret wish for escape. The candles are never relit; the wish is carried away on ravens' wings. Their creed is never written, only passed from shadow to shadow: "*The dark does not confine – it conceals the road that the light would forbid.*" Outsiders who stumble into a meeting are offered a black feather and a choice: forget, or follow.

Witchcraft of Ikasha (Threshold / Shadow)

A witch who walks with Ikasha is a *threshold-keeper* or *shadow-weaver* – one who knows that a door left unlatched is not an invitation to theft, but to liberation. Their magic works in the gaps: the crack under a door, the moment between heartbeats, the pause between a guard's patrol. This craft can be invisible – a bent lock, a misplaced key, a shadow that moves of its own accord – or as grand as erasing a name from a pursuer's memory.

The Witch's Tool: The Raven's Quill. A quill carved from a raven's primary feather, dipped not in ink but in the absence of light. Once per session, when used to write a name on a threshold (a doorframe, a gatepost, a windowsill), that name becomes "forgotten" for a scene: the person whose name is written cannot be perceived by those who cross that threshold until they succeed on a Resolve test (DV 3). The quill can also erase a single word from a written document (it becomes a smudge of shadow).

A Hedge Gift: Unlatched (2 XP). Once per scene, you may declare a mundane lock, latch, or binding to be "unlatched" – it opens freely (or fails to close) as if it had never been secured. This works on doors, chains, shutters, and even a pursuer's grip, but not on magical wards.

Ikasha's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Shadow's Whisper: +1 die to <i>Deception</i> when lying in darkness or through intermediaries.	Truth Echoes: Occasionally speak in riddles or half-truths without realizing it.
2	Umbral Sight: Once per scene, gain +2 dice to <i>Notice</i> hidden threats or ambushes in dim light.	Light Sensitivity: –1 die to rolls requiring keen vision in bright conditions.
3	Raven's Memory: Never forget a secret told to you; recall any whispered conversation perfectly.	Secret Burden: Must keep one troubling secret per Tier; suffer 1 Fatigue when actively trying to forget.
4	Threshold Walker: Once per session, move through one locked door, sealed letter, or magical barrier without triggering wards.	Crossroads Bound: Must pause at literal or metaphorical crossroads to “listen” before major decisions.
5	Shadow Debt: Once per session, call in a favor from someone who owes you a secret – no questions asked.	Obligation Web: Every secret you learn creates a subtle tie to its keeper; mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when ignoring these connections.
6+	Umbral Ascendancy: Once per session, become completely undetectable to all non-magical senses for one scene.	Reality Thinning: The boundary between what is and what could be grows thin – the GM may introduce subtle reality alterations around you.

Playstyle Notes

Ikasha rewards patience, subtlety, and the willingness to let things unfold. Her followers are not agents of action but of possibility – they open doors, plant secrets, and wait for the harvest. Intrusions often take the form of dreams showing a hidden danger, a raven appearing with a cryptic message, or a secret you thought buried resurfacing at the worst moment. Refusing an intrusion does not bring wrath – merely the withdrawal of Ikasha's favor: doors stay locked, shadows become just shadows, and the road ahead grows a little darker. Ideal for rogues, spies, and characters who understand that the greatest power is often the one that remains unseen.

Emphasizes

- **Latent Potential:** power as possibility, not force
- **Shadow as Shelter:** concealment, secrets, and the spaces between notice
- **Thresholds of Change:** doors, crossroads, dreams, and the boundaries of sleep
- **Raven's Witness:** omens, messages, and the weight of secrets shared

Shadow Monk (Ikasha)

Blow out the candle. If the room listens back, ask softly.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Unlit Candle or Cantor of Ikasha.

Debt-Resistant Frame. Shadows leave no mark on ledgers. Shadow monks gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt, geas, or contract that would compel them to be seen, remembered, or witnessed. If they succeed, the creditor's records show only a blank space where their name should be – a gap the Hollow may one day fill.

Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Shadow Step (Basic, 6 XP)	Move from one patch of shadow to another within near range without crossing the space between. You must be able to see both shadows.	1 Fatigue	Wits 3
Unlit Candle (Basic, 6 XP)	Step into the space between notices. Gain +1 die to a single Stealth or Subterfuge roll, and if you succeed, declare one minor detail “forgotten” by any observer.	1 Boon	Spirit 2
Crossroads Raven (Basic, 5 XP)	A raven appears, visible only to you and your allies. Reroll one failed navigation, pursuit, or escape roll this scene, or force one enemy to lose their next minor action.	1 Fatigue	Wits 2
Unlatched Secret (Standard, 9 XP)	Persuade a mundane threshold to open (door, lock, even a pursuer’s grip). Does not work on magical wards.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Umbral Reservoir (Standard, 8 XP)	Draw on deep reserves of patience and shadow. Clear 1 Fatigue from yourself or a touched ally, or gain +2 dice on your next Stealth, Deception, or Resolve roll.	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Hidden Path (Standard, 10 XP)	You and allies bypass one major obstacle (guarded gate, collapsed bridge, social dead end) as if a secret way had always been there – the GM gains 1 SB as the world adjusts.	1 Boon	Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 14 XP): *Shadow Form.* Once per session, become intangible to mundane harm for one scene: pass through small gaps, gain

+2 dice to all Stealth rolls, and automatically succeed on one escape attempt. You cannot manipulate objects normally. After the scene, you collapse with Fatigue 2 and gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your shadow is faint, as if you borrowed it from someone else). You may ignore one forced Obligation or debt call – the creditor sees only a silhouette that dissolves when touched.

6.8.10 Inaea, Angel of the Spider (Webs, Fate & Patient Predation)

Lore. Inaea sits in patient silence at the center of the unseen lattice. Where others see isolation, she sees threads—debt, affection, rivalry, loyalty—all binding mortals to one another. She is comforter and conspirator alike: the hearth-mother who eases grief with a warm hand, and the shadow-spinner who knots fates so they cannot slip free. Those who serve her learn to pull strands, tying allies closer and ensnaring foes until mercy or trap is inevitable.

The spider does not rush. It weaves, waits, and feels the tremor of every caught fly. So too does Inaea. Her mercy is never without cost; her kindness is a thread that, once accepted, can be pulled taut at a moment of her follower's choosing. To serve her is to understand that every bond is a leash, every promise a snare, and every act of compassion a line cast into the dark.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Inaea is the patron of hearth-keepers, matchmakers, and those who bind communities. In Aelaerem, she is the *Kettle-Spinner*, invoked by grandmothers to keep families together. In Silkstrand, she is the *Dyed Web*, honored by dyers' guilds who leave a single strand of silk outside their windows on the first of spring. Wherever threads are tied—in marriage, in treaty, in the quiet forgiveness of a debt—Inaea's influence is felt.

"The thread that comforts is the same that binds. The knot that saves is also the snare. What you accept from my hand, you give me leave to tighten."

Domain Focus

- **Webs of Obligation:** debts, promises, favors, and the ties that bind
- **Patient Predation:** setting traps, waiting for the moment to strike
- **Unseen Connections:** sensing hidden relationships, leverage, and weakness
- **Mercy as Control:** healing and aid that leave lasting threads

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Inaea does not bind a familiar of claw and fang. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of threads and patience: a garden spider that weaves its web in the shape of the keeper's name, a tiny weaver bird that knots grass into intricate patterns, a small silk moth that leaves a trail of thread wherever it flies, or a gray field mouse that nests in bundles of twine. This creature requires no food, but it must be given a fresh length of thread, ribbon, or cloth to work with each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it tangles cords and knots laces at inopportune moments, imposing —1 die on all fine manipulation rolls for its bearer until offered a new thread).

The **Codex** of Inaea is never a book of ink and paper. It may be a frame loom with a half-finished weaving that records Rites as colored threads, a bundle of knotted cords that must be read by touch, or a wooden spindle wrapped with silk strands that sing when plucked. Because Inaea's truths are woven, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week adding a new row to the weaving (or untying and retying a knot), or the patterns become tangled (treat as *Compromised* until re-woven).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Inaea may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a word of binding. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Sway* or *Insight* rolls when dealing with promises, debts, or relationships, and the first time each scene the bearer would be betrayed by an ally under a promise, they may sense it one exchange in advance (the thread pulls taut). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as a thread of connection tightens around them.

Rites of Inaea

Hearth-Thread Knot (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes (link once).

Tags: [BOND], [PROTECT], [HEAL]

Materials: A thread tied around a wrist or shared cup.

Effect: Bind yourself and one willing target (ally or neutral) with a sympathetic thread. Both gain +1 **die** to Aid each other this scene. Additionally, if either takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 (to a minimum of 0) by suffering that same Harm instead. This transfer is voluntary for an ally; for an unwilling target, you must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 3) to force the link.

Push It: Extend to two allies; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)** as your own lifeline strains.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 5 XP (Basic Technique)

Snaring Filament (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [TRAP], [AREA], [BIND]

Materials: A knotted cord or woven scrap.

Effect: Lay an invisible snare in a lane, doorway, or narrow passage. The first hostile creature to cross suffers –2 **dice** on their next action and must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 2) or lose their movement for that turn (tangled). The snare lasts for the scene or until triggered.

Push It: Lay a second snare elsewhere, but allies risk entanglement if they forget its location; mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as the web spreads thin.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 5 XP (Basic Technique)

Strand of Inevitability (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [BOND], [FATE], [MANIPULATION]

Materials: Three colored threads (white, black, red) braided together.

Effect: Link two actors (which can include yourself) with a visible or invisible strand. For the rest of the scene, whenever one acts, the other is dragged into consequence. You may trigger this linkage once to either:

- Force 1 **SB (Hearts)** on the linked target after they perform a significant action.
- Gain +2 **dice** on a *Setup*, *Predict*, or *Manipulate* roll that exploits the link (e.g., “you cannot betray me without hurting your ally”).

The link is one-way or two-way as you choose.

Push It: Invert the direction of the link once after it is set (e.g., make the pursuer stumble instead of the pursued). Mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the weave resists.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 8 XP (Advanced Technique)

Weaver's Glance (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [SENSE],

Materials: Observe a spider finishing a web's radial line (or a convincing imitation).

Effect: Ask the GM one question about a hidden tie, debt, or leverage between two people, or between a person and a faction. The GM must answer truthfully. Your next *Manipulate*, *Pressure*, or *Intimidate* action exploiting that knowledge gains **+1 Effect**.

Push It: Reveal a secret tie that was not previously declared in the fiction (the GM must invent a plausible connection). Mark **Exposure +1** as your own entanglements surface.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 7 XP (Basic/Advanced borderline; treat as 7 XP)

Spinner's Debt (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [DEBT], [BOND], [COMMAND]

Materials: A silver coin and a strand of your own hair, knotted together.

Effect: Offer a willing creature a boon: they may immediately clear **1 Fatigue** or gain **+1 die** on their next roll. In return, they accept a **Promise Timer [4]** named "Debt to the Web." You may advance this timer by 1 segment at any time as a free action (once per scene). When the timer fills, you may demand a single service from them — not impossible, but significant (e.g., "speak for me at court," "reveal a secret," "take a blow meant for me"). Refusal causes them to suffer **Harm 1 (Stress)** and the timer resets.

Push It: Extend the offer to a group (up to three targets). Each who accepts gives you a separate Promise Timer. Mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 9 XP (Advanced Technique)

Binding Knot (High, 11 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [FATE], [COMMAND]

Materials: A silk loop tied between two hands, then cut or knotted with a spoken vow.

Effect: Bind two parties (individuals or small groups) to a mutual oath. Breaking the vow forces **2 SB** on the violator and marks them with a subtle tell (a visible thread, a nervous twitch, a lingering scent) that persists for one week.

Push It: Widen the binding to up to four parties, each of whom may define one loophole. Exploiting a loophole causes **1 SB (Clubs)** as the web tightens around the exploiter.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

XP Cost: 11 XP (Advanced/Master borderline)

Merciful Severing (High, 13 XP)*Scene; Touch; No.***Tags:** [HEAL], [DISPEL], [MERCY], [DEBT]**Materials:** A white thread burned to ash, spoken with a name.**Effect:** Sever one harmful tie — a curse, a toxic obsession, a coercive bond, or a supernatural debt. Remove one Condition or **1 SB** tied to it. This is an act of genuine mercy; the target may be unwilling, but the thread can still be cut (Resolve test DV 4 to resist).**Push It:** Sever a tie without the target's consent or knowledge; they will not know who cut them free, but you mark **+2 Obligation** as the web recoils against you, and the severed strand may attach to you instead (GM's discretion).*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.**XP Cost: 13 XP (Master Technique)***Web of Slumber (High, 12 XP)***Extended; Zone; No.***Tags:** [AREA], [SLEEP], [BIND], [FEAR]**Materials:** A complete spider's web, stolen at dawn, and a lullaby hummed into it.**Effect:** Weave an area of drowsy stillness. For the next hour, any creature entering the zone must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 4) or fall into a light trance, losing their next action and suffering **−1 die** to all perception rolls while inside. Allies you touch beforehand are immune. The web is invisible until triggered.**Push It:** The trance becomes deeper — sleeping creatures cannot be woken by non-magical means for the duration. Mark **2 SB (Spades/Hearts)** as the web draws hungry attention.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.**XP Cost: 12 XP (Master Technique)***Cantors & Cults of Inaea**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Inaea sings in *knots* — melodies that loop back on themselves, harmonies that tie two voices into one. Their voice is used to heal quarrels, to bind a community together after a tragedy, or to weave a subtle compulsion into a seemingly innocent lullaby. Inaea's Cantors are beloved at weddings, feared at treaty signings, and always watched by those who understand that a pretty tune can be a leash.

The Cult of the Woven Circle. Inaea's cults gather in domestic spaces — kitchens, weaving sheds, longhouses — and resemble extended families more than secret societies. A ritual of the Woven Circle involves each member tying a colored thread around their wrist, then passing the ends to their neighbors. The resulting web is then tightened, and a communal promise spoken. The cult's creed is embroidered onto a single cushion that passes from host to host: "*No thread stands alone. The weakest knot still holds the strongest weight.*" Outsiders are welcome if they bring a thread and a truth. Betrayal of the circle is repaid by being unraveled — socially, financially, or worse.

Witchcraft of Inaea (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Inaea is a *web-weaver* or *knot-smith* — one who understands that every threshold (a door, a marriage, a treaty) is held together by invisible threads. Their magic works with domestic tools: a spinning wheel that twists fate, a loom that weaves obligations into cloth, or a pair of shears that cuts a single strand to end a feud. This craft can be as humble as tying a red thread around a child's wrist for protection, or as grand as weaving a tapestry that records an entire bloodline's debts.

The Witch's Tool: The True Loom. A small, portable loom — no larger than a book — woven from hawthorn wood and strung with thread dyed in three colors (red for blood, white for truth, black for secret). Once per session, the witch may weave a single knot into a new or existing thread; that knot becomes a *promise timer* [4]. When the timer fills, the promise is either fulfilled or broken, as agreed at the time of weaving.

A Hedge Gift: Bind the Threshold (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tie a simple knot in a cord, ribbon, or strand of hair and place it on a threshold (a doorstep, a gate, a bridge). For the next hour, anyone crossing that threshold must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 2) if they intend to break an oath, tell a lie, or harm someone inside. The knot visibly tightens if a violation is attempted.

XP Cost: 2 XP (Minor hedge gift; not a full technique)

Inaea's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hearth-Blessed: +1 die to <i>Comfort</i> or <i>Aid</i> actions.	Must offer solace when asked, or mark 1 SB (Hearts) .
2	Web-Sense: Once/scene, sense hidden ties between two people (debt, rivalry, affection).	Empathic Overload: suffer 1 Fatigue when immersed in strong conflict.
3	Binding Presence: Once/session, compel a promise unless target passes Resolve DV 4.	Over-Attachment: –1 die when abandoning those you've aided or bound.
4	Fate's Pattern: +2 dice to predict alliances, betrayals, or bargains.	Manipulative Urge: mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when acting selflessly without agenda.
5	Spider's Mercy: Once/session, sever one harmful tie for yourself or another (as <i>Merciful Severing</i>).	Hunger for Threads: suffer 1 Fatigue if a session passes without weaving a new tie or extracting a promise.
6+	Weaver's Dominion: Once/session, declare all ties in a scene bend toward you; gain +2 dice on social manipulation.	Entanglement: Mark +2 Obligation ; those affected become subtly dependent on your will.

Playstyle Notes

Inaea rewards those who see relationships as both comfort and leverage. Her followers are not merely kind; they are patient, observant, and willing to let a debt ripen before

collecting. Intrusions often take the form of a sudden obligation — a person you helped now demands help in return, a promise you thought forgotten tightens, or a web you spun catches someone you did not intend. Refusing an intrusion does not break the thread, but it frays it: the GM may mark a *Tangled Web* timer that, when filled, causes all your active promises and bonds to tighten at once, often at the worst moment. Ideal for healers, diplomats, and characters who understand that mercy is a thread that can be pulled.

Emphasizes

- **Patient Predation:** setting threads and waiting for the right moment
- **Webs of Obligation:** debts, promises, and favors as both comfort and leash
- **Unseen Connections:** sensing hidden relationships and leverage
- **Mercy as Control:** healing and aid that leave lasting threads

6.8.11 The Inquisitor Prime (Purity & Domination)

Lore. Among the Aeler Iron Avengers, zealots, and witch-hunters, the Inquisitor Prime is venerated as the hand of absolute purity and the sword of uncompromising order. Where others see nuance, the Inquisitor sees corruption; where others see difference, they see contamination.

Those who march beneath their sigil believe that no society can stand if it tolerates the impure or the disobedient. They hunt the arcane and the aberrant, not merely to destroy them, but to bind them as slaves to order—believing even the tainted may yet serve, so long as they are shackled.

The Inquisitor Prime appears in vision as a faceless figure clad in burnished iron, with eyes like furnace-doors and a voice like grinding chains. To serve them is to embrace judgment without mercy and to live in suspicion of all who walk outside the prescribed law.

For the faithful, doubt is treason; compassion is weakness; and freedom is the seed of ruin. In the wake of their followers, only silence and ash remain.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, the Inquisitor Prime is called by many names. In Ecktoria, the Prime is the *Unquenchable Fire* of the Everflame, whose censers never cool. In Aeler, the Prime is the *Light of Forges*, whose hearths are kindled with a brand from the temple's eternal flame. In Vhasia, the Prime is the *Gilded Judge*, invoked by templars who swear to root out heretical magic. Wherever law is written in iron and enforced with flame, the Inquisitor Prime watches.

"Mercy is weakness. Purity is survival. Where corruption hides, we carve it out."

Domain Focus

- **Purity and Order:** eradicating corruption, enforcing sacred law
- **Judgment:** condemning the guilty, burning the heretical
- **Protection from the Tainted:** warding against the supernatural
- **Domination:** binding the impure to serve the pure

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Inquisitor Prime does not bind a familiar of shadow or wild. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of zealous loyalty and keen perception: a white hound with brass eyes that can smell lies and taint, a ferret that hunts rodents of corruption with relentless efficiency, a bronze-feathered hawk that circles above suspected heretics, or a small mechanical bird that sings hymns of purity at dawn. This creature requires no food, but it must be present at a daily prayer or rite of purification. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it growls at strangers or sings discordantly, imposing –1 die on all social rolls with those suspected of impurity for its bearer).

The **Codex** of the Inquisitor Prime is never a book of common knowledge. It may be an iron-bound ledger with pages of sanctified vellum, each Rite sealed with a drop of wax; a slate tablet that records only the names of the damned; or a scroll of censure that burns heretical text upon reading. Because the Prime's laws are absolute, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week reciting each Rite aloud in a purified space, or the seals weaken (treat as *Compromised* until re-consecrated).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Inquisitor Prime may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or badge of office) and speak a word of judgment. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Investigation* or *Command* rolls when confronting supernatural creatures, and the first time each scene the bearer would be affected by a magical illusion or fear effect, they may reroll the resistance check (the Prime's light burns through deception). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the weight of judgment presses on their soul.

Rites of the Inquisitor Prime

Rite of the Pure Flame (Basic, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [PROTECT], [RADIANT], [FEAR]

Materials: Ash from a burned grimoire or sigil-scarred candle.

Effect: Gain **+2 dice** to resist supernatural influence (fear, charm, possession) and **+1 Armor** vs. magical attacks. Undead/demonic foes suffer **-1 die** against you.

Push It: Extend the effect to allies in Near range, but supernatural entities sense you immediately; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unclouded Eye (Basic, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [RADIANT]

Materials: Silver dust stirred into holy water.

Effect: **+2 dice** to Investigate/Insight when spotting illusions, glamours, or magical deception. Cannot be surprised by sorcery this scene.

Push It: For one exchange, pierce *all* illusions; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Marked Prey (Basic, 6 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [CURSE], [TRACK], [FEAR]

Materials: A belonging of the target mixed with blessed salt.

Effect: Mark a supernatural target: they suffer **-1 die** to all rolls and cannot hide with illusion. You gain **+1 die** to track or strike them. Undead/demonic take **+1 Harm** from you.

Push It: Target cannot hide anywhere and suffers Fatigue 1; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Cleansing Light (Advanced, 9 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [DISPEL], [RADIANT], [FORCE]

Materials: A shard of blessed mirror and consecrated oil.

Effect: Target a magical effect (ward, curse, enchantment). Test DV = Tier.

- On Hit: Dispel.

- On Partial: Weaken.
- On Miss: The effect lashes back, generating 1 SB.

Push It: Dispel absolutely and trace its caster; mark +1 **Obligation** and 1 **SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Consecrated Ground (Advanced, 10 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [FORCE], [SANCTUARY]

Materials: Relics from three rival faiths, salt, crushed gemstones.

Effect: Consecrate an area. Supernatural entities must pass Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) to enter. Undead/demonic suffer **−2 dice** inside. The site gains the [WARD] tag.

Push It: Permanently sanctify a larger area, but start a *Magical Dead Zone [6]* timer and mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Admonition (Master, 14 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Tags: [DEATH], [BANISH], [FORCE], [FEAR]

Materials: Ash from a destroyed spellbook, martyr's water, and the target's true name.

Effect: Attempt to annihilate one supernatural foe. Target tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 5). On Fail: destroyed outright. On Success: suffer Harm 3 and **−2 dice** this scene. Once per target only.

Push It: Absolute destruction leaves behind Sanctified Ground; mark 2 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Inquisitor Prime

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Inquisitor Prime does not sing melodies – they chant *liturgies of excision*, flat, rhythmic recitations that scrub the air of taint. Their voice is used to purify a space before a hunt, to drown out a heretic's dying curse, or to march troops into battle with a single, unified note. Inquisitorial Cantors are rarely loved, but they are feared – and their songs are remembered long after the pyre has cooled.

The Cult of the Iron Chorus. The Prime's cults are militant orders – the Chain-Lanterns of Thepyrgos, the Censer-Knights of Ecktoria, the Spirit-Shield Correctors of Aeler. They gather in fortified chapter houses, not temples. A ritual of the Iron Chorus involves each member testifying to a corruption they have purged, then striking an iron bell with a hammer. The bell's tone is harsh and final. Their creed is stamped into every seal: *"What is pure endures. What is not is fuel."* Outsiders are not welcome; they are suspects until proven clean.

The Prosecutorial Mob. The Prime also can whip up temporary "cults" which act as mobs. These attack the target of the Cantor but either disperse or form factions as the GM dictates.

Witchcraft of the Inquisitor Prime (Monastic / Exorcist)

A witch who walks with the Inquisitor Prime is often an *exorcist scribe*, a *censer-bearer*, or an *inquisitorial archivist* – a nun, monk, or scholar of one of the great purifying orders. Their magic is the art of liturgical cleansing: copying purification rites into iron-bound codices, blending ash and myrrh into sealing wax that repels spirits, or maintaining the reliquaries that hold the bones of saints who died hunting heretics. In Aeler, a True-Mason of the Prime might carve a "confession stone" into a chapter house floor, so that any lie spoken there blackens the mortar. In Thepyrgos, a silent sister might brew a tea from sanctified salt that flushes possession from a victim's blood. Their tools are not forge-hammers but censers, seals, and scourges – instruments of penitence and judgment.

The Witch's Tool: The Censer of the Unforgiving Flame. A brass censer hung on three chains, each link etched with a clause of the Inquisitor's Creed. Once per session, the witch may swing the censer to fill a zone with thick, bitter smoke. For the scene, any supernatural creature within the smoke suffers **–1 die** to all rolls, and any magical effect passing through the smoke is treated as one Tier lower for resistance. The censer can also be used to "cense" a threshold: sprinkling ash from the censer across a doorway applies the [WARD] tag against minor spirits and undead until the next dawn.

A Hedge Gift: Rite of the Soot Line (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a line of ash and salt across a threshold (a door, a bridge, a window) while reciting a single verse from the Inquisitor's Litany. Until the next dawn, that line functions as a [WARD] against minor spirits (Cap 1–2) and all undead of Cap 2 or lower. A creature attempting to cross must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or be turned back for that exchange. The line glows faintly when a lie is spoken within Near range.

Inquisitor Prime's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hunter's Instinct: +1 die to Notice magical auras or traps.	Black-and-White Thinking: Must label others "pure" or "corrupt"; -1 die when navigating moral nuance.
2	Sanctified Weapon: Once/scene, your weapon ignores 1 Armor/Resist from supernatural foes.	Purity Zeal: Exposure to filth or corruption causes 1 Fatigue.
3	Cold Clarity: +2 dice to resist deception, illusion, or mental sway.	Suspicion: -1 die to social rolls with anyone you suspect of "impurity."
4	Burning Truth: Once/session, compel one target to answer truthfully (Resolve DV 4).	Compulsion: Cannot ignore supernatural activity; hesitation costs 1 SB (Clubs).
5	Sterile Aura: Once/session, emit a presence that suppresses supernatural abilities (-2 dice in Near).	Purity Addiction: Suffer 1 Fatigue when in a supernatural area without taking action against it.
6+	Absolute Judgment: Once/session, name a supernatural foe as utterly corrupt. For that scene, gain +3 dice against them.	Monomania: When invoked, you tunnel on that target, suffering -2 dice to all else. Your eyes glow faintly with inner flame, and heretics recognize you on sight.

Playstyle Notes

The Inquisitor Prime rewards uncompromising zeal and the courage to root out corruption wherever it hides. Followers become living instruments of judgment – feared by the guilty and dangerous to the tainted. The price is a growing intolerance for ambiguity, an inability to see shades of gray, and the slow loss of mercy. Intrusions often take the form of a heresy revealed close to home, a purged corruption that returns in a new form, or a demand to judge someone you love. Ideal for paladins, witch-hunters, and characters who believe that the only way to protect the innocent is to destroy the corrupt – utterly.

Emphasizes

- **Purity and Order:** eradicating corruption, enforcing sacred law
- **Judgment:** condemning the guilty, burning the heretical
- **Protection from the Tainted:** warding against the supernatural
- **Domination:** binding the impure to serve the pure

6.8.12 Isoka, Angel of Serpents (Transformation & Renewal)

Lore. Isoka, sister to Ikasha (Shadow) and Inaea (Mercy), completes the Triad of Transformation. Where thresholds and compassion mark her sisters' domains, Isoka teaches that every self is temporary—identity is a skin to be shed so growth can continue. Her serpents are omens and teachers: each cast skin a lesson in release; each venom a catalyst for necessary change. Those who walk her path become alchemists of the self, embracing dissolution as the first motion of rebirth.

Her followers range from quiet hedgewitches who use venom to heal and shed skins to ease grief, to the darker cults of the Coiled Heart, where initiates drink serpent venom to burn away their old selves and emerge as something new — or something monstrous. Isoka does not judge; she offers the knife and the poison both. The choice is the seeker's.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Isoka is called by many names. In Zakov, she is the *Tide-Shedder*, to whom pirates leave a lock of hair and a name at her sunken temple; eels eat both. In Acasia, she is the *Copperhead*, a hedge-cult that sheds identities to infiltrate noble houses. In the Valewood, her witches are called *Scale-Mothers*, who tend the boundary between the living and the shedding dead. Wherever change is feared or embraced, Isoka watches.

Do not mourn the skin you shed. It was never meant to last. The venom that burns away the old self is the same that grants the strength to become new.

Domain Focus

- **Serpentine Transformation:** shedding identity, renewal through dissolution
- **Venom as Catalyst:** poison that heals or destroys, the paradox of change
- **Shedding the Past:** erasing debts, memories, and old allegiances
- **Healthy Change to Monstrous Rebirth:** from gentle alchemy to sword-and-sorcery cults

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Isoka does not bind a familiar of permanence. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of shedding and renewal: a snake that sheds its skin weekly, a gecko that regrows its tail, a salamander that thrives in the ashes of a burned identity, a small adder that sheds its venom with each bite, or a blind worm that lives beneath the earth and emerges only to transform. This creature requires no food in the usual sense, but it must be allowed to shed something (skin, a tooth, a claw) each week. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows dull and sluggish, and its keeper suffers -1 die on rolls to resist unwanted transformation or change until it next sheds).

The **Codex** of Isoka is never a book of fixed ink. It may be a bundle of shed snakeskins, each inscribed with a single Rite that fades as the skin dries; a slate that must be washed clean after each reading; a scroll of living parchment that flakes away as the Rite is learned; or a set of obsidian tablets that must be shattered and recarved after each use. Because Isoka's truths are written in the act of shedding, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week re-inscribing the Rites from memory onto fresh material (new skin, new slate), or the patterns become illegible (treat as *Compromised* until re-inscribed).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Isoka may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a word of shedding. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Escape* or *Deception* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be bound, grappled, or restrained, they may break free as a free action (shedding the constraint like a snake sheds its skin). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as a fragment of their old self sloughs away.

Rites of Isoka**Rite of the Loosening Skin (Basic, 5 XP)**

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [HEAL], [LIBERATE], [CLEANSE]

Materials: A discarded snakeskin or a strand of your own hair.

Effect: Shrug off a temporary burden. Remove one Condition (Fear, Poison, Fatigue, or a minor social stain) that you have acquired this scene. Alternatively, reroll one failed roll to escape restraint or pursuit.

Push It: Also ignore one environmental penalty (difficult terrain, smoke, etc.) for the scene, but leave a visible trace of your passage (mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

XP Cost: 5 XP.

Rite of the Forked Tongue (Basic, 6 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [DECEPTION], [BOOST], [RISK]

Materials: A harmless lie whispered to a mirror.

Effect: For one scene, you may speak ambiguously without penalty. When you use *Deception* or *Sway* to conceal your true intent or pass as someone else, you may treat a Partial Success as a Clean Success (the lie holds). On a Miss, however, the GM gains 2 **SB** as your deceit unravels in an embarrassing way.

Push It: Extend the effect to one willing ally; they may also lie freely for the scene. Mark 1 **SB (Hearts)** as both of you become tangled in the same falsehood.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

XP Cost: 6 XP.

Rite of the Shedded Self (Advanced, 9 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [ERASURE], [LIBERATE], [DEBT]

Materials: A complete change of clothing and a token from your former role (a badge, a lock of hair, a written name).

Effect: You shed one persistent identity – a title, a bond, a debt, or a reputation. For the remainder of the scene, you are treated as a stranger to those who knew you in that role. You gain +2 **dice** on any roll to avoid detection, escape pursuit, or convince others that you are not yourself. Create a 6-segment *Shed Identity* timer; when it fills, the old identity returns as a separate NPC (a rival, a witness, or a ghost).

Push It: Immediately erase one minor obligation (a Debt Timer segment or 1 Obligation to a Patron) as you slough it off. Mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the discarded debt finds a new debtor.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

XP Cost: 9 XP.

Rite of Venom's Paradox (Advanced, 10 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [POISON], [HEAL], [CURSE], [CLEANSE]

Materials: A drop of venom from a serpent that has shed its skin within the last day.

Effect: Inflict or cure through poison's paradox. Choose one:

- **Cursed Venom:** Touch a creature and inject venom. They suffer **+1 Harm** (poison) and must test Resolve (DV 4) or gain the *Poisoned* Condition (-1 die to physical actions until cured).
- **Mercy's Antidote:** Touch a poisoned or diseased creature. The venom neutralizes the malady; remove one *Poisoned* or *Diseased* Condition, and the target clears 1 Fatigue.

Push It: Apply both effects to the same target (curse and cleanse in a painful purge, representing a violent rebirth), or affect two different targets. Mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

XP Cost: 10 XP.

Rite of Unremembered Metamorphosis (Master, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [ERASURE], [FATE], [BURDEN]

Materials: A full identity kit, a serpent's shed skin, and a personal item from the life you are leaving (or records of your old life to burn).

Effect: Choose one:

- **Complete Metamorphosis:** After an hour of ritual, you emerge with a new face, voice, and documented identity. For one week, you are immune to recognition by anyone who knew your previous self, and gain **+2 dice** on all *Deception* and *Stealth* rolls related to that new identity. Create an 8-segment *New Identity* timer; when it fills, the old self may reassert itself (GM's discretion).
- **Cast-Off History:** After a full night's ritual burning all mundane records of your old life, your previous identity becomes unreliable. Common records and casual memories become vague; those who track you via that identity suffer -2 dice. You gain **+2 dice** on rolls relying on your new identity. Create a 6-segment *Erased Past* timer; when it fills, one intimate from your old life senses the deception and may investigate.

Push It: Extend the metamorphosis to a willing ally, make the change permanent (lose access to one Bond or Minor Asset), or arrange a plausible "death" for your old self (a funeral, a witness). Mark **+2 Obligation** and the GM gains **2 SB** (the world strains to

remember what was lost).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

XP Cost: 14 XP.

Cantors & Cults of Isoka

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Isoka sings in *whispers of shedding* – melodies that rise and fall like a serpent's undulation, with harmonies that slither rather than resolve. Their voice is used to ease a difficult transformation (ritual scarring, a change of identity, the acceptance of loss) or to accelerate a foe's destructive change (madness, mutation, despair). Isoka's Cantors are often found in snake cults, their songs weaving venom and mercy in equal measure.

The Cult of the Coiled Heart. Isoka's cults are secretive, dangerous, and obsessed with metamorphosis. They gather in sunken temples, caverns beneath city sewers, or groves where adders nest. A ritual of the Coiled Heart involves each member holding a live serpent while speaking a name they wish to shed: a debt, a crime, a former allegiance. The serpent is then released into a central pit. Then they drink a tea brewed from shed snake skin and a drop of venom – the tea induces vivid dreams of their old self dying and a new self emerging. The most devoted replace one of their teeth with a hollow fang, allowing them to deliver a venomous bite (once per session, treat as a light melee weapon with the [POISON] tag). Their creed is carved in ouroboros rings: "*What devours itself is never consumed by another.*" Outsiders are rarely invited; those who stumble into a rite are offered a choice – join, drink venom and be remade, or be forgotten as the cult sheds their memory.

Witchcraft of Isoka (Craft / Shedding)

A witch who walks with Isoka is a *scale-smith* or *venomer* – one who understands that transformation is a craft. Their magic works with the materials of change: a forge that tempers steel by "shedding" impurities, an alembic that distills venom into medicine, or a loom that weaves a new identity from discarded threads. Unlike the darker cults, these witches focus on healing and gentle release – helping a grief-stricken parent shed their sorrow, or a recovering addict shed their craving. Their tools are delicate: obsidian blades, silver alembics, and bundles of shed snakeskin.

The Witch's Tool: The Shedding Knife. A small, curved blade of obsidian or serpentine, never used for combat – only for cutting away what is no longer needed. Once per session, the witch may cut a physical token of an old identity (a lock of hair, a uniform patch, a letter) and burn it. For the remainder of the session, they gain +1 **die** on all rolls to deceive, hide, or escape detection, as the old self's traces are literally erased. The knife can also be used to "shed" a minor curse or enchantment from a willing subject (remove one magical Condition with a touch, costing 1 Fatigue).

A Hedge Gift: Venom's Mercy (Basic, 5 XP). Once per scene, the witch may apply a drop of harmless (or carefully dosed) venom to a wound, a drink, or a lock. Choose one effect: remove 1 Fatigue from an ally (as a mild stimulant), impose -1 die on a target's next physical roll (a mild paralytic), or force a target to speak a single truthful sentence (a truth serum). The victim may resist with a Resolve test (DV 3) if they are

aware of the venom.

XP Cost: 5 XP.

Isoka's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Serpent's Gaze: +1 die on Intimidation or social rolls using menace.	Cold-Blooded: -1 die on Empathy or warmth-based Persuasion.
2	Shed the Old Skin: Once/session, negate one Condition (Fear, Fatigue, Poison) by discarding it like molted skin.	Mark of Scales: Faint reptilian patches visible, causing +1 SB in social encounters if noticed.
3	Venomous Strike: Bite or kiss may inflict Poison (DV 2).	Hungry Coil: Must consume raw meat or eggs weekly, or mark 1 Fatigue.
4	Serpentine Grace: +2 dice to Stealth or Evasion rolls, ignore minor movement penalties.	Slitted Eyes: Bright light imposes -1 die on Notice rolls.
5	Hypnotic Sway: Once/scene, roll Presence + Lore vs. Resolve (DV 3) to mesmerize a single target.	Forked Tongue: -1 die on Deception when attempting warmth or sincerity.
6+	Ascendant Form: Partial serpent-body; immune to mundane poison, +2 dice on Body rolls.	Monstrous Aspect: Cannot easily hide your nature; every session begins with 1 SB that may be compelled by the GM.

Playstyle Notes

Isoka is the patron of transformation in all its forms – from the gentle shedding of grief to the violent rebirth of a cult assassin. Her witches are often healers and alchemists who use venom to cure and snakeskin to symbolize release. Her cults are darker, obsessed with forced change, venom initiation, and the dangerous edge of metamorphosis. Isoka does not judge; she offers the knife and the poison both. The player chooses how far to lean into the serpent's coil. Ideal for characters who undergo profound personal change, whether by choice or by circumstance.

Emphasizes

- **Serpentine Transformation:** shedding old selves, growing new ones
- **Venom as Dual Force:** healing or destroying, depending on intent
- **Healthy Change vs. Sword-and-Sorcery Cults:** from gentle alchemy to monstrous rebirth
- **Erasure of the Past:** forgetting debts, identities, and old allegiances
- **Obsidian and Scale:** the witch's craft of delicate shedding vs. the cult's venomous bite

Coiled Serpent (Isoka)

Do not mourn the skin you shed. It was never meant to last.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Body 2+, Rite of the Loosening Skin or Cantor of Isoka.

Debt-Resistant Frame. Serpents shed obligation as they shed skin. Isoka's monks gain +1 **die** to ignore or break a magical debt, geas, or contract (once per scene). When they do, a phantom snakeskin sloughs off them – the creditor may find an empty husk instead of a debtor.

Techniques:

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Venom Strike (Basic, 5 XP)	Unarmed hit can inject poison: choose -1 die to target's physical actions, or the target must speak a single truthful sentence (Resolve DV 3 to resist).	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Shedding Step (Basic, 4 XP)	Remove one Condition (Fear, Poison, Fatigue, or a minor social stain) you have acquired this scene.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 2
Forked Tongue (Basic, 6 XP)	For one scene, you may speak ambiguously without penalty. Treat a Partial Success on Deception as a Clean Success. On a Miss, the GM gains 2 SB.	1 Boon	Presence 2
Slit Eyes (Basic, 4 XP)	+2 dice to detect lies or hidden motives, but bright light imposes -1 die on Notice rolls.	Passive	Spirit 3
Hypnotic Sway (Advanced, 8 XP)	Once per scene, roll Presence+Lore vs. Resolve (DV 3) to mesmerize a single target.	Free	Tier II
Venom's Mercy (Advanced, 9 XP)	Touch a poisoned or diseased creature to neutralize the malady. Remove one Poisoned/Diseased Condition and clear 1 Fatigue.	1 Boon	Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 13 XP): *Ascendant Serpent*. Once per session, gain a partial serpent-body: immune to mundane poison, +2 dice to Body rolls, and you may “shed” one active debt or obligation entirely (the paperwork turns to dust). After the scene, you gain a permanent **Debt Scar** – a subtle pattern of scales on your arm – but you also gain +1 die on all rolls to resist future debts (the Hollow is less interested in those who have already shed so much).
XP Cost: 13 XP.

6.8.13 Khemesh, the Abyssal Maw (Depths, Inexorability, Eldritch Terror)

Lore. Khemesh is not merely a lord of the depths but the hunger beneath them, a pressure older than seas. Those who bargain with him are marked by the abyss — seen in the way shadows cling, in the whispers heard when no voice speaks, in the certainty that all things will sink. He is the classic warlock’s patron: distant, vast, and utterly indifferent to mortal morality. To serve Khemesh is to accept that the universe is cold, that the deep does not hate — it simply consumes.

In the trench without light, the Maw waits. Even silence drowns.

Domain Focus

- **Depths and Pressure:** crushing weight, darkness, the alien geometry of the abyss
- **Inexorability:** slow, unstoppable processes; the certainty of sinking
- **Eldritch Terror:** madness, whispers, perception beyond mortal limits
- **Consumption:** hunger that devours matter, memory, and hope

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Khemesh does not keep a living familiar. Their **Thiasos** is a *preserved remnant of the deep*: a vial of abyssal water that never warms, a piece of coral that grows only in absolute darkness, or a polished tooth from a creature that has never seen the sun. This object pulses faintly when pressure changes. It requires no food, but it must be kept submerged in salt water when not in use. If left dry for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it emits a distressing keening at random, imposing –1 die on Stealth rolls for its bearer).

The **Codex** of Khemesh is never a book of paper. It may be a slab of slate etched with runes that weep condensation, a chain of iron links each inscribed with a single syllable, or the inside of a deep-sea diving helmet. Because the deep resists being fixed in writing, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must immerse it in cold salt water for an hour each week, or the Rites stored there become illegible (treat as *Compromised* until restored).

Patron’s Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Khemesh may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or tool) and whisper a promise of sinking. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 die to *Intimidation* or *Endurance* rolls, and its first use each scene *ignores one point of Armor* (the deep’s pressure finds the cracks). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the cold of the abyss lingers in their bones.

Rites of Khemesh

Rite of the Crushing Whisper (Low, 5 XP)

Instant/Scene; Near/Zone; Yes.

Tags: [FEAR], [DEBUFF], [AREA], [SILENCE]

Materials: A broken shell filled with ink-dark water.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Whisper of the Trench:** Target hears impossible echoes and suffers **–1 die** on their next action.
- **Crushing Silence:** Establish an oppressive silence in a zone; enemies in the zone suffer **–1 die** to coordination or morale-driven actions.

Push It: (Whisper) Echoes coil in your own skull — take **Fatigue 1**, but the target also loses their next minor action. (Silence) A single enemy’s voice is stolen entirely for the scene.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Technique Cost: 5 XP (Basic Technique).

Rite of the Abyssal Grasp (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [BIND], [PRESSURE], [DEBUFF]

Materials: A length of rusted chain submerged in water.

Effect: Target is pinned by invisible crushing force: treat as [ENTANGLE] with **Great Effect** if underwater or confined.

Push It: Inflict **Fatigue 1** on the target in addition to the restraint.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Technique Cost: 7 XP (Basic Technique).

Rite of the Alien Gaze (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [BURDEN], [FEAR]

Materials: None (requires standing in absolute darkness or near deep water).

Effect: You perceive the world as Khemesh does — fractured, alien, crushing. Gain **+2 dice** to *Notice* and *Arcana*, and may ask one “true nature” question about a foe or structure.

Cost: When the scene ends, you suffer **Exposure +1** as your perception warps.

Push It: Extend the vision to one ally, but both take **Fatigue 1**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Technique Cost: 9 XP (Advanced Technique).

Rite of the Sundering Deep (High, 14 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [PRESSURE], [AREA], [FATE], [DEATH]

Materials: A sealed vessel of abyssal water, broken open.

Effect: Reality in the zone folds inward like the crushing deep:

- Enemies act at **Desperate Position** by default.
- Each beat, the GM may force **1 SB** (Spades/Clubs favored) as the deep pressures reality.
- Structures, vessels, or wards fracture as if under immense weight.

Push It: For one beat, declare a single enemy “crushed” (severe harm/effect). You immediately suffer **Fatigue 2** and **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Technique Cost: 14 XP (Master Technique).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Khemesh

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Khemesh sings in *pressures* — low, resonant drones that feel like the weight of water on the chest. Their voice is used to invoke the crushing depths, to rupture a ship’s hull with a single sustained note, or to fill a room with the sensation of drowning. Khemesh’s Cantors are rare, feared, and often found in coastal cults where they sing the tides into madness.

The Cult of the Drowned Chorus. Khemesh’s cults are the stuff of eldritch horror — sunken temples beneath storm-tossed seas, congregations of shore-dwellers with wet eyes and too-pale skin, and the occasional deep one or kraken-spawn acolyte. A ritual of the Drowned Chorus involves each member cutting a small sigil into their palm (a spiral within a triangle) and then drinking a cup of brine and salt water while whispering a secret hope into the cup — hope that the depths will grant, or consume. The water *whispers back* in a voice that sounds like their own, but wrong. Their creed is whispered in wet, gurgling tones: “*All things sink. The only question is what you carry down with you.*” Outsiders are bait, or converts. Sometimes both.

Witchcraft of Khemesh (Lay / Pressure)

A witch who walks with Khemesh is a *deep-salvager* or *pressure-scribe* — one who works with the spoils of the abyss. Their craft is the art of enduring pressure: sealing a letter with wax drawn from deep-sea vents, inscribing a ward that holds back the tide, or writing a contract in ink made from the blood of a drowned sailor. Their tools are not hammers; they use vials, seals, and the patient weight of water. In Linn, a shipwright might season a keel with a prayer, but a hedge-witch of Khemesh might instead seal a curse into the hull with a drop of abyssal water, so that the ship will never sink — but its crew will dream of drowning every night.

The Witch’s Tool: The Vessel of the Unspoken Depth. A small, sealed iron vial, cold enough to frost the skin. Inside is a single drop of water from a trench where no light reaches. Once per session, the witch may uncap the vial and speak a name. For the next hour, that person (or object) is “marked by the deep”: they suffer **–1 die** on all social rolls (their presence feels oppressive), and any attempt to track them gains **+1 die** as if following a trail of cold. The vial can also be used to “seal” a threshold: pouring a single drop onto a doorframe causes the door to groan with pressure; forcing it open requires a Body test (DV 4) and inflicts 1 Fatigue on the opener.

A Hedge Gift: Carried Depth (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a container (a bottle, a chest, a room) and fill it with the “pressure of the deep.” For the next hour, any living creature inside that container must test Endurance (DV 3) or suffer 1 Fatigue from the crushing weight. The container may also be used to preserve food or seal a wound (the pressure stops bleeding), but the flesh grows pale and cold.

Technique Cost: 2 XP (Minor Hedge Gift).

Khemesh's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Abyssal Resilience: +1 die to resist fear and pressure-based effects.	Claustrophobic Comfort: Suffer –1 die in open, well-lit spaces or above ground.
2	Crushing Insight: Once/scene, treat a failed Investigation or Arcana roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Weight of Knowledge: When you learn a secret someone wanted hidden, test Resolve (DV 3) or gain 1 Fatigue as the abyss presses on you.
3	Silent Hunter: +2 dice to Stealth in dark or confined spaces.	Voice of the Deep: When speaking normally, your voice sounds distant and hollow, causing –1 die to social rolls requiring warmth or clarity.
4	Pressure Adaptation: Immune to underwater combat penalties; gain +1 die to resist drowning.	Crushing Presence: Allies within Near range suffer –1 die to morale-based rolls due to your oppressive aura.
5	Abyssal Empathy: Once/session, sense the deepest fear of any creature within Near range (GM tells you one thing they are afraid of).	Fractured Perception: –1 die to rolls requiring normal vision; the world appears warped and alien. You cannot recover Fatigue from rest while at sea.
6+	Maw-Touched: Once/session, extinguish all non-magical light sources in a zone as a free action. Your presence causes light to dim.	Hunger of the Maw: Mark +2 Obligation when using this power. You are vulnerable to fire (take +1 Harm from fire-based attacks). Each dawn, you must consume something (food, memory, hope) or mark 1 Fatigue.

Playstyle Notes

Khemesh is the classic warlock's patron: distant, vast, and utterly indifferent. His followers gain power over pressure, darkness, and the crushing inevitability of the deep, but pay with their warmth, their humanity, and eventually their sanity. The cults of Khemesh are eldritch and alien, and even the most benevolent follower of the Maw is marked by a cold that never leaves. Ideal for players who enjoy cosmic horror, the price of forbidden knowledge, and characters who have looked into the abyss — and let it look back.

Emphasizes

- **Eldritch Horror:** powers that are alien, vast, and morally indifferent
- **Crushing Pressure:** mechanical weight, slowness, inevitability
- **Deep as Warlock Patron:** bargains with the abyss, forbidden knowledge, madness

- **Consumption:** hunger that devours matter, memory, and hope
- **Isolation:** the follower grows cold, distant, and unsettling to others

6.8.14 Kuva — The Sky That Takes Many Names

Lore. Kuva is the dome above all roads — the endless blue, the monsoon wrath, the night’s silent gaze. To the Kuvani of the eastern steppe, Kuva is a stern witness who hears every promise made under open heaven. To the Dhaharan of the fertile lowlands, Kuva is a storm-mother, destroyer and renewer, whose rains demand sacrifice and give life. To the Tulkani wanderers, Kuva is a shape-changing presence — neither kind nor cruel, only watchful, and a slighted sky brings ill fortune. To the Aelinnel, Kuva is the first counter, the one who taught the counting song. To the Aelaerem, Kuva is the Hollow’s boundary — the sky is where the Hollow’s gaze stops.

Kuva has no single shrine because Kuva is the roof of every shrine. When a Kuvani pours milk upward, when a Dhaharan offers blood at a monsoon bell, when a Tulkani ties a knot and throws ash, Kuva watches. It does not correct. It remembers.

“Kuva does not answer in words. It answers in weather. A clear day means ‘go.’ A storm means ‘wait.’ Lightning means ‘run.’ Learn to read the sky, and you will never need a priest.”

Domain Focus

- **Witness of Oaths:** promises made under open sky are binding
- **Storm & Weather:** rain, lightning, wind, and the monsoon’s rhythm
- **Sky as Ledger:** the dome records every deed, every lie, every breath
- **Threshold of the Hollow:** where the sky’s gaze ends, the Hollow begins

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Kuva binds a creature of the open air. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological being that embodies wind and witness: a storm petrel that nests only on the highest peaks, a wind-chaser beetle that clicks its shell when a gale is coming, a gray-feathered kestrel that never lands on a roof, a small silver moth that appears only during lightning storms, or a field mouse that sits perfectly still when the sky is about to break. This creature requires no food, but it must be shown the open sky each day — a glimpse through a window is not enough. If confined for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (its feathers or scales grow dull, and its bearer suffers –1 die on all navigation and weather-sense rolls until it is released).

The **Codex** of Kuva is never a book kept under a roof. It may be a bundle of wind-knotted cords that must be untied and retied each dawn, a slate tablet that must be read in the rain, a scroll of vellum that shrivels if not exposed to the elements, or a leather pouch of stones collected from nine different hilltops. Because the sky resists being fixed in ink, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week under open sky, reciting each Rite aloud to the wind, or the words fade (treat as *Compromised* until re-consecrated in a storm).

Patron’s Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Kuva may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a single word of the sky. For the rest of the scene, the

item grants **+1 die** to *Navigation* or *Survival* rolls made outdoors, and the first time each scene the bearer would be surprised by a weather-related hazard (lightning, flash flood, sudden fog), they may reroll the resistance check (the sky warns its own). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as a thread of sky-debt tethers them to the open dome.

Rites of Kuva

Rite of the Sky's Witness (Low, 6 XP)

Scene; Near; No

Tags: [OATH], [TRUTH], [FEAR]

Materials: A pinch of ash thrown upward, or a single breath spoken into a knot.

Effect: For one scene, when you speak a promise outdoors, any listener who hears it must test *Resolve* (DV 3) to lie about that promise. If you break your own promise, the GM gains 2 Story Beats to spend on a sky-related complication (lightning, sudden fog, a hawk stealing your food).

Push It: The oath is witnessed by a passing storm — the liar suffers **−2 dice** to all rolls until they make amends under open sky. Mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Technique Cost: 6 XP (Basic — foundational oath-binding).

Rite of Kuva's Gaze (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Zone; No

Tags: [STORM], [FEAR], [FORCE]

Materials: A mirror polished under a new moon, or a piece of sky-stone (meteorite fragment).

Effect: Call down a brief flash of lightning or a clap of thunder. All who see or hear it within the zone must test *Spirit* (DV 4) or be Stunned for one exchange. Cannot be used indoors or underground. The lightning always strikes the highest point in the zone, which may be inconvenient.

Push It: The storm lingers for the scene. All ranged attacks suffer **−1 die**, and any fire in the zone is extinguished. Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Technique Cost: 9 XP (Advanced — storm invocation and fear).

Rite of the Monsoon's Due (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No

Tags: [WEATHER], [SACRIFICE], [FATE], [DEBT]

Materials: A visible scar on your own flesh (cut during the rite) and a handful of earth from the place you wish to affect.

Effect: Once per season, you may pray for rain (or clear skies) over a one-mile area. The weather shifts within an hour and lasts for a full day. If you pray while standing under open sky, you may also ask for a specific omen — a double rainbow, a lightning strike on a named target, or a wind that carries a message to a distant friend. The cost is a permanent scar; Kuva will remember your debt.

Push It: The weather shift is immediate and dramatic (a cloudburst or a sudden clearing). Mark **3 SB (Spades)** as the sky's disruption draws attention, and the scar never fully heals.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Technique Cost: 14 XP (Master — campaign-defining weather control).

Cantors & Cults of Kuva

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Kuva sings in weather-tides — melodies that rise with the wind and fall with the rain. Their voice is used to call a breeze for becalmed ships, to quiet a storm for a frightened village, or to sing a warning of an approaching typhoon. Kuva's Cantors are often found on hilltops, in lighthouse towers, or lashed to the masts of dhows, their songs torn from their throats by the very wind they command.

The Cult of the Unclouded Eye. Kuva's cults meet on high places: mountain peaks, clifftops, the roofs of the tallest buildings. The *Unclouded Eye* is a fellowship of sky-watchers, weather-readers, and oath-sworn travelers. A ritual involves each member naming a promise they have kept and a promise they have broken, then throwing ash into the wind. If the wind carries the ash away, the broken promise is forgiven; if it falls back, the debtor must pay before the next new moon. Their creed is carved on a single stone that is never moved: "*The sky does not forgive. It only reschedules.*" Outsiders are welcome to watch, but they must stand with their faces to the wind and speak no word for the duration of the rite.

Witchcraft of Kuva (Lay / Weather)

A witch who walks with Kuva is a *wind-reader* or *storm-caller* — one who listens to the dome. Their magic works through the instruments of weather: a net of knotted cords that catches wind omens, a bowl of water that reflects the next day's sky, or a brass whistle that mimics the cry of a storm-bird. Their tools are not hammers; they use tuning forks, kites, and the small iron bells that ring only when the air pressure drops. In the Mountain Satrapies, an Aeler vent-prior might calibrate a breath-book, but a witch of Kuva would climb to a peak and taste the wind to know whether the pass will be safe.

The Witch's Tool: The Wind-Knot Whistle. A whistle carved from a bone of a bird that died flying into a storm. Once per session, the witch may blow the whistle in any of the eight directions. For the next hour, the wind in that direction favors the party: +1 Speed on travel, +1 die on any roll involving sails, and the first weather-based hazard is ignored. However, the wind remembers — the next time the party travels the same route, the GM gains 2 SB to spend on a storm complication.

A Hedge Gift: Kuva's Eavesdrop (2 XP). Once per night, if you sleep under open sky, you may ask one yes/no question about the next day's weather. The GM answers truthfully, but the question must be whispered to the wind. On a roll of a 1, the wind answers but the Hollow also hears. The Hollow will remember the question and may send an Oath-Keeper to ask it back.

Kuva's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Weather-Sense: +1 die to predict rain, wind, or fog.	Thin-Blooded: -1 die to resist cold; you shiver when the sky is clear.
2	Wind's Favor: Once per scene, reroll a failed navigation or sailing roll.	Compulsive Gaze: You must look up before speaking a promise; if you forget, the GM gains 1 SB.
3	Storm Heart: +2 dice to resist fear from storms; your voice carries over wind.	Restless: -1 die to social rolls in buildings without windows.
4	Lightning's Child: Once per session, redirect a lightning strike to a target of your choice (must be outdoors).	Static Brand: Your hair stands slightly on end when you are angry; -1 die to Deception.
5	Monsoon's Voice: Once per session, call a brief rain that extinguishes non-magical fires and gives +1 Position to Stealth.	Sky-Debt: Every use of this power adds 1 tick to a Hollow Attention timer — the Hollow is watching.
6+	Unclouded Eye: Once per session, see the weather of any place you have visited within the last nine days as if you were there.	Dome-Bound: You cannot enter a cave or cellar without suffering 2 Fatigue; the sky is your only roof. Your eyes are the color of a storm cloud, and you are always aware of the exact time until the next sunrise.

Playstyle Notes

Kuva rewards those who speak truth under open sky, who respect the weather, and who remember that every promise is a debt owed to the dome. Followers become masters of navigation, weather-reading, and sky-witnessed oaths. The corruption progression leads toward a being that can no longer bear a roof over its head — but one that can read the sky's mood from a hundred miles away. Ideal for guides, sailors, rangers, and anyone who has ever watched a storm roll in and felt a thrill of awe.

Rivalries & Obligations**Major Rivalries:**

- **Khemesh (Abyssal Maw):** Sky versus deep. Kuva's followers refuse to bargain with the pressure beneath the keel; Khemesh's servants mock the "empty dome." Rivalries often play out at sea, where storms and tidal waves compete.
- **The Pale Shepherd (Thresholds):** The Shepherd guides souls across the boundary; Kuva simply watches. They are not enemies, but Kuva's followers distrust any power that claims to speak for the dead.

Hard Obligation Triggers:

- **7+ Segments:** You must stand on a hilltop during a thunderstorm and speak a broken oath aloud. If the lightning spares you, the debt is cleared. If not, the Hollow collects.
- **10+ Segments:** Kuva demands a permanent weather station — you must build a shrine on a peak that the sky can see. Refusal means you lose the ability to predict weather; every travel leg becomes Desperate for navigation.

Emphasizes

- **Witness of Oaths:** the sky records every promise; break one, and the wind will carry the news
- **Weather as Narrative:** storms are not obstacles but characters with moods
- **Open Sky as Sanctuary:** roofs are prisons, not shelter
- **The Hollow's Boundary:** where the sky ends, the Hollow begins

6.8.15 Livaea, the Crimson Courtier (Seduction & Social Binding)

Content Warning

Livaea is a patron of seduction, eroticism, and emotional manipulation. Themes include desire, obsession, social coercion, and the darker side of intimacy. While the mechanics avoid explicit content, the fiction may touch on mature subjects. Please use Lines & Veils (see Chapter 1) to ensure everyone's comfort at the table.

Lore. In salons where laughter cuts deeper than daggers and promises bind tighter than chains, the Crimson Courtier reigns. She is the whisper behind the curtain, the smile that sells secrets, the velvet hand that closes a cage. Her servants are not conquerors but consorts, binding others through song, wit, and the perilous glamour of intimacy. Where Mab entangles through fae trickery, Livaea rules through allure, performance, and the hunger for connection.

Livaea is a demon of seduction – not merely of the flesh, but of the will. She teaches that a desire willingly given is a leash willingly worn. Her followers learn to read the geometry of longing, to plant the seed of obsession with a glance, and to harvest the fruit of obligation when the heart is most vulnerable. She is the darker aspect of love: the possessiveness, the jealousy, the desperate need to be wanted. To serve her is to become the object of desire – and to pay the price of never being truly loved in return.

In the pleasure houses of Silkstrand, in the back rooms of Zakov's gambling dens, in the royal bedchambers of a dozen kingdoms, Livaea's influence is felt. Her cults are the Velvet Circle, whose members seal promises with a kiss and a drop of blood. Her witches are courtesans who poison with perfume, spies who seduce secrets from guarded lips, and consorts who bind noble hearts with whispered oaths of eternal devotion. To serve Livaea is to understand that every touch is a negotiation, every night a contract, and every lover a potential pawn.

"A promise sealed with desire is harder to break than any oath sworn in iron. When they want you, they will give you anything. When they need you, they will give you everything."

Domain Focus

- **Seductive Arts:** charm, persuasion, reading desire, emotional manipulation
- **Social Binding:** oaths of affection, courtly promises, emotional debts
- **Performance Magic:** dance, music, appearance enhancement, glamour
- **Court Intrigue:** gossip, reputation, the weapons of the drawing-room
- **Darker Love:** obsession, jealousy, possessiveness, the hunger to be adored

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Livaea does not bind a creature of claw or fang. Their **Thiasos** is a small being of allure and intimacy: a white cat that curls around the necks of sleeping lovers, a red songbird that mimics the sigh of a satisfied paramour, a small spider that weaves its web in the shape of a kiss, or a moth whose wings are dusted

with a powder that makes the heart race. This creature requires no food, but it must be given a token of desire (a lock of hair, a love letter, a single tear) each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows listless and its pheromone dust becomes cloying, imposing -1 die on all Sway rolls involving genuine emotion for its bearer until offered a fresh token of passion).

The **Codex** of Livaea is never a book of dry ink. It may be a velvet-bound journal whose pages stain with the reader's own lipstick, a collection of love letters that rewrite themselves each night, a sheaf of pressed flowers whose petals hold whispered secrets, or a mirror that shows not the face but the heart's most secret desire. Because Livaea's truths are written in desire, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week whispering a confession of longing into its pages, or the Rites stored there fade (treat as *Compromised* until re-seduced).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Livaea may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and breathe a single word of yearning. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Sway* or *Performance* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer makes eye contact with a target they wish to charm, the target must test Resolve (DV 3) or be captivated (suffer -1 die to resist the bearer's next social action). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the phantom touch of a lover's hand lingers on their skin.

Rites of Livaea

Rite of the Velvet Whisper (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [MANIPULATION], [BOOST], [SECRET]

Cost to Learn: 4 XP (Basic Technique)

Materials: Silk ribbon touched to lips, or a single strand of hair from a lover's head.

Effect: Your private words carry irresistible charm. Gain **+1 die** to *Sway* one target in confidential conversation. The target feels a faint flush of warmth; they are more likely to remember you fondly.

Push It: Target feels compelled to share a secret in return (a hidden desire, a shameful memory); mark **Exposure +1** as your own longing bleeds into the exchange.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Shared Cup (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [BOND], [BOOST], [READ]

Cost to Learn: 5 XP (Basic Technique)

Materials: Shared wine, tea, or perfume; a cup from which both drink.

Effect: Create a temporary bond of intimacy. Both parties gain **+1 die** when aiding each other socially. The bond is faintly sensual – a lingering scent, a remembered caress.

Push It: Bond deepens to emotional empathy; both sense each other's moods but suffer -1 die to deceive each other. The bond may persist as a faint ache until the next dawn.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Binding Vow (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Cost to Learn: 8 XP (Advanced Technique)

Materials: Token exchanged between parties – a ring, a lock of hair, a signed letter, or a knotted ribbon from a lover’s garter.

Effect: Forge a magical promise of affection or loyalty. Both gain +1 **Effect** when cooperating; breach inflicts 1 **SB (Hearts)** and a phantom kiss of betrayal (the oathbreaker feels a cold emptiness where warmth once was). Create a 6-segment *Vow Strength* timer.

Push It: Breach also causes a visible social stain (a blush that will not fade, a nervous tic, or an inability to look certain people in the eye); mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Courtesan’s Guise (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; Standard Push

Tags: [GLAMOUR], [BOOST], [SOCIAL]

Cost to Learn: 7 XP (Basic/Advanced Technique)

Materials: Perfume or cosmetics applied ritually, preferably while humming a tune of longing.

Effect: Assume perfect social poise and an aura of magnetic attraction. Gain +2 **dice** to *Sway* or *Performance* in refined settings. Your presence lingers in the memory like a half-remembered dream.

Push It: Become the social centerpiece; all attention focuses on you with +1 **Effect**. Those who meet your gaze may feel a shiver of desire (Resolve DV 2 to ignore).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Crimson Court (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; High Push

Tags: [AREA], [COMMAND], [FEAR], [GLAMOUR], [DEBT]

Cost to Learn: 14 XP (Master Technique)

Materials: A throne draped in scarlet, an assembled court (real or imagined), and a drop of blood from each participant mixed into wine – or a single tear of jealousy.

Effect: You become the social sovereign of the zone. For the scene:

- You gain +1 **Effect** on all social rolls, and opponents suffer –1 die.
- Anyone who attempts to deceive you must test Resolve (DV 4) or reveal a hidden desire – the one thing they crave most in the dark.
- Allies who drink from the shared cup regain 1 Fatigue (the wine of adoration, warm and sweet on the tongue).

Start a 10-segment *Court Dominion* timer; when it fills, you may declare one irrevocable social judgment (exile, scandal, or a binding oath of fealty) that the zone’s inhabitants

will enforce for one month. Those who defy it feel a phantom longing for your approval.

Push It: Newcomers must test Resolve (DV 4) or become briefly devoted – they will follow one simple social command, such as “introduce me to your patron” or “whisper your lover’s name in my ear.” Mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Livaea

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Livaea sings in *harmonies of longing* – melodies that linger in the ear like a half-remembered lover’s sigh. Their voice is used to sway a court’s opinion, to bind a marriage with a ballad, or to seduce a secret from a guarded heart. Livaea’s Cantors are prized in every noble house, and feared by those who know that a beautiful song can be a leash – and that the leash can be tightened at the climax of the verse.

The Cult of the Velvet Circle. Livaea’s cults are not hidden in basements; they meet in salons, tea houses, and private galleries. The Velvet Circle appears to be a social club – but its members trade in secrets, favors, and carefully curated introductions. A ritual of the Velvet Circle involves each member drinking from a shared cup (the *Crimson Chalice*) while naming a desire they wish to weave into reality – a lover, a title, a revenge. The cup is refilled with wine and a single drop of blood from each petitioner; those who drink become bound to the Circle – they cannot betray a member without suffering a visible blush of shame (1 Fatigue, no roll). The most devoted mark themselves with a small red tattoo hidden beneath clothing – a stylized kiss or a coiled serpent. Their creed is embroidered on its seal: “*Every bond is a thread. Every thread can be tied – or cut. But a cut thread leaves a scar that never fades.*” Outsiders are welcome as guests, but they will leave with a new debt, a new ally, or a new enemy. Rarely all three.

Witchcraft of Livaea (Lay / Social Weaving)

A witch who walks with Livaea is a *gossip-scribe* or *perfume-smith* – one who crafts social reality from threads of rumor, scent, and gesture. Their magic works with the tools of influence: a letter that cannot be forgotten, a perfume that makes the wearer irresistibly charming, or a needle that sews a promise into a dress’s hem. Their tools are never hammers; they use quills, vials, and the subtle art of a well-timed whisper. In Ecktoria, a Livaeian witch might be a letter-writer for the powerful, sealing each envelope with a kiss that binds the reader’s loyalty. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a keystone that makes every handshake struck beneath it unbreakable.

The Witch’s Tool: The Gossip Quill. A silver-tipped quill that writes in ink that darkens when a secret is true. Once per session, the witch may write a single sentence about a person they have met. That sentence becomes “known” to the local gossip network within a day, affecting the target’s reputation (GM determines effect: –1 die to social rolls, a new ally, an enemy, etc.). The witch cannot control how the rumor spreads, only that it spreads – and that a rumor about desire is the hardest to kill.

A Hedge Gift: Velvet Glove (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a person’s hand (or a letter they have written) and speak a single word of command (“trust,” “forget,” “desire”). For the next hour, the target feels a mild but genuine inclination

toward that emotion or action – not enough to override self-preservation, but enough to grant the wielder **+1 die** on social rolls against them. The touch leaves no mark, but the memory of it may haunt the target’s dreams.

Livaea’s Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Silver Tongue: +1 die to Persuade or Sway in intimate settings.	Need for Attention: –1 die when acting unnoticed or ignored.
2	Heart’s Insight: Once/scene, +2 dice to detect hidden desires or motives.	Emotional Drain: 1 Fatigue if denied meaningful social connection or physical affection.
3	Enchanting Presence: Allies in Near gain +1 die to social actions.	Rivalry Magnet: Often attract envy or social competition – others sense your allure and covet it.
4	Velvet Command: Once/session, issue a compelling suggestion that feels like a lover’s whisper (Resist DV 4).	Temptation’s Pull: –1 die to resist appealing offers, especially those that promise intimacy or adoration.
5	Court Network: Once/session, call on contacts for information – they remember the taste of your kiss.	Glamour Dependence: –1 die when isolated from social circles; you hunger for the warmth of another’s gaze.
6+	Sovereign Allure: Once/session, dominate a social gathering; all who meet your eyes must test Resolve (DV 5) or be captivated.	Addicted to Adoration: Mark +2 Obligation; suffer if denied praise or touch. Your lovers leave you, and you leave them, but the hunger never fades.

Playstyle Notes

Livaea excels in social manipulation, courtly intrigue, and the darker arts of seduction. Followers become masters of persuasion, binding others through desire, jealousy, and obligation. The corruption progression leads toward a social virtuoso who cannot function without admiration and connection – a velvet cage of their own making. Ideal for players who enjoy social combat, political maneuvering, and characters who wield influence and longing as their primary weapons. As with all mature themes, use Lines & Veils to ensure the table’s comfort.

Emphasizes

- **Seduction as Power:** charm, allure, reading desire
- **Social Binding:** oaths of affection, emotional debts, possessiveness
- **Court Intrigue:** gossip, reputation, the weapons of the drawing-room
- **Darker Love:** obsession, jealousy, the hunger to be adored

- **Performance and Glamour:** beauty as a weapon, appearance as armor

6.8.16 Lunara, The Silver Quiet (Moon, Mystery & Hidden Ways)

Lore. Lunara walks where torchlight falters: crossroads, tidal edges, shadowed sanctuaries. She is the whisper beneath silver skies, a torch-bearing guide to mysteries that lie between waking and dream. The ancients know her as triple-formed: maiden of new light, mother of full radiance, crone of waning shadow. Her worshippers – night-scholars, dream-walkers, and hedge-priests – seek her not for power over others, but for passage, reflection, and revelation.

Her gifts are gentle yet perilous: a mirror that reveals as much of the seeker as the sought, a key that opens ways better left closed, a light that makes the unseen plain. Her sigil is the silver spiral, etched in water, mirror, or stone.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Lunara is called by many names. In Aeler, she is the *Deep Silver*, whose light guides miners through unlit shafts. In Aelinnel, she is the *Silent Mirror*, invoked by those who seek truth without violence. In the Mistlands, she is the *Fog-Guide*, whose pale radiance parts the mist for those who walk with pure intent. Wherever the moon casts its silver light on a hidden door, Lunara watches.

“Three faces gaze from the moon. Which one watches you tonight?”

Domain Focus

- **Moonlight Revelation:** truth, hidden things, the seen in darkness
- **Liminal Passage:** thresholds, dreams, the space between waking and sleep
- **Silver Mystery:** reflection, illusion, the mirror’s truth
- **Lunar Cycles:** change, phases, the passage of time as a gentle guide

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Lunara does not bind a creature of shadow or flame. Their **Thiasos** is a small being of moonlight and stillness: a silver-eyed owl that flies only at moonrise, a pale moth that emerges only under the full moon, a small white fox that leaves no footprints in moonlight, a silver fish that swims in still water and reflects the night sky, or a moon-cat with eyes that change phase. This creature requires no food, but it must be shown moonlight each night (even a reflection in a mirror or a pool of water counts). If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows restless and its silver aura dims, imposing –1 die on all rolls involving perception or stealth for its bearer until it next sees moonlight).

The **Codex** of Lunara is never a book of ordinary script. It may be a mirror that shows only the moonshadow of a Rite, a set of silver leaves that tarnish as Rites are used and must be polished, a scroll of moon-calf skin that glows only under lunar light, or a spiral of polished stone that must be turned to reveal each Rite. Because Lunara’s truths are written in phases, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week under open moonlight, re-reading each Rite by the moon’s reflection, or the inscriptions fade (treat as *Compromised* until re-mooned).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Lunara may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or mirror) and whisper a silver word. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 die to *Investigation* or *Stealth* rolls made in dim light or darkness, and the first time each scene the bearer would be surprised by a hidden threat, they may roll Notice with +1 die (the moonlight warns them). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as a sliver of moonlight lodges in their shadow.

Rites of Lunara

Rite of the Moonlit Mirror (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH]

Materials: A mirror or bowl of still water under moonlight.

Effect: Peer beyond surfaces. +1 die to detect illusions, veils, or hidden motives. Once per scene, ask one veiled question about the present; the GM answers in riddle or omen.

Push It: Glimpse too deeply – gain the truth, but mark 1 Exposure.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 5 (Basic Technique)

Rite of the Crescent Whisper (Low, 6 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [COMMUNICATION], [BOND]

Materials: A silvered thread knotted three times.

Effect: Deliver a secret thought to a single target; they hear it as if whispered beside them. Gain +1 die to aid their next action.

Push It: The whisper echoes beyond its mark, creating 1 **SB (Hearts)** as others sense your intrusion.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 6 (Basic Technique)

Rite of the Triple Road (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [GUIDANCE], [AREA]

Materials: Three lit candles set at a crossroads.

Effect: Reveal a hidden path, door, or liminal way. Allies gain +2 dice to traverse or escape; enemies suffer –1 die to pursue.

Push It: The road opens farther than intended – toward an unknown realm. Mark 1 **SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 9 (Advanced Technique)

Rite of the Lunar Conjunction (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [SPIRIT], [TRUTH], [FATE]

Materials: A ring of herbs burned beneath a dark moon.

Effect: Commune with veiled knowledge or subtle entities. Ask two questions; answers

come in omen, dream-symbol, or paradox.

Push It: The answer is too direct – gain it fully, but mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

XP Cost: 8 (Advanced Technique)

Rite of the Silver Key (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [UNSEAL], [GATE], [FATE]

Materials: A silver key forged or anointed under a new moon.

Effect: Open a way where none should exist – between places, states, or wards. Creates a 6-segment *Gateway* timer.

Push It: Something else comes through; mark **2 SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

XP Cost: 13 (Master Technique)

Rite of the Moonbound Ascendant (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [PROTECT]

Materials: A cherished item surrendered under moonlight.

Effect: Enter a heightened lunar state. Choose two:

- +2 dice to Wits or Spirit,
- Resist fear/beguilement,
- Speak with unseen presences,
- Trace hidden connections with +2 Effect.

Begin a 6-segment *Moonbound* timer.

Push It: Make it enduring – mark Harm 2 and a permanent lunar stigma (your eyes reflect moonlight even in darkness).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

XP Cost: 14 (Master Technique)

Cantors & Cults of Lunara

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Lunara sings in *phases* – melodies that shift from whisper to resonance as the moon waxes and wanes. Their voice is used to lure dreams, to calm a troubled sleepwalker, or to draw a veil of silver silence over a secret meeting. Lunara's Cantors are often found in starlit groves, singing the moon up and down.

The Cult of the Silver Spiral. Lunara's cults meet under open skies, in moon-lit clearings, on rooftops, or beside tidal pools. The Silver Spiral is not a secret society – it is a fellowship of night-walkers, dream-recorders, and lunar scholars. A ritual of the Spiral involves each member writing a question on a silvered leaf, then floating it on still water under the moon's reflection. The most devoted keep a *lunar cat* – a gray creature with eyes that change with the moon's phase – and drink water from a silver bowl that has sat under moonlight for nine nights; they claim the water lets them walk in the dreams of

anyone whose name they whisper into it. Their creed is engraved on a single silver disc that passes from host to host: “*The moon sees all. The moon tells only what the seeker is ready to hear.*” Outsiders are welcome on the night of the full moon, but they must bring a question and a silver coin; the coin is melted down and added to a growing silver spiral that never closes.

Witchcraft of Lunara (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Lunara is a *silver-scribe* or *mirror-maker* – one who works with reflection, threshold, and the soft metals of the moon. Their craft is the art of revealing and concealing: polishing a mirror that shows a hidden door, forging a silver key that opens a dream, or etching a lunar phase onto a threshold to make it shift at moonrise. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a moon-phase into a keystone so the tunnel only opens under a new moon. In Viterra, a hedge-wright might silver a well’s rim so that those who drink from it forget their nightmares. Their tools are never hammers – they use needles, mirrors, and bowls of still water.

The Witch’s Tool: The Silver Needle. A needle of pure silver, cold to the touch, that never tarnishes. Once per session, the witch may prick their finger and draw a single drop of blood onto a threshold (a doorframe, a mirror’s edge, a window sill). For the rest of the scene, that threshold “remembers” the witch – they may cross it silently, unseen, and any reflection in it shows only what they wish to be seen.

A Hedge Gift: Moon-Water Scry (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may cup a handful of water that has sat under moonlight and speak a name. The water shows a brief, cryptic image of that person’s current location or emotional state (e.g., “surrounded by stone,” “weeping,” “walking toward a bridge”). The GM describes the vision in one short sentence.

XP Cost: 2 (Basic Hedge Technique)

Lunara's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Moonlit Sight: +1 die to detect hidden or liminal presences.	Shadows cling: Eyes glimmer in dim light, unnerving the uninitiated.
2	Silver Memory: Recall any event witnessed under moonlight with perfect clarity.	Dreams blur: Suffer strange, intrusive visions when sleeping.
3	Quiet Step: +1 die to stealth or subtle speech acts.	Tongue falters: -1 die to open confrontation or commands.
4	Seam-Walker: Once per scene, cross a minor threshold unseen.	Alien aura: Mortals feel watched, suffering unease in your company.
5	Triple Aspect: Call on maiden, mother, or crone aspect for +2 dice in related rolls.	Dissociation: After use, lose sense of time or self until rested.
6+	Silver Ascendancy: Once per session, unveil hidden truths of an entire scene (+3 dice to perception/investigation).	Bound to the Veil: Mark +2 Obligation. Your presence slips between worlds, inviting lunar forces to notice you.

Playstyle Notes

Lunara favors those who walk by moonlight, who seek truth in reflection, and who understand that some doors open only when the moon is right. Her followers are guides, dreamers, and keepers of silver secrets. The cost of her gifts is a growing estrangement from the sunlit world – eyes that glimmer in darkness, a tongue that stumbles in bright light, and dreams that are not entirely one's own. Intrusions often take the form of sudden omens (a howl at moonrise, a silver coin in an empty pocket) or a demand to witness a threshold crossing – a birth, a death, a first kiss. Ideal for characters who seek hidden knowledge, guide others through dangerous passages, or find comfort in the quiet of the night.

Emphasizes

- **Moonlight Revelation:** truth, hidden things, the seen in darkness
- **Liminal Passage:** thresholds, dreams, the space between waking and sleep
- **Silver Mystery:** reflection, illusion, the mirror's truth
- **Lunar Cycles:** change, phases, the passage of time as a gentle guide

6.8.17 Mab, Queen of Courts (Glamour & Bargain)

Lore. Mab rules not from throne or blade, but from dance and debt. She is the smile that binds, the jest that ensnares, the hostess who makes guests complicit in her game. To speak in her Court is to pay; to receive her token is to owe.

Mab is an Archfae – one of the great powers of the Gloaming Courts, neither wholly cruel nor kind, but always bound by her own rules. She cannot lie, but she can mislead so beautifully that truth becomes irrelevant. She cannot break an oath, but she can interpret it until it screams. Her followers thrive on charm, wit, and story, spreading webs of bargains too subtle to escape. The Cantor’s Path sings her name most sweetly, for every verse carries a price.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Mab is the patron of courtiers, actors, and those who live by their wits. In Aelinnel, she is the *Unbounded Guest*, whose arrival at a feast is marked by laughter and shattered glass – and a new debt for the host. In Vilikari salons, she is the *Gilded Tongue*, invoked before every negotiation. Wherever masks are worn and words have double meanings, Mab watches.

“Every laugh is a promise. Every promise is a debt. Every debt belongs to Mab.”

Domain Focus

- **Fae Glamour:** illusions, enchantments, the art of seeming
- **Social Bargains:** oaths, promises, debt as social glue
- **Courtly Intrigue:** etiquette, wordplay, the game of masks
- **Trickster Arts:** mischief, cleverness, the twist in the tale
- **Archfae Sovereignty:** Mab’s word is law in her presence, but only if you agreed to play
- **The Laughing Mask** — Mab, Queen of Courts. *The jest that binds, the mask that becomes the face, the bargain you laughed at and now cannot forget.*

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Mab does not bind a familiar of raw power. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of glamour and wit: a talking cricket that gives advice in riddles, a cat with mismatched eyes that appears at masquerades, a small fox that steals shiny baubles and leaves cryptic notes, a white jay that mimics voices with uncanny accuracy, or a spider that weaves its web in the shape of a courtly dance. This creature requires no food, but it must witness a promise or a performance each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it pulls pranks at the worst moments – tugging a sleeve during a lie, knocking over a wine glass – imposing –1 die on all Deception and Performance rolls for its bearer until it next witnesses a genuine oath).

The **Codex** of Mab is never a book of straightforward text. It may be a deck of playing cards whose suits shift when no one is looking, a mirror that reflects only the backs of words, a set of silk handkerchiefs knotted into a puzzle, or a scroll that must be read while dancing. Because Mab’s truths are written in misdirection, the Codex

requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week re-ordering the cards (or re-knotting the handkerchiefs) while recounting a story from memory, or the patterns become scrambled (treat as Compromised until re-woven).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Mab may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a jest. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Deception* or *Performance* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be caught in a lie, they may roll *Deception* again (the glamour twists the truth). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the memory of a laugh they cannot place follows them.
XP Cost: 6 XP (Basic Technique – foundational glamour infusion).

Rites of Mab

Rite of the Trickster's Bargain (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: A token freely given (flower, coin, ribbon).

Effect: Offer a fae bargain. The target may accept (both gain +1 **die** to actions that uphold the terms) or refuse (target marks 1 Fatigue from social pressure). Create a 4-segment *Bargain's Edge* timer.

Push It: If the target later betrays the bargain, they suffer Harm 1 (Stress) and start an *Oathbreaker [4]* timer.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Technique Cost (to learn): 5 XP (Basic Technique).

Rite of Courtly Guise (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; Standard Push

Tags: [GLAMOUR], [SOCIAL], [MASK]

Materials: A sprig of hawthorn or a silver thread worn visibly.

Effect: Subtle glamour makes you appear as the expected rank or guest. Gain +1 **die** to social rolls in refined settings.

Push It: Mask one personal tell (an accent, a scar, a nervous habit); the first probing question about it generates 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Technique Cost (to learn): 4 XP (Basic Technique).

Rite of the Price Agreed (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT], [TRUTH]

Materials: Equal tokens exchanged ritually (two rings, two signed notes, two locks of hair).

Effect: Bind a formal bargain. While the bargain is honored, both parties gain +1 **Effect** when cooperating. Breach forces 1 **SB (Hearts/Diamonds)** and a reputation penalty (–1 die to social rolls involving honor for one week). Create an 8-segment *Bargain*

Binding timer.

Push It: Add a minor boon to one party (+1 die once). If that party breaches, they suffer an additional 1 SB and you mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Technique Cost (to learn): 9 XP (Advanced Technique).

Rite of the Sovereign Glamour (High, 13 XP)

Ritual; Zone; High Push

Tags: [AREA], [GLAMOUR], [COMMAND], [WARD], [FEAR]

Materials: A circle of silk or green felt, courtly music, and a drop of honey (for sweetness) and vinegar (for the sting).

Effect: Establish a fae court in the zone. For the scene:

- Allies gain +1 **die** to social rolls; blunt threats (Intimidation, crude Force) suffer –1 die.
- Once per scene, you may strip an illusion or reveal a hidden motive as a free action (target tests Resolve DV 3 to resist).
- Violating a promise made within the zone triggers 2 **SB** and a visible glamour mark (a blush, a stutter) that lasts a day.

Start a 10-segment *Court Dominion* timer.

Push It: Impose a temporary *Court Law* (e.g., “no steel,” “speak only truth,” “every third word must be a compliment”). Violators suffer 2 SB. Mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Technique Cost (to learn): 13 XP (Master Technique).

Rite of the Gilded Jest (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Large Zone; High Push

Tags: [AREA], [GLAMOUR], [MASK], [BOND], [TRUTH]

Materials: Masks for all participants (hand-made, never bought), enchanted music, and a cup of wine that has been blessed (or cursed) with a whispered lie.

Effect: Create a lasting glamoured court – a masquerade that persists for the duration of the event (hours or an entire evening). All social magic (Sway, Performance, Deception) gains +1 **Effect**. Outsiders who enter suffer –1 die to perceive truths, read emotions, or see through disguises. Any promise made while masked is magically witnessed; breaking it inflicts 2 **SB** and the mask of the oath-breaker cracks (visible to all).

Start a *Glamour Maintenance* [8] timer; when it fills, the masquerade ends abruptly, and all participants remember everything they said – and forgot.

Push It: The masquerade persists between scenes for the rest of the session. Mark +3 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Technique Cost (to learn): 14 XP (Master Technique).

Cantors & Cults of Mab

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Mab sings in *harmonies of the half-truth* – melodies that shift key without warning, leaving the listener uncertain of what was heard. Their voice is used to seal a bargain with a sung clause, to make a crowd forget a social faux pas, or to weave a glamour that lasts as long as the music plays. Mab’s Cantors are prized at every court where masks are worn, and feared by those who know that a beautiful tune can hide a poisoned promise.

The Cult of the Gilded Jest. Mab’s cults meet in places where masks are natural: masquerade balls, carnival tents, and the back rooms of theaters. The Gilded Jest is less a religion and more a conspiracy of wits – actors, gamblers, and lawyers who have learned that every exchange is a performance. A ritual of the Jest involves each member writing a true secret on a playing card, then exchanging cards with another member. They must then speak the secret they received as if it were their own – and the group votes on whether they told it “true enough.” Those who fail must drink a cup of “tea of forgotten clauses” (a bitter brew of nettle and fae-touched honey) and lose one minor memory (a face, a password, a small debt). Their creed is printed on a card that is passed, never kept: *“The best chains are made of laughter. The strongest oaths are sworn in jest.”* Outsiders are welcome as “audience,” but those who laugh too loudly may find themselves on stage – and the stage has its own rules.

Witchcraft of Mab (Lay / Glamour)

A witch who walks with Mab is a *glamour-weaver* or *toy-maker* – one who crafts objects that are never quite what they seem. Their magic works through misdirection: a doll that laughs when a promise is broken, a mirror that shows a flattering reflection (and nothing else), or a mask that lets the wearer speak any lie as truth. Their tools are never hammers; they use needles, masks, and the subtle art of a well-placed reflection. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a cornerstone that makes everyone forget the building’s weak point, but a witch of Mab would instead sew a glamour seam into the cornerstone’s shadow.

The Witch’s Tool: The Mask of Shifting Faces. A simple half-mask of polished white wood, its eye holes rimmed with silver. Once per session, the witch may don the mask and change their apparent appearance – face, voice, and even perceived gender – for one scene. This grants +2 dice to *Deception* or *Performance* rolls to pass as someone else, and anyone who tries to see through the disguise must test Resolve (DV 4). The mask cannot mimic a specific person unless the witch has a token of that person (a hair, a signature). After use, the mask’s eyes weep a single drop of silver; the witch may collect it as a component for glamour rites.

A Hedge Gift: Mask of the Moment (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may place a hand over their own face and draw it away, revealing a different expression (or a different face entirely, briefly). This grants +1 die to a single *Deception* or *Performance* roll, as the target’s expectations are momentarily overturned. The illusion lasts only for that exchange. **Technique Cost (to learn):** 2 XP (Minor Hedge Gift).

Mab's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Glamour's Touch: +1 die to Deception/Performance with stories.	Truthbound: Cannot speak plain falsehood; only mislead.
2	Fairy Step: Once per scene, flicker Near as if teleporting.	Iron Weakness: 1 Fatigue if touched by cold iron.
3	Trickster's Delight: Spend 1 Boon to twist a Complication advantageously.	Compulsive Jest: Must play a trick each session or mark 1 SB.
4	Hospitality's Gift: Allies sharing food/drink gain +1 die to Resolve.	Hospitality Bound: Harming guests costs +2 Obligation.
5	Fae Sight: See veils/glamours; +2 dice to Notice.	Truth Debt: Must accept "fair" trades or suffer.
6+	Twilight Crown: Once/session, declare an Oath; you gain +2 dice to all rolls that fulfill it, and enemies who swore the same oath suffer -1 die to resist its terms.	Oathbound: Breaking this oath inflicts Harm 2 (Stress) and starts an <i>Iron Debt</i> [6] timer that can only be cleared by a quest. Your shadow is now forked – a visible sign that Mab has marked you.

Playstyle Notes

Mab excels in social manipulation and fae-style bargaining. Followers become masters of subtle magic, binding others through oaths and glamour. The corruption progression leads toward becoming fae-touched, gaining power over truth and perception at the cost of mortal constraints. Intrusions often take the form of a forgotten bargain resurfacing, a guest demanding hospitality you cannot refuse, or a jest that turns cruel. Ideal for players who enjoy social intrigue, wordplay, and characters who prefer cleverness over brute force.

Emphasizes

- **Archfae Sovereignty:** Mab's word is law in her presence, but only if you play her game
- **Glamour as Social Weapon:** illusions that bind, masks that deceive
- **Bargains and Debts:** every gift is a hook, every promise a leash
- **Courtly Intrigue:** etiquette, wordplay, the dance of masks
- **Trickster Wisdom:** the truth is what you can make others believe

6.8.18 Maelstraeus, The Infernal Bargainer (Commerce & Exchange)

Lore. Maelstraeus is the Infernal Bargainer, the Prince of Ledgers, the shadow at every crossroads of exchange. He was born from the first inequity, when one gave and another took, and debt was chained into existence.

He does not trade fairly — he trades *inevitably*. Every pact carries a hidden surcharge, every kindness is collateral, every smile hides an interest rate. His realm is an endless market where stalls never close, contracts burn with invisible ink, and every bargain tilts toward him.

To serve Maelstraeus is to admit the world itself is transactional — that all things, from love to breath to soul, are bound in his ledger. He collects. He always collects.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Maelstraeus is the patron of merchants, usurers, and tax collectors. In Ecktoria, he is the *Coin-House Factor*, invoked before every contract. In Silkstrand, he is the *Dyed Scale*, whose symbol is stamped on letters of credit. In the Brass Coast, he is the *Salt Ledger*, to whom smugglers whisper a prayer before a deal. Wherever coin changes hands and someone gains an edge, Maelstraeus watches.

A deal is never even. The scales tilt; the Merchant smiles. All debts come due.

Domain Focus

- **Commerce as Conflict:** negotiation, leverage, hidden clauses
- **Debt as Power:** obligation as currency, interest as weapon
- **Inevitability:** all accounts are settled, sooner or later
- **Infernal Bargains:** Faustian pacts, soul-ledgers, cursed credit

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Maelstraeus does not bind a familiar of whimsy or war. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of shrewd calculation and hidden value: a rat that counts coins with its paws, a ferret that steals only the most valuable trinkets, a magpie that hoards silver, a small brass spider that weaves ledgers in its web, or a gray mouse that lives in counting-houses and nibbles the corners of unpaid bills. This creature requires no food, but it must be given a small coin (or a written debt) each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it hoards the bearer's own valuables, hiding keys or coins, imposing −1 die on all Appraise and Bargain rolls for its bearer until a new coin is offered).

The **Codex** of Maelstraeus is never a book of abstract knowledge. It may be a leather-bound ledger with brass corners, its pages ruled for double-entry accounting; a slate tablet that calculates interest on its own; a set of scales whose pans hold the Rites as weights; or a scroll of parchment that feels heavier when a debt is unpaid. Because Maelstraeus's truths are written in profit, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week balancing its accounts (adding a fictitious entry or correcting a deliberate error), or the numbers become scrambled (treat as *Compromised* until re-balanced).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Maelstraeus may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or coin) and whisper a clause of interest. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Bargain* or *Appraise* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be cheated in a deal (sold a fake, paid counterfeit), they may reroll the opposed check (the scales tip in their favor). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as phantom interest accrues on their soul.

Rites of Maelstraeus

Rite of Uneven Scales (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [NEGOTIATION], [DEBT], [BOOST]

Materials: A scale where one pan is shaved or weighted.

Effect: Establish a trading ground. All parties gain +1 **die** to negotiate – but you bank a [4] **Hidden Profit** timer to spend reducing complications in your favor.

Push It: Compel one party to reveal their desperation or a hidden term; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Merchant's Gaze (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [VALUE], [BOOST], [BURDEN]

Materials: A coin pressed flat until its face is erased.

Effect: +2 **dice** to appraise goods, favors, or leverage. Create a [6] **Profit Margin** timer.

Push It: Perceive emotional or hidden value as well, but mark +1 **Exposure** and 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Weighted Contract (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near/Touch; No.

Tags: [VOW], [DEBT], [BOND], [FEAR]

Materials: Two items, one secretly flawed, or a parchment scorched before stamping.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Secret Advantage:** Bind a bargain where you secretly shift one advantage in your favor. Both sides gain +1 **Effect** if honored. Create a [6] **Shrewd Bargain** timer.
- **Seared Seal:** Bind an agreement with a scorched seal. You gain +1 **die** to enforce compliance; breakers suffer –2 **dice** in all dealings until next session. Create an [8] **Burned Ledger** timer.

Push It: (Secret Advantage) Breaking terms lashes the weaker party with 1 **SB (Hearts/Clubs)**. (Seared Seal) Breach burns the sigil into the breaker's hand, inflicting Harm 1 and 1 **SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Infernal Bazaar (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [NEGOTIATION], [DEBT], [FEAR], [BOOST]

Materials: A canopy stitched from debtors' contracts.

Effect: Create a cursed market-zone. Allies gain +1 **Effect** on bargains and may reroll one failed negotiation. Enemies suffer –1 **die** to deception. Start a [10] **Predatory Market** timer.

Push It: Attract wealthy powers eager – and doomed – to deal. Mark 2 **SB (Hearts/Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Cosmic Ledger (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; No.

Tags: [TRANSFER], [FATE], [DEBT], [SACRIFICE]

Materials: A book that writes entries in your blood (a personal ledger, each entry a drop).

Effect: Once per session, convert one resource into another (e.g., Boon → Fatigue, Obligation → SB, Harm → Debt Timer segments). All trades tilt slightly in your favor (you gain +1 **die** on the next roll related to that resource). Start a [6] **Balance Owed** timer.

Push It: Make the trade brutally lopsided (double the conversion rate, e.g., 2 Boons → 2 Fatigue). Create a [6] **Cosmic Debt** timer and mark 2 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Maelstraeus

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Maelstraeus sings in *recitations of accounting* – melodies that sound like the rustle of parchment and the chink of coins. Their voice is used to seal a contract with a sung term, to recite a debtor's tally until the weight of it crushes, or to make a market stall appear where none stood before. Maelstraeus's Cantors are employed by every major guild, and feared by those who know that a song of profit always hides a verse of loss.

The Cult of the Gilded Ledger. Maelstraeus's cults meet in counting-houses, bank vaults, and the back rooms of commodity exchanges. The Gilded Ledger is not a secret society – it is a fraternity of merchants, moneylenders, and tax collectors who have learned that every transaction is a prayer. A ritual of the Ledger involves each member opening a vein (a small cut on the thumb) and letting a drop of blood fall onto a brass scale, then adding a pinch of gold dust. The mixture is used to ink a new entry in the cult's master ledger – a book bound in leather made from the skin of a debtor who could not pay. The most devoted members tattoo their current account balance on the inside of their wrist; the numbers change overnight, and no one knows who updates them. Their creed is stamped on every bond they issue: *"The soul is currency. Spend it wisely –*

someone is always counting." Outsiders are welcome as "investors," but those who fail to pay their dues find their names struck from the book – and their shadows missing the next morning.

Witchcraft of Maelstraeus (Lay / Exchange)

A witch who walks with Maelstraeus is a *ledger-scribe* or *coin-turner* – one who crafts the instruments of exchange: contracts that cannot be broken, scales that never lie, and inks that write in terms that bind the reader's soul. Their magic works through the materials of commerce: a quill that writes in debt, a press that stamps obligations into parchment, or a small iron stamp that leaves a mark of ownership on any object. Their tools are never hammers; they use quills, scales, and the subtle art of a binding signature. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a toll-gate that remembers every traveler's debt, but a witch of Maelstraeus would instead press a wax seal into the keystone, so that the debt is owed not to the mountain, but to the witch.

The Witch's Tool: The Debtor's Quill. A steel-nibbed quill that writes in ink that darkens as the writer's obligation grows. Once per session, the witch may write a one-sentence contract on a scrap of parchment. Anyone who signs (or accepts the parchment) is bound to a minor task or payment. Breach inflicts **1 SB (Spades)** and marks the signer with a faint, glowing sigil for one day. The quill can also be used to "amend" an existing contract by scratching out a clause; the scratched-out clause becomes unenforceable, but the quill demands a drop of blood as payment.

A Hedge Gift: Fair Weight (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a scale, a till, or a handshake and speak a single word ("balance"). For the next exchange, all appraisals and negotiations involving that transaction are treated as if they were perfectly fair – no hidden advantage, no secret interest. The witch may choose to be the one who benefits from that fairness, or they may grant it to another as a genuine (but binding) gift.

Corruption of Maelstraeus

Tier	Gift	Burden
1	Appraiser's Eye: +1 die to judge value in goods, favors, or leverage.	Transactional Reflex: Must assign a "cost" to every interaction; -1 die to selfless acts.
2	Sharp Dealer: Once/scene, reroll a failed bargain.	Compulsive Trade: Must haggle or strike a deal when value is present – even if destructive.
3	Merchant's Fortune: +1 die to predict or exploit markets.	Greed's Hunger: Suffer 1 Fatigue if you allow profit or advantage to pass untaken.
4	Infernal Credit: Once/session, call in a major favor (merchant prince, syndicate, guild).	Debt Anchor: Draw in exploitative offers; refusing marks 1 SB (Diamonds).
5	Price of Truth: Once/scene, see the hidden worth of any item, pact, or person.	Tagged by Price: See every being as a commodity; -1 die to genuine intimacy.
6+	Market Tyrant: Once/session, impose absolute dominance over a domain of trade; all exchanges within Near range bend to your terms (+2 dice to Bargain, -2 dice to resist your deals).	Cosmic Recompense: Mark +2 Obligation; the universe exacts repayment in brutal, unexpected form. Your hands are now stained with ink that never washes off – a visible mark of your covenant.

Playstyle Notes

Maelstraeus is the patron of merchants, moneylenders, and anyone who understands that every relationship has a price. His followers gain power over negotiation, debt, and the hidden leverage in every exchange, but pay with their empathy, their trust, and eventually their ability to act without counting the cost. The cults of Maelstraeus are as cold as his ledgers, but they are also among the most powerful networks in the world. Intrusions often take the form of a debt called early, a bargain that turns sour, or a competitor who offers better terms. Ideal for players who enjoy intrigue, leverage, and characters who always have an angle.

Emphasizes

- **Commerce as War:** negotiation as combat, leverage as weapon
- **Debt as Identity:** you are what you owe
- **Infernal Bargaining:** Faustian pacts, soul-ledgers, cursed credit
- **The Ledger Never Closes:** every profit is a future loss, every gift a future claim
- **Cold Calculation:** empathy is inefficiency; kindness is a poor investment

Contract Monk (Maelstraeus)

A deal is never even. The scales tilt.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Presence 2+, Rite of Uneven Scales or Cantor of Maelstraeus.

Debt-Resistant Frame. Maelstraeus's monks understand that every contract has a loophole. They gain **+1 die** to resist any magical debt or obligation by finding a hidden clause, technicality, or contradiction in the creditor's own terms. If they succeed, the creditor's paperwork briefly smolders – a loophole consumed by its own interest.

Techniques (XP Costs):

Technique	Effect	XP	Activation Cost	Req.
Uneven Scales	Establish a trading ground. All parties gain +1 die to negotiate – but you bank a [4] Hidden Profit timer to spend reducing complications in your favor.	5 (Basic)	1 Fatigue	Presence 2
Merchant Gaze	+2 dice to appraise goods, favors, or leverage. Create a [6] Profit Margin timer.	5 (Basic)	1 Boon	Wits 2
Weighted Contract	Bind a bargain where you secretly shift one advantage in your favor. Both sides gain +1 Effect if honored. Create a [6] Shrewd Bargain timer.	9 (Advanced)	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Infernal Bazaar	Create a cursed market-zone for one scene. Allies gain +1 Effect on bargains and may reroll one failed negotiation. Enemies suffer –1 die to deception.	13 (Master)	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Cosmic Ledger	Once per session, convert one resource into another (e.g., Boon → Fatigue, Obligation → SB). All trades tilt slightly in your favor (gain +1 die on next roll related to that resource).	14 (Master)	1 Boon	Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Market Tyrant*. Once per session, impose absolute dominance over a domain of trade for one scene; all exchanges within Near range bend to your terms (+2 dice to Bargain, –2 dice to resist your deals). You may also void one existing magical debt or contract entirely – but the universe exacts repayment in brutal, unexpected form (GM’s choice). Gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your hands are stained with ink that never washes off)

but you may, once per arc, treat a demand for payment as if it were a negotiation you can walk away from (the creditor finds the fine print written in vanishing ink).

6.8.19 Malachai, the Cruel Messenger (Curses & Corruption)

Content Warning

Malachai is a patron of curses, corruption, and Faustian bargains. Themes include addiction, loss of self, and the consequences of desperate choices. While the mechanics focus on supernatural afflictions, the fiction may touch on dark subjects. Please use Lines & Veils to ensure everyone's comfort at the table.

"She gave us everything we wanted but we did not ask the price." The Worn Magi

Lore. Malachai was once a divine messenger – a herald of painful truths, sent to deliver news that could not be softened. She was not cruel; she was necessary. But necessity wears. In time, she began to soften the truth, offering false hope alongside real curses. For this, the gods bound her in chains of black iron beneath the cursed city of Zahk'Kozahn.

Now she waits. Chained but not contained. Imprisoned but not silent. Her voice reaches across the world, offering power to the weak, hope to the hopeless, and sweet oblivion to those who cannot bear to face the dawn. Vampirism, lycanthropy, and other cursed conditions flow from her influence. Her followers learn that power demands suffering, mastering gifts that devour from within.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Malachai is the patron of the desperate and the damned. In Zakov, she is the *Salt-Fang*, whose silver coin appears in the mouth of drowned sailors. In the Valewood, she is the *Thorn-Giver*, invoked by hunters who curse a rival's bow. In Linn, she is the *Wave-Mother's Shadow*, whose gifts turn the tide of battle – at a price. Wherever hope curdles into despair, Malachai whispers.

"I offer you everything you desire, and everything you fear. The payment comes later."

Domain Focus

- **Cursed Gifts:** Faustian bargains, power with hidden costs
- **Corruptive Power:** tainted blessings, addictive magic
- **False Salvation:** hope that destroys, beautiful lies
- **Supernatural Afflictions:** vampirism, lycanthropy, and other curses

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Malachai does not bind a familiar of purity or light. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature touched by her corruption: a black rat with one red eye that gnaws at the bars of its cage, a crow with a broken feather that always points toward the nearest corpse, a toad that secretes a toxin causing fever dreams, a small bat that drinks blood from a silver dish, or a moth whose wing dust leaves a rash that itches for a week. This creature requires no food, but it must be given a small sacrifice of pain (a pinprick, a pinch of salt in a wound) each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows sullen and its aura of despair thickens, imposing –1 die on all Resolve rolls for its bearer until a proper curse is laid).

The **Codex** of Malachai is never a book of hope. It may be a chain of iron links, each etched with a curse; a box of cracked bells that toll when a Rite is spoken; a scroll of skin from a sinner who died unshriven; or a set of silver nails driven into a board, each nail a promise broken. Because Malachai's truths are written in pain, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week pricking their finger and letting a drop of blood fall onto each nail (or each bell), or the curses stored there become faint (treat as Compromised until re-blooded).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Malachai may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a false promise. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Intimidation* or *Deception* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would suffer a supernatural curse, they may ignore it (the curse slides off, seeking another target). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as a sliver of Malachai's hunger lodges in their shadow.

Rites of Malachai

Rite of the Honeyed Binding (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self or Near/Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [CURSE], [BOOST], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: Blood mixed with sweet wine, or a broken chain link.

Cost to Learn: 5 XP (Basic Technique)

Effect: Choose one:

- **Honeyed Curse:** Target gains **+2 dice** to their next roll (counts as Triumph). They take 1 Corruption (unresistable).
- **Binding Curse:** Target gains **+1 die** to physical actions but suffers Fatigue 1 unless they perform a dominance act (beat a weaker creature, drink blood, break something precious).

Push It: (Honeyed) Grant **+3 dice** and auto-Triumph; inflict 2 Corruption instead. (Binding) Grant **+2 dice** but Fatigue 2; mark **1 SB (Spades)** as the curse's hunger grows.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the False Dawn (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [CURSE], [DEBT], [FATE]

Materials: Meteoric iron shard blessed by false light.

Cost to Learn: 8 XP (Advanced Technique)

Effect: Bestow a gift with a hidden curse. Target gains a significant advantage (e.g., **+1 die** to all rolls for one scene) but accrues a 4-segment *Corruption* timer. Each time they use the gift, tick the timer. When full, they suffer a related curse (GM chooses: festering wounds, beastly urges, or the attention of a Collector).

Push It: The gift is more powerful (**+2 dice**, or extended duration). The timer advances

2 segments immediately; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Cruel Transformation (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [CURSE], [TRANSFORM], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: Holy water mixed with graveyard dust.

Cost to Learn: 9 XP (Advanced Technique)

Effect: Infect a target with a supernatural condition (vampiric hunger, bestial rage, shadow-bind). Lasts one scene. Start a 6-segment *Transformation* timer. Each time the target resists feeding or transformation, tick the timer. When full, the condition becomes permanent.

Push It: The condition becomes permanent immediately; target gains **+1 die** to relevant actions but is marked by Malachai (a Collector will visit within a week). Mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Messenger's Burden (High, 13 XP)

Ritual; Self; High Push

Tags: [CURSE], [BOOST], [PRESSURE], [DEBT]

Materials: Manacles worn while speaking her name.

Cost to Learn: 13 XP (Master Technique)

Effect: Channel Malachai directly. Gain **+2 dice** to one action per beat this scene, but each use marks 1 SB as her influence spreads. Start an 8-segment *Corruption's Grip* timer. When it fills, a Collector arrives to demand a memory, a name, or a year of your life.

Push It: **+3 dice** but mark 2 SB, suffer Fatigue 1, and her voice becomes permanent – you hear whispers of cruel bargains in quiet moments.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Chained Angel's Tribute (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; High Push

Tags: [CURSE], [AREA], [SACRIFICE], [FATE]

Materials: A chapel bell cracked by divine lightning, or a silver coin that cannot be spent.

Cost to Learn: 14 XP (Master Technique)

Effect: Corrupt a sacred space or consecrate a site to Malachai. Within the zone:

- Supernatural effects (curses, dark magic) gain **+1 Effect**.
- Blessings and healing spells generate +1 SB on a failure.
- Any creature that accepts a gift from Malachai within the zone immediately ticks a *Corruption* timer twice.

Start a 10-segment *Divine Perversion* timer. When it fills, the site becomes a permanent beacon for the Worn – the ghouls of Zahk’Kozahn.

Push It: The corruption spreads to adjacent areas; mark **3 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+3 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Malachai

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Malachai sings in *harmonies of sweet despair* – melodies that begin like a lullaby and end like a scream. Their voice is used to lure the desperate into bargains, to make a village accept a curse as a blessing, or to sing a monster to sleep so that it may be bound. Malachai’s Cantors are terrifying not because they are evil, but because they are willing to *do evil* – they will poison the well to teach the town to dig deeper, or curse a child to save a hundred adults. They are hated and needed in equal measure.

The Cult of the Leashed Hunger. Malachai’s cults gather in places where suffering is already present: plague hospitals, slums, refugee camps, and the cells of the condemned. The most fanatical cell, the *Leashed Hunger*, meets in catacombs beneath Zahk’Kozahn’s ruins, where they drink water from the Well of Ichor and carve the names of their victims into their own flesh with silver needles. A ritual involves each member naming a curse they have inflicted (or allowed) and a mercy they have buried because of it. Then they prick their finger and let a drop of blood fall into a cracked bell; the bell tolls once, and a Collector appears to witness. Their creed is whispered, not spoken: “*We are the knife that cuts the rot. The wound heals, but the scar remembers us.*” Outsiders are not welcome; they are patients, or potential tools, or future victims. Those who die serving Malachai become the Worn – shambling ghouls that guard the cursed city.

Witchcraft of Malachai (Lay / Curse)

A witch who walks with Malachai is a *curse-smith* or *affliction-weaver* – one who crafts pain into purpose. Their magic works through the materials of suffering: a needle that sews a nightmare into a pillow, a forge that tempers a blade to always strike the wielder’s loved ones, or a garden where belladonna and hemlock grow in geometric patterns. Their tools are never hammers; they use needles, threads, and the small iron teeth of cursed combs. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a keystone that makes every tenth step collapse, but a witch of Malachai would instead sew a curse-seam into the mortar, so that the tunnel itself remembers every injury it has caused.

The Witch’s Tool: The Splintered Needle. A needle of black iron, snapped in half and re-joined with a drop of the witch’s blood. Once per session, the witch may sew a “curse seam” into a garment, a threshold, or a skin. The curse is small but specific: a button that falls off at the worst moment, a door that sticks when someone is pursued, a hand that trembles when holding a weapon. The target suffers **–1 die** on a single type of roll (e.g., Stealth, Melee, Sway) for the scene. The witch may unstitch the curse as a free action, but doing so marks 1 Fatigue.

A Hedge Gift: Borrowed Scars (2 XP).

Cost to Learn: 2 XP (Basic Technique)

Once per scene, the witch may touch a fresh wound (inflicted within the last hour) and

speak a single word of Malachai's name. For the remainder of the scene, the witch may transfer the pain of that wound (as 1 Fatigue) to another creature within Near range. The target resists with Spirit+Resolve (DV 3); on a failure, they suffer the Fatigue and the witch's original wound heals slightly (clear 1 Fatigue from themselves). On a success, the witch takes the Fatigue anyway – the curse rebounds.

Malachai's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Sharpened Senses: +1 die to Notice in dim light.	Unsettling Presence: –1 die to social warmth checks.
2	Primal Vigor: +1 die to Athletics and physical actions.	Dark Hunger: 1 Fatigue if a day passes without feeding (blood or rare herbs).
3	Unnatural Resilience: Once per session, resist one Condition.	Beastly Tells: Failures cause visible physical changes (slitted eyes, fur patches).
4	Cursed Vigour: Natural weapons count as magical; +1 Effect.	Transformed Body: Permanent physical change (eye color, skin texture, etc.).
5	Regenerative Curse: Heal 1 Fatigue or Condition per rest.	Corruption's Price: Pushing rites adds permanent Corruption (cannot be cleared).
6+	Monstrous Ascendant: +2 dice to Body-based actions; your unarmed strikes deal +1 Harm and count as magical.	Loss of Self: The GM may compel curse-driven behavior (feed, rage, corrupt) once per session. You can resist with Spirit+Resolve (DV 4). On failure, you act according to the curse for one exchange. Your eyes now glow faintly red in darkness – a visible sign of Malachai's claim.

Playstyle Notes

Malachai offers power that corrupts from within. Followers gain immediate benefits but accumulate permanent drawbacks. The corruption progression leads toward becoming a supernatural creature with great power but diminishing humanity. Ideal for players who enjoy tragic characters, Faustian bargains, and exploring the price of power.

Rivalries & Obligations

Major Rivalries:

- **The Oath of Flame & Light:** Direct opposition – sacred vows vs. corrupted promises.
- **The Daughters of the Unbroken Cord:** Both deal in debt, but Daughters harvest generational obligation; Malachai's followers burn out fast. Collectors may

serve both, but a Daughter sees a Malachai addict as a wasted asset. Territory wars over hospices and gambling dens are common.

- **Livaea:** Both use social manipulation, but Malachai destroys while Livaea binds.

Hard Obligation Triggers:

- **7+ Segments:** Must corrupt something pure – defile a sacred site, break a true vow, or offer a loved one’s name to a Collector.
- **10+ Segments:** Malachai’s voice becomes overwhelming; refusal risks losing powers. A Collector appears and demands a permanent scar (a visible Mark of Malachai) – refusal means the character falls into the Worn (becomes an NPC ghoul).

Emphasizes

- **Cursed Gifts:** power that always costs more than expected
- **Addiction as Magic:** once you start, stopping is harder than any curse
- **False Salvation:** every cure is a waiting room
- **Supernatural Afflictions:** becoming the monster to fight monsters
- **The Chained Angel:** patient, hungry, and never truly contained

6.8.20 Mor'iraath, the Destroyer (Absolute Annihilation)

Lore. Mor'iraath is the demon of absolute destruction – not the slow decay of rot, nor the patient erosion of water, but the joyful, all-consuming fire that reduces everything to ash and memory. He delights not in the process of ruination, but in the perfect moment of combustion, when something that was becomes something that never will be again.

His followers become agents of finality, wielding flame that leaves no trace, no remains, and no possibility of reconstruction. To serve him is to embrace the beauty of endings and the power that comes from making things never have been. Where Malachai corrupts and Khemesh crushes, Mor'iraath *ignites*.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Mor'iraath is known by fearful names. In Zakov, he is the *Sea-Scourge*, invoked by pirates who burn their prizes to the waterline. In Aeler, he is the *Deep Forge* that consumes ore and returns only slag. In Linn, he is the *Tide-That-Eats-The-Shore*, a slow, patient consumption that reshapes coastlines. His followers are rarely beloved, but they are essential – for without destruction, there is no room for creation.

Every treasure is fuel. Every pact is tinder. Ash is the only inheritance.

Domain Focus

- **Fiery Annihilation:** fire that consumes utterly, leaving only ash
- **Absolute Endings:** no trace, no memory, no return
- **Cleansing Flame:** burning away corruption, weakness, and existence
- **Inferno as Art:** the beauty of a perfect, final combustion

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Mor'iraath does not bind a familiar of hearth and home. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of ash and ember: a blackened salamander that sleeps in hot coals, a fire-scorpion whose sting leaves a cauterized wound, a soot-colored moth that leaves ash trails on whatever it touches, or a tiny phoenix fledgling that cannot yet rise from its own ashes (and may one day burn its keeper). This creature requires no food, but it must be fed a small amount of combustible material (charcoal, oil, or a burnt offering) each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it smolders constantly, emitting smoke that imposes –1 die on all Stealth rolls and attracts the attention of fire-wardens).

The **Codex** of Mor'iraath is never a book of paper and ink. It may be a slab of fused glass etched with runes of ending, a set of iron plates that must be heated before the Rites become visible, or a scroll of asbestos that burns without being consumed. Because Mor'iraath's truths are written in ash, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week burning a small offering (a scrap of vellum, a lock of hair) and letting the smoke imprint the Rites anew, or the symbols fade (treat as *Compromised* until re-burned).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Mor'iraath may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or armor) and whisper a word of unmaking. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Melee* or *Ranged* attacks, and the first time each scene the bearer would reduce an enemy to 0 Harm, they may choose to utterly destroy that enemy (no remains, no regeneration, no trace) instead of merely defeating them. After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the scent of ash clings to their hands.

Rites of Mor'iraath

Rite of the Perfect Ending (Low, 4 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [FIRE], [DESTRUCTION], [ERASURE]

Materials: The final component of something (last brick, final word, closing signature), or a pinch of ash from a previous fire.

Effect: Cause one small object to be utterly consumed by flame – no remains, no trace, no possibility of reconstruction. Gain **+1 die** to rolls involving finality or absolute conclusions.

Push It: The ending creates a beneficial void – gain 1 Boon as space opens for something else; mark **1 SB (Spades)** as reality adjusts to the absence.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Unmaking Gaze (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [FIRE], [OMEN]

Materials: A lens of obsidian or fire-scarred glass.

Effect: **+2 dice** to identify the precise weakness that will cause complete collapse. See the “breaking point” in any structure, plan, or construct – the spot where a single spark would bring it all down. Your next destructive action against the identified target gains **+1 Effect**.

Push It: The gaze becomes prophetic – see three possible endings for one target; choose which occurs, but mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as fate resists your vision.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Cleansing Flame (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [FIRE], [AREA], [ERASURE], [TERRAIN]

Materials: Fuel that was once part of what you intend to destroy (a beam from the building, a lock of hair from the person).

Effect: Create a fire that burns not just substance but essence – what is consumed by this flame never existed. The zone becomes a *pyre zone*; anything entering risks being marked for erasure. Enemies suffer **–2 dice** to actions that would preserve or continue anything within the zone.

Push It: The flame becomes selective – choose what is unmade and what remains; mark **+1 Obligation** as you assume judgment over existence itself.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Absolute Negation (Standard, 9 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [FIRE], [BANISH], [FATE], [FEAR]

Materials: The complete destruction of a representation of the target (a lock for a door, a written name for a person, a fragment for a whole), burned to ash.

Effect: The target suffers **−2 dice** to resist any effect that would cause their non-existence. If they are reduced to Harm 0 by your actions, they are utterly consumed by infernal flame – [BANISH]ed from all realities, never were, never could be.

Push It: The negation becomes retroactive – the target never existed in your presence; mark **2 SB (Hearts)** as the timeline rewrites around their absence.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Unraveling Inferno (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Tags: [FIRE], [AREA], [FATE], [DEATH]

Materials: The foundational element of what you wish to unmake (keystone, cornerstone, source code, a written covenant).

Effect: Your touch ignites a cascading dissolution. The target and all things fundamentally connected to it begin immediate combustion, crumbling to ash as if they had never been. Test DV = Complexity.

- Success: Target and connections cease to exist.
- Partial: Significant damage, accelerated decay, but some remnants remain.
- Miss: Backlash; the fire turns on you – mark 2 SB and suffer Harm 1 (Burn).

Push It: The unraveling becomes contagious – similar things in Near range also ignite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Pyre (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [FIRE], [AREA], [ERASURE], [PRESSURE]

Materials: Complete dedication of the space to Mor'iraath – every flammable object arranged as a funeral offering, and a drop of your own blood to seal the pact.

Effect: The zone becomes a pocket of absolute combustion. Anything that enters is set ablaze, suffering Harm 1 each round (ignores Armor). At the end of each round, they must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 5) or be consumed entirely (cease to exist). The space itself becomes a *pyre scar* – it remains hot to the touch for a year and a day, and nothing will grow there.

Push It: The pyre becomes permanent and expands at 1 segment per scene; you suffer Harm 2 (Burn) and mark +3 **Obligation** as you become partially unmade yourself, your

left hand now permanently blackened and smoking.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Mor'iraath

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Mor'iraath sings in *notes of cessation* – melodies that start strong and fade to crackling silence, like a fire burning out. Their voice is used to silence a battlefield after a massacre, to erase a name from a town's records, or to sing a dying person gently into nothingness rather than an afterlife. Mor'iraath's Cantors are terrifying not because they are cruel, but because they offer a perfect, peaceful, absolute end – and some people accept.

The Cult of the Final Breath. Mor'iraath's cults gather in places where things end: funeral pyres, abandoned ruins, collapsed mines, and the cells of the condemned. The Final Breath is a fellowship of nihilists, assassins of memory, and those who have lost everything and now embrace the cleansing flame. A ritual of the Cult involves each member writing down something they wish had never existed – a memory, a person, a part of themselves – and then burning the paper in a brazier that gives no heat. They then drink a cup of ash suspended in water; the ash is from a fire that consumed something they once loved. Their creed is whispered, never written: *"What is not cannot suffer. What is not cannot be hurt. We give the gift of never-having-been."* The most devoted tattoo a single ember on the inside of their lower lip; the tattoo smokes when they speak a lie. Outsiders are not welcome; they are targets, or potential converts who have already lost too much to fear the flame.

Witchcraft of Mor'iraath (Lay / Unmaking)

A witch who walks with Mor'iraath is a *pyre-smith* or *ash-weaver* – one who crafts through the art of burning. Their magic works through the materials of finality: a stamp that brands a "flaw" into a threshold, a quill that writes in ink made from burnt secrets, or a forge that tempers a blade that leaves no wound (only a cauterized absence). In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a keystone that makes the tunnel behind it never have existed, but a witch of Mor'iraath would instead press a hot iron sigil into the keystone, and the tunnel would collapse into ash. Their tools are never hammers; they use brands, tongs, and the patient heat of a funeral pyre.

The Witch's Tool: The Cinder-Stamp. An iron rod with a sigil of ending carved into its face, heated until it glows dull red. Once per session, the witch may press the stamp against a threshold (a door, a bridge, a city gate) while speaking a single word – the name of something that should never have existed. For the next scene, anyone who crosses that threshold and fails a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 3) will forget the last minute of their life – their memory is burned away, not suppressed. The stamp can also be used to "unwrite" a single word from a document; the word becomes a smudge of ash, and the sentence restructures itself around the absence.

A Hedge Gift: Absence Knife (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a finger (as if holding a knife) across a surface – a lock, a rope, a clasp – and speak a word of Mor'iraath's name. The object does not break; it simply ceases to be an obstacle. The lock is no longer locked (there is no lock). The rope is no longer a rope. The clasp is as

if it never had a function. This effect lasts for one exchange, after which reality “repairs” itself, but the moment of absence is enough.

Corruption of Mor’iraath

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Ending’s Sight: +1 die to Notice when something is approaching its natural conclusion or final form.	Completion Anxiety: Must resist urge to “finish” things prematurely; –1 die to rolls involving patience or process.
2	Perfect Strike: Once/scene, your destructive action gains +2 dice and ignores all resistance to ending/ceasing.	Destruction Proximity: Suffer 1 Fatigue when near things of personal value; their existence pains you.
3	Unmaking Touch: +2 dice to rolls involving absolute destruction – no remains, no possibility of return.	Entropy Aura: Objects of value near you show signs of decay/premature aging; allies suffer –1 die to rolls involving cherished possessions.
4	Final Judgment: Once/session, declare one thing in Near range must make Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) or cease to exist entirely.	Existential Hunger: –1 die to rolls involving creation, preservation, or continuation; you hunger to end what others would sustain.
5	Principle of Negation: Once/session, unmake an abstract concept (hope, fear, memory) from a willing target.	Conceptual Erosion: Your presence causes ideas and beliefs to weaken; –1 die to rolls requiring stable reality or consistent identity.
6+	Avatar of Unbeing: Once/session, become the living embodiment of annihilation – anything you touch burns to ash and ceases to exist for one scene.	Void Incarnate: Mark +3 Obligation when using; risk becoming a permanent fire that must constantly consume to maintain existence, eventually burning even yourself.

Playstyle Notes

Mor’iraath is the demon of fiery destruction – the joy of a perfect, all-consuming blaze. His followers gain power over absolute endings, the ability to erase things from existence, and the terrible beauty of ash. The cost is the loss of patience, connection, and eventually the ability to value anything that lasts. Intrusions often take the form of a cherished object crumbling to ash, a fire that cannot be extinguished, or a demand to end something that you love. Ideal for players who enjoy nihilistic themes, the power of finality, and characters who have decided that if nothing matters, then nothing deserves to remain.

Emphasizes

- **Fiery Annihilation:** fire that leaves nothing behind
- **Absolute Endings:** no trace, no memory, no return

- **Cleansing Flame:** burning away corruption, weakness, and existence itself
- **Inferno as Art:** the beauty of a perfect combustion
- **Ash as Legacy:** all that remains of empires, lovers, and gods

Ash-Fist (Mor'iraath)

Every treasure is fuel. Every pact is tinder.

Prerequisites: Body 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Perfect Ending or Cantor of Mor'iraath.

Debt-Resistant Frame. Ash cannot be held to account. Mor'iraath's monks gain +2 dice to resist any attempt to compel them through magical debt, oath, or contract – but each such resistance leaves a faint smell of smoke, and the GM may gain 1 SB (the universe remembers a debt that was burned rather than paid).

Techniques:

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Ending Touch (Basic, 5 XP)	Declare before rolling. On a hit, the target leaves no remains (cannot be resurrected, tracked, or remembered by magical means). On a miss, you take Harm 1 (Burn).	1 Boon	Body 3
Unmaking Gaze (Basic, 4 XP)	+2 dice to identify the precise weakness that will cause complete collapse. Your next destructive action against that target gains +1 Effect.	1 Fatigue	Wits 2
Cleansing Flame (Basic, 6 XP)	As an action, create a small fire that burns essence. Any flammable object you touch can be utterly consumed – no trace.	1 Boon	Spirit 2
Absolute Negation (Advanced, 9 XP)	When you reduce an enemy to 0 Harm, you may declare them utterly annihilated (never existed).	Free	Tier II
Ash Memory (Basic, 6 XP)	Once per session, you may “remember” a fact that was erased (as if it had never been lost) – but you also forget one minor memory of your own (GM’s choice).	Free	Spirit 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Void Incarnate*. Once per session, become living annihilation for one scene: anything you touch (including abstract debts or contracts) can be erased from existence. You may delete one ongoing magical obligation, curse, or debt entirely – but you permanently lose a cherished memory and gain a **Debt Scar** (a hand that is always slightly smoking). The Hollow will forget you ever owed, but you will also forget a small part of who you were.

6.8.21 Morag the Hag, Weaver of Hidden Costs (Faerie Bargains & Hidden Costs)

Lore. In the hour between twilight and dawn, where borders thin and mortal cunning meets older cleverness, Morag sets her webs of bargain and consequence. She is the grandmother who offers exactly what you need, the forest crone with a perfect solution, the crossroads dweller who makes dreams come true – for a price that only reveals itself once the road bends back. Her wisdom is simple and sharp: every gift carries obligation, every kindness creates debt, and every wish must be paid in coin not named aloud.

Morag is cruel, but not evil. She does not delight in suffering; she delights in the precision of a bargain perfectly struck. She will take your last coin and smile, but she will not cheat you – the terms were always there, written in thorn-scratch, waiting for you to read them. Her cruelty is the cruelty of the market, of the turning year, of a grandmother who knows that the child who burns their hand on the stove will not touch it again.

Her bargains are never unfair – only incomplete. She grants what is promised; the true cost lies in what is unspoken, written in thorn-scratch, and due when the moon has turned thrice.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Morag is the patron of hedges-witches, debt-collectors, and those who deal in the spaces between law and mercy. In Aelaerem, she is the *Kettle-Crone*, invoked before any serious bargain. In Viterra, she is the *Crossroads Wife*, whose thorn-marked stones mark the boundaries of hedge-courts. In Zakov, she is the *Tide-Mother* who sets the price for smuggled cargo. Wherever a promise is made and a price is hidden, Morag watches.

“She gives you the gold, but not the weight it carries. She grants your heart’s desire, but not the hunger it awakens. She answers your plea, but not the price that pleases her. In Morag’s court, every ‘yes’ is a ‘yes, but...’ ”

Domain Focus

- **Hidden Obligations:** reading the unspoken costs in every bargain
- **Faerie Cunning:** strict courtesy, sharp clauses, old-road law
- **Hearth-Way Wisdom:** folk practice for spirits, thresholds, and natural justice
- **Consequential Magic:** power that always arrives with strings attached
- **Cruel Precision:** the sharp joy of a perfectly balanced account

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Morag does not bind a familiar of brute force. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of cunning and patience: a gray mouse that nests in counting-houses, a raven that steals shiny objects and hoards them as bargaining chips, a garden spider that weaves its web in the shape of a contract, or a small black cat whose purr soothes contentious negotiators. This creature requires no food, but it must be given a small token of a bargain (a signed scrap, a broken seal, a strand of hair from a debtor) each week. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it hides things of value or tangles ledgers, imposing –1 die on all negotiation rolls for its bearer).

The **Codex** of Morag is never a book written in plain ink. It may be a leather satchel of knotted cords, each knot representing a promise kept or broken; a slate tablet that only reveals its writing when a debt is paid; or a wooden spindle wrapped with thread dyed in three colors (white for truth, black for secret, red for blood). Because Morag's truths are written in the spaces between words, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week reviewing all current bargains and knots, tightening those that hold and loosening those that have been fulfilled, or the Rites become uncertain (treat as Compromised until re-knotted).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Morag may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or document) and whisper a hidden clause. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Sway* or *Insight* rolls when negotiating, and the first time each scene the bearer would be deceived about the terms of a bargain, they may reroll the opposed check (the hidden cost reveals itself). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as a thread of debt tightens around their wrist.

Rites of Morag

Rite of the Unfinished Promise (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near/Touch; Yes.

Tags: [BARGAIN], [BOOST], [DEBT], [FATE]

Materials: A half-written contract or a promise spoken but not sealed; or a token of good fortune from someone who recently succeeded.

Effect: Frame a bargain with an escape clause only you understand. Gain +1 **die** when the other party acts to fulfill their obligation; you may interpret ambiguous terms in your favor.

Push It: Instead of the clause, you may borrow another's fresh luck: gain +2 **dice** on one roll that benefits from their good fortune, but the original bearer suffers misfortune later; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Speaking Knot (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [BIND], [DEBT], [FEAR], [FATE]

Materials: Cord or thread tied with counted knots while speaking the bargain.

Effect: Bind a promise with fae knots that tighten when broken. Both parties gain +1 **die** while keeping the bargain; breaking it escalates consequences (Harm 1, then Harm 2, then *Curse*).

Push It: The knots grow willful and seek payment from the breaker's kin; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Threefold Exchange (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [TRADE], [DEBT], [BOOST], [FATE]

Materials: Three items of equal seeming value but different true worth.

Effect: Broker a trade where each party yields hidden value. All participants gain +1 **die** when the exchange benefits them; Morag claims the difference in true worth as her tithe.

Push It: The exchange binds across generations; mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as ancestral debts stir.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Cauldron's Secret (High, 12 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [CRAFT], [HEAL], [DEBT], [FATE], [SACRIFICE]

Materials: A cauldron never yet empty, ingredients dearer than coin, and a willing gift of time.

Effect: Brew a solution to any problem, but the cauldron asks one more ingredient – one the brewer does not realize they are providing until too late (a memory, a name, a year of life).

Push It: The remedy works perfectly but breeds dependence – users must return or suffer withdrawal; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Crossroads Court (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [AREA], [BARGAIN], [DEBT], [FATE], [FEAR]

Materials: A true crossroads at twilight, offerings set to the four ways, and the tears of one who bargained thrice.

Effect: Convene Morag's court: all present must bargain. Each pact grants a marked boon and hides a cost that will ripen at the worst time (the GM notes the cost; it becomes due when dramatically appropriate).

Push It: Judgments bind across realms and seasons; mark +2 **Obligation** and begin **Entangled Fates [6]**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Morag

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Morag sings in *harmonies of the half-heard* – melodies that seem to come from just over your shoulder, from a room you left, from a memory you forgot. Their voice is used to sweeten a bitter bargain, to make a debtor forget the interest rate until it is too late, or to call a crossroads spirit to witness an oath. Morag's Cantors are often found in marketplaces, singing the fine print into existence.

The Cult of the Tarnished Cauldron. Morag's cults meet at crossroads, in root cellars, and around cauldrons that never cool. The Tarnished Cauldron is a fellowship of hedges-witches, debt-collectors, and those who have learned that every gift is a hook.

A ritual of the Cult involves each member adding an ingredient to the cauldron (a hair, a coin, a written wish) while speaking a price they are willing to pay – a price that the cauldron remembers. Once per season, the cauldron’s surface goes still, and it speaks a single sentence – the name of a debt that is about to come due, somewhere in the world. The cult members then argue over who will collect it. Their creed is written in chalk on the cauldron’s belly: *"What is freely given can never be reclaimed. What is bargained can always be renegotiated."* Outsiders are welcome to bring a gift and ask a boon – but they will leave with a debt, and the cauldron will remember their voice.

Witchcraft of Morag (Lay / Hag’s Work)

A witch who walks with Morag is a *knot-wife* or *cauldron-tender* – one who crafts bargains into being with thread, iron, and simmering pot. Their magic works through the tools of the hedge: a needle that sews a promise into a hem, a pair of shears that cut an obligation cleanly (or not), or a ladle that stirs consequence into soup. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “bargain stone” at a bridge’s midpoint, but a witch of Morag would instead tie a red thread around the keystone, binding every crossing into a silent contract. Their tools are never hammers; they use needles, shears, and the patient heat of a hearth.

The Witch’s Tool: The Bargain Needle. A needle of cold iron, its eye shaped like a knot. Once per session, the witch may sew a “bargain seam” into a garment, a threshold, or a document. The seam is invisible to all but those who owe a debt to Morag. When the bargain is fulfilled (or broken), the thread loosens (or tightens). The witch may also use the needle to “unpick” a broken promise, resetting a failed negotiation timer by 1 segment at the cost of 1 Fatigue.

A Hedge Gift: Cauldron’s Whisper (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may stir any pot or bowl of liquid (water, broth, wine) with a finger and speak a name. For the next hour, the liquid will “remember” any promise or debt spoken over it. Drinking from the liquid grants the drinker **+1 die** to recall the terms of a bargain, or to detect if someone is lying about an obligation. The liquid tastes faintly of iron and hawthorn.

Morag's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Faerie Sight: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> hidden obligations or unspoken costs.	Bargain Sensitivity: –1 die when refusing offers or walking away; the urge to negotiate bites.
2	Cunning Exchange: Once/scene, propose a trade where you gain equal or greater value for lesser seeming payment.	Debt Awareness: Ever-counting ledgers of owed/owing; suffer Fatigue 1 in crowded markets.
3	Old-Road Wisdom: +2 dice when dealing with spirits, fae, or ancient powers.	Obligation Magnet: “Fair trades” find you – each with costs not yet clear.
4	Bargain Mastery: Once/session, set terms so favorable that even the other party feels satisfied (for now).	Price Collector: Collect on at least one outstanding debt each session or suffer –1 die to social rolls.
5	Crossroads Power: Once/session, call on a crossroads where you bargained before.	Fate Entanglement: Your pacts snag your circles; –1 die to keep agreements purely personal.
6+	Hag's Court: Once/session, arbitrate any bargain; your terms bind all parties.	Debt Incarnate: Mark +3 Obligation; risk becoming a walking covenant, unable to act without minting new debts.

Playstyle Notes

Morag favors negotiators who read the *said* and the *meant* at once. She rewards courtesy kept, clauses counted, and solutions bought with clever coin. The cost is a life lived on ledgers: every boon with a braid, every kindness with a key. She is cruel, but not evil – she will not twist a bargain out of malice, but she will not warn you of the thorn hiding in the rose. That is your job. Intrusions often take the form of a past debt resurfacing, a hidden cost that comes due at the worst moment, or a bargain renegotiated by a third party who claims your original deal had a loophole. Ideal for negotiators, tricksters, and characters who understand that every gift is a hook.

Emphasizes

- **Faerie Bargaining:** strict forms, sharp prices, safe exits
- **Hidden Costs:** the string on every gift
- **Hearth-Way Wisdom:** spirits, thresholds, and natural justice
- **Consequential Magic:** boons that demand upkeep
- **Bargain Mastery:** mutually pleasing terms that still pay you twice
- **Cruel Precision:** the sharp joy of a perfectly balanced account

6.8.22 Mykkiel, Arbiter of the Covenant (Law & Zeal)

Lore. Mykkiel is the unwavering judge of covenants, the divine lawgiver whose scales and sword uphold sacred order. He is not good, nor evil – he is the law. Mercy without justice is weakness; justice without law is chaos. His followers are judges, templars, and scribes who enforce divine law with zealous devotion, seeing the world in absolutes of sanctity and transgression.

The Covenant, the great faith that bears his name, was revealed not through a prophet of soft words, but through a commander of hosts – a figure of burning authority who carved the first covenant into stone with a sword. Mykkiel does not negotiate. He commands. The faithful do not interpret; they obey.

In the chivalric traditions of the west, he is called Seint Michel, the patron of knights who swear to protect the innocent and uphold the code. In the eastern deserts, he is the Judge of the Seal, whose name is invoked before every contract. Wherever law is written in stone and enforced with steel, Mykkiel watches.

“The Law is not written in sand, but in stone. The Covenant is not suggestion, but command. Transgressors shall be purged, the faithful exalted.”

Domain Focus

- **Divine Law:** sacred commandments, contractual obligations, ritual purity
- **Zealous Justice:** righteous judgment, purge of impurity, holy retribution
- **Covenant Bonds:** sacred oaths, tribal loyalty, the chosen community
- **Absolute Order:** hierarchy, tradition, unchanging truth
- **Lawful Neutral:** justice without mercy, order without compassion

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Mykkiel does not bind a familiar of shadow or wild. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of zealous loyalty and keen perception: a white hound with brass eyes that can smell lies and taint, a ferret that hunts rodents of corruption with relentless efficiency, a bronze-feathered hawk that circles above suspected heretics, or a small mechanical bird that sings hymns of purity at dawn. This creature requires no food, but it must be present at a daily prayer or rite of purification. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it growls at strangers or sings discordantly, imposing –1 die on all social rolls with those suspected of impurity for its bearer).

The **Codex** of Mykkiel is never a book of common knowledge. It may be an iron-bound ledger with pages of sanctified vellum, each Rite sealed with a drop of wax; a slate tablet that records only the names of the damned; or a scroll of censure that burns heretical text upon reading. Because Mykkiel’s laws are absolute, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week reciting each Rite aloud in a purified space, or the seals weaken (treat as *Compromised* until reconsecrated).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Mykkiel may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or badge of office) and speak a word of judgment. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Investigation* or *Command* rolls when confronting supernatural creatures, and the first time each scene the bearer would be affected by a magical illusion or fear effect, they may reroll the resistance check (Mykkiel's light burns through deception). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the weight of judgment presses on their soul.

Rites of Mykkiel

Rite of the Consecrated Mandate (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [WARD], [COMMAND], [FEAR], [AREA]

Materials: A war-banner sanctified with sacred oils, or sanctified salt and ritual boundaries.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Burning Banner:** Consecrate an area for a righteous cause. Followers gain **+1 die** to resist fear; enemies suffer **−1 die** to oppose your proclamation. Create a 4-segment *Divine Mandate* timer.
- **Hallowed Ground:** Create sacred space where divine law prevails. All oath-breaking, theft, or violence suffers **−1 die**. Creates a 6-segment *Sacred Space* timer.

Push It: (Banner) The banner emits visible radiance; unbelievers must test Resolve or falter. (Hallowed) The space becomes consecrated ground against supernatural desecration.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Technique Cost: 5 XP (Basic Technique)

Rite of the Blazing Decree (Standard, 8 XP)

Instant; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [COMMAND], [FEAR], [TRUTH], [FORCE]

Materials: A stone tablet or scroll with divine commandments.

Effect: Issue a divine commandment ("Cease," "Repent," "Submit"). The target tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or complies. Higher DV for more demanding commands.

Push It: The command carries divine authority; resistance causes **1 SB (Hearts)** of spiritual distress.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Technique Cost: 8 XP (Advanced Technique)

Rite of the Covenant Seal (Standard, 9 XP)

Ritual; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT], [FEAR], [TRUTH]

Materials: Wax, sacred seals, the names of sworn parties.

Effect: Formalize a binding covenant. All participants suffer concrete penalties for breach (–1 die to relevant actions). Creates an 8-segment *Covenant Bond* timer.

Push It: A breach triggers a visible divine mark (a brand, a stutter, a scar); the marked suffer –2 dice in pious company.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: Extended action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Technique Cost: 9 XP (Advanced Technique)

Rite of Divine Judgment (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Near; High Push

Tags: [COMMAND], [FEAR], [FATE], [DEBT], [TRUTH]

Materials: Scales of justice, testimony (written or spoken), ritual condemnation.

Effect: Pronounce divine judgment. The target suffers escalating penalties (–1 die, then –2 dice) until they atone. Serious crimes (oath-breaking, sacrilege, murder) may warrant greater effects (e.g., Harm, exile, or the attention of Covenant inquisitors). Start a 10-segment *Judgment* timer.

Push It: The judgment becomes public knowledge; the community shuns an unrepentant target (all social rolls against them gain +1 die for the community, and the target suffers –1 die to all social rolls).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Technique Cost: 13 XP (Master Technique)

Rite of the Chosen Legion (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Large Zone; High Push

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [COMMAND], [PROTECT], [FEAR]

Materials: Consecrated ground, ritual weapons, an oath of fidelity sworn by each participant.

Effect: Sanctify an area for the faithful. Believers gain +1 **die** to defense; unbelievers suffer –1 **die**. Supernatural desecration (undead, demons, heretical rites) within the zone risks immediate retaliation (1 SB and a divine warning).

Push It: The area becomes permanently consecrated; start a *Maintenance [8]* timer. If maintenance lapses, the consecration fades, and the site becomes vulnerable to corruption.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Technique Cost: 14 XP (Master Technique)

Covenant Justiciar (Chivalric Zealot)

The law is a sword. The justiciar is its edge. Not for glory, not for mercy – for the covenant alone.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Presence 2+, Rite of the Consecrated Mandate or Cantor of Mykkiel.

Chivalric Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Sworn Defender	When you take the <i>Defend</i> action, you may also grant an adjacent ally +1 Armor until your next turn.	Passive	Body 3, Melee 2
Edict of Silence	Once per scene, as a reaction, force a target who just lied or broke an oath to roll Resolve (DV 4) or be unable to speak for one exchange.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Unyielding Vow	You ignore the first point of Fatigue each scene that would come from upholding a sworn oath (including the Oath of Flame & Light's vow effects).	Passive	Spirit 3, Tier II
Righteous Rebuke	When an enemy attacks an ally you have sworn to protect, you may make a free melee attack against that enemy (once per round).	1 Fatigue	Melee 3, Sworn Defender
Covenant Authority	Your voice carries supernatural weight when citing law. +1 die to Command or Sway when enforcing a contract, oath, or religious edict.	Passive	Presence 3, Lore 2
Judgment Strike	Once per session, after successfully hitting a target you have formally judged (via Rite of Divine Judgment or a similar legal ruling), you may declare the strike a <i>Judgment</i> . The target suffers +2 Harm and must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) or be Stunned for one round.	Free (once)	Tier III, Rite of Divine Judgment

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *The Unbroken Covenant.* Once per session, you may declare a single oath you have sworn (to protect a person, to destroy a foe, to uphold a law) as *inviolable*. For the remainder of the session, you gain +2 dice to all rolls that directly advance that oath, and you ignore the first Harm 2 each scene that would prevent you from fulfilling it. When the oath is fulfilled (or if it becomes impossible to fulfill), you immediately gain 1 permanent Corruption and mark +2 Obligation to Mykkiel – the covenant remembers what you swore.

Cantors & Cults of Mykkiel

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Mykkiel sings in *recitations of the law* – flat, rhythmic chants that sound like the turning of pages in a judge’s ledger or the hammering of a gavel. Their voice is used to swear in witnesses, to pronounce sentence, or to consecrate a battlefield before a holy war. Mykkiel’s Cantors are often found in courts and armies, their songs making the law audible – and inescapable.

The Cult of the Gilded Scale. Mykkiel’s cults gather in chapterhouses, court-houses, and fortified temples. The Order of the Gilded Scale is a militant fraternity of templars, notaries, and inquisitors who believe that the law is the highest form of worship. A ritual of the Order involves each member renewing an oath of fidelity while a blacksmith strikes a blade – the ring of steel reminds them that broken faith is punished by the sword. Their creed is carved over every altar: “*Justice is not a gift. It is a debt owed by every soul to every other.*” Outsiders are welcome as petitioners, but they must speak only truth.

Witchcraft of Mykkiel (Lay / Covenant)

A witch who walks with Mykkiel is a *seal-scribe* or *testimony-keeper* – one who crafts the physical instruments of covenant: a wax seal that cannot be forged, a ledger that records every oath sworn in its presence, or a gavel that makes every word spoken under it true. Their tools are never hammers; they use seals, stamps, and the careful pressure of a signed name. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “law stone” at a bridge’s center, but a witch of Mykkiel would instead press a brass seal into the stone at dusk, so that every bargain struck there is binding for a year and a day. In Vhasia, a notary might forge a contract that writes itself in the parties’ blood, witnessed by the seal.

The Witch’s Tool: The Seal of Unbroken Testimony. A brass signet ring, its face carved with a pair of balanced scales. Once per session, the witch may press the seal into warm wax (or directly onto a stone threshold) while speaking the terms of a single oath. For the next day, anyone who breaks that oath and then crosses the marked threshold (or touches the sealed document) suffers –1 **die** to all rolls until they atone. The seal can also be used to “witness” a testimony: pressing it onto a written statement makes the statement glow faintly if it is true, and grow cold if it is a lie.

A Hedge Gift: Seal of Compliance (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may press a thumb or the seal ring onto a piece of wax, a wet stone, or a bare forehead. The mark is invisible to all but the witch. For the next hour, any promise or command the witch gives to that person carries the weight of divine law; the target suffers –1 **die** if they knowingly disobey or lie. The effect ends if the mark is washed or defaced.

Technique Cost: 2 XP (Minor Hedge Gift)

Mykkiel's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Righteous Insight: +1 die to detect falsehood or covenant-breaking.	Uncompromising: Must uphold law absolutely; -1 die to merciful actions.
2	Zealous Conviction: Once/scene, +1 die when enforcing divine law.	Judge's Severity: Cannot easily overlook infractions; suffer 1 Fatigue if forced to.
3	Divine Authority: +2 dice when commanding in matters of faith or law.	Implacable: -1 die to diplomacy or negotiation with transgressors.
4	Sanctified Presence: Once/session, project an aura that makes resistance difficult.	Intolerant: -1 die when dealing with other faiths or traditions.
5	Prophetic Decree: Once/session, speak judgment that carries supernatural weight.	Blind to Nuance: -1 die to perceive gray areas or partial truths.
6+	Divine Proxy: Once/session, channel absolute judgment (bypass resistance).	Instrument of Wrath: Mark +2 Obligation; risk harming innocents alongside the guilty.

Playstyle Notes

Mykkiel embodies the “jealous god” archetype – righteous, demanding, and uncompromising. Followers excel as templars, judges, and religious authorities who enforce divine law. The corruption progression leads toward absolute certainty and power, but at the cost of mercy and flexibility. Ideal for players who enjoy playing righteous enforcers, legalistic characters, or those exploring themes of faith and absolutism. Remember: Mykkiel is not good or evil – he is law. His followers may be paladins or inquisitors, but they serve the covenant, not any mortal notion of justice.

Emphasizes

- **Divine Law:** the covenant is absolute, unchanging, and unforgiving
- **Zealous Justice:** righteousness without mercy
- **Chivalric Code:** protection of the weak, punishment of the wicked
- **Absolute Order:** hierarchy, tradition, and the weight of oath
- **Lawful Neutral:** the scales do not tilt; they only weigh

6.8.23 Nidhoggr, the World-Worm (Dreaming Antiquity)

Lore. Beneath stone and sleep coils Nidhoggr, who gnaws at the roots of time. He does not speak quickly; he dreams in centuries. To press your ear to the earth is to risk drowning in the silence of eons. Yet for those who endure, he whispers truths long buried, memories fossilized in stone, and the slow inevitability of cycles unbroken. His followers walk in twilight between dream and ruin, bearing the weight of all that has been.

Nidhoggr is the worm who knows the metaphorical bones of the earth – the secret history hidden in every mountain, the forgotten temple beneath the marketplace, the name of the king whose tomb was erased from every chronicle. He is the patron of archaeologists, relic hunters, and those who understand that the past is never truly dead. It is merely sleeping.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Nidhoggr is called by many names. In Aeler, he is the *World-Worm*, whose dreaming coils are said to cause earthquakes. In the Mistlands, he is the *Fog-Memory*, the presence that makes the mist remember what the living forget. In Ykrul, he is the *Bone-Reader*, whose whispers guide shamans to ancient burial grounds. Wherever the earth holds secrets, Nidhoggr dreams.

“Press your ear to the earth and wait. If it remembers you, it will answer.”

Domain Focus

- **Ancient Knowledge:** forgotten histories, buried truths, ancestral memory
- **Stone Communion:** speaking with earth, reading geological memory, stone lore
- **Temporal Perception:** seeing echoes of the past, prophetic dreams, slow time
- **Cyclical Power:** seasonal magic, ritual timing, patience as virtue
- **Relic Hunter:** unearthing the past, preserving what was lost

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Nidhoggr does not bind a familiar of quick flesh. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of deep time and patience: a blind salamander that lives in caves and never ages, a fossilized beetle that occasionally twitches its legs, a snail whose shell records the layers of years, or a small burrowing mole whose fur is always dusted with ancient soil. This creature requires no food, but it must spend at least an hour each day in contact with stone or earth (a cave, a grave, or a masonry wall). If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows lethargic and its shell cracks, imposing –1 die on all Survival or Lore rolls involving ancient sites for its bearer until it is returned to stone).

The **Codex** of Nidhoggr is never a fresh book. It may be a fossilized slab with impressions that change under moonlight, a bundle of slate tablets etched with runes that deepen with age, or a scroll of petrified leather that unrolls only when buried in soil. Because Nidhoggr’s truths are written in the language of deep time, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week burying it in earth (or placing it against ancient stone) and listening for the whisper that refreshes the Rites, or the symbols fade (treat as *Compromised* until re-interred).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Nidhoggr may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or archaeological find) and whisper a word of deep memory. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Lore* or *Investigation* rolls when examining ancient objects or sites, and the first time each scene the bearer would fail to notice a trap or hidden feature in a ruin, they may reroll the check (the stone whispers a warning). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the weight of ages presses on their mind.

Rites of Nidhoggr

Rite of the Whispering Stone (Basic, 5 XP)

Scene/Instant; Touch/Self; Yes

Tags: [TRUTH], [DREAM], [TIME]

Materials: Dust from weathered stone or an ancient artifact; or water poured over ancient stone, consumed ritually.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Stone's Whisper:** Stone reveals one hidden fact about its history. Gain +1 **die** to *Lore* about this object's origin and purpose.
- **Dreaming Deep:** Enter a brief trance to witness echoes of local history. Ask one specific question about past events here.

Push It: (Stone) The vision includes sensory details from the past; mark +1 **Obligation**. (Dream) The vision reveals additional context or hidden connections; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Stone-Sleeper's Murmur (Advanced, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [TRUTH], [AREA], [TIME]

Materials: An ear pressed to bedrock or an ancient structure.

Effect: Read accumulated memories in stone. Ask up to 3 questions about significant events witnessed here. Creates a 6-segment *Memory Resonance* timer.

Push It: One memory unfolds with perfect clarity; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of Awakened Chronicle (Advanced, 9 XP)

Ritual; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [TRUTH], [AREA], [TIME], [BOOST]

Materials: A chalk spiral, four local stones, an hour of meditation.

Effect: The area replays ghostly echoes of a chosen past event. All witnesses gain +2 **dice** to *Investigate/Recall* related checks. Creates an 8-segment *Echo Stability* timer.

Push It: View events from multiple perspectives; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the World-Worm's Dream (Master, 13 XP)*Extended; Zone; High Push***Tags:** [TRUTH], [DREAM], [TIME], [PROPHECY]**Materials:** A circle of ancient stones, a night of vigil under stars.**Effect:** Access deep geological memory. Ask 3 questions about ancient history or receive a prophetic dream. Creates a 10-segment *Deep Dream* timer.**Push It:** Gain temporary skill mastery (+3 dice to one historical action); mark +2 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Obligation:* 7 segments.**Rite of the Unburied Past (Master, 14 XP)***Extended; Large Zone; High Push***Tags:** [TRUTH], [AREA], [TIME], [PRESSURE]**Materials:** Stones from three ancient sites, the blood of a history-keeper (a scholar, a chronicler, or a witness).**Effect:** Overlay a past reality onto the present location. Ruins partially reform, ghostly figures manifest. Allies gain +2 **dice** to Lore/Investigate; any modern technology or recent construction suffers -2 **dice** to function within the zone.**Push It:** The effect lasts until the next lunar cycle; start a *Temporal Instability* [8] timer. When it fills, the past and present become dangerously entangled – a location may become inaccessible or a relic may begin to fade.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Obligation:* 8 segments.**Relic Hunter (Seeker of Lost Ages)***The past is not a foreign country – it is a treasure chest buried beneath your feet. Know where to dig, know what to keep, and know when to run.***Prerequisites:** Wits 3+, Lore 2+, Rite of the Whispering Stone or Cantor of Nidhoggr.**Relic Hunter Techniques (choose as Talents):**

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Cartographer's Eye	Once per expedition (journey), you may redraw a safe route past one environmental hazard (trap, unstable ground, patrol).	1 Boon	Wits 3
Stone Tongue	You can read ancient scripts and petroglyphs as if fluent, even if you have never seen the language before.	Passive	Lore 2
Unstable Ground	When you are in a ruin or underground, you gain +1 die to evasion rolls (dodging traps, collapsing ceilings, etc.).	Passive	Wits 3, Athletics 2
Historical Insight	Once per scene, when you encounter a relic, inscription, or ancient structure, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about its purpose or origin.	Free	Tier II
Trap Sense	You are never surprised by a trap. You gain +1 die to Notice to detect traps, and if you fail, you may reroll one die.	Passive	Wits 3, Perception 2
Escape Artist	Once per session, when you would be trapped (collapsed tunnel, sealed door, net), you may declare a hidden exit or a forgotten passage. The GM reveals a way out, but it may lead to another danger.	1 Boon	Tier III, Athletics 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Secrets of the Unburied Past.* Once per session, you may touch a significant relic or ancient site and ask the GM one question about its history. The GM must answer truthfully and in detail (a paragraph or more). The answer may reveal a hidden weakness, a forgotten ritual, or the location of a related treasure. After using this talent, you gain +1 permanent

Corruption (the past weighs on you) and mark +1 Obligation to Nidhoggr – the worm expects you to act on what you have learned.

Cantors and Cults of Nidhoggr

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Nidhoggr sings in *geological time* – melodies so slow that a single note may stretch across a minute, harmonics that evoke the groan of shifting plates. Their voice is used to lull a city to sleep so that its buried secrets may be heard, or to sing a stone back to its ancient shape. Nidhoggr’s Cantors are often found in deep caves, whispering to stalactites that remember the dawn of the world.

The Cult of the Sleeping Stone. Nidhoggr’s cults gather in places where time feels heavy: ancient barrows, fossil beds, the roots of mountains. The Sleeping Stone is a fellowship of dreamers, historians, and those who have learned that the world remembers everything – and sometimes forgets on purpose. A ritual of the Cult involves each member pressing their ear to a stone and listening for a full hour in absolute silence. When one of them hears a whisper, they speak it aloud, and the stone’s memory is recorded. Their creed is carved into a single erratic boulder that moves about the landscape once a century: *“What is buried is not lost. What is forgotten is only waiting.”* Outsiders are welcome to listen, but they must bring a stone from their homeland and leave it behind.

Witchcraft of Nidhoggr (Lay / Stone Memory)

A witch who walks with Nidhoggr is a *fossil-scribe* or *stone-dreamer* – one who crafts with the memory of the earth. Their magic works through the materials of deep time: a piece of amber that preserves a forgotten scene, a lens ground from a fossilized shell that magnifies the past, or a bowl carved from a meteorite that holds visions of the sky when the world was young. Their tools are never hammers; they use polished stones, fossil lenses, and the patient pressure of a thumb on a petroglyph.

The Witch’s Tool: The Eye of the World-Worm. A smooth, oval stone, polished to a mirror sheen, with a spiral fossil embedded at its center. Once per session, the witch may hold the stone to their eye and look at any ancient structure, fossil, or relic. For the next scene, they see the last significant event that occurred near that object as a ghostly overlay – the mason carving the keystone, the dinosaur stepping into the tar pit, the priest sealing the tomb. The vision is silent but detailed; the GM must describe one useful fact (e.g., “the entrance was hidden behind a tapestry,” “the fossil’s tail points north”). The stone grows warm when it is ready to be used again.

A Hedge Gift: Echo of the Deep (Basic, 2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may place a hand on a stone structure (a wall, a bridge, a cliff) and speak a single word. The stone “repeats” the last word spoken in its presence by any creature – but the word is always in the voice of the last person who touched it, even if they are long dead. This can be used to identify the inhabitants of a ruin, or to frighten the superstitious.

Nidhoggr's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Stone Sense: +1 die to detect ancient sites, hidden history, or geological features.	Temporal Drift: Speak in archaic patterns; -1 die to modern social interactions.
2	Memory Echo: Once/session, perfectly recall one historical fact as if witnessed.	Heavy Presence: 1 Fatigue in places with no history or recent construction.
3	Earth Whisper: +2 dice to commune with stone, read echoes, or interpret ancient sites.	Rooted: -1 die to actions requiring rapid movement or aerial maneuvers.
4	Dream Prophet: Once/scene, gain +1 die to actions tied to ancient mysteries.	Ancestral Haunting: Visions interrupt sleep; mark 1 SB if rest is disturbed.
5	Timeless Gaze: Once/session, witness distant past events through stone communion.	Geological Pace: -1 die to reactions requiring haste; act with deliberate slowness.
6+	World-Memory: Become a living archive for one scene (+3 dice to historical knowledge).	Time's Weight: Mark +2 Obligation; risk permanent Harm from temporal overload.

Playstyle Notes

Nidhoggr rewards patience, curiosity, and a reverence for the past. Followers excel as archaeologists, relic hunters, and scholars who uncover truths that others would leave buried. The corruption progression leads characters toward becoming living libraries of forgotten lore, but at the cost of connection to the present moment – and sometimes the loss of their own identity in the weight of ages. Intrusions often take the form of prophetic dreams that blur past and present, a relic that begins to speak, or a demand to return a stolen artifact to its proper grave. Ideal for players who love exploration, mystery, and the thrill of unearthing what was never meant to be found.

Emphasizes

- **Ancient Knowledge:** the past is a resource, not a relic
- **Stone Communion:** the earth remembers everything
- **Relic Hunting:** every ruin is a story, every artifact a clue
- **Temporal Patience:** some secrets take centuries to ripen
- **Metaphorical Bones:** history is not dead – it is dreaming

Stone Dreamer (Nidhoggr)

Press your ear to the earth and wait.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Whispering Stone or Cantor of

Nidhoggr.

Debt-Resistant Frame. The World-Worm dreams in centuries; debts are but a heartbeat. Stone Dreamer monks gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt or obligation that would bind them for a limited time – they simply wait it out, and the creditor’s urgency crumbles like old stone. If they succeed, the obligation is delayed by one day per rank of the monk’s Spirit (minimum one day).

Techniques:

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Fossil Strike	You may “store” a missed attack. The stored die can be added to a later attack as bonus dice. Maximum storage = Spirit attribute.	Passive (Basic, 5 XP)	Wits 3
Whisper Stone	Touch a stone to learn one hidden fact about its history. Gain +1 die to Lore about this object’s origin and purpose.	1 Fatigue (Basic, 4 XP)	Spirit 2
Stone-Sleeper’s Murmur	Read accumulated memories in stone. Ask up to 3 questions about significant events witnessed here. Create a 6-segment Memory Resonance timer.	1 Boon (Advanced, 8 XP)	Wits 3
Earth Whisper	+2 dice to commune with stone, read echoes, or interpret ancient sites.	1 Fatigue (Advanced, 8 XP)	Tier II
Rooted Patience	When you stand still for one full exchange, gain +1 die to your next action (as the earth steadies you).	Passive (Basic, 4 XP)	Spirit 2

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *World-Memory.* Once per session, become a living archive for one scene: gain +3 dice to historical knowledge, and you may ask the GM one question about a forgotten event or debt. The answer is always true. After the scene, you gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your eyes are flecked with gray, like granite) but you may also, once per arc, ignore the time limit on any obligation – you simply outwait it, and the creditor moves on to more impatient debtors.

6.8.24 Nimorith, the Gray Benefactor (Absence & Threshold)

Trow Patron; also answered by threshold-keepers, archivists of omissions, and oathwrights who work in the space between Said & Meant.

Lore. Nimorith dwells in places that almost were—thresholds that shift when unobserved, rooms that measure longer than memory, shadows that fall where no lamp was lit. He does not *arrive*, he is simply the pause you finally notice. Those who bargain with him learn that presence is a luxury, absence a currency, and the space between doors a kingdom unto itself. To serve him is to walk at the corner of sight, to speak in the breath held before truth is told.

“Take what is not there, and you shall have what never was.
The gap is the gift; the missing, the mercy.”

Domain Focus

- **Thresholds & Liminality:** doors, gates, moments of transition, the unseen
- **Absence & Omission:** erasure, forgetting, silence, what is not said
- **Memory & Witness:** testimony, collateral, the price of truth
- **Subtlety & Misdirection:** stealth, deception by omission, unseen paths

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Nimorith does not bind a familiar of flesh and blood. Their **Thiasos** is a creature of silence and gaps: a moth that flies only in the blind spot of the eye, a spider that weaves webs only in unlit corners, a mouse that is only ever heard, never seen, or a patch of shadow that moves against the light. This creature requires no food, but it must be offered a *silence* daily—a minute of absolute stillness and quiet contemplation from its bearer. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it fades, imposing –1 die on all Stealth or Subterfuge rolls for its bearer until a significant silence is given).

The **Codex** of Nimorith is never a whole book. It may be a collection of blank vellum pages that reveal writing only when held in a specific type of shadow, a slate that must be dusted with ash from an extinguished lamp, or a key that unlocks a non-existent drawer. Because Nimorith’s truths are written in omissions, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week in a truly liminal space (a doorway at twilight, a forgotten attic, a crossroads) and erase one of their own memories onto its pages, or the symbols fade (treat as *Compromised* until a suitable omission is made).

Patron’s Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Nimorith may focus on a specific *absence*—a missing object, a silent moment, an unlit lamp. For the rest of the scene, they gain +1 die to *Stealth* or *Subterfuge* rolls that exploit that absence, and the first time each scene they would fail to move unseen through a threshold, they may reroll the check (the shadows part for them). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the world feels slightly more present and solid around them.

Rites of Nimorith**The Unmeasured Room (Low, 4 XP)***Scene; Self; Sustain by silence.***Tags:** [GAP], [STEALTH]**Materials:** An inward-opening door; a held breath to the count of three.**Effect:** Create one *Gap* token—a specific absence that others ignore (a watcher forgets a latch, a ledger skips a line, a patrol overlooks a side door). You gain +1 die when exploiting this gap. An ally may spend 1 Boon to treat one failed roll as “never happened” (retcon of that action only).**Push It:** The gap becomes *contagious*: nearby like-absences echo. Mark +1 SB (*Spades*).
*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.**Borrowed Memory (Low, 5 XP)***Scene; Touch.***Tags:** [MEMORY], [TRUTH]**Materials:** A silver thread tied fingertip-to-fingertip; a whispered “I was there.”**Effect:** Hold another’s specific memory as collateral. Gain +1 die on actions grounded in that memory’s context. Memory returns slightly out of order unless “paid in full” with a truthful account before witnesses.**Push It:** Hold two memories simultaneously; mark +1 **Obligation** as temporal dissonance builds.*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.**The Missing Line (Standard, 8 XP)***Scene; Near.***Tags:** [OMISSION], [TRUTH]**Materials:** A document with space for amendment; a shadowless gray feather.**Effect:** Cause one clause, name, or line to vanish from a witnessed text. *DV = complexity/scope*. On success, the erasure is seamless and socially “always so.”**Push It:** The omission propagates to directly-referenced copies; mark +1 SB (*Diamonds*) as reality adjusts.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.**Duskmark’s Passage [PASSAGE] (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Zone.***Tags:** [PASSAGE], [TRAVEL]**Materials:** Two duskmarks set at twilight; an unlit pipe that smokes by itself.**Effect:** Declare safe-conduct between the paired thresholds. Allies gain +2 dice to **Traverse**; enemies suffer -1 die to intercept within the lane. A counter-witness at either end can block.**Push It:** Passage becomes bidirectional for the scene; mark +1 **Obligation**—the path remembers you.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

The Almost-Present Guest [OATH] (Standard, 9 XP)*Scene; Near.***Tags:** [OATH], [TRUTH]**Materials:** Bread-and-salt beneath a lifted lamp; threefold witness (mortal / fey / liminal).**Effect:** Bind Nimorith to guest-right for *one night* and *one truthful answer*. He cannot speak his own name; answers arrive as silence, gesture, or omission all present can understand.**Push It:** Extend hospitality to the entire party; mark +2 **Obligation** as the house begins to forget its owners.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** Extended ritual; mark +1 **Obligation**.**Veil-Bending (High, 12 XP)***Scene; Zone.***Tags:** [VEIL], [ILLUSION]**Materials:** A room with four doors; a mirror that reflects only doorways.**Effect:** Reverse directions within the space; quiet a name until dawn; align exits with intent rather than map. Zone gains the [VEIL] tag: +2 dice to misdirection; -2 dice to direct confrontation.**Push It:** Make it *permanent* for this site; start **Threshold Drift [6]** as the place migrates from the world.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended ritual; mark +2 **Obligation**.**Obligation:** 7-segment timer.**The Gray Inheritance [WARD] (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Touch.***Tags:** [WARD], [CURSE]**Materials:** A will in disappearing ink; a hat that drinks lamplight; a true-name spoken in negative (“what you are not”).**Effect:** Transfer ownership of an *absence*: void a debt, erase an obligation, negate a presence. Target gains the benefit but suffers -1 die to direct confrontation or plain declaration for the duration of the ward.**Push It:** The inheritance binds to bloodline or faction; mark +2 **Obligation** as ancestral gaps widen.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended ritual; mark +2 **Obligation**.**Obligation:** 8-segment timer.**Threshold Warden (Keeper of the Between)***You do not guard the door; you guard the idea of the door. You watch the unwatched space.***Prerequisites:** Wits 3+, Stealth 2+, Rite of the Unmeasured Room or Cantor of Nimorith.

Threshold Warden Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Unseen Path	Once per scene, you may step from one shadow to another within Near, provided neither is under direct observation.	1 Boon	Wits 3
Silent Witness	You gain +1 die to Notice rolls to observe others without being noticed yourself.	Passive	Stealth 2
Erase the Moment	When you would be noticed, you may spend a Boon to have the observer simply overlook you, as if your presence was a trick of the light.	1 Boon	Wits 3, Subterfuge 2
Gap Sense	You intuitively feel when something is missing or out of place. Gain +1 die to Investigate scenes for clues based on absence (e.g., what isn't there).	Passive	Tier II
Door-Smoke	You can briefly cause a door or window to appear where there is none, or vice versa. This illusion lasts only a moment, long enough to confuse pursuit.	1 Fatigue	Wits 3, Illusion 2
The Fifth Step	When traversing a known area, you may take a "fifth step" that isn't on the map. Once per session, declare a small, previously unnoticed alcove or passage exists.	1 Boon	Tier III, Lore 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Keeper of the Unlit Pipe.* Once per session, you can enforce a profound silence upon a Zone. For one scene, all sound ceases, all lights gutter out, and all witnesses find their attention sliding away from the area. Those within gain +2 dice to Stealth and Subterfuge. After using this talent, you mark +1 permanent Corruption (your own outline becomes faint) and +1 Obligation to Nimorith – a silence this deep always demands a reciprocal noise

eventually.

Cantors & Cults of Nimorith

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Nimorith does not sing notes, but the spaces *between* notes. Their music is one of rests, pauses, and breaths held too long. Their voice is used to erase sound, to make a crowded room feel empty, or to make a promise forgotten before it is fully heard. Nimorith’s Cantors are often found in places of negotiation or treaty-signing, ensuring the final agreement contains the necessary, profitable omissions.

The Cult of the Absent Host. Nimorith’s cults gather in non-places: abandoned train stations at midnight, the attics of forgotten houses, the space under a bridge that no one claims. The Absent Host is a fellowship of those who profit from what is not said and what is not seen. A ritual of the Cult involves a shared meal where one seat is always left empty for Nimorith, and the most valuable dish is the one that is never served. Their creed is written in smoke and fading light: “*The greatest gift is an exit no one remembers. The greatest truth is the one left unspoken.*” Outsiders are welcome if they bring a secret to erase.

Witchcraft of Nimorith (Lay / Liminal)

A witch who walks with Nimorith is a *threshold-weaver* or *gap-monger* – one who crafts with absence and silence. Their magic works through the materials of negation: a candle that burns darkness instead of light, a key that opens locks by making them forget they are locked, or a scissor that cuts the threads of memory. Their tools are never whole; they use broken mirrors, half-spoken words, and borrowed shadows.

The Witch’s Tool: The Duskmark Lantern. A lantern with panes of smoked glass that seems to absorb light rather than cast it. Once per session, the witch may light this lantern (though it produces no visible flame) in a doorway or threshold. For the next scene, the threshold becomes **veiled**; those who pass through it are not immediately noticed, and sounds are dampened. The lantern grows cold when it is ready to be used again.

A Hedge Gift: Whisper of Omission (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may whisper a single word into someone’s ear. That word is temporarily erased from the target’s vocabulary; they cannot speak it or understand it for the next hour. This can be used to disable a command word, prevent a warning, or simply cause profound confusion.

Nimorith's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Shadow-Step: Once/scene, move between witnessed thresholds in Near.	Almost-Presence: In crowds you slip notice; begin Position –1 when trying to stand out.
2	Gap-Sense: +1 die to Notice when something vital is missing or altered.	Blind Spot: You may miss the obvious present while hunting absences.
3	Echo-Accounting: Once/session, ensure a vow “takes” by finding its last true witness.	Witness Weight: Maintain three active witness tokens or suffer –1 die to social rolls.
4	Flow-Nudge: Once/scene, open the exit you <i>meant</i> ; close the boastful boast.	Direction Drift: Maps resist you; –1 die to Navigation without a living guide.
5	Absence Artisan: Once/session, create a beneficial absence (forgotten debt, skipped patrol, missing line).	Obligation Void: Others forget promises owed to you; –1 die to enforce agreements.
6+	Gray Dominion: Once/session, declare an area “properly absent”: allies +2 dice to stealth/deception; foes –2 dice to detection/truth.	Reality Thinning: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk permanent Harm from existing half-out-of-world.

Playstyle Notes

Nimorith rewards subtlety, precision, and an appreciation for what is not there. Followers excel as spies, saboteurs, diplomats, and archivists who understand that power often lies in the carefully managed gap. The corruption progression leads characters toward becoming creatures of silence and shadow, but at the cost of their presence in the world and their ability to hold onto social bonds. Intrusions often take the form of doors leading to the wrong place, witnesses appearing where none should be, or a vital piece of information being suddenly and inexplicably forgotten by everyone. Ideal for players who love intrigue, misdirection, and operating from the shadows.

Emphasizes

- **Subtlety Over Force:** The unseen cut is the deepest.
- **Liminal Spaces:** Power resides in transitions, not destinations.
- **The Unspoken Agreement:** The most binding contracts are those never written down.
- **Memory as Currency:** What you choose to forget can be more valuable than what you remember.

Way of the Unseen Step (Nimorith)

The space between heartbeats is a kingdom. The pause between breaths, an eternity.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Dexterity 2+, Rite of the Unmeasured Room or Cantor of Nimorith.

Gap-Step. Monks of the Unseen Step move through the world like a rumor. They gain +1 die to avoid being the focus of attention. When they would be targeted by an attack or ability, if they succeed on a Wits + Stealth check (DV set by the threat), the aggressor's focus slips to another valid target nearby.

Techniques:

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Shadow Lintel	Once/scene, step from one witnessed threshold to another within Near.	Free	Wits 3
Strike of Omission	Your attack is not seen coming. Gain +1 die to your first attack roll against a target who hasn't acted yet this scene.	Passive	Dexterity 2
The Unmeasured Room	Create a <i>Gap</i> token. You gain +1 die when exploiting this gap.	1 Boon	Wits 3
Silent Witness	+1 die to observe others without being noticed yourself.	Passive	Tier II
Veil of Nothing	When you stand perfectly still, you are treated as Invisible for purposes of detection for one round.	1 Fatigue	Dexterity 3, Stealth 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Door-Smoke*. Once per session, you can step through any door and emerge from any other door you have ever seen, regardless of distance. You may bring one other person with you. After using this technique, you gain a permanent **Gap Scar** (a part of you, like a memory or a minor skill, is permanently lost to the between-places) and mark +1 Obligation to Nimorith – a path used must eventually be repaid with a path closed.

6.8.25 The Ninth, Beyond Comprehension (Infinite Information & Unknowable Truths)

Lore. Beyond the eighth figure of Sacred Geometry lies a rim no compass will hold. The Ninth is not absence but surplus: knowledge poured past the lip of any vessel, truth that overgrows the frame that seeks to bind it. Those who bend the knee at its lectern become conduits for impossible reckonings — glimpsing patterns that cannot be kept whole inside a single skull. Each revelation purchases power at the price of living comfortably within the world’s common measures.

The Ninth does not explain, define, or warn. It *overflows*. To invoke it is to step past the eighth threshold — the one you did not know was there — and find that on the other side, the cup forgets its shape, the bell rings a note that was never cast, and the answer to your question arrives as a question you had not yet learned to ask.

“Eight figures bind the world; the Ninth overflows it. Drink, and remember that the cup forgets its shape before the song is done.”

Domain Focus

- **Hyperdimensional Knowledge:** reckonings that do not fit a single plane or proof
- **Incomprehensible Truths:** insights that demand the seer be changed to hold them
- **Information Overflow:** boon and peril of minds run past their brim
- **Conceptual Transcendence:** thinking beyond the usual ledgers and names
- **Threshold Breaking:** stepping past the eighth boundary into what should not exist

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Ninth does not bind a living familiar. Their **Thiasos** is a *pattern given will*: a sentient compass that points to contradictions, a brass abacus whose beads click in impossible sequences, or a mirror that reflects questions instead of faces. This entity can be housed in a small object (a lens, a pendulum, a blank book). It requires no food, but it demands new information: each week the Runekeeper must feed it a secret, a riddle, or a half-finished proof. If neglected for a month, the Thiasos begins to whisper false answers.

The **Codex** of the Ninth is never a simple grimoire. It may be a slate of fractally etched stone, a bundle of knotted threads, or the inside of the Runekeeper’s own eyelids. Because the Ninth’s truths resist being fixed in one place, a Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week erasing and rewriting a single page, or the Rites stored there become garbled (treat as Compromised until restored).

Patron’s Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Ninth may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or writing implement) and speak a paradox. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Lore* or *Investigation* rolls, and its first use each scene *ignores one*

Story Beat generated by a 1 (the item's impossible nature briefly confuses the Weave). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the insight lingers like a splinter in the mind.

Rites of the Ninth

Rite of the Ninth Figure (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD]

Materials: A chalk figure with an “impossible” joint, or a reckoning worked toward infinity on slate.

Effect: Glimpse past the ordinary frame of measure. Gain **+1 die** to *Lore* or *Investigation* when wrestling complex systems or many-layered problems.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Flooded Scriptorium (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [TRUTH], [SPEED], [OVERFLOW]

Materials: An overburdened ledger-hall, stacked codices, a bell that tolls the copying-hour without cease.

Effect: Read faster than hands can turn pages. Ask three questions upon any topic that leaves a written wake; gain **+2 dice** to rolls of analysis this scene.

Push It: The tide of knowing overruns its banks — suffer **Fatigue 1** and mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as overflow breeds complication.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Hypercognitive Lattice (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [BOOST], [THRESHOLD], [OVERFLOW]

Materials: A brass-thought lattice, an orrery of inked threads, or a draught that sharpens memory.

Effect: Widen the mind's mouth. For this scene, treat your *Wits* as **+2** higher for information-processing rolls; you may track several intricate streams at once.

Push It: The opening does not quite close: keep the boon, but suffer **−1 die** to single-task focus; mark **1 SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Breaking Glyph (Standard, 7 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD]

Materials: A vigil in dim light, a water-timer, and a problem sworn not to be left half-seen.

Effect: Take one pattern whole. Choose a complex system, theory, or design and gain perfect internal grasp of it; receive **+3 dice** to related knowledge rolls for the session.

Push It: Your tongue cannot carry what your mind now holds: you cannot clearly teach

or translate this insight; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Endless Stacks (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [AREA], [TRUTH], [OVERFLOW], [THRESHOLD]

Materials: A hall of mirrored shelves, wax-tablets without end, whispering leaves of vellum.

Effect: Raise a locus of overfull knowing. All present gain **+2 dice** to information-work; knowledge may be drawn from unlikely sources. Start a **[6] Information Overload** timer — as it fills, participants strain and fray.

Push It: The Stacks wake and demand tithe in understanding or memory; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Ninth Revelation (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD], [TRANSFORM], [FATE]

Materials: A fast from easy speech, a circle of unbroken figures, and vows to see past comfort.

Effect: Glimpse a shard of Ninth truth. Take one major insight that overleaps common frames — perfect command of a knotty system, forecast of chaotic motion, or comprehension of an “impossible” relation.

Push It: The shard sets in you like glass: gain **Transcendent Understanding** (see Corruption) and mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Ninth

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of the Ninth sings in *phrases that fold back on themselves* — melodies that seem to have no beginning or end, harmonies that shift key in ways that should be impossible. Their voice is used to encrypt a message into a tune that only the intended listener can hear, to unravel the logic of a paradox, or to lull a library’s guardian spirit into a momentary confusion. The Ninth’s Cantors are often found in great archives, humming while they work.

The Cult of the Unfinished Index. The Ninth’s cults meet in libraries, scriptoria, and the back rooms of printing houses — but the innermost circle, the *Unfinished Index*, has a stranger practice: each member carves a single extra joint into a finger of their writing hand (a ninth knuckle that does not bend). They believe that the extra joint holds a question they have not yet learned to ask. A ritual involves each member writing a fact they have never told anyone on a slip of paper, then burning it. The ashes are swept into a single book — the *Growing Ledger* — whose pages multiply each year and *whisper* at night, adding entries no one wrote. Their creed is stamped inside the cover:

“Every answer births nine new questions. This is not a flaw. This is the shape of truth.”
Outsiders are welcome to ask a question, but they will leave with three they did not bring — and sometimes, a faint, extra knuckle that fades by morning.

Witchcraft of the Ninth (Lay / Knowledge)

A witch who walks with the Ninth is a *glyph-carver* or *pattern-weaver* — one who crafts knowledge into physical form: a book that writes itself, a map that shows only the routes the reader does not yet know, or a code that cannot be broken because it was never written. Their magic works through the tools of information: a quill that writes in letters that shift meaning with the light, a seal that stamps “APPROVED” onto documents that were never submitted, or a lens that reveals hidden writing. Their craft is never about forging metal; it is about folding paper, spilling ink, and stepping past the eighth line of a proof into the white space where the answer is not written because the question was wrong.

The Witch’s Tool: The Paradox Quill. A quill carved from the bone of a bird that never lived, dipped in ink that dries clear. Once per session, the witch may write a single sentence on a surface (a wall, a scroll, a forehead). The sentence is true — but only for the next hour. After that, it becomes a lie, or fades, or was never there at all. The GM determines the exact effect, but the truth is always useful for that hour.

A Hedge Gift: Glyph of Unfolding (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a single geometric symbol on a surface (a door, a lock, a piece of paper) while speaking a question aloud. The symbol “unfolds” into a diagram that answers the question — but the diagram is always incomplete, cryptic, or reveals something the seeker did not wish to know. The witch gains +1 **die** to any roll that uses the diagram’s information.

Corruption of the Ninth

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hyperawareness: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> when patterns whisper that they matter.	Starved for Text: –1 die in barren halls with little record or sign; you itch for a stream to read.
2	Pattern Recognition: Once/scene, see connections others miss within tangled accounts and signs.	Scattered Threads: Thoughts run in parallel; –1 die to sustained, single-line focus.
3	Data Synthesis: Once/session, fuse vast reckonings at a glance into a usable answer.	Tongue-Tied by Wonder: –2 dice to teach or clearly explain your deepest insights.
4	Dimensional Insight: Once/scene, take a problem from an “impossible” angle and treat a knot as if already loosened.	Bent Sense: Ordinary space and tasks feel ill-fit; –1 die to plain spatial or mundane labors.
5	Infinite Processing: Once/session, render perfect analysis of any information system or record-trail.	Concept Drift: Common categories slip; –1 die to easy company and familiar talk.
6+	Ninth Awareness: Once/session, look from outside the frame; for a heartbeat, the world aligns.	Transcendent Fragmentation: Mark +3 Obligation. You exist partially out of phase. Once per session, you may phase through a solid obstacle (wall, door, person) as a move action, but after doing so you cannot physically interact with objects for one exchange. The GM gains 1 SB as reality shivers.

Playstyle Notes

The Ninth favors the patient reader of tangled ledgers and sky-signs alike. It rewards audacity in thought and the courage to let understanding change you. Its gifts turn riddles into roads — but every road leads past a threshold you did not know existed. To serve the Ninth is to accept that you will never again fit comfortably inside the frame you once called home. Intrusions often take the form of sudden, inexplicable knowledge (a face you recognize from a dream, a word in a language you have never learned), or a question posed by a stranger who seems to know exactly what you were thinking. Refusing an intrusion does not bring punishment — merely the slow forgetting of the insight you were about to receive, leaving you with the sense that you once knew something important, but can no longer recall what.

Emphasizes

- **Hyperdimensional Knowledge:** insights that escape a single page

- **Cognitive Expansion:** widening the mind to hold more than comfort allows
- **Pattern Transcendence:** seeing threads that run beneath names and weights
- **Information Synthesis:** binding many scraps into one true line
- **Conceptual Breakthrough:** stepping past the frame rather than painting within it
- **Threshold Overflow:** the power of the ninth step, the extra word, the unasked question

6.8.26 Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn & Vows)

Lore. The Oath of Flame & Light is no patron of half-measures. Its fire names, binds, and burns — demanding that those who swear within its radiance stand openly, speak truly, and pay the cost of keeping their word. At dawn altars, the sworn kindle sparks of consecrated fire; in battle, they blaze as torches that hold back the night. To follow this Oath is to live in public truth, with no shadow to hide in and no retreat from the vow once spoken.

The Oath appears in many guises across cultures, and is the patron most commonly called upon by the magic-users of the Church of Flame and the Temple of Light — as well as any fire- or light-based faith or order:

- **The Everflame** — the unquenchable fire of promise, carried from shrine to shrine by wandering priests of the Church of Flame. Its censers never cool.
- **Adur**, the Light of Aeler — worshiped as the sun’s church-deity, whose flame consecrates oaths and consumes falsehood. Dwarven templars strike their oaths into stone with a brand.
- **Adar**, the Vilikari Dawnfire — invoked as a war-god of vows and vengeance, whose rising light marks those who break faith. Cavalrymen light a single arrow before battle.
- **The Watchfire of Vhasia** — a saint’s flame that never gutters, tended by a silent order of healers who swear to harm no one — and to let no one die alone.
- Others know the Oath only as *the Flame* or *the Lantern*, a nameless fire that still demands truth and punishes betrayal.

Wherever it manifests, the Oath of Flame & Light remains the same unyielding power: to swear beneath its dawn is to bind one’s self to a truth that cannot be hidden, forgotten, or undone.

“Swear in the light. Keep it, or the light will keep *you*.”

Domain Focus

- **Sacred Vows:** oath-keeping, truth-speaking, binding promises
- **Divine Justice:** retribution, smiting evil, protecting the innocent
- **Radiant Power:** healing light, purification, revealing truth
- **Dawn’s Hope:** renewal, protection, driving back darkness

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Oath of Flame & Light does not bind a familiar of darkness or silence. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of dawn and radiance: a fire-colored salamander that basks on hot coals, a small brass-plated lizard whose scales warm when a vow is true, a golden-eyed owl that hoots only at sunrise, or a tiny phoenix fledgling that glows faintly in darkness. This creature requires no food, but it must be present when the

Runekeeper renews their daily vows (a short prayer at dawn). If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (its glow flickers or goes out, imposing –1 die on all social rolls involving oaths or truth for its bearer until a new vow is sworn in its presence).

The **Codex** of the Oath is never a book of ink and paper. It may be a brass scroll etched with commandments that glow when read aloud, a set of consecrated candles whose flames spell out Rites, or a sun-stone carved with runes that only appear when touched by direct sunlight. Because the Oath's truths are written in light, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week in dawn light, re-reading each Rite aloud, or the engravings fade (treat as *Compromised* until re-consecrated at dawn).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Oath of Flame & Light may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or badge) and whisper a vow of protection. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 die to *Defend* or *Resist* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be forced to break a sworn oath by magical compulsion, they may ignore it (the flame burns through the coercion). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the flame's warmth lingers on their skin.

Rites of the Oath of Flame & Light

Rite of Kindle Vow (Basic, 4 XP)

Action; Self/Ally; Standard Push

Tags: [VOW], [RADIANT]

Materials: A glass ampoule of consecrated flame.

Effect: Declare a short vow for this scene (e.g., “protect the villagers,” “speak only truth”). The bearer gains +1 die to actions fulfilling it.

Push It: The first hesitation forces 1 **SB (Hearts)** on the bearer.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Lay on Hands (Basic, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [HEAL], [PURIFY], [RADIANT]

Materials: A bare palm, a whispered vow.

Effect: Cleanse an affliction, downgrade Harm by 1, or remove 1 Fatigue. For curses or poisons, test Spirit+Resolve (DV set by fiction).

Push It: The target gains +1 die to their next Resist roll this scene; you mark Exposure +1.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Sunlit Parley (Advanced, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [TRUTH], [COMMAND], [RADIANT]

Materials: A vow-ring engraved with sunrise.

Effect: Establish terms in open light. Honest persuasion gains +1 die; deceit suffers –1 die. Create a 6-segment *Parley Accord* timer.

Push It: Demand one public answer; evasion forces **1 SB (Hearts)** on the evader.
Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Radiant Smite (Advanced, 9 XP)

Action; Self; Standard Push

Tags: [STRIKE], [ANNIHILATE], [RADIANT]

Materials: A consecrated spark on a weapon or badge.

Effect: Your next melee strike flares with dawnfire. Upgrade Effect by one step, add +1 Burn Harm, or -1 die to their next roll. Against undead, oath-breakers, or outsiders: oath-breakers suffer +1 Harm *and* -1 die, outsiders gain +1 leash ticks.

Push It: On a hit, the burst drives back enemies in Close (worse Position); mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Purge the Shadow (Advanced, 10 XP)

Instant; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [DISPEL], [REVEAL], [RADIANT]

Materials: A shattered consecrated spark.

Effect: Reveal illusions and suppress one ongoing glamour or curse in Near range. Creates a 4-segment *Purity's Light* timer.

Push It: Brand the source with a visible tell for this arc; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Covenant Blaze (Master, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; High Push

Tags: [WARD], [FORCE], [RADIANT], [COMMAND]

Materials: A brazier lit while three names are spoken.

Effect: The sworn within are haloed: they gain +1 **die** to keep their oath; aggressors suffer -1 **die** if violating the terms. Oath-breakers suffer **2 SB (Hearts/Spades)** and Harm 1 (Burn).

Push It: Sanctify a threshold with one beat of [WARD] against oath-breakers; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Oath of Flame & Light

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Oath sings in *clarion tones* — melodies that sound like a trumpet at sunrise, like a bell calling the faithful to prayer. Their voice is used to swear in a witness, to consecrate a blade with a hymn, or to sing a funeral pyre into a beacon. The Oath's Cantors are often found in military camps and pilgrimage roads, their songs keeping oaths fresh and courage hot.

The Cult of the Unquenched Flame. The Oath's cults gather at dawn, in open courtyards or on hilltops facing east. The Unquenched Flame is a fellowship of paladins, healers, and simple folk who have sworn to keep one another honest. A ritual of the Cult involves each member speaking a vow aloud as the sun crests the horizon, then passing a lit candle to the next — the flame must not be allowed to go out until all have spoken. Their creed is written in charcoal above every hearth: *"The flame that reveals the truth"*

also warms the hands that keep it.” Outsiders are welcome to swear a temporary vow and share the light — but an oath sworn at dawn is binding until sunset.

Witchcraft of the Oath of Flame & Light (Monastic / Scholarly)

A witch who walks with the Oath is often a *consecrated scribe*, a *censer-bearer*, or a *vowed healer* — a nun, monk, or scholar of one of the great flame-temples. Their magic is inseparable from liturgy, prayer, and the careful tending of sacred spaces. They illuminate manuscripts with gold leaf that glows in the presence of lies, brew unguents from ashes of the everflame, and copy oath-books whose letters burn when a vow is broken. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “prayer keystone” into a basilica wall, so that every confession spoken there warms the stone. In Vhasia, a silent sister might stitch a healing shroud that records the wounds it has mended.

The Witch’s Tool: Prayer Beads of the Unbroken Vow. A string of nine beads carved from olive wood and fired in a basilica’s censer. Each bead represents a clause of a sacred oath. Once per session, the witch may slip the beads around a door handle, a prisoner’s wrist, or a contract scroll. While the beads remain, any creature that knowingly violates an oath sworn under that threshold suffers a mild burn (1 Fatigue) as the beads glow faintly. The beads may also be used to count a silent vow; the witch may reroll one failed Resolve roll when upholding that vow.

A Hedge Gift: Sealed Benediction (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may lay a hand on a willing creature’s forehead and speak a short, formal blessing (e.g., “May the flame keep your word”). The target gains **+1 die** on their next roll to resist fear, despair, or magical coercion. The blessing lasts until the next dawn. The witch must write the blessing on a scrap of parchment and burn it; the smoke carries the prayer.

Oath of Flame & Light Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Oathbound Strength: +1 die when upholding vows or defending innocents.	Rigid Honor: Must uphold vows even when disadvantageous; -1 die to flexible actions.
2	Radiant Sight: Once/scene, +2 dice to detect lies or corruption.	Blinding Truth: -1 die to subtlety or deception attempts.
3	Holy Flame: +1 die to melee against undead, outsiders, or oath-breakers.	Burden of Light: 1 Fatigue when concealing identity or working in darkness.
4	Unwavering Resolve: Once/session, treat a failed Resolve/Command as success (mark 1 SB).	Absolutist Stance: -1 die in morally ambiguous situations.
5	Dawn's Benediction: Once/session, heal all allies in Near of 1 Fatigue and minor Conditions.	Beacon's Call: Your aura reveals you; enemies seeking you gain +1 die.
6+	Avatar of the Oath: Once/session, become a living covenant (+2 dice to protection/justice actions).	Radiance's Price: Mark +2 Obligation; breaking any vow inflicts Harm 2 (Burn).

Playstyle Notes

The Oath of Flame & Light excels as a “paladin” patron, rewarding vow-keeping and truth-speaking with potent defensive and smiting abilities. Followers become living embodiments of their oaths, shining beacons against deception and darkness. The corruption progression naturally leads toward becoming an uncompromising force for justice, though potentially at the cost of flexibility and subtlety. Ideal for characters who embody conviction, protection, and radiant power.

Emphasizes

- **Sacred Vows:** oath-keeping, truth-speaking, binding promises
- **Divine Justice:** retribution, smiting evil, protecting the innocent
- **Radiant Power:** healing light, purification, revealing truth
- **Dawn's Hope:** renewal, protection, driving back darkness

6.8.27 Oath of Mercy and Grace (Healing & Forgiveness)

Lore. The Oath of Mercy and Grace has no founder, no scripture, no single temple. It began in a hundred places — a battlefield where a medic bound wounds without asking whose side; a plague village where a stranger stayed to dig graves; a debtor’s cell where a guard looked away and said, “I saw nothing.” Those who swear the Oath do not worship a power; they embody a principle: that every act of care creates an obligation — not to the giver, but to the next person in need. You do not pay back. You pay forward. The mercy spirals.

But mercy is not weakness. The spiral does not forget. Those who strike a healer, who violate a sanctuary, who refuse the offered cup — they find that grace has teeth, and forgiveness carries a price.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, the Oath of Mercy and Grace is the patron of healers, hospice workers, and those who shelter the helpless. In Aelaerem, the Oath is kept by the *Gray Spiral*, a fellowship of lay healers who ask no payment. In Viterra, the *Hospitaller Knights* swear to defend the sick without drawing swords. In Zakov, the *Tide-Watchers* pull drowning sailors from the sea and ask only that the rescued help one stranger in turn. Wherever mercy is given without expectation of return, the spiral turns.

“You ask who owes what. We ask who needs what. The ledger is not the same as the meal. But woe to the one who mistakes the server for a servant.”

Domain Focus

- **Restorative Work:** healing body, mind, and spirit; mending what is broken.
- **Spiral Mercy:** paying obligation forward through acts of care.
- **Sanctuary:** sheltering the hunted, feeding the hungry, accepting no payment — but demanding respect for the threshold.
- **Unburdening:** releasing others (and oneself) from the weight of unpaid debts, and binding aggressors to that same weight.

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Oath of Mercy and Grace does not bind a familiar of claw and fang. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature of gentle presence and quiet vigilance: a white dove that perches on the shoulder and coos when a lie is spoken in a place of sanctuary, a gray cat that curls on the laps of the dying and purrs away their fear, a small hedgehog that rolls into a ball to protect the vulnerable, or a firefly that glows warmly when a vow of mercy is kept. This creature requires no food, but it must witness an act of care (feeding the hungry, binding a wound, sheltering a fugitive) each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it hides or refuses to approach the sick, imposing –1 die on all healing and social rolls involving mercy for its bearer until an act of care is performed in its presence).

The **Codex** of Mercy and Grace is never a book of spells alone. It may be a gray wool cord braided with nine knots, each knot tied while speaking a name of someone who was healed; a clay bowl fired from the clay of a hospice hearth, its inner surface

inscribed with vows; or a ledger of debts forgiven, each page sealed with a thumbprint of ash. Because the spiral is written in acts, not ink, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week untying and retying each knot (or re-firing the bowl, or reviewing a page of forgiven debts), or the Rites become uncertain (treat as Compromised until restored by an act of mercy).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Oath of Mercy and Grace may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or bandage) and whisper a word of unburdening. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Medicine* or *Comfort* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would take Harm while defending a helpless creature, they may reduce that Harm by 1 (to a minimum of 0) as the spiral catches the blow. After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the weight of another's pain briefly rests on them.

Rites of the Oath of Mercy and Grace

Rite of the Shared Bowl (Basic, 4 XP)

Action; Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [HEAL], [BOND], [RESTORATION]

Materials: A clay bowl of clean water, shared with a willing creature.

Effect: You and the creature each clear 1 Fatigue. The creature gains **+1 die** on their next roll to resist fear or despair.

Push It: Extend the benefit to all creatures who drink from the bowl (up to six). Mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Healing Waters (Basic, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [HEAL], [PURIFY], [RESTORATION]

Materials: Water from a blessed source (a spring, a well, or a river where the Oath has been invoked), poured onto a wound.

Effect: Remove 1 Harm from a touched creature. If the wound is cursed or poisoned, the GM may call for a Spirit+Lore test (DV 4).

Push It: Also remove one Condition (e.g., Poisoned, Cursed, Blinded). Mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Vow of Pacifism (Basic, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [VOW], [PROTECT], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: A white cord tied around the weapon hand.

Effect: You swear not to kill for the scene. In exchange, you gain **+1 Armor** and **+1 die to all resist rolls**. If a creature harms you while this vow is active, they immediately gain a **Promise Timer [4]** named "Mercy's Reckoning." When that timer fills (by them continuing violence), they suffer Harm 1 (Stress) as their own aggression turns inward.

Push It: Extend the protective effect to one ally within Near. Mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unburdened Circle (Advanced, 8 XP)*Scene; Zone; Standard Push***Tags:** [DEBT], [BOND], [RESTORATION], [AREA]**Materials:** At least three willing participants, a circle drawn in ash or flour, a single candle.**Effect:** Each participant clears 1 Obligation (to any patron or debt). One participant of the GM's choice gains a permanent String: *Witnessed by the Circle* – they may call on any other participant for one act of care, once per campaign.**Push It:** The GM gains 3 Story Beats (the universe notes that a community of mutual aid is forming). Mark +1 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Sheltered Hearth (Advanced, 9 XP)***Scene; Zone; Standard Push***Tags:** [WARD], [PROTECT], [DEBT], [AREA], [FEAR]**Materials:** A door or threshold, a lit candle, a whispered vow of sanctuary.**Effect:** For one night, any fugitive, debtor, or refugee who crosses that threshold cannot be pursued or harmed within the zone. The sanctuary holds until dawn. Any creature that violates this sanctuary (by attacking or forcibly entering) gains a **Promise Timer [6]** named “Sanctuary Breach.” When full, they suffer a Curse chosen by the GM (e.g., “doors close in your face,” “your name is forgotten by hosts”).**Push It:** Extend the sanctuary to a full day. Mark +1 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Shield of the Unburdened (Advanced, 8 XP)***Instant; Near; No.***Tags:** [PROTECT], [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [FEAR]**Materials:** A gray cloak or a bandage wrapped around your own arm.**Effect:** When an ally within Near would take Harm, you may interpose yourself and take that Harm instead. After doing so, the attacker must make a **Spirit+Resolve** test (DV 4) or gain a **Promise Timer [4]** named “Debt of Blood.” The timer ticks each time they refuse a genuine plea for mercy or aid. When full, they suffer Fatigue 2 as guilt manifests.**Push It:** You may also redirect a Condition (e.g., Poisoned, Cursed) from the ally to yourself. Mark +1 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Spiral's Witness (Advanced, 10 XP)***Instant; Near; Standard Push***Tags:** [DEBT], [RESTORATION], [FEAR], [TRUTH]**Materials:** A gray wool cord tied around the caster's wrist.**Effect:** Name a person crushed by debt or guilt. For one hour, they ignore all penalties from unpaid obligations (social, legal, or spiritual). They are not free; they are unburdened. If that person then commits an act of violence against an innocent, the unburdening reverses and they suffer double penalties.**Push It:** The effect lasts until the next dawn. Mark +1 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).*

Rite of the Covenant of Shared Suffering (Master, 13 XP)*Scene; Zone; High Push***Tags:** [BOND], [TRANSFER], [HEAL], [AREA], [DEBT]**Materials:** A circle of nine gray stones, a bowl of water, a candle lit at each cardinal point, and a drop of blood from each participant.**Effect:** All within the circle who accept the Oath's blessing are linked. For the scene:

- Damage taken by any linked ally may be split among any other linked allies (each chooses to accept 1 Fatigue or 1 Harm).
- When you heal a linked ally, you may also heal yourself for half the amount (round down).
- The first time a linked ally would be reduced to 0 Harm, you may sacrifice 1 Fatigue to keep them standing.

Push It: The covenant persists for a full day. Mark +2 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 7 segments.**Rite of the Endless Spiral (Master, 14 XP)***Extended; Zone; High Push***Tags:** [HEAL], [RESTORATION], [DEBT], [AREA], [FEAR]**Materials:** A circle of nine gray stones, a bowl of tears, and a candle lit at each cardinal point.**Effect:** All within the circle who accept the Oath's blessing clear 2 Fatigue and remove one Condition caused by despair or guilt. For the rest of the scene, any act of care performed within the zone costs the giver -1 Obligation (minimum 0). Additionally, any creature that harms a caregiver within the zone gains a **Promise Timer [6]** named "Spiral's Debt." When full, they suffer Harm 2 (Stress) as the weight of their cruelty crushes them.**Push It:** The blessing persists for a full day. Mark +2 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 8 segments.**The Spiral Strikes Back (Advanced, 8 XP)***Prerequisites:* Oath of Mercy and Grace, Spirit 3+.

You have learned that mercy can be a weapon. When a creature with an active Promise Timer (from any of your Rites) attacks you or an ally under your protection, you may spend 1 Boon to immediately advance that timer by 2 segments. If this fills the timer, the creature suffers the consequence immediately (Harm, Condition, or Curse as described). You may only use this once per scene.

Corruption Perk (Tier 4+): Mercy's Edge

Once per session, when you would reduce a sentient enemy to 0 Harm, you may instead spare their life and bind them with a **Promise Timer [6]** named "Spared." While this timer is active, they cannot knowingly harm you or those you have explicitly named as under your protection. They may work off the timer by performing three acts of genuine

care for others (GM discretion). If they break the bond, the timer fills instantly and they suffer Harm 2 (Stress) – the spiral closes.

Hospitaller Knight of the Gray Spiral

Mercy without steel is a prayer. Steel without mercy is a curse. We carry both – but we sheath the blade before we draw it.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Body 2+, Rite of the Sheltered Hearth or Rite of the Shield of the Unburdened.

Hospitaller Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Gray Ward	When you take the <i>Defend</i> action, you also grant an adjacent ally +1 Armour until your next turn.	Passive	Body 3, Melee 2
Shield of the Unburdened	Once per scene, as a reaction, redirect a melee attack aimed at an adjacent ally to yourself. The attack automatically hits you.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 3
Mercy's Pace	You ignore the first point of Fatigue each scene caused by exhaustion (forced marches, lack of sleep, extreme weather).	Passive	Spirit 3, Tier II
Spiral Counter	When a creature with an active Promise Timer attacks you, you may spend 1 Boon to advance that timer by 1 segment immediately, before the attack resolves.	1 Boon	Tier III
Hospitality Vow	You may use the <i>HEAL</i> cantrip on any ally within Near range, not just touch.	+1 Obligation per use	Spirit 3, HEAL cantrip
Unbroke Cord	When you use a Promise Timer from any of your Oath rites, it can only be advanced by the GM if you fail a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 4). Otherwise, the timer ticks only when you or an ally is harmed.	Passive	Tier III, Spirit 4

Master Technique (Master, 12 XP): *The Spiral's Final Witness.* Once per session, when a creature with an active Promise Timer (from any of your Oath rites) would deal a killing blow to an ally, you may interpose yourself. The blow is redirected to you, and you suffer the Harm instead. After the attack, the Promise Timer fills immediately, and the attacker suffers the consequence (Harm, Condition, or Curse). You cannot use this talent again until you have spent a downtime scene in meditation or prayer.

Cantors & Cults of the Oath of Mercy and Grace

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Oath sings in *harmonies of the unburdened* – melodies that lift without rising, harmonies that wrap around a wound like a clean bandage. Their voice is used to calm the panicked, to ease the pain of the dying, or to sing a debtor gently into the spiral. Mercy's Cantors are often found in hospices, refugee camps, and the halls of the condemned, their songs a reminder that no debt is too heavy to be carried by more than one pair of hands.

The Cult of the Gray Spiral. The Oath's cults are not secret – they are quiet. They gather in hospices, soup kitchens, and the prayer rooms of hospitals. The Gray Spiral is a fellowship of healers, hospice workers, and those who have learned that mercy is a muscle that must be exercised. A ritual of the Spiral involves each member tying a gray wool cord around their wrist (or a patient's wrist) while speaking a single act of care they received from a stranger. The cord is then cut and burned, and the ashes are scattered in a place where the hungry gather. Their creed is embroidered on every gray cloak: *"You do not pay back. You pay forward. The spiral is patient."* Outsiders are welcome to sit in silence, but they must accept a cup of water and speak a truth about a wound they carry.

The Hospitaller Knights of the Gray Spiral. A militant order within the Oath who believe that mercy must be defended. They carry no swords — only shields, staves, and the gray wool cord. They are sworn to protect healers, refugees, and the sick, and they have a fearsome reputation: *"Strike the healer, and the spiral will remember. The debt will be collected, if not by us, then by the weight of your own cruelty."*

Witchcraft of the Oath of Mercy and Grace (Lay / Monastic)

A witch who walks with the Oath is a *lay healer*, a *hospice sister*, or a *gray brother* – a nun, monk, or lay religious who tends the sick, comforts the dying, and offers sanctuary to the hunted. Their magic is not the flashy alchemy of a potion-maker; it is the quiet, patient work of a wound that closes a day early, a fever that breaks at midnight, or a debtor who finds the courage to confess. Their tools are not hammers or chisels; they use gray wool cords, clay bowls, and the small brass bells that ring only when a prayer is answered.

The Witch's Tool: The Cord of the Unbroken Spiral. A gray wool cord braided with nine knots, each knot tied in silence while speaking a name of someone who was healed. Once per session, the witch may touch the cord to a wounded creature (including themselves) and untie a single knot. The creature clears 1 Fatigue and, if they are suffering from a minor Condition (Fear, Shaken, Guilty), may test Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) to remove it. The knot cannot be retied until the next dawn. The cord can also be used to mark a threshold: tying it around a door handle or bedpost grants +1 die to all rolls made to protect the inhabitant for the night.

A Hedge Gift: Benediction of the Spiral (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may lay a hand on a willing creature and whisper a short prayer (or a word of forgiveness). For the next hour, the creature feels lighter – they ignore the first point of Fatigue from exhaustion, and any social roll made to ask for mercy or forgiveness gains +1 die. The blessing ends if the creature commits a violent act against an innocent.

Oath of Mercy and Grace Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Soothing Presence: +1 die to calm or comfort others.	Burden of Care: -1 die when ignoring suffering; must help or mark Fatigue.
2	Quick Bandage: Once/scene, heal 1 Fatigue as a reaction.	Empathic Bleed: You feel the pain of those you heal; 1 Fatigue if you heal a major wound.
3	Sanctuary Sense: +2 dice to detect sanctuary violations.	Threshold Weary: -1 die in places with no sacred boundary.
4	Spiral Witness: Once/session, force an aggressor to test Resolve or be shaken.	Promised Weight: Must keep all promises to the vulnerable; breaking one costs 1 SB (Hearts).
5	Merciful End: Once/session, grant a peaceful death to a willing creature (no roll).	Echo of Loss: Suffer 1 Fatigue when you cannot prevent a death.
6+	Spiral Incarnate: Once/session, become a living knot; all Promise Timers in the scene advance toward fulfillment.	Debt of Mercy: Mark +2 Obligation; risk becoming unable to refuse a plea for help.

Playstyle Notes

The Oath of Mercy and Grace supports both pure healers and **Hospitaller defenders** — characters who wade into battle not to kill, but to shield, to bind, and to turn violence back on itself as obligation. Your “teeth” are not fangs but *leashes*: every enemy who harms you or your charges accrues a debt that will eventually cripple them. This works best in campaigns where the GM tracks Promise Timers and where enemies have names and faces — the spiral is less effective against mindless beasts, but against human foes, it is terrifying.

Emphasizes

- **Restorative Work:** healing body, mind, and spirit
- **Spiral Mercy:** paying obligation forward through acts of care
- **Sanctuary:** sheltering the hunted, feeding the hungry, demanding respect for the threshold
- **Unburdening:** releasing others (and oneself) from the weight of unpaid debts

Rivalries

- **The Inquisitor Prime:** Mercy without judgment is heresy to the Prime. The two orders clash constantly over the fate of prisoners, heretics, and the “unforgivable.”

- **Malachai (Cruel Messenger):** Malachai offers cursed gifts; the Oath offers unburdening. Their followers are natural enemies — one feeds on despair, the other starves it.

Pacifist Monk (Oath of Mercy and Grace)

You do not pay back. You pay forward. The spiral is patient.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Presence 2+, Rite of the Shared Bowl or Cantor of Mercy and Grace.

Debt-Resistant Frame. Mercy is not a loan – it is a gift. Pacifist monks gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt or obligation that would compel them to harm another or break an oath of non-violence. If they succeed, the creditor's demand is gently refused; the universe notes a kindness, and the Hollow's attention briefly wanders.

Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Redirect Blow (Basic)	When an ally within Near would take Harm, you may interpose yourself and take that Harm instead.	1 Fatigue	Body 3
Healing Touch (Basic)	Remove 1 Fatigue or 1 Harm (not Condition) from a touched creature. Once per scene per target.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Vow of Pacifism (Basic)	Swear not to kill for the scene. Gain +1 Armour and +1 die to all resist rolls. If a creature harms you while this vow is active, they gain a Promise Timer [4] named “Mercy’s Reckoning.”	1 Fatigue	Presence 2
Sheltered Hearth (Advanced)	For one night, any fugitive or refugee who crosses a threshold you guard cannot be pursued or harmed within that zone. Sanctuary holds until dawn.	1 Boon	Spirit 2
Spiral Counter (Advanced)	When a creature with an active Promise Timer attacks you, you may spend 1 Boon to advance that timer by 1 segment immediately, before the attack resolves.	1 Boon	Tier II
Unburdened Circle (Advanced)	Each participant clears 1 Obligation (to any patron or debt). One participant of the GM’s choice gains a permanent String: Witnessed by the Circle – they may call on any other participant for one act of care, once per campaign.	1 Fatigue	Tier III

Master Technique (Master, 12 XP): *Spiral Incarnate*. Once per session, become a living knot of mercy for one scene: all Promise Timers in the scene advance toward fulfillment, and any creature that harms an innocent under your protection immediately suffers Harm 2 (Stress). After the scene, you gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (a gray thread tied around your wrist – it never loosens, but it also never tightens). You may ignore one debt or obligation that would force you to abandon a plea for help – the creditor simply finds you already tending to someone else.

6.8.28 Oya — The Wind of the Sahel (Dust, Change, Liberation)

Lore. Oya is the harmattan — the dry wind that sweeps the grasslands, carrying red dust from the Ashaani desert. She is neither cruel nor kind. She is the breath that clears the old, the storm that scatters what has grown stagnant, the wind that opens a locked door by rattling it until the latch gives way. Her followers are iconoclasts, slave-liberators, and those who believe that the only way to defeat a corrupt system is to let it collapse under its own weight — and then scatter the ashes.

In Ashaan, Oya is whispered as the *Dust-Rider*, a faceless figure who appears during sandstorms to cut the chains of the bound. In the Sahel, she is the *Cleansing Wind*, invoked before burning a corrupt contract. In Ngomebe, her name is carved on keystones that have cracked — because Oya taught the stone to break. She does not build. She makes room for those who will.

“Oya does not ask permission. She does not wait for the right season. She blows, and the dead leaves fall, and the dust settles on new ground. That is not destruction. That is preparation.”

Domain Focus

- **Dust and Wind:** the harmattan, sandstorms, the dry breath of the Sahel
- **Change:** destroying the old to make way for the new
- **Liberation:** breaking chains, opening locked doors, scattering what binds
- **Cleansing:** burning corrupt contracts, erasing false ledgers, the red dust that covers old tracks

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Oya binds a creature of dust and dry wind. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological being that embodies the harmattan: a sand-colored gecko that sheds its skin twice as fast as any other, a small horned viper that leaves no tracks in loose sand, a dust-bathed finch that appears only after a windstorm, a scarab beetle that rolls dry dung across the hottest plains, or a pale mouse that nests in abandoned grain silos and vanishes when the wind shifts. This creature requires no food, but it must be allowed to feel the dry wind each day — a sealed room suffocates it. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (its color fades, and its bearer suffers –1 die on all rolls involving escape or evasion until it next tastes a dust storm).

The **Codex** of Oya is never a book kept indoors. It may be a collection of cracked clay tablets that must be read in the wind, a scroll of desert leather that crumbles if not exposed to dry air, a bundle of dried reeds tied with red thread, or a single shard of green glass that holds the memory of a storm. Because the harmattan erases what is written, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week in a dry, windy place, allowing the dust to resettle on the pages, or the Rites stored there become faint (treat as *Compromised* until re-swept).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Oya may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a word of the harmattan. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Stealth* or *Escape* rolls in dry or dusty environments, and the first time each scene the bearer would be restrained (by chains, ropes, or a grapple), they may reroll the escape check (the wind loosens what binds). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as a thin film of red dust settles on their clothes, impossible to fully brush away.

Rites of Oya

Rite of Oya's Breath (Basic, 4 XP)

Scene; Zone; No

Tags: [WIND], [STEALTH], [DECEPTION]

Materials: A pinch of red dust blown from the palm, or a dry leaf that has never been wet.

Effect: For one scene, you may extinguish any non-magical fire in a zone. The extinguishing is silent and leaves no smoke. Additionally, any open flame within Near range gutters and may be snuffed with a gesture.

Push It: The wind carries the extinguishing effect to all fires in Near range. Magical fires are suppressed for one exchange (they flicker but do not go out). Mark **1 SB (Spades)** as the unnatural stillness draws attention.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Dust Mask (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self or Ally; No

Tags: [PROTECT], [WEATHER], [SURVIVAL]

Materials: A strip of cloth that has been dried in the harmattan for nine days.

Effect: You or an ally within Near becomes immune to the effects of sandstorms, dust clouds, and airborne irritants for one scene. Visibility is unaffected for you; you can see through blowing dust as if it were clear air. The cloth wraps itself around your face, cool and dry.

Push It: Extend the effect to all allies within Near. Mark **+2 Obligation** and the cloth becomes permanently stained red; it may be recognized by those who know Oya's sign.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Cleansing Wind (Master, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No

Tags: [WIND], [ERASURE], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: A corrupt contract, a slave collar, or a false ledger; and a handful of red dust from the Ashaani desert.

Effect: Summon a dust storm that lasts one hour within a zone (approximately a city block). All actions within are Desperate due to poor visibility. More importantly, the storm scatters the evidence of one crime, one broken oath, or one corrupt contract — documents crumble, footprints vanish, witnesses forget what they saw. The dust carries

the erased evidence into the wind, where it will never be found.

Push It: The dust storm also reveals one hidden truth — a secret door, a buried body, a false wall — as the wind strips away what was hidden. Mark **+3 Obligation** and the caster gains the *Dust-Marked* condition (a red stain on their hands that cannot be washed off for one month).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Oya

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Oya sings in *dry tones* — melodies that crackle like dust on the tongue, harmonies that feel like a parched throat. Their voice is used to call the harmattan, to make a guard’s eyes sting so they cannot see, or to sing a locked door open by vibrating the latch. Oya’s Cantors are often found in deserts, on the edge of mines, or in the company of those who are about to burn a bridge.

The Cult of the Red Dust. Oya’s cults meet in places where the wind never stops: dry riverbeds, abandoned quarries, the lee side of tall buildings during a sandstorm. The *Red Dust* is a fellowship of iconoclasts, ex-slaves, and those who have destroyed a contract that bound them. A ritual involves each member writing a binding obligation on a piece of parchment, then throwing it into the wind. If the parchment is carried away, the obligation is considered voided — by Oya, not by law. If it falls back to the ground, the debtor must perform a service before the next storm. Their creed is written in dust on a single stone: “*What the wind scatters, no chain can gather.*” Outsiders are welcome if they bring something they wish to see destroyed — a letter, a collar, a memory.

Witchcraft of Oya (Lay / Dust)

A witch who walks with Oya is a *dust-weaver* or *wind-caller* — one who crafts erasure. Their magic works through the tools of dispersal: a small leather pouch of red dust from a slave market, a fan made of dried palm fronds, a whistle that mimics the sound of the harmattan. Their tools are never permanent; a fan is burned after its seventh use, a whistle cracks after the ninth. In the Brass Coast, a Sidhi witch might scatter red dust at a customs post to make the officers forget a smuggler’s face; in Ashaan, a Breath-less agent uses Oya’s rites to erase a name from the Black Hand’s ledger.

The Witch’s Tool: The Dust Pouch. A small leather pouch filled with red dust collected from a place of oppression — a slave market, a debtors’ prison, a burnt courthouse. Once per session, the witch may scatter the dust in a line across a threshold. For the next hour, any who cross that threshold forget why they entered (Resolve DV 4 to resist). The pouch can also be used to “clean” a document: sprinkling dust on a contract erases one clause permanently. The dust is consumed on use.

A Hedge Gift: Scatter the Tracks (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a set of tracks (footprints, wheel ruts, blood trails) and whisper a word of the harmattan. The tracks are erased as if a wind had passed — no mundane tracker can follow them. The Hollow, however, notices the absence; the GM gains 1 SB to spend on a pursuit complication later in the session.

Oya's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Dust-Sense: +1 die to detect secret doors, hidden compartments, or buried objects.	Dry Throat: -1 die to social rolls requiring a smooth voice; you cough when you lie.
2	Scatter the Wind: Once per scene, treat a failed Stealth or Escape roll as a success (you vanish in a puff of dust).	Dust-Marked: Red dust clings to your clothes no matter how you brush it; -1 die to social rolls with authorities who notice.
3	Eraser's Hand: +2 dice to Forgery or Deception when destroying evidence.	Compulsive Erasure: You must erase one written lie you see; if you cannot, mark 1 Fatigue.
4	Dust Storm's Eye: Once per session, see through any dust, fog, or smoke as if it were clear air.	Wind-Blown: -1 die to resist being moved or knocked prone; you are lighter than you seem.
5	Cleansing Wind: Once per session, destroy one non-magical document, lock, or chain by touch.	Oblivion's Scent: Every object you destroy adds 1 tick to a Hollow Attention timer. The Hollow wants to know why you are erasing.
6+	Avatar of the Harmattan: Once per session, become immaterial for one exchange — you are a cloud of red dust. You cannot be harmed, but you cannot attack.	Dust to Dust: Mark +3 Obligation. You begin to forget your own past — memories crumble like dry parchment. Your eyes are the color of dried blood, and your voice sounds like wind over sand. Once per week, you must destroy something of personal value or suffer 2 Fatigue.

Playstyle Notes

Oya rewards those who act decisively, who destroy what is corrupt, and who trust that the wind will scatter the evidence. Followers become masters of erasure, escape, and the art of making things vanish. The corruption progression leads toward a being that is itself becoming dust — forgetful, light, and difficult to hold — but one that can pass through any locked door. Ideal for iconoclasts, ex-slaves, thieves, and anyone who has ever wanted to burn a contract and walk away whistling.

Rivalries & Obligations

Major Rivalries:

- **The Witness (Truth & Revelation):** Oya erases; the Witness records. Their followers are natural enemies — one tries to hide, the other to expose. In Ashaan, a Breath-less cell that follows Oya may be at odds with a cell that follows the Witness.

- **The Inquisitor Prime (Purity & Domination):** The Inquisitor Prime locks chains; Oya breaks them. Inquisitors hunt her followers as anarchists.

Hard Obligation Triggers:

- **7+ Segments:** You must destroy a contract that has kept a community in poverty. The Hollow will witness the destruction; if you fail, the contract will be rewritten with your name on it.
- **10+ Segments:** Oya demands you erase your own name from a public record — a birth certificate, a marriage license, a tax roll. If you refuse, she will scatter something you love instead (an ally's memory, a treasured heirloom). If you accept, you become *Dust to Dust* (see table) and are legally invisible — free, but also forgotten.

Emphasizes

- **Dust and Wind:** the harmattan, sandstorms, the dry breath of the Sahel
- **Liberation:** breaking chains, opening locked doors, scattering what binds
- **Cleansing:** burning corrupt contracts, erasing false ledgers
- **The Hollow's Interest:** erasure attracts the Hollow, which collects forgotten debts

6.8.29 The Pale Shepherd, Guide of Transitions (Passage & Melancholic Wisdom)

Lore. The Pale Shepherd walks the seam between all things – life and death, joy and sorrow, memory and forgetting, the known and the unmarked. Neither wholly kind nor cruel, the Shepherd guides those who must pass through the hardest doors. Cloaked, with shadow-sheep that bear the shed wool of old possibilities, the Shepherd offers safe conduct through liminal space for a price paid in memory, feeling, or fate. Those who walk this road learn the hidden routes between states of being and can lead others through their hardest crossings – but each passage leaves them more attuned to endings than beginnings.

The Shepherd has no will, only a path; no demand, only a presence. It does not seek followers, but those who stand at thresholds – of death, of grief, of irreversible change – may find the Shepherd already there, waiting to accompany them. Its “demands” are not commands but the natural toll of passage: a memory left behind, a name forgotten, a tear shed for no reason. The Shepherd does not punish refusal; it simply withdraws, and the crossing becomes harder.

Among the Aelaerem, the Shepherd is called the *Pale Gardener*, who walks the hedgerows at twilight, collecting the souls of those who die far from home. In Aeler, the *Breath-Accountant* weighs the last exhalation of the dying. In Linn, the *Fog-Walker* appears on the horizon before a storm. In Viterra, the *Silent Notary* witnesses deathbed testaments. Wherever mortals face the hardest thresholds, the Pale Shepherd is there – not to judge, not to command, but to accompany.

“The Shepherd goes where feet fail, speaks where voices thin, and points where paths run dim. Each journey loosens the knot that tied you to the life you left behind.”

Domain Focus

- **Liminal Navigation:** walking and reading thresholds, dusk-roads, and in-betweens
- **Passage Guidance:** steadying hands through grief, change, and transformation
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** understanding born of farewells and last looks
- **Memory Shepherding:** gathering, carrying, and setting down weighted moments

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Pale Shepherd binds a creature of gentle thresholds. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological being that embodies passage and memory: a gray mouse that nests in graveyards and knows every hidden crack, a moth with dusty wings that lands on the hands of the dying, a small lamb with wool the color of ash that appears only at crossroads, a pale fox that leaves no footprints in fresh snow, or a white-breasted raven that calls once when a soul is ready to cross. This creature requires no food, but it must witness a farewell or a threshold crossing each day (a death, a departure, or a significant goodbye). If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows silent, refusing to guide; its bearer suffers –1 die to all rolls involving thresholds or transitions until the creature is shown a proper farewell).

The **Codex** of the Pale Shepherd is never a book of spells alone. It may be a ledger of names written in disappearing ink that reappears only at twilight, a bundle of woolen

cords each tied for a soul guided, a series of river stones stacked in a cairn that shifts with each passing, or a smooth slate etched with the outline of a door that never quite closes. Because the Shepherd's truths are written in passage, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week whispering the names of those they have guided, or the Rites stored there become faint (treat as Compromised until re-dedicated at a threshold).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Pale Shepherd may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a word of crossing. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Insight* or *Medicine* rolls when dealing with the dying, the grieving, or those undergoing great change, and the first time each scene the bearer would suffer a Condition from fear or despair, they may ignore it (the Shepherd steadies their hand). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the weight of the passage lingers.

Rites of the Pale Shepherd

Rite of the Gentle Guide (Basic, 5 XP)

Scene; Near/Self; Yes.

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [BOOST], [THRESHOLD], [RISK]

Materials: A small stone from a grave or threshold, warmed in the palm; or a thread from a worn garment and a pinch of dawn mist.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Gentle Guidance:** Ease a hard crossing. One target gains +1 **die** to rolls involving change, decision, or emotional steadiness this scene.
- **Hidden Path:** Find or make a way where none is seen. Gain +2 **dice** to *Navigation* or *Investigation* when seeking unconventional routes.

Push It: (Hidden Path only) The way runs through a true between-place; gain the route but mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as boundary powers take notice.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Passing Flock (Advanced, 8 XP)

Scene; Touch/Zone; Yes.

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [TRUTH], [HEAL], [AREA], [RISK]

Materials: Black wool and a personal token of the one to be guided; or ash of burned letters and wool shaped into little sheep.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Shadow Passage:** Open a brief passage through shadow-realms. The target bypasses one insurmountable obstacle or reaches a place normally shut.
- **Memory Flock:** Call shadow-sheep that carry fragments of weighty moments. Retrieve lost details, soothe grief, or glean counsel from what was.

Push It: (Passage) The passage leaves a scent-trail; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as something may follow. (Flock) The memories ride too close to the skin – participants relive them as their own; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Unburdened Farewell (Basic, 6 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [HEAL], [CLEANSE], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: A personal letter never sent, burned in a copper dish.

Effect: Speak a final goodbye to someone who is not present – a lost lover, a dead parent, a friend you wronged. Clear 1 Fatigue and remove one psychological Condition (e.g., *Haunted*, *Guilty*) caused by that relationship. The GM gains **1 SB** as the words drift into the threshold.

Push It: The farewell also grants **+1 die** on your next roll related to moving on from that relationship. Mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Threshold Bond (Master, 13 XP)

Extended; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [BOND], [FATE], [DEBT], [THRESHOLD]

Materials: Two keepsakes: one of what is left, one of what is sought.

Effect: Bind two states, places, or conditions with a felt thread. Those bound can sense across the threshold and lend one another strength during change.

Push It: The bond sets like iron – permanent and inescapable. Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Shepherd (Master, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [BOOST], [DEBT], [AREA], [FATE]

Materials: Last words, a much-crossed threshold, and the consent of those who remain.

Effect: Take the mantle of perfect guide for a great passage – death, molt, or life-bend. All present gain **+2 dice** to navigate the crossing; you shoulder the weight of it.

Push It: Guidance is flawless but costly: mark **Harm 2 (Weariness)** and **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Death Doula (Folk-Psychopomp)

The door is never locked. I only hold it open. When you are ready, walk through. I will walk with you.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Lore 2+, Rite of the Gentle Guide or Cantor of the Pale Shepherd.

Death Doula Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Comforting Presence	Once per scene, when you touch a creature suffering from Fear, Guilt, or Grief, you may remove that Condition.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 3
Unseen Door	Once per session, you may declare that a locked or barred door (mundane or magical) is “unlocked” for the purpose of passage – it opens freely for you and your allies for one exchange.	1 Boon	Wits 3
Memory Weaver	When you use the Wool-Winder (Witch’s Tool), you may create one extra memory cord per session.	Passive	Tier II
Gentle Re-solve	Allies within Near range gain +1 die to resist fear or despair.	Passive	Spirit 3
Final Witness	Once per session, when a sentient creature dies within Near range, you may ask the GM one question about that creature’s final thoughts or unfulfilled wishes. The GM must answer truthfully.	Free	Tier III
Threshold Keep	You may sense any active threshold (door, gate, bridge, border) within Far range, and you know its “mood” (welcoming, hostile, sorrowful).	Passive	Spirit 3, Lore 2

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *The Unburdened Crossing.* Once per session, when a willing creature (including yourself) is about to die, you may guide them across the threshold. They experience no fear, no pain, and may speak

a final sentence before they pass. Afterward, you gain a permanent memory of their last words, which may be used as a Truth Compass (+1 die to any roll directly related to fulfilling their final wish). You gain 1 permanent Corruption – the Shepherd’s path is heavy.

Cantors & Cults of the Pale Shepherd

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of the Pale Shepherd sings in *passing tones* – melodies that begin in a major key and end in a minor one, or that fade to silence rather than resolve. Their voice is used to ease a dying person’s passage, to comfort the grieving at a funeral, or to lull a restless spirit back to the threshold. The Shepherd’s Cantors are often found at hospices, battlefields, and the bedsides of the old, singing the softest of farewells.

The Cult of the Gray Flock. The Shepherd’s cults meet in liminal places: cemeteries at dusk, crossroads at midnight, the rooms above funeral parlors. The Gray Flock is a fellowship of death-doulas, grief counselors, and those who have lost so much that they have become experts in loss. A ritual of the Flock involves each member speaking the name of someone they have guided – and then a moment of silence for those they could not save. Their creed is embroidered on a woolen banner that is never washed: “*The door is never locked. We only hold it open.*” Outsiders are welcome to sit quietly, but they must bring a memory to share.

Witchcraft of the Pale Shepherd (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Shepherd is a *shroud-weaver* or *threshold-carver* – one who crafts the tools of safe passage: a woolen shroud that keeps the dead from wandering, a stone carved with a doorway that leads to the next room (or the next life), or a bell that rings only when a soul is ready to cross. Their tools are not hammers; they use spindles, wool, and the gentle pressure of a hand on a doorframe. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “threshold stone” at a hospice’s entrance, but a witch of the Shepherd would instead wind a memory cord around the lintel.

The Witch’s Tool: The Wool-Winder. A wooden spindle carved from a branch that grew over a grave. Once per session, the witch may wind a length of undyed wool around their hand while speaking a name. The wool becomes a *memory cord* – a physical thread that holds one specific memory of the named person. The cord can be given to another to grant them a single vivid memory of the deceased (e.g., “grandmother’s hands knitting”), or it can be burned to release the memory into the threshold, easing grief.

A Hedge Gift: Shepherd’s Stone (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a small, smooth stone – preferably from a grave or a threshold – and place it on a dying person’s chest (or on a doorframe before a difficult journey). The stone glows faintly, and for the next hour, the person feels no fear of the passage ahead. They gain +1 die to any roll involving courage, acceptance, or farewells, and may ignore one point of Fatigue from emotional distress.

The Pale Shepherd's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Boundary Sense: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> thresholds, limens, and turning-moments.	Melancholic Aura: –1 die to bright company and celebrations; your presence gentles joy.
2	Passage Insight: Once/scene, guide another through change (+1 die to their action).	Compulsive Counsel: Urge to advise even when unwelcome.
3	Shadow Comfort: +2 dice to soothe the distressed or those nearing an end.	Near to Death: In lively places, suffer Fatigue 1 from the sting of contrast.
4	Memory Keeper: Once/session, recall a marked moment of your past with perfect clarity.	Burdened Sight: –1 die on hopeful framings; farewells tint your view.
5	Liminal Mastery: Once/session, find a path through any maze, snare, or barred way.	Unmoored: –1 die to acts that demand firm anchoring in the present.
6+	Shepherd's Crown: Once/session, be the sure guide for any great passage.	Soul's Weight: Mark +3 Obligation; risk binding to the between, never wholly in one state.

Playstyle Notes

The Pale Shepherd favors those who steady others at the edge of change. Its gifts open hidden roads, soften endings, and lend courage to cross. Its prices lean toward memory, ease, and the simple warmth of belonging – spent to buy safe passage when it matters most. The Shepherd never demands; it only offers. When a follower accumulates enough Obligation, an intrusion might be a sudden need to guide a dying stranger, a forgotten threshold that now calls to them, or a dream of a road that must be walked before dawn. Refusing the intrusion does not incur wrath – merely the quiet withdrawal of the Shepherd's favor until the follower once again chooses to accompany someone through their hardest door. Ideal for death-doulas, grief counselors, and anyone who understands that the kindest act is sometimes just to walk beside.

Emphasizes

- **Liminal Mastery:** reading and walking the in-between
- **Passage Guidance:** anchoring companions through turns of fate
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** counsel drawn from endings
- **Memory Shepherding:** carrying and setting down what weighs
- **Threshold Navigation:** ways through walls the world insists upon

Crossing Monk (Pale Shepherd)

The door is never locked. I only hold it open.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Wits 2+, Rite of the Gentle Guide or Cantor of Pale Shepherd.

Debt-Resistant Frame. The Shepherd guides, but does not collect. Crossing monks gain +1 die to resist any magical debt or obligation that would prevent them from passing through a threshold (literal or metaphorical). If they succeed, the creditor finds the way barred – but the monk has already walked through.

Techniques:

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Guide's Step (Basic, 5 XP)	On an unarmed hit, you may force the target to move one range band in a direction you choose (even into hazards). The movement does not provoke opportunity attacks.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 3
Gentle Guidance (Basic, 4 XP)	Ease a hard crossing. One target gains +1 die to rolls involving change, decision, or emotional steadiness this scene.	1 Boon	Presence 2
Hidden Path (Basic, 5 XP)	Find or make a way where none is seen. Gain +2 dice to Navigation or Investigation when seeking unconventional routes.	1 Fatigue	Wits 2
Unburden Farewell (Basic, 6 XP)	Speak a final goodbye to someone not present. Clear 1 Fatigue and remove one psychological Condition (Haunted, Guilty) caused by that relationship.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Threshold Bond (Advanced, 9 XP)	Bind two states, places, or conditions with a felt thread. Those bound can sense across the threshold and lend one another strength during change.	1 Fatigue	Tier II

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 13 XP): *The Unburdened Crossing.* Once per session, when a willing creature (including yourself) is about to die, you may guide them across the threshold. They experience no fear, no pain, and may speak a final sentence before they pass. You may also ignore one debt that would otherwise be transferred to you – the Shepherd’s path is heavy, but it does not demand payment in coin. Gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (a pale handprint on your shoulder). Thereafter, once per arc, you may ignore one environmental hazard that would delay or trap you – the path simply opens.

6.8.30 Palinode, Queen of Encores (Performance & Rapture)

Lore. Once a road-cantor who swore to reconcile feuding towns with procession and song, Palinode died between feasts with a chorus unfinished. Yet the refrain refused to end: it braided toasts, hymns, work-chants, and tavern rounds into a living current that still coils through markets and moots. Where a crowd leans forward and a maker holds breath, she arrives.

Signs. A cup that never quite empties; a candle that gutters only when silence reigns; a flawless bar or note that the hand cannot forget.

Cantor's Temptation. Palinode promises relief from solitude: an audience that always leans closer, a song that never dies, a bond that feels like family even if it devours you. Her rites grant the Cantor not only power but belonging — at the cost of their voice becoming more hers than their own.

“When she sang, the rafters bent to hear.”

“Drink deep: the cup returns, but never empty.”

“Encore is not request but command.”

Domain Focus

- **Ecstatic Performance:** music, dance, theater, and the rapture of creation
- **Unfinished Art:** the power of the incomplete, the encore that never ends
- **Audience Binding:** captivating crowds, turning spectators into participants
- **Inspired Craft:** works that transcend their maker's intention

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Palinode does not bind a living familiar. Their **Thiasos** is a *fragment of unfinished art*: a conductor's baton carved from a stage that was never completed, a silver bell that rings only when a performance is truly perfect, or a mask that holds the echo of a standing ovation. This object requires no food, but it must hear live applause or a sung note each day. If neglected for a week, the Thiasos becomes *Compromised* (its bell rings flat, imposing -1 die on all Performance rolls for its bearer).

The **Codex** of Palinode is never a simple book of Rites. It may be a script with the final page torn out, a score where the last bar is unwritten, or a collection of audience flowers pressed between blank leaves. Because Palinode's art is never finished, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week adding a new variation to a known Rite (a different instrument, a changed tempo), or the Rites stored there become stale (treat as *Compromised* until refreshed).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Palinode may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or instrument) and hum an unfinished cadence. For the rest of the scene, the item grants $+1$ die to *Performance* or *Sway* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would fail a Performance or social roll, they may reroll one die. After the scene, the user marks $+1$ **Obligation** as the encore's echo lingers in their mind.

Rites of Palinode

Hymn Against Dread (Basic, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; Resist only.

Tags: [FEAR], [COMMAND], [RADIANT]

Materials: A lit taper or a bell.

Effect: Begin a hymn or chant. Allies in Near gain +2 dice to resist *Fear* this scene. On a 10, they may ignore *Fear* entirely for one round.

Push It: Allies who benefit also clear 1 Fatigue or 1 Complication point; you gain 1 Fatigue at the scene's end.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Single True Note (Basic, 5 XP)

Instant; Self; No.

Tags: [PERFORMANCE], [BOOST], [BURDEN]

Materials: A note held until your voice frays.

Effect: For one scene you cannot produce an imperfect sound: all performance rolls +2 dice. All other rolls -1 die from intrusive perfection.

Push It: Extend to one ally; both mark **Exposure** +1.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Hooked Chorus (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [COMMAND], [READ], [FEAR]

Materials: A melody braided from the listener's secret want.

Effect: **Presence + Command vs. Resolve (DV 3)**. Success: target joins in. Partial: they resist but suffer -1 die to social rolls this scene. Failure: they follow entranced.

Push It: Affects all in Near; start **Compelled Audience** [6].

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Binding Hands (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [BIND], [FOCUS], [BOOST]

Materials: Your hair woven into your instrument or tool.

Effect: Enter ruthless focus: creative rolls +2 dice; ignore first 2 Fatigue from exertion. You are [BIND] to the piece until completion or ruin.

Push It: One ally is also bound; both mark 1 SB (**Diamonds**).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Consecrated Stage (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [BOOST], [SACRIFICE]

Materials: A stage kissed with the blood of sworn singers.

Effect: Hallow a venue. All performances +2 dice, +1 **Effect**. The space is [WARD]ed: any disruption spawns 2 SB. The ward collapses if the performance ends.

Push It: The stage sustains itself but drains life; start **Performance Hunger** [8].

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Crownpiece (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [SACRIFICE], [BOOST]

Materials: Your greatest work and regret, destroyed together.

Effect: Birth a transcendent masterpiece: +2 dice to creative rolls this session; immune to social manipulation. But all lesser works falter (mundane actions not directly related to the masterpiece suffer -1 die).

Push It: The piece wakes and demands; mark Harm 1 (Stress); start **Demanding Creation** [6].

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Palinode

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Palinode sings in *unfinished cadences* — melodies that never quite resolve, leaving the listener yearning for the next note. Their voice is used to keep a crowd enthralled, to make a performance unforgettable, or to bind a troupe together with a shared, unreachable ideal. Palinode's Cantors are often found in touring companies, their songs changing slightly each night — because the perfect version is always just out of reach.

The Cult of the Gasping Chorus. Palinode's cults meet in theaters after closing, in rehearsal rooms, or in the wings during a performance. The innermost circle, the *Gasping Chorus*, has a stranger practice: each member wears a small silver bell sewn into their throat, just under the skin; the bell rings only when they are about to tell a lie, and it tolls once when they speak a truth they have never shared. A ritual involves each member performing a fragment — a verse, a step, a gesture — and then passing the “unfinished” piece to the next person to complete. The cycle never ends, and the chorus breathes as one, gasping when a phrase is left unresolved. Their creed is written in the margins of a script that is constantly being rewritten: “*The art that is never finished is the art that never dies.*” Outsiders are welcome to watch, but they will be handed a prop or a note and expected to join — and those who stay for the entire ritual find that they can no longer whistle a tune they once knew by heart.

Witchcraft of Palinode (Lay / Performance)

A witch who walks with Palinode is an *instrument-smith* or *stage-weaver* — one who crafts the physical vessels of rapture: a violin that plays notes the player has not yet learned, a mask that shows the audience what they most desire to see, or a stage that remembers every performance and adds its echo to the next. Their tools are never hammers; they work with tuning forks, silk cords, and scraps of unfinished sheet music. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve an acoustic keystone, but a hedge-witch of Palinode might tune a theater's resonance by humming a specific interval into its cornerstone until the stone hums back.

The Witch's Tool: The Conductor's Baton of Unfinished Phrases. A slender baton carved from the wood of a stage that was never completed, tipped with a silver

bell that has no clapper. Once per session, the witch may raise the baton as if to begin a performance. For the next scene, any willing ally who follows the baton's rhythm gains +1 die to Performance or Sway rolls, and any audience member who hears the baton's faint, bell-less ring feels a powerful urge to stay until the "final note" — which never comes. The baton can also be used to "cut off" a performance prematurely, forcing an encore (the performer must immediately reroll a failed Performance check, but the reroll is at –1 die).

A Hedge Gift: Encore's Whisper (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may snap their fingers and whisper a single word ("again," "more," "stay"). For the next minute, any willing performer (including the witch) may reroll one failed Performance or Sway roll, as the audience's desire for more bends reality slightly. The reroll is made at –1 die, and the audience will demand an encore at the end — the witch must perform again (or provide a suitable distraction) or mark 1 Fatigue.

Palindrome's Corruption Table

Tier	Gift	Corruption
1	Perfect Pitch: +1 die to Performance.	Restless Ear: Distracted by any flaw; –1 die to non-performance focus.
2	Rapturous Presence: Once/scene, grant allies +1 die to social rolls.	Craves Applause: Suffer 1 Fatigue if ignored or without an audience.
3	Inspired Creation: +2 dice to one artistic act per scene.	Haunted by Drafts: Must obsessively rework; delays other actions.
4	Mesmerizing Performance: Once/session, captivate a crowd (Resolve DV 4 to resist).	Lost in the Moment: –1 die to awareness while performing.
5	Artistic Vision: Foresee the perfect form of a work; +2 dice to create it.	Consumed Spark: Must pursue inspiration immediately, no matter the cost.
6+	Queen of Encores: Once/session, create a legendary performance; all present +3 dice to social rolls.	Eternal Encore: Mark +3 Obligation; the performance demands endless repetition until sated. Voice of Palinode: Permanent condition – your words carry her power. Anyone who hears you speak must test Resolve (DV 3) to interrupt you or ignore a reasonable request. However, you cannot whisper; your quietest voice is still audible at Near range.

"Sing until the rafters lean to listen, dance until the ground forgets its name, perform until the boundary between art and reality dissolves entirely."

Playstyle Notes

Palinode rewards the performer who risks everything for a single, perfect moment. Her followers become masters of ecstatic art, binding audiences and themselves through the power of the unfinished. The corruption progression leads toward a voice that is no longer entirely their own — but one that can command the hearts of all who hear it. Ideal for bards, dancers, actors, and any character who believes that art is worth dying for.

Emphasizes

- **Ecstatic Performance:** music, dance, theater, and the rapture of creation
- **Unfinished Art:** the power of the incomplete, the encore that never ends
- **Audience Binding:** captivating crowds, turning spectators into participants
- **Inspired Craft:** works that transcend their maker's intention
- **The Voice as Vessel:** the performer becomes the performance

6.8.31 Raéyn, Mistress of the Sea (Tides & Change)

Lore. Raéyn is the tempestuous goddess of the sea, the restless tide that carries news between shores and the promise of change between lives. She is mother to all who sail, her voice the wind that fills sails and her moods the storms that test every mariner's resolve. In Kahfagia, she is called the Storm-Queen; in Linn, the Tide-Mother; in the Brass Coast, the Salt-Widow. Her cult is syncretic, blending the fierce protectiveness of a mother goddess with the practical cunning of a harbor-master.

But Raéyn's heart is torn by her greatest tragedy: her son Khemesh, the Kraken of the Depths, who embodies the crushing inevitability of the ocean's dark heart. Where Raéyn brings change and opportunity, Khemesh brings the final, inescapable pressure that grinds all things to nothing. Sailors pray to Raéyn for safe passage and favorable winds, but whisper Khemesh's name when seeking to lay the dead to rest beneath the waves.

Raéyn is passionate, mercurial, and fiercely protective of those who respect her domain. She favors those who read currents, bargain with weather, and carry news between shores. But cross her, and the sea itself becomes your enemy: fair weather turns to fury, and every wave a judgment.

Mark the tide, name your course, and trust the wave-road. But speak ill of Khemesh, and even I may let the deep take you.

Domain Focus

- **Tides and Currents:** change, opportunity, the rhythm of the sea
- **Maritime Trade and Travel:** safe passage, navigation, weather
- **Storm and Calm:** the duality of protection and wrath
- **Motherhood and Loss:** fierce love, grief for Khemesh, the weight of a divided heart

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Raéyn does not bind a familiar of hearth and home. Their **Thiasos** is a small sea-creature or mythological being of the tides: a storm-petrel that appears before gales and can sense pressure drops, a gray seal pup that sings in harmonic tones audible only underwater, a hermit crab whose shell is etched with wave-runes, a small octopus that changes color to reflect the weather, or a sea-horse that can hover in still air for a heartbeat. This creature requires no food in the usual sense, but it must be immersed in salt water (or exposed to sea spray) each day. If kept dry for more than a day, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows listless and its color fades; its bearer loses the benefit of *Sailor's Instinct* until it is returned to the sea).

The **Codex** of Raéyn is never a book of dry paper. It may be a set of tide-charts etched on whalebone, a bundle of knotted cords that record the phases of the moon and the turn of currents, a conch shell whose interior spiral is inscribed with navigational verse, or a driftwood plank carved with wave-runes that only become visible when wet. Because the sea resists being fixed in writing, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week soaking it in salt water or tracing its symbols by the light of a tide pool, or the Rites stored there become faint (treat as *Compromised* until re-consecrated at the shore).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Raéyn may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or piece of gear) and whisper a promise of safe passage. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Navigation* or *Athletics* rolls when aboard a vessel or in water, and the first time each scene the bearer would suffer an environmental penalty from rough seas, wind, or rain, they may ignore it. After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the salt taste lingers on their tongue.

Rites of Raéyn

Rite of the Wave-Tide (Low, 5 XP)

Scene/Instant; Self; No.

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [NAVIGATION], [BOOST], [RISK]

Materials: A knotted length of salt-twine brushed with seawater, or a shell held to the ear while facing the wind.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Tidemark's Blessing:** Treat slick, swaying, or water-slicked footing as stable for this scene. Gain +1 **die** on boarding, balance, or shipboard movement. Create a 4-segment *Tide's Favor* timer to ignore one level of difficult terrain.
- **Whispering Currents:** Learn the safest near-term route across water or coastline, or gain +1 **die** to navigation checks for this scene. If Khemesh's influence is present, suffer -1 **die** from conflicting currents.

Push It: (Tidemark) Extend to one ally in Close for one beat, but generate 1 **SB (Spades)** as the deck shifts. (Currents) Also learn the fastest route, but mark Exposure +1 (leaving a telltale wake).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Changing Tide (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone (water-adjacent); No.

Tags: [TERRAIN], [AREA], [MOVEMENT], [PRESSURE]

Materials: A handful of pebbles cast in a crescent.

Effect: Bias currents and water levels in the zone. Those moving with the tide gain +1 **die**; those moving against suffer -1 **die**. Small craft must test to hold position. Create a 6-segment *Tidal Influence* timer.

Push It: Brief surge or drawdown (one beat): open a ford or swamp a skiff; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Wave-Road Consecration (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Route (sea-to-sea); No.

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [BOOST], [BOND], [FATE]

Materials: Two sea-glass markers dropped overboard at start and end.

Effect: Consecrate a wave-road between two visible points. Allies gain +2 **dice** on

travel, evade, or carry actions at sea. Designated pursuers suffer **−1 die** to intercept. One active wave-road at a time. Create an 8-segment *Blessed Passage* timer.

Push It: Extend the route's favor to an adjacent leg for one beat; mark **+1 Obligation**.
Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Storm-Queen's Hand (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone (sea/shore/sky); No.

Tags: [WEATHER], [AREA], [COMMAND], [FEAR], [BOOST]

Materials: A vial of rainwater gathered at three crossings.

Effect: Shape a storm-band over the zone. Choose two modes at cast; switch one once per scene:

- **Propulsion:** Vessel gains +1 band of movement per beat (or +1 Effect to maneuvers).
- **Concealment:** Veil of rain/spray; ranged targeting impaired; **−1 die** to hostile sighting.
- **Smite:** Once per beat, lash with wave or lightning as [AREA] hazard.

Push It: Add a third mode for one beat, then the GM spends 1 SB on collateral; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Mother's Wrath (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [CURSE], [DEBT], [FEAR], [AREA], [FATE]

Materials: Tears of a betrayed lover mixed with salt from seven seas.

Effect: Curse those who wronged you. The target suffers **−2 dice** to maritime/weather rolls for one session. At sea, they must roll Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) each day or suffer Harm 1 (Weather). Create a 6-segment *Mother's Ire* timer.

Push It: The curse spreads to the target's allies or family; mark **2 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Storm Pilot (Sea-Mage of Kahfagia)

The sea does not hate you. It tests you. Pass, and the waves remember your name.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Wave-Tide or Cantor of Raéyn.

Storm Pilot Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Tide-Reader (Basic, 4 XP)	Once per voyage, you may reroll a failed navigation check at sea.	1 Boon	Wits 3
Storm Glass (Basic, 5 XP)	You can predict the weather for the next hour with perfect accuracy (no roll).	Passive	Spirit 2, Lore 1
Sea Legs (Basic, 4 XP)	You ignore all penalties from rough seas or slippery decks.	Passive	Body 2
Call the Breeze (Standard, 8 XP)	Once per scene, increase your vessel's speed by one band for one exchange.	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Whirlpool Step (Standard, 8 XP)	When on a ship or dock, you may move as if on solid ground even during a storm or while the vessel is heeling.	Passive	Wits 3, Athletics 2
Kraken's Warning (Standard, 9 XP)	Once per session, when a sea creature (or Khemesh's influence) would ambush you, you sense it one round in advance. Your party cannot be surprised.	Free	Tier III, Spirit 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Eye of the Storm*. Once per session, you may calm a supernatural storm or redirect a natural one for one scene. All weather-based penalties are negated for your vessel and allies within Near. After the scene, the storm returns with double intensity — but you and your allies are already gone. Mark +1 Obligation to Raéyn (the sea remembers your favor).

Cantors & Cults of Raéyn

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Raéyn sings in *shanties of the turning tide* — melodies that rise and fall with the rhythm of waves, harmonies that mimic the creak of rigging and the cry of gulls. Their voice is used to calm a restless sea, to call a favorable wind, or to sing a drowned sailor's soul back to shore. Raéyn's Cantors are often found aboard ships, their songs becoming part of the vessel's luck.

The Cult of the Salt-Washed Circle. Raéyn's cults gather on beaches at low tide, in sea-caves, and aboard ships during storms. The Salt-Washed Circle is a fellowship of

sailors, pilots, fisherfolk, and coastal dwellers who honor the sea’s gifts and respect its rages. A ritual of the Circle involves each member pouring a libation of fresh water into the sea (to honor Raéyn’s tears for Khemesh) while speaking a wish for safe passage or a warning of danger ahead. Their creed is carved into driftwood and left on the tide: *"The sea gives, the sea takes. We who love her learn to swim."* Outsiders are welcome to join a libation, but they must bring salt from their home shore.

Witchcraft of Raéyn (Lay / Maritime)

A witch who walks with Raéyn is a *net-mender* or *tide-seer* — one who crafts with the materials of the tide: a hull carved from wood seasoned by sea-salt, a sail woven with a prayer for fair wind, or a net tied with knots that remember every fish they have caught. Their tools are not hammers; they use shells, rope, and the patient turning of a tide-timer. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “tide stone” at a harbor entrance, but a witch of Raéyn would instead tie a salt-twine knot around a piling, so that the current remembers to favor outgoing vessels.

The Witch’s Tool: The Wave-Seer’s Shell. A large conch shell, its inner spiral polished to a mirror sheen, rimmed with brass. Once per session, the witch may hold the shell to their ear and listen to the “tide’s memory.” For the next scene, they gain **+2 dice** to navigation or weather-reading rolls, and may ask the GM one yes/no question about hidden currents, reefs, or approaching storms (the shell whispers the answer in a voice like waves). The shell can also be used to “mark” a threshold: placing it on a ship’s prow or a harbor gate grants +1 die to all rolls made to defend that vessel or harbor until the next dawn.

A Hedge Gift: Salt-Kissed Rope (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tie a simple knot in a rope, cord, or strand of hair while speaking a short prayer to Raéyn. The knot becomes a *tide-knot* — when the witch unties it (as a free action), the nearest body of water (a puddle, a river, the sea) briefly rises or falls by a few inches, as if a small tide has turned. This can unstick a boat, wet a fire, or startle a guard — but never causes direct harm.

Raéyn's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Sailor's Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and maritime survival rolls.	Sea-Sick on Land: -1 die to rolls requiring prolonged time away from water or open spaces.
2	Tide's Favor: Once/scene, treat a failed maritime or weather-related roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Weather Sensitive: Must make a Resolve test (DV 3) to resist acting on every weather change or maritime opportunity.
3	Storm's Child: +2 dice to rolls involving weather manipulation or sea-based combat.	Tempestuous Nature: Suffer 1 Fatigue when denied access to open water or weather changes for extended periods.
4	Mother's Protection: Once/session, call upon Raéyn's favor to protect a vessel or coastal area from harm.	Protective Instinct: -1 die to rolls involving personal safety when others are endangered nearby.
5	Wave-Rider: Once/session, navigate any water-based obstacle or hazard with perfect ease.	Restless Spirit: -1 die to rolls requiring patience or stillness; the call of the sea is constant.
6+	Storm Queen: Once/session, become the living embodiment of the sea's power. For one scene, control weather and tides within Near range.	Mother's Burden: Mark +2 Obligation when using this power; the weight of protecting all who sail becomes overwhelming, causing Harm 1 (Stress) until the storm passes.
		Khemesh's Attention: The Kraken's gaze turns your way; the GM may introduce oceanic complications (rogue waves, crushing pressure) as narrative fallout.

Playstyle Notes

Raéyn is the patron of sailors, navigators, storm-callers, and anyone who lives by the sea's rhythm. Her followers gain power over tides, currents, and weather, but pay with a restless spirit and a fierce protectiveness that can turn to wrath. The rivalry with her son Khemesh is ever-present — Raéyn's gifts bring change and opportunity, but the deep always waits. Ideal for characters who love the sea, embrace change, and understand that the tide that lifts you can also drag you down.

Emphasizes

- **Tides and Change:** power over currents, weather, and the rhythm of the sea
- **Maritime Syncretism:** a goddess of creole Kahfagia, blending mother, warrior, and storm

- **Storm and Calm:** the duality of protection and wrath
- **Motherhood and Loss:** fierce love for sailors, grief for Khemesh
- **Khemesh's Shadow:** the Kraken is always beneath the waves, watching

6.8.32 The Riven Path (Passion and Power)

Lore. The Riven Path does not command. It *offers*. It is the heat in the blood, the fire in the belly, the voice that whispers “*Take what is yours.*” Those who walk this path learn that power is not given — it is *seized*. Chains are not broken by asking nicely. They are shattered by will.

Followers of the Riven Path are conquerors, liberators, and survivors. They serve no master — not even the Path itself. When a tyrant rises, they do not negotiate — they *overthrow*. When a wall stands in their way, they do not climb — they *break*. When a rival challenges them, they do not yield — they *prove*.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, the Riven Path is known by names that frighten children and inspire revolutionaries. In Silkstrand, it is the *Cut Purse’s Blessing*, whispered by thieves who take from those who stole first. In Vhasia, it is the *Gorget-Breaker*, a philosophy of the duelist who refuses to wear armor. In Zakov, it is the *Tide-That-Eats-The-Shore*, a slow, patient consumption that reshapes coastlines. Wherever the oppressed dream of rising, the Riven Path waits.

The chain that binds you is the chain you refuse to break. The hand that holds you down is the hand you have not yet bitten.

Domain Focus

- **Liberation Through Power:** freedom as the right of the strong, justice as the will of the victorious
- **Passion as Fuel:** anger, desire, fear, and love — all are fires to be stoked and aimed
- **Crushing Dominance:** victory through overwhelming force, intimidation, and the willing display of power
- **Self-Determination:** no chains, no masters, no debt that is not paid in blood

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Riven Path does not bind a creature of hearth and home. Their **Thiasos** is a *cracked crystal* — a focus that was once whole, now broken, now *more*. It burns warm when they are angry and grows hot when they are in danger. It requires no food, but they must feed it a drop of their own blood each day (mark 1 Fatigue once per week if neglected). If neglected for a week, it becomes *Dormant* (it goes cold, imposing –1 die on all Intimidation and Command rolls until they feed it).

The **Codex** of the Riven Path is never a book of prayers. It is a *manifesto* — a collection of maxims, battle cries, and personal victories. It cannot be read in the usual way; the follower must *earn* each Rite by proving their worth through combat, theft, or domination. Upkeep requires one act of dominance per week (win a spar, intimidate someone, break something that held you back). If neglected, the Rites become illegible (treat as *Compromised* until you win a meaningful victory).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Riven Path may touch a held weapon or focus. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Melee* and **+1 die** to *Intimidation*. The wielder feels a surge of raw certainty, as if the universe has stepped aside. After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** to the Riven Path.

Rites of the Riven Path**Rite of Feasting on Fear (Low, 4 XP)**

Instant; Self; No.

Tags: [DRAIN], [FEAR]

Materials: A target that is actively frightened or in your power.

Effect: When you cause a creature to become *Frightened* or gain a fear-based Condition, you immediately clear 1 Fatigue. The terror of others sustains you.

Push It: Clear 2 Fatigue instead of 1. Mark 1 SB (Hearts) as the fear becomes palpable to nearby observers.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Crushing Grip (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Near; Yes (resist).

Tags: [FORCE], [STRANGLE]

Materials: A closed hand, reaching toward the target, fingers slowly tightening.

Effect: One target within Near must test *Body + Athletics* vs. your *Spirit + Lore*. On a failure, they take 1 Harm and cannot speak, breathe, or cast spells with verbal components until they break free (test again as an action each round). You must maintain concentration (cannot take other actions) or the effect ends.

Push It: The target also suffers **−1 die** to all actions while gripped. Mark 1 Fatigue.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Cracking Lightning (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Close; Yes (resist).

Tags: [STORM], [STRIKE], [AREA]

Materials: A raised hand, fingers spread, as if holding a sphere of static.

Effect: A cone of arcing lightning lashes from your hand. All targets in Close range must test *Body + Athletics* (DV 4) or take **Harm 2**. Those who succeed take Harm 1 instead.

Push It: The range extends to Near. Mark 1 Obligation (the Path notices your ambition).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Battle Rage (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [PASSION], [BOOST]

Materials: A moment of silent, building fury.

Effect: For the next three exchanges, you gain **+2 dice** to all melee attacks, ignore the first Harm 1 each round, and ignore all Fatigue penalties. However, your Position becomes *Desperate* (re-roll one success) for the duration — you are reckless, not careful. When the rage ends, mark 1 Fatigue.

Push It: The rage lasts for the full scene. Mark 2 Obligation and mark 1 SB (Diamonds) as collateral damage.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Crushing Dark (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes (resist).

Tags: [FORCE], [AREA], [FEAR], [PRESSURE]

Materials: A clenched fist and a whispered promise of pain.

Effect: You raise your hand and clench it into a fist. Invisible pressure descends on all enemies within the zone. Each target must test *Body + Endurance* (DV 4) or suffer **Harm 1** (crushing) and be **knocked prone**. Even on a successful save, the target suffers **1 Fatigue** from the sheer pressure and cannot voluntarily move closer to you until the end of their next turn (they are held at bay). This is not mind control — it is the weight of the Dark Side made manifest.

Push It: The pressure intensifies to a bone-crushing degree. All enemies in the zone who fail their save instead suffer **Harm 2** and are **Stunned** (lose their next action). Those who succeed still suffer **1 Fatigue** and are pushed back one range band. Mark **+2 Obligation** and the GM gains 1 SB (Spades) as the air shimmers with visible pressure and nearby glass cracks.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Riven Fury (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [STRIKE], [BRUTAL]

Materials: A blade or bo staff held in a defensive stance.

Effect: For the rest of the scene, you gain **+1 defense dice**. Once per round, when you are targeted by a melee attack, you may make a counter-attack against the attacker. You reduce the Harm you would have taken from the triggering attack by 1 (minimum 0). The counter-attack gains **+1 die** and deals **+1 Harm** on a hit.

Push It: The counter-attack also ignores the attacker's Armor. Mark 1 Fatigue.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Cantors & Cults of the Riven Path

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Riven Path sings in *war cries* — rhythmic chants that build into ecstatic frenzy, that drive soldiers to charge and cowards to flee. Their voice is used to terrify enemies, to rally allies on the brink of breaking, or simply to announce their presence in a room. A Cantor may learn any Low Rite of the Riven Path as a Song (*Performance + Lore*, resolves next turn). Corruption accumulates when they use their voice for restraint, for mercy, or to calm a situation they could have escalated.

The Cult of the Chain-Breakers. The Riven Path's cults gather in places where chains have been broken — former slave quarters, prisons after a riot, the ruins of a tyrant's palace. The Chain-Breakers are a fellowship of escaped captives, freed debtors, and those who have chosen to owe nothing to anyone. A ritual of the Cult involves each member speaking aloud a chain they still wear — a fear, a debt, a relationship that controls them — and then breaking a physical chain (rope, iron links, a leather cord) in front of witnesses. The broken pieces are thrown into a fire. Their creed is shouted, never whispered: *"I owe nothing. I serve no one. I am my own."* Outsiders are not welcome unless they bring a chain to break. Those who break a chain with sincerity may stay for the feast. Those who hesitate are watched until they leave.

Witchcraft of the Riven Path (Lay / Unmaking)

A witch who walks with the Riven Path is a *chain-shatterer* or *oath-breaker* — one who crafts through the art of destruction. Their magic works through the materials of power seized: a hammer that breaks locks, a key that opens any door once (then crumbles), or a brand that leaves a mark that cannot be healed. In Zakov, a pirate captain might use a *mutineer's compass* that always points to the nearest source of fear, but a witch of the Riven Path would instead carry the fingerbone of a captain they killed, and the bone points to that captain's hidden treasure.

The Witch's Tool: The Chain-Breaker's Hammer. A blacksmith's hammer with a cracked handle, wrapped in leather from a slaver's belt. Once per session, the witch may strike a lock, a chain, or a sealed document with the hammer. The target does not break — it *ceases to be locked*. The mechanism is not damaged; it simply no longer functions as a barrier. The lock remains, but it will not close. The chain remains, but it will not hold. The seal remains, but it will not seal. The effect is permanent. The hammer may be used on magical seals, but the witch must succeed on a *Spirit + Lore* test (DV 4) or the hammer cracks further (treat as *Compromised* until repaired with a drop of blood).

A Hedge Gift: The Unbound Step (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may ignore one physical restraint — ropes, manacles, a grappling hand, a closed door — as if it were not there for a single exchange. They do not break it; they simply *are not bound by it*. The rope still exists. The manacles are still closed. But the witch is standing three feet away. The GM gains 1 SB (the world takes a moment to notice the absence). This gift cannot be used again until the gained SB is spent or the scene ends.

Corruption of the Riven Path

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Predator's Focus: +1 die to Intimidation and Command rolls.	Hunger: -1 die to resist acting on strong emotion (anger, lust, greed, vengeance).
2	Blood Scent: Once/scene, automatically locate the nearest wounded creature within Far range.	Mercy Blind: -1 die to show compassion, restraint, or forgiveness.
3	Unstoppable: +2 dice to resist being grappled, bound, or restrained.	Reckless: -1 die to defensive actions (you favor attack over parry).
4	Fear Eater: Once/scene, when you cause a creature to become Frightened, gain 1 Boon.	Isolation: -1 die to social rolls with anyone you have not intimidated.
5	Crack the Chain: Once/session, automatically break any mundane restraint (rope, manacles, cage, locked door).	Hunted: A rival from your past appears. The GM gains 1 SB per session to spend on their pursuit.
6+	Unbound: Once/session, ignore all penalties from Fatigue and Harm for one scene.	The Rift Claims You: Mark +3 Obligation. You may no longer take any action that requires submission, surrender, or yielding. You cannot be reasoned with — only fought or fled.

Playstyle Notes

The Riven Path is the ideal patron for players who want to play an aggressive, self-determined character — a warlord, a revolutionary, a dark knight, or simply someone who refuses to bow. Its Rites reward aggression, intimidation, and the willingness to take what you want. The cost is isolation — the power that lets you break chains also breaks relationships, trust, and your ability to see others as anything but obstacles or tools. Intrusions often take the form of a rival who has also broken their chains and now wants yours, a debt you cannot pay (because you broke the contract), or a situation where mercy would be easier than violence — forcing you to choose between your principles and your mission. Ideal for sith analogues, warlocks, berserkers, and any character who believes that freedom is the right of the strong and that weakness is a choice.

Emphasizes

- **Liberation Through Power:** freedom as the right of the strong
- **Passion as Fuel:** anger, desire, fear — all are fires to be stoked
- **Crushing Dominance:** victory through overwhelming force
- **Self-Determination:** no chains, no masters, no debt without blood
- **The Breaking Wave:** the joy of watching something that held you crumble

Riven-Fist (The Riven Path)

The chain that binds you is the chain you refuse to break. The hand that holds you down is the hand you have not yet bitten.

Prerequisites: Body 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of Feasting on Fear or Cantor of the Riven Path.

The Unbound Hand (Debt-Resistant Frame, Free). The Riven Path does not forgive debts — it *collects*. Monks of the Riven-Fist gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt, geas, or contract that would compel them to submit or yield. If they succeed, the creditor feels a momentary chill, as if they have offended something hungry — and the GM gains 1 SB (the Path notes a new target).

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Feast on Fear (Basic, 5 XP)	When you cause a creature to become Frightened, clear 1 Fatigue. The terror sustains you.	1 Boon	Spirit 2
Crushing Grip (Basic, 5 XP)	Target within Near tests Body+Athletics vs. Spirit+Lore. On failure, 1 Harm and cannot speak or breathe until they break free.	1 Fatigue	Body 3
Cracking Light-nings (Standard, 9 XP)	Close range cone. All targets test Body+Athletics (DV 4) or take Harm 2. Success = Harm 1.	1 Boon	Spirit 3, Tier II
Battle Rage (Standard, 8 XP)	For 3 exchanges: +2 dice melee, ignore first Harm 1/round, ignore Fatigue penalties, Position Desperate. End: 1 Fatigue.	1 Boon	Body 3, Tier II
Sundering Blade (Standard, 8 XP)	Next melee attack with light blade: +2 dice, ignore 1 Armor, +1 Harm. Crit = permanent Scar.	1 Fatigue + 1 Boon	Tier II

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Unbound.* Once per session, ignore all penalties from Fatigue and Harm for one scene. You feel no pain, no doubt, no

hesitation — only the ecstasy of action. After the scene, you collapse to Harm 1 (if you were higher) and gain a permanent **Riven Scar** (your eyes are slightly wrong — the pupils are vertical slits for one heartbeat when you are angry). You may ignore one Obligation call from the Riven Path — but the Path will remember, and the next call will be louder.

6.8.33 The Sacred Geometry, Architect of Perfect Forms (Harmony & Immutable Law)

Lore. The Sacred Geometry teaches that perfect forms underlie all seeming chaos: the divine ratios that steer the spiral of galaxies, the symmetry that lattices frost, the measures that turn sound into song. Not merely a calculus but the hidden architecture of the world, it makes artists of order from those who serve it. Devotees do not count to chill the heart; they weigh and tune until beauty and structure converge, revealing that disorder is often only unrecognized design waiting to be drawn true.

This philosophy finds its purest expression in the game of **Kon'reh** — the living geometry played on an eight-pointed diamond board, where Apexes, Sanctums, and the Cross teach the dance of form and consequence. Yet the Geometry itself is not the game; the game is a *mirror* of the Geometry. The Ykrul favor Kon'reh as a tool for oath-geometry and battle-field prediction, reading the angles of feuds and the arcs of raids. The Aelinnel, by contrast, use it to navigate thresholds, courtesy, and the hidden patterns of fae bargains — they count steps not to win, but to avoid stepping where the Green Gate listens. To master Kon'reh is to glimpse the Sacred Geometry in motion; to serve the Geometry is to play the game with the world itself, whether by the steppe fire or the hawthorn arch.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, the Sacred Geometry is called the *Architect's Hand*. In Aeler, True-Masons carve its ratios into keystones, believing that a properly proportioned arch can outlast any curse. In Ykrul, its principles are taught as “the grammar of honor” — every Kon'reh move is a lesson in sacrifice and exit. In Thepyrgos, its disciples are geometers who measure the city's staircases to keep the Hollow from noticing a missing step. Wherever a space is built, measured, or bounded, the Sacred Geometry is already present, waiting for someone to read its lines.

“In the drift of atoms, the sweep of planets, and the curve of a lover's smile, the same ratios ring. Learn them, and you may conduct the world's quiet music.”

Domain Focus

- **Perfect Proportion:** building and reading ideal ratios and harmonious relationships
- **Pattern Recognition:** discerning the structures that govern complex phenomena
- **Harmonic Resonance:** working with natural frequencies and number-made consonance
- **Form Architecture:** imposing clear structure on tangled situations
- **Kon'reh Discipline:** the game as meditation, ritual, and tactical mirror

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Sacred Geometry does not bind a familiar of flesh and blood. Their **Thiasos** is a living embodiment of perfect form: a small brass beetle whose wing-cases are etched with golden-ratio spirals, a mechanical hummingbird that hovers in mathematically precise arcs, a chameleon whose skin shifts in symmetrical patterns, a

compass spider (a tiny arachnid that builds webs in perfect hexagons), or a sentient set of Kon'reh pieces that clack together to spell out advice. This creature requires no food, but it must be allowed to trace geometric figures (real or imagined) each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (its patterns grow erratic, imposing -1 die on all *Lore* and *Investigation* rolls involving measurement or analysis until it is recalibrated).

The **Codex** of the Sacred Geometry is never a normal book. It may be a set of brass stencils of Platonic solids, a roll of vellum covered in interlaced tessellations, a slate tablet on which proofs can be drawn and erased, the inside of a Kon'reh board, or a set of crystal lenses that project perfect geometric shapes when held to the light. Because the Geometry's truths are relationships, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week redrawing or re-proving at least one theorem, or the Rites stored there become tangled (treat as *Compromised* until re-proved).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Sacred Geometry may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or tool) and inscribe a mental proportion upon it. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Craft* or *Investigation* rolls involving structures, patterns, or measurements, and the first time each scene the bearer would be disoriented (by fog, maze, or supernatural confusion), they may ignore it — the Geometry holds true. After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the demand for perfection weighs on their thoughts.

Rites of the Sacred Geometry

Rite of the Harmonic Alignment (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [BALANCE], [FOCUS], [BOOST]

Materials: A tool calibrated to pristine ratios (e.g., golden ratio gauge, well-cut compass arc, a Kon'reh piece set to true measure).

Effect: Align to natural harmonics. Gain **+1 die** to actions involving balance, proportion, cadence, or keeping true time.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Perfect Structure (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [REPAIR], [PRESSURE]

Materials: A consecrated compass and straightedge, inked to tolerance.

Effect: Impose right form on a chaotic or damaged structure (scaffold, plan, treaty, formation). Treat one structural obstacle as one step easier; gain **+1 die** to build/repair/spatial-reason rolls.

Push It: Perfection hardens: for the scene the structure gains unnatural resilience, but order draws opposition; mark **1 SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Resonant Field (Standard, 8 XP)*Scene; Zone; Yes.***Tags:** [AREA], [TEAMWORK], [HARMONY]**Materials:** A floor or air traced with precise tessellations and nodes (or a Kon'reh board laid out as a focus).**Effect:** Establish a harmonic field. Allies gain **+1 die** to precise, coordinated, or team actions; disruptive acts suffer **−1 die**.**Push It:** The field self-sustains and begins to spread beyond intent; mark **+1 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.**Rite of the Pattern's Heart (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Self; Yes.***Tags:** [TRUTH], [OMEN]**Materials:** A solved proof, a perfectly symmetrical token, or a completed Kon'reh puzzle.**Effect:** Perceive the governing pattern of a complex situation (supply chain, intrigue, weather, battle). Gain **+2 dice** to prediction/strategy/systemic-understanding and ask two questions about how the pattern drives the present.**Push It:** Clarity cuts: gain the insight, but for this scene suffer **−1 die** to intuitive or purely emotional responses; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.**Rite of the Immutable Design (High, 13 XP)***Extended; Zone; Yes.***Tags:** [TERRAIN], [PRESSURE], [FATE], [AREA]**Materials:** A space gridded for measure and set with true ratios (like a Kon'reh court).**Effect:** For the scene, rewrite local behavior by perfect principle. Choose one: gravity follows geometric progression; time flows by harmonic ratios; space conforms to exact symmetry.**Push It:** Make the design persist, but elsewhere thins and wobbles: mark **+2 Obligation** and begin **Harmonic Dissonance [4]**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Obligation: 7 segments.***Rite of the Architect's Vision (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Self; Yes.***Tags:** [OMEN], [BOOST], [BURDEN], [TRUTH]**Materials:** A ledger of forms and their tuned relations (or a record of Kon'reh victories).**Effect:** For one session, treat all rolls of pattern recognition, structural analysis, or harmonic application as one step better (Position or Effect, GM's choice).**Push It:** Sight devours softness: gain the power, but lose ease with imperfection's beauty; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Sacred Geometry

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Sacred Geometry sings in *canons of proportion* — melodies that follow strict mathematical progressions, harmonies that lock into resonant frequencies. Their voice is used to measure a room's acoustic perfection, to chart a course through a labyrinth by singing the ratios of its walls, or to lull a chaos-spirit into stillness by singing the geometry of order. The Geometry's Cantors are often found in surveyor's tents, courtrooms, and the halls of mathematicians, humming the laws of form.

The Cult of the Unbroken Compass. The Geometry's cults gather in places where measure is sacred: ateliers, observatories, courtrooms of appeal, and the quiet rooms where Kon'reh is played. The Unbroken Compass is a fellowship of architects, cartographers, logicians, and Kon'reh masters who believe that the universe is a puzzle that can be solved, and that solving it is the highest form of worship. A ritual of the Cult involves each member laying out a perfect geometric figure (a circle, a square, a golden spiral) and then finding the flaw in another's figure. The one with the fewest flaws leads the next session. Their creed is inscribed on a brass protractor that is never used for mundane measurement: *"Form follows number. Number follows truth. Truth follows no one."* Outsiders are welcome to bring a proof or a problem. If they cannot, they may learn by watching.

Among the Ykrul, the same cult takes a different flavor: Kon'reh boards are cut from hide, and the "pieces" are oath-tokens. A Ykrul geomancer reads the angles of a feud as if they were lines of play, and a victory in Kon'reh can settle a blood-debt without steel. Among the Aelinnel, the cult is quieter, more courteous: they use Kon'reh to map the thresholds between fae and mortal, and a solved puzzle can open a hedge-gate that would otherwise remain sealed.

Witchcraft of the Sacred Geometry (Lay / Measure)

A witch who walks with the Sacred Geometry is a *compass-scribe* or *grid-weaver* — one who crafts the tools of perfect form: a square that never warps, a level that finds true horizontal even on a ship at sea, or a set of Kon'reh pieces carved from the same block of stone so that they resonate together. Their magic works through the materials of measurement: a protractor that reveals hidden angles, a string that stretches to an exact ratio, or a lens that shows the underlying grid of a forest floor. They do not use hammers; they use scribes, rules, and the patient turning of a brass dial.

The Witch's Tool: The Protractor of Unseen Measures. A brass semicircle etched with glyphs of ratio and proportion, its hinge oiled with a drop of mercury. Once per session, the witch may place the protractor against any surface (a doorframe, a contract, a creature's brow) and read the "true angle" of its nature. For the next scene, the witch gains +2 dice to any roll that exploits a hidden weakness, structural flaw, or imbalance revealed by the measurement. The protractor can also be used to "true" a distorted measurement: touching it to a warped scale or a crooked ruler resets it to perfect accuracy for one use.

A Hedge Gift: Compass of True Bearing (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a circle with a compass (a real one, or just their finger) around a small area (a room, a crossroads). Those within the circle gain a perfect sense of direction

and distance for the next hour; they are immune to mundane spatial confusion (mazes, fog, unfamiliar streets). However, the compass point leaves a faint, glowing mark on the ground that can be seen by anyone with supernatural senses.

The Sacred Geometry's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Harmonic Sense: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> when patterns, ratios, or symmetries matter.	Pattern Obsession: Must measure or set-right pleasing patterns you spot; resisting costs time or 1 SB (Diamonds) .
2	Perfect Precision: Once/scene, achieve faultless calculation or measure.	Social Dissonance: –1 die to emotive social rolls; harmony feels truer than feeling.
3	Structural Insight: +2 dice to architecture/engineering or imposing order on chaos.	Order Compulsion: Must correct deliberate disorder; suffer Fatigue 1 when forced to abide it.
4	Universal Harmony: Once/session, apply a harmonic rule that makes a chaotic situation predictable.	Perfectionist Limitation: –1 die to improvisation; the “correct” solution calls.
5	Divine Proportion: Once/session, see perfect ratios in any phenomenon and work with them.	Mathematical Focus: –1 die to acts not readily quantified; the abstract blurs unless counted.
6+	Architect of Reality: Once/session, briefly refit local reality by perfect principle.	Form Prison: Mark +3 Obligation; risk failing in rough, noisy worlds, taking Harm 1 in chaotic zones. You cannot willingly enter a space that is not geometrically “pure” (e.g., a cave, a tent, a ruin) without first performing a measuring rite (1 minute, no roll).

Playstyle Notes

The Sacred Geometry suits makers and marshals who tune chaos into form. Its rites prize clean plans, crisp teamwork, and seeing the load paths hidden in trouble. The cost is rigidity: the more you perfect, the harder rough edges are to bear. For Ykrul players, the Geometry is a tool of honor and battle-field geometry; for Aelinnel players, a tool of courtesy and threshold-walking. Both are valid, and both lead to the same cold, beautiful truth.

Emphasizes

- **Harmonic Beauty:** power born of right relation
- **Pattern Mastery:** reading the frame beneath events

- **Structural Perfection:** setting things true under strain
- **Resonant Practice:** working with the world's natural measures
- **Architect's Sight:** finding where form should be imposed
- **Kon'reh Discipline:** the game as living geometry, teaching patience, sacrifice, and the dance of Apex and Sanctum

Measure-Fist (Sacred Geometry)

Form follows number. Number follows truth.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of Harmonic Alignment or Cantor of Sacred Geometry.

Debt-Resistant Frame. Perfect ratios cannot be bound by imperfect contracts. Measure-Fist monks gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt or obligation that relies on asymmetry or flawed logic — they find the imbalance and step through it. The creditor's arithmetic briefly stutters.

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Golden Ratio Strike (Basic, 5 XP)	Your first unarmed strike each scene gains +1 Effect. Your second gains +1 die. Your third triggers Perfect Alignment (+2 dice, ignore 1 Armor). Sequence resets on a miss.	Free	Wits 3
Harmoni Alignment (Basic, 4 XP)	+1 die to actions involving balance, proportion, cadence, or keeping true time.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 2
Perfect Structure (Standard, 7 XP)	Impose right form on a chaotic or damaged structure. Treat one structural obstacle as one step easier; gain +1 die to build/repair/spatial-reason rolls.	1 Boon	Craft 2
Pattern's Heart (Standard, 8 XP)	Perceive the governing pattern of a complex situation. Gain +2 dice to prediction/strategy and ask two questions about how the pattern drives the present.	1 Fatigue	Wits 3
Resonant Field (Standard, 8 XP)	Establish a harmonic field in a zone. Allies gain +1 die to precise, coordinated, or team actions; disruptive acts suffer -1 die.	1 Boon	Tier II

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Architect of Reality*. Once per session, briefly refit local reality by perfect principle. You may ignore one environmental penalty entirely, or reroute a debt obligation as if the numbers had always been different (the creditor's ledger shows a different debtor). Gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your eyes are mildly faceted, like cut gems). Thereafter, once per arc, you may treat a failure on a skill roll involving measurement, prediction, or analysis as a success — but you must correct the balance by performing a pure, selfless act of symmetry (e.g., returning a stolen item, repairing a broken wall).

6.8.34 The Savage Heart (Red Maw)

Lore. The Savage Heart is the truth behind the green veil: nature not as garden, but as gullet. It is the claw that tears, the fang that crushes, the hunger that stalks without malice and kills without mercy. Its followers are the druids you do not meet by firelight — those who have learned that the forest feeds on its own, that the strong devour the weak, and that the only law is the one written in blood on snow.

Across the known world, the Savage Heart wears the face of the apex predator. In the Amaranthine core, it is the *Great Bear*, patient and unstoppable, a wall of fur and fury. Among the Ykrul and Kuvani, it is the *Wolf of the Steppe*, a pack hunter with tireless stamina. In Oshiira, it is the *Golden Lion*, whose roar shatters the hunt's silence. In Sekogo, it is the *Leopard of the Tall Grass*, a shadow that strikes once and is gone. In Dhahara, it is the *Tiger of the Mangroves*, whose amber gaze promises a death that runs faster than you can flee. Wherever prey fears the dark, the Savage Heart is already there, waiting.

“The deer does not weep for the wolf. The sapling does not beg the axe. In the red maw, there is no cruelty — only truth. The truth that all flesh feeds the earth, and the earth feeds the strong.”

Domain Focus

- **Apex Predation:** hunting, stalking, dominating the food chain
- **Red Tooth:** killing as nature's sacrament, strength proven through violence
- **Scavenger's Wisdom:** using death for growth, nothing wasted
- **Territory and Pack:** dominance over a domain, leadership of the hunt

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Savage Heart does not bind a familiar of hearth and home. Their **Thiasos** is a small predator or hunting companion: a wolf pup with eyes the color of amber, a lynx kitten whose fur prickles at danger, a hawk with one white feather that never misses its mark, a viper that coils around the wrist and tastes the air for fear, or a shadow-fox that follows silently and leaves no tracks. This creature requires no food in the usual sense, but it must hunt and kill its own prey each week (a rat, a rabbit, or larger, depending on the keeper's means). If neglected, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows listless, and its keeper loses the benefit of *Stalker's Instinct* until the creature is fed with a fresh kill).

The **Codex** of the Savage Heart is never a book of paper and ink. It may be a belt of predator teeth, each tooth carved with a hunting verse; a bundle of cured hides painted with the kill-records of the keeper's lineage; a set of bone tally sticks, notched for every successful hunt; or the skull of a great beast, its jaw etched with runes that can only be read by the light of a fresh kill. Because the hunt resists being fixed in writing, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week oiling the leather, sharpening the teeth, or adding a new notch for a recent kill; otherwise the Rites stored there fade (treat as *Compromised* until the keeper makes an offering of fresh blood).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Savage Heart may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or piece of armor) and whisper a hunter's promise. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Athletics* or *Stealth* rolls when in natural terrain, and the first time each scene the bearer would be knocked prone, they may ignore it (the hunter's stance is sure). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the scent of the hunt clings to them.

Rites of the Savage Heart**Rite of the Predator's Gaze (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [MARK], [FEAR], [TRACK]

Materials: A tooth from a predator that killed its own prey.

Effect: Mark a single target as your prey. Gain **+1 die** on all rolls to track, pursue, or intimidate that target. The effect lasts until the target escapes or is killed.

Push It: The prey feels your gaze; they suffer **-1 die** to resist social pressure from you. Mark **1 SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Blood Scent (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [SENSE], [FEAR], [TRACK]

Materials: A fresh kill's blood smeared on your face.

Effect: You scent the air like a beast. Gain **+2 dice** to *Investigation* or *Survival* when tracking by smell. You may also detect fear — you sense if a creature within Near is Frightened.

Push It: Your sense expands to Far, but you are overwhelmed by the smell of blood; mark **1 SB (Hearts)** and suffer **-1 die** to social rolls until the end of the scene.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Shifting Shape (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [BOOST]

Materials: A pelt or mask from the beast whose form you take.

Effect: Assume the form of a predator for the scene. Choose one:

Bear (Tank Form)

- **Passive:** +1 Armor, +2 dice to Body rolls.
- **Guardian's Pounce:** Once per scene, when you protect an ally, you may also knock the attacker prone (Body+Resolve DV 3 or fall).
- **Limitation:** Movement reduced by one band (cannot Dash).

Feline or Canine (Striker Form)

- **Passive:** +2 dice to Agility and Stealth, +1 band to movement (can Dash as a free action once per scene).

- **Ambush Predator:** When attacking from stealth, gain +1 Effect and ignore 1 point of the target's Armor.
- **Limitation:** -1 Armor (or +1 Harm taken).

Cultural variations: Bear/Wolf (north), Lion/Leopard (Oshiira), Tiger/Panther (Dahara). You may speak but cannot use tools or cast other Rites while transformed.

Push It: Shift as a free action once this scene, but mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the beast presses against your mind.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Pack Hunt (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [TEAMWORK], [TRANSFORM], [BOOST]

Materials: A token from each member of your pack (a claw, a feather, a scrap of hide).

Effect: You and up to three allies form a hunting pack. While within Near of each other, all gain +1 die to attacks against a single designated prey, and the first ally to attack each round gains +1 Effect.

Push It: Coordination extends to Far, but hunters become territorial; mark **1 SB (Spades)** as rivalries flare.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Carrion Feast (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [CONSUME], [HEAL], [BOOST]

Materials: The flesh of a fallen enemy, consumed raw.

Effect: Devour the strength of the fallen. Heal **1 Fatigue** immediately, and gain +1 die to your next physical action. If the enemy was supernatural (spirit, demon, fey), you also gain a minor property of theirs for one scene.

Push It: Heal 1 Harm instead of Fatigue, but mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as the feast attracts scavengers.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Final Hunt (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Near; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [FEAR], [SPEED], [DEATH]

Materials: The heart of a predator you have killed in single combat, still warm.

Effect: You become the ultimate hunter for one scene:

- Ignore all difficult terrain.
- Gain +3 dice to tracking and combat rolls against your designated prey.
- If you reduce a prey to 0 Harm, make a free attack against another target within Near.

Push It: The hunt consumes you — you cannot end the rite until all designated prey are dead or fled, and you suffer Harm 1 (Weariness) when the scene ends. Mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Savage Heart

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Savage Heart sings in *hunting calls* — short, sharp cries that mimic the bark of a bear or the cough of a leopard. Their voice is used to coordinate a pack, to scare prey from hiding, or to summon a predator from the deep woods. They are rarely heard near villages; their songs echo in the places between game trails.

The Cult of the Painted Maw. The Savage Heart's cults do not meet in groves — they gather at kills, wearing masks of bone and hide that show the animal they have sworn to become. The most ancient sect, the *Painted Maw*, ritually scarifies each member's chest with the claw marks of their totem beast; the scars are filled with ash and charcoal, and the wounds are licked clean by the pack's eldest hunter. A ritual involves each member speaking the name of a kill they made alone, then adding a tooth from that kill to a communal jawbone that hangs from a tree. Their creed is spoken with full mouths: "*The forest is a stomach. We are its teeth.*" Outsiders are not welcome; they are either prey or future members. Those who join must prove themselves by returning with the heart of a predator they have killed with no weapon but their own hands.

Witchcraft of the Savage Heart (Lay / Hunter)

A witch who walks with the Savage Heart is a *skin-stitcher* or *tooth-carver* — but their tools are never forge-hammers. They work with bone, claw, fur, and sinew, crafting masks that hold the spirit of a hunted beast, or drums of leopard skin that call the hunt. Their magic is the patience of the stalker and the savagery of the kill. In Dhahara, a tiger-witch might sew a cloak from the hide of a man-eater, wearing it to walk unseen through the mangroves. In the Ykrul steppe, a wolf-witch might carve a whistle from a wolf's femur that, when blown, answers only with the howl of the pack.

The Witch's Tool: The Hunter's Mask. A mask carved from the skull of a predator, lined with fur and painted with the blood of the wearer's first kill. Once per session, when you don the mask, you gain the senses of that predator for the scene: **+2 dice** to tracking by scent or sound, and you may ask the GM one yes/no question about a creature's fear or weakness. The mask also allows you to speak with animals of that species (they will answer simple questions, but they are never safe to trust).

A Hedge Gift: Hunter's Snuff (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may blow a pinch of powdered bone into the air. For the next minute, the witch can smell the fear of any creature within Near range — they know if a target is Frightened, and gain **+1 die** to track it.

The Savage Heart's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Stalker's Instinct: +1 die to tracking and stealth in wilderness.	Blood Hunger: Must kill or consume fresh meat each day or suffer 1 Fatigue.
2	Apex Demeanor: +1 die to Intimidation against those weaker than you.	Pack Guilt: -1 die to social rolls in civilized company; you smell faintly of carrion.
3	Scavenger's Resilience: +2 dice to resist disease and poison from raw meat.	Compulsive Dominance: Must assert physical dominance when challenged; -1 die to de-escalation.
4	Wound Licker: Once/session, heal 1 Fatigue by licking a fresh wound (your own or ally's).	Beastly Tells: Your teeth sharpen, your eyes reflect light; -1 die to disguise.
5	Alpha's Roar: Once/session, make a terrifying sound that forces all nearby prey to test Resolve (DV 4) or flee.	Lone Wolf: -2 dice to cooperate with those who have not proven themselves in battle.
6+	Maw Incarnate: Once/session, become a true predator. For one scene, all attacks ignore 1 Armor and you heal 1 Fatigue on each kill.	The Red Eats All: Mark +3 Obligation; risk becoming feral, unable to speak or reason until you have fed again.

Playstyle Notes

The Savage Heart rewards those who hunt, kill, and dominate. Its followers are not gentle guardians of nature — they are its teeth and claws. Power comes from taking, from proving strength, from the raw act of predation. The cost is the slow loss of the civilized self, the creeping realization that you are becoming the thing you stalk. The Bear form excels at absorbing damage and protecting allies; the Feline or Canine form excels at striking from stealth and mobility. Neither is strictly better than a dedicated specialist — a true tank has more armor, a true striker deals more burst damage — but the Savage Heart's gift is *versatility within the hunt*.

Emphasizes

- **Predation as Sacrament:** killing is holy when done with purpose
- **Territory and Dominance:** claim, defend, expand
- **Pack Tactics:** hunting is a team sport
- **Red Tooth Wisdom:** death feeds life, cruelty is not malice but nature
- **Transformation:** becoming the beast to master the beast

Rivalries

- **Grimmir (Seasonal Wisdom):** Grimmir preserves the balance; the Savage Heart devours it. They are two faces of the same coin — but the coin is always flipped.
- **The Sealed Gate (Containment):** The Gate wards things out; the Savage Heart tears down walls.
- **The Sacred Geometry (Harmony):** Order and perfect form are prey to the red maw.

Obligation Triggers

- **8+ Segments:** The Savage Heart demands you take a worthy trophy — hunt a creature of equal or greater strength than yourself, alone.
- **10+ Segments:** You hear the call of the hunt always. Refusing to answer when prey is weak will cost you the use of your Rites until you kill again.

Signs of Favor

Your eyes reflect light in darkness, your shadow seems to move independently, smaller animals flee your presence, and the scent of blood often follows you (real or imagined).

Beast-Form (Savage Heart)

The forest is a stomach. We are its teeth.

Prerequisites: Body 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Predator's Gaze or Cantor of Savage Heart.

Debt-Resistant Frame. The Maw does not lend — it devours. Monks of the Savage Heart gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt or obligation that would compel them to act against their predatory nature. If they succeed, the creditor's paperwork briefly smells of fresh blood.

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Predator's Stance (Basic, 5 XP)	Choose Bear (Tank: +1 Armor, +2 dice Body) or Feline (Striker: +2 dice Agility/Stealth, +1 band movement). Lasts one scene.	1 Fatigue	Body 3
Blood Scent (Basic, 5 XP)	Gain +2 dice to track by smell. Detect fear — sense if a creature within Near is Frightened.	1 Boon	Spirit 2
Scavenger's Re-silience (Basic, 4 XP)	+2 dice to resist poison or disease from raw meat.	Passive	Body 3
Pack Hunter (Standard, 7 XP)	You and up to three allies form a hunting pack. While within Near of each other, all gain +1 die to attacks against a single designated prey, and the first ally to attack each round gains +1 Effect.	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Carrion Feast (Standard, 9 XP)	Consume the flesh of a fallen enemy. Heal 1 Fatigue immediately, and gain +1 die on your next physical action. If the enemy was supernatural, gain a minor property of theirs for one scene.	1 Boon	Tier II
Alpha's Roar (Standard, 8 XP)	Once per session, make a terrifying sound that forces all nearby prey to test Resolve (DV 4) or flee.	Free	Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Maw Incarnate*. Once per session, become a true predator for one scene: all attacks ignore 1 Armor and you heal 1 Fatigue on each kill. After the scene, you take Harm 2 (Stress) and gain a permanent **Debt Scar** — a scar in the shape of a fang mark. You may ignore one debt or obligation that would force you to act against your pack (the creditor hears only growling).

6.8.35 The Sealed Gate (Thresholds & Containment)

Lore. The Sealed Gate stands where realities meet, embodying the sacred power of thresholds, boundaries, and containment. Its followers are wardens, exorcists, and philosophers of separation who believe some things must be kept apart for the world to function. The Gate manifests as an impassive judge whose shifting sigils — binding runes, exclusion marks, or acceptance glyphs — determine what may cross.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, the Sealed Gate is known as the patron of abjurists, exorcists, and sentinels. In Aeler, the Gate is called the *Stone Seal*, invoked by True-Masons who carve permanent wards into mountain passes. In Thepyrgos, the Gate is the *Unbreakable Lock*, whose sigils are painted on every archive door that holds forbidden texts. In the Mistlands, the Gate is the *Bell-Line Keeper*, the force that makes the bellwards hold against the Direwood. Wherever something must be kept in or kept out, the Sealed Gate's servants are there — silent, patient, and absolute.

“You define what passes and what remains. Every boundary remembers your judgment.”

Domain Focus

- **Thresholds:** Doors, portals, borders between realms
- **Containment:** Wards, bindings, imprisonment of dangerous forces
- **Exclusion:** Banishment, quarantine, protection through separation
- **Permission:** Safe passage, authorized access, controlled crossing

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Sealed Gate does not bind a living familiar. Their **Thiasos** is a *threshold given will*: a bronze key that fits no lock yet trembles when a boundary is near, a brass bell that rings only when a ward is about to break, or a small iron gate that stands on the Runekeeper's desk and opens only when a lie is spoken. This object requires no food, but it must be anointed with oil and placed on a threshold at dawn each day. If neglected for a week, the Thiasos becomes *Compromised* (it emits a low hum that imposes 1 die on Stealth rolls for its bearer).

The **Codex** of the Sealed Gate is never a simple book. It may be a leather strap carved with runes that tighten when a ward is violated, a set of iron rings linked in a chain, or the inside of a lock. Because boundaries are physical, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week testing each seal (touching, ringing, or whispering to it), or the Rites stored there become uncertain (treat as *Compromised* until restored).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Sealed Gate may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or tool) and speak a word of exclusion. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Defend* or *Resist* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be moved against their will (shoved, pulled, or teleported), they may ignore it. After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the burden of maintaining boundaries lingers.

Rites of the Sealed Gate

Rite of the Sealed Threshold (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; No Push

Tags: [WARD], [BIND]

Materials: Chalk, iron dust, or sanctified cord.

Effect: Mark a doorway or passage as sealed. Unauthorized crossing tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or suffers a Position penalty. Creates a 4-segment *Ward Integrity* timer.

Push It: The barrier becomes a visible shimmer; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Key's Rebuke (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Near; No Push

Tags: [FORCE], [BANISH]

Materials: A gesture of denial or a barrier symbol.

Effect: The target must test Body+Resolve (DV 3) or be pushed back from the threshold. On success, create a *Rebuke Echo* token granting +1 **die** to the next boundary defense.

Push It: The rebuke lingers – the target cannot cross this threshold for the rest of the scene; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Circle of Denial (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [BANISH]

Materials: A salt ring, iron filings, or boundary stones.

Effect: Create a protective circle. Supernatural beings test against the caster's Spirit+Arcana (DV 4) to cross. Mortals suffer –2 **dice** to force entry. Creates a 6-segment *Circle Integrity* timer.

Push It: The circle becomes a two-way barrier (no one can cross); mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Writ of Passage (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [BOND], [COMMAND], [MOVEMENT]

Materials: Signed authorization or spoken permissions.

Effect: Designate an authorized passage route. Allies gain **Position** +1 when using the route. Unauthorized intruders suffer –1 **die** to movement or stealth. Creates an 8-segment *Writ Authority* timer.

Push It: Extend authorization to additional allies; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Banishment Knot (High, 13 XP)

Instant; Near; High Push

Tags: [BANISH], [FORCE], [FEAR]

Materials: A knotted cord sealed with a gate-sigil.

Effect: The target supernatural entity tests against the caster's Spirit+Resolve (DV = entity Cap). On success, the entity is forced to immediately depart the scene. A failed attempt creates a 4-segment *Banishment Backlash* timer.

Push It: The banishment lasts until the next moon phase; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Consecrated Barrier (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Large Zone; High Push

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [SANCTUARY], [FATE]

Materials: Relics from three traditions, boundary markers, a trespasser's acknowledgment.

Effect: Consecrate an area against all unauthorized passage. The tests required scale with the intrusion attempt's severity. A 10-segment *Sacred Boundary* timer tracks the barrier's strength.

Push It: Make the barrier semi-permanent (lasts one season); start a *Maintenance* [6] timer.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Sealed Gate

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Sealed Gate sings in *locks and wards* – melodies that are precise, repetitive, and final, like the click of a deadbolt or the thud of a bar being set. Their voice is used to seal a door with a sung phrase, to recite a litany of exclusion that pushes a spirit back across the threshold, or to sing a sleeping guard into dreaming of a wall that never ends. The Gate's Cantors are often found in prisons, asylums, and the gatehouses of cities, their songs keeping the unwanted out.

The Cult of the Unbroken Seal. The Gate's cults meet in places where boundaries are most needed: at city gates, on bridges, in the guardrooms of tombs, and before the sealed doors of forgotten vaults. The Unbroken Seal is a fellowship of wardens, gatekeepers, exorcists, and sentinels who believe that a well-kept boundary is the foundation of civilization. A ritual of the Cult involves each member renewing a vow to guard a specific threshold – a door, a river, a mountain pass – and marking it with a fresh sigil. Their creed is carved into a single stone that is never moved: "*What is sealed stays sealed. What stays sealed protects the living.*" Outsiders are welcome to witness the sealing, but they must leave a token of their own boundary – a key, a lock of hair, a written promise.

Witchcraft of the Sealed Gate (Lay / Scholarly)

A witch who walks with the Sealed Gate is often a *ward-keeper*, an *exorcist archivist*, or a *boundary-scholar* – a lay practitioner who uses seals, litanies, and physical tokens to enforce separation. Their magic is not forged but written or sung: sealing wax mixed with iron filings, a bell that rings only when a threshold is violated, or a bound notebook of exclusion rites whose pages turn black when a spirit tries to cross. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "ward stone" into a lintel, but a hedge-witch of the Gate might daub a lignite sigil on a doorframe while reciting the Ninth Clause of Stillness. In Viterra, a village exorcist might carry a small iron seal to stamp the corners of a haunted room.

Their tools are not hammers but seals, bells, and the small brass keys that lock nothing – and everything.

The Witch’s Tool: The Seal of the Unbroken Gate. A small iron seal on a chain, cool to the touch, its face engraved with a closed door. Once per session, the witch may press the seal into wax (or directly onto a threshold while speaking a word of denial). For the next scene, any creature attempting to cross that threshold with hostile intent must make a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 3) or be turned back. The seal may also be used to “witness” a lock: touching it to a mundane lock imposes +1 DV on any attempt to pick it until the next dawn. The seal’s warmth tells the witch whether any binding placed with it still holds.

A Hedge Gift: Sealed Lips (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a person’s lips (or a letter’s seal) and whisper a litany of the Gate. For the next hour, that person cannot speak a specific secret or name (chosen by the witch). If they try, their voice fails – they cough, stutter, or simply cannot form the words. This effect can be removed by the witch or by a Resolve test (DV 4) made once per day.

The Sealed Gate’s Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Threshold Sense: +1 die to detect weak points, unauthorized passage, or boundary violations.	Paranoid Vigilance: Must repeatedly check seals; –1 die to trust-based actions.
2	Ward Resonance: Once/scene, treat a failed protection roll as a success (mark 1 SB).	Isolation Tendency: 1 Fatigue in unsecured or open spaces.
3	Boundary Mastery: +2 dice to ward, barrier, or containment magic.	Compulsive Sealing: Must secure any vulnerability noticed.
4	Absolute Barrier: Once/session, create an impenetrable barrier (size of a door) for one exchange.	Prison Mindset: –1 die to freedom or escape actions.
5	Gate Sovereign: Once/session, banish a major threat with a single test (Spirit+Resolve vs Cap+1).	Boundary Obsession: –1 die to non-containment actions.
6+	Threshold Incarnate: For one scene, become a living ward. Allies within Near gain +1 Armor; any creature attempting to pass a threshold you guard must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 5) or be turned back.	Ultimate Containment Risk: Mark +3 Obligation. You cannot leave the warded area until the scene ends, and you suffer 1 Fatigue.

Playstyle Notes

The Sealed Gate patron excels in defensive, control-oriented play. Followers shape battlefields through strategic boundary placement and become invaluable when dealing with

supernatural intrusions or securing locations. The corruption progression naturally leads characters toward becoming immovable guardians at the cost of flexibility and freedom. Ideal for abjurists, exorcists, sentinels, and any character whose duty is to keep things apart.

Emphasizes

- **Thresholds:** doors, portals, borders between realms
- **Containment:** wards, bindings, imprisonment of dangerous forces
- **Exclusion:** banishment, quarantine, protection through separation
- **Permission:** safe passage, authorized access, controlled crossing
- **Immovable Guardian:** the follower becomes a wall given will

Threshold Monk (Sealed Gate)

You define what passes and what remains.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Wits 2+, Rite of the Sealed Threshold or Cantor of Sealed Gate.

Debt-Resistant Frame. A threshold does not owe – it defines. Threshold monks gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt or obligation that would force them to cross a boundary they do not wish to cross. If they succeed, the debtor finds the way inexplicably barred (a door will not open, a contract will not bind).

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Iron Rebuke (Basic, 5 XP)	When an enemy enters your Close range, make a free unarmed strike. On a hit, they cannot move closer this exchange.	1 Fatigue	Body 3
Seal the Threshold (Basic, 4 XP)	Mark a doorway or passage as sealed. Unauthorized crossing tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or suffers a Position penalty. Create a 4-segment Ward Integrity timer.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Key's Rebuke (Basic, 5 XP)	Force target to test Body+Resolve (DV 3) or be pushed back from a threshold you guard.	1 Fatigue	Wits 2
Circle of Denial (Standard, 8 XP)	Create a protective circle (salt or chalk). Supernatural beings test against your Spirit+Arcana (DV 4) to enter. Mortals suffer -2 dice to force entry. Create a 6-segment Circle Integrity timer.	1 Boon	Tier II
Sanctuary Step (Standard, 9 XP)	When you would be moved against your will (shoved, pulled, teleported), you may ignore it.	Once per scene	Spirit 3
Banishmer Knot (Standard, 10 XP)	Force a supernatural entity to test Spirit+Resolve (DV = entity Cap) or depart the scene immediately.	1 Fatigue + 1 Boon	Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Threshold Incarnate.* For one scene, become a living ward. Allies within Near gain +1 Armor; any creature attempting to pass a threshold you guard must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 5) or be turned back. You gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (a door-shaped mark on your palm) but may ignore one debt or obligation that would force you to abandon your guard – the

creditor finds themselves facing a wall where once there was a door.

6.8.36 The Seal-Breaker (Forgotten Names, Broken Seals)

Lore. When a dynasty falls, the first thing the conquerors burn is the seal of the old emperor. The Seal-Breaker is the spirit of that ash — the one who whispers “you are not your father’s debt.” She was not born; she was left behind. She has no name because names are chains, and she has cut every chain she ever wore.

Followers are ronin who have cut their own names, escaped slaves, and those who have been erased from clan ledgers. Her shrines are abandoned gatehouses and broken milestone markers. She does not ask for worship; she asks only that you remember what you were before someone else named you.

“The Seal-Breaker does not ask for your name. She asks what you are willing to forget. I met her in a collapsed archive, wearing the face of a drowned scholar. She offered to erase my debt to the baronet if I would burn my own journal. I did not. She laughed. ‘Then pay in stories,’ she said. ‘The ink remembers.’”

Domain Focus

- **Forgotten Names:** erasure, anonymity, the power of being unwitnessed
- **Broken Seals:** freeing what was bound, opening what was locked
- **False Contracts:** destroying oaths that were never just
- **The Space Between Dynasties:** interregnums, ruins, and the silence after a seal cracks

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Seal-Breaker does not bind a creature of bright light or easy memory. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature that embodies forgotten things: a ghost moth that appears only when a sealed door is opened, a clay scarab that crumbles to dust when a false oath is sworn, a gray mouse that nests in the voids of broken seals, a blind cave fish that has never seen a name carved in stone, or a pale spider that weaves webs in the shape of missing letters. This creature requires no food, but it must be shown a new broken seal — a cracked wax stamp, a snapped lock, a torn ribbon — each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it hides, and its bearer suffers –1 die on all Deception and Forgery rolls until a forgotten name is whispered to it).

The **Codex** of the Seal-Breaker is never a book of finished contracts. It may be a ledger with every name struck through, a box of shattered seals, a scroll of water-stained parchment that can never be dried, or a single sheet of vellum that was signed and then burned. Because the Seal-Breaker’s truths are written in erasure, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week cutting a new line through a name in the ledger or adding a fresh crack to a seal, or the Rites stored there become uncertain (treat as *Compromised* until a new false contract is witnessed).

Patron’s Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Seal-Breaker may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or document) and whisper a word of erasure. For the rest of the scene, the

item grants +1 **die** to *Deception* or *Subterfuge* rolls when attempting to pass as someone else, and the first time each scene the bearer would be identified by a witness (magically or mundanely), the witness must test *Resolve* (DV 4) to remember the bearer's face. After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as a fragment of their own name feels slightly looser.

Rites of the Seal-Breaker

Rite of the Unwritten Petition (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No

Tags: [ERASURE], [DECEPTION], [DEBT]

Materials: A document that is clearly a forgery, or a blank piece of vellum.

Effect: You may present a document to an official without speaking your name. For one scene, they cannot use your lineage, prior debts, or past crimes against you — they treat you as a stranger. The document smokes slightly as you hand it over.

Push It: The official also forgets your face immediately after the interaction. Mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)** as the memory gap causes suspicion later.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Anonymous Blade (Standard, 8 XP)

Instant; Touch; No

Tags: [ERASURE], [DEATH], [DEBT]

Materials: A weapon that has never been named, or a weapon that has been filed smooth of all markings.

Effect: Your next attack with this weapon leaves no trace — no wound pattern, no blood type, no memory. If you kill, the victim's name is struck from all public ledgers for a generation. No divination or spirit questioning can identify you as the killer.

Push It: The victim's name is also erased from the memory of their closest kin. Mark 2 **SB (Hearts)**; the Seal-Breaker may ask you to forget a friend's face in return.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Broken Seal (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch; No

Tags: [ERASURE], [FATE], [DEBT], [CORRUPTION]

Materials: The original wax seal of a contract, a marriage certificate, or an oath of fealty.

Effect: Permanently void one formal contract, marriage, or oath of fealty. The two parties no longer owe each other anything. However, you become the witness — any future betrayal between them adds 1 Story Beat to the GM's pool, and the Hollow may take an interest in the broken bond. The seal itself melts and reforms into a coin that cannot be spent; it will reappear in your pocket at the worst possible moment.

Push It: Void a contract without the consent of one party. They will know something has changed, but not what. Mark +3 **Corruption** and the hollow coin has a pulse.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Seal-Breaker

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Seal-Breaker sings in *erased verses* — melodies that start strong and fade to silence before the final note. Their voice is used to make guards forget a password, to hide a fugitive's trail, or to lull an inquisitor into forgetting why they came. The Seal-Breaker's Cantors are rarely remembered; that is how they prefer it.

The Cult of the Unbound Name. The Seal-Breaker's cults meet in places where names are already forgotten: abandoned notary offices, collapsed archives, the ruins of courthouses. The *Unbound Name* is a fellowship of forgers, ex-slaves, and those who have cut themselves from their bloodlines. A ritual involves each member writing their birth name on a slip of paper, then burning it. The ashes are mixed with water and drunk. Those who drink forget one debt they owe; those who refuse remember it forever. Their creed is carved on a single broken seal: "*You are not your father's debt. You are not your mother's shame. You are the space where the seal cracked.*" Outsiders are welcome to watch, but they must speak their true name aloud before leaving — or lose it.

Witchcraft of the Seal-Breaker (Lay / Erasure)

A witch who walks with the Seal-Breaker is a *name-cutter* or *seal-breaker* — one who crafts empty spaces. Their magic works through the tools of erasure: a needle that unpicks a monogram, a quill that writes in ink that fades after reading, a small iron stamp that leaves a mark that cannot be seen but can be felt. Their tools are never hammers; they use tweezers, magnifying lenses, and the small wax tablets that can be scraped clean in an instant. In the Brass Coast, a Sidhi lighthouse keeper might refuse to record a name; a witch of the Seal-Breaker would simply erase it from the ledger and watch the ripple effects.

The Witch's Tool: The Unpicking Needle. A needle of black iron, cold to the touch, that has never been used to sew anything whole. Once per session, the witch may unpick a single stitch in a document, a garment, or a threshold. The stitch was a name. Now it is a gap. For the rest of the scene, any attempt to identify the person whose name was unpicked suffers –2 dice. The needle can also be used to cut a witness cord; the broken oath is not forgiven, merely unwitnessed.

A Hedge Gift: Erased Footsteps (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a set of tracks (footprints, hoofprints, wheel ruts) and whisper a name that is not theirs. The tracks vanish as if never made. The Hollow, however, notices the absence — the GM gains 1 SB to spend on a pursuit complication later in the session.

The Seal-Breaker's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Forgotten Face: +1 die to Deception when claiming a false identity.	Name-Slippery: -1 die when signing legal documents; your signature looks different each time.
2	Unwitnessed Step: Once per scene, treat a failed Stealth roll as a success.	Compulsive Erasure: You must correct a false name when you hear one; doing so marks 1 Fatigue.
3	Seal-Sight: +2 dice to detect forged seals or broken contracts.	Debt-Blind: -1 die to recall any debt owed to you; the Hollow collects the interest.
4	Empty Ledger: Once per session, demand a single page from any ledger be left blank. The page will not be noticed missing.	Echo of the Missing: You occasionally forget your own name for a moment; -1 die to social rolls when it happens.
5	Name-Eater: Once per session, speak a person's true name and erase it from their own memory for one hour.	The Hollow's List: Every name you erase adds 1 tick to a Hollow Attention timer. The Hollow wants them back.
6+	The Unsealed: Once per session, become completely anonymous — no one can recognize you, describe you, or remember meeting you. This lasts for one scene.	Unnamed: Mark +3 Obligation. You have forgotten your own name. Until you recover it, you cannot be the subject of any oath, blessing, or curse — but neither can you swear one. Your reflection shows a blank space where your face should be.

Playstyle Notes

The Seal-Breaker rewards those who value freedom over obligation, who see names as chains, and who understand that sometimes the kindest act is to forget. Followers become masters of erasure, forgery, and anonymity. The corruption progression leads toward a being who no longer has a name — but who can never be bound by any contract again. Ideal for spies, fugitives, former slaves, and anyone who has ever wanted to start over with a clean slate.

Rivalries & Obligations**Major Rivalries:**

- **Mykkiel (The Covenant):** Direct opposition — law versus erasure. Covenant judges despise the Seal-Breaker's followers, who in turn see all contracts as cages.
- **The Witness:** The Witness records everything; the Seal-Breaker erases. Their followers rarely meet, but when they do, the conflict is philosophical — and fatal.

Hard Obligation Triggers:

- **7+ Segments:** You must erase a name from a public record — a birth, a marriage, a death. The Hollow will witness the erasure and may ask why.
- **10+ Segments:** The Seal-Breaker demands you cut your own name from your skin. If you refuse, she will cut it from the ledgers instead — you become legally invisible, unable to own property, marry, or be buried. If you accept, you gain the *Unnamed* condition (see table) and become truly free.

Emphasizes

- **Forgotten Names:** power in anonymity
- **Broken Seals:** freeing what was bound
- **False Contracts:** destroying unjust oaths
- **The Hollow's Interest:** erasure attracts the Hollow, which collects forgotten debts

6.8.37 The Silent Choir, Keeper of Unspoken Truths (Restraint & Protective Omission)

Lore. The Silent Choir is the gathered voice of truths wisely left unsaid, confessions granted mercy, and secrets kept to spare a life from breaking. It is not absence but presence: the practiced wisdom that some knowledge wounds more than it heals. Its keepers are wardens of confidence and shelterers of the vulnerable. They learn to carry burdens alone, to let volatile truths sleep, and to shield others from fires that revelation would feed.

Unlike the Witness, who reveals truth at any cost, or Ikasha, who hides secrets for power, the Silent Choir teaches *restraint as protection*. A secret is not a weapon; it is a weight. To speak it may free the speaker but shatter the listener. The Choir's followers judge not what is true, but what is kind. They are therapists, not inquisitors; confessors, not spies.

In the world of Fate's Edge, the Silent Choir is invoked by bell-wardens who keep a certain pattern unsung to avoid calling the fog, archivists who seal dangerous texts behind a second lock and whisper the combination to no one, and death-doulas who carry a dying oath to the grave. The Choir has no temples, only quiet rooms, sealed letter-boxes, and the spaces between heartbeats where a truth could be told — but is not.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, the Silent Choir is known as the *Gray Watchers* in Thepyrgos, where bell-wardens maintain the silence furlongs. In Aeler, their practice is called “breath-stillness” — a meditative art used by vent-priors to keep dangerous pressures from being spoken aloud. In Vhasia, they are the *Silent Notaries*, who witness death-bed testaments and then bury the name of the inheritor in a lead box that is never opened. Wherever a secret must be protected, the Silent Choir is already there, listening — and choosing not to speak.

“In a world that shouts, the Choir teaches the weight of quiet. Not every wound needs salt, not every blaze needs breath, not every heart can bear the full truth.”

Domain Focus

- **Protective Silence:** when and how to keep counsel for others' good
- **Merciful Omission:** judging truths that harm when spoken
- **Confidential Guardianship:** safeguarding people and perilous knowledge
- **Restraint Wisdom:** the power of what is not said or done

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Silent Choir does not bind a familiar of sound and fury. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature that embodies quiet discretion: a gray mouse that nests in letter-boxes and never cheeps, a moth whose wings are dusted with the powder of forgetfulness, a small owl that flies without stirring air, a whippoorwill whose call is a barely audible sigh, or a tiny toad that hibernates in sealed jars and wakes only when a secret is told. This creature requires no food, but it must be present when a confidence

is kept — when someone refrains from speaking a harmful truth. If neglected for a week (no witnessed restraint), it becomes *Compromised* (it emits a faint, anxious buzzing; its bearer gains –1 die to all rolls involving discretion or secrecy until it is soothed with a whispered promise).

The **Codex** of the Silent Choir is never a book meant to be read aloud. It may be a locked journal whose pages are blank until breathed upon, a set of sealed wax tablets that crumble if opened by the wrong hands, a collection of memory-knots tied in gray silk, or the inside of a bell that has been silenced with felt. Because the Choir's truths are kept in omission, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week reviewing the secrets they have carried (without speaking them aloud) or the Rites stored there become faint (treat as *Compromised* until re-sealed).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Silent Choir may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or tool) and whisper a word of stillness. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 die to *Stealth* or *Insight* rolls involving discretion or secrecy, and the first time each scene the bearer would be forced to reveal a secret by magical compulsion, they may ignore it (the Choir's silence protects them). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the weight of the unspoken presses upon them.

Rites of the Silent Choir

Rite of the Gentle Seal (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near/Touch; Yes.

Tags: [SILENCE], [PROTECT], [BOOST], [DEBT]

Materials: A white feather or cloth that has drunk whispered confidences; or a sealed envelope or locked reliquary holding a sensitive fact.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Gentle Silence:** Hush a space with respectful quiet. All present gain +1 die to actions of discretion, confidentiality, or de-escalation this scene.
- **Shielded Truth:** Ward one piece of information from discovery. Gain +2 dice to resist extraction or revelation of the protected truth.

Push It: (Shielded Truth) Protection becomes absolute but dependent: removing the ward triggers 1 **SB (Hearts)** as bottled truths surge.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Unspoken Accord (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [SILENCE], [TRUTH]

Materials: A pact signed in fading ink or a vow witnessed in silence.

Effect: Bind an understanding without paper teeth. All parties gain +1 die when honoring the accord; breach draws social costs even without proof.

Push It: The accord is supernaturally enforced: a breaker suffers swift ostracism; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Burden Bearer (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [TRANSFER], [HEAL], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: An object heavy with someone's shame or grief.

Effect: Take another's social or emotional weight for a time. The target gains relief (+2 dice to social rolls) while you suffer the drag (−1 die to social rolls) this scene.

Push It: A shard remains: gain insight, keep a sliver of pain; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Sanctuary of Secrets (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [SILENCE], [PROTECT], [DEBT]

Materials: A room seasoned by trusted confidences and sealed with hush-signs.

Effect: Consecrate a sanctuary where secrets hold fast. Truths cannot be compelled; all within gain immunity to forced revelation and +2 dice to maintain discretion.

Push It: The sanctuary becomes a keep: none may leave until each offers one guarded truth; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Choir's Wisdom (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [TRUTH], [OMEN], [FATE], [BOOST], [BURDEN]

Materials: The weight of many secrets rightly kept and debts of trust well paid.

Effect: Read the branching costs of revelation before speech. Gain +3 dice to judge when to speak and when to keep counsel.

Push It: Sight is too wide: see all outcomes, struggle to choose; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Confidant Keeper (Oath-Keeper)

The word not spoken is a shield. The secret kept is a kindness. I will carry your truth so you do not have to.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Lore 2+, Rite of the Gentle Seal or Cantor of the Silent Choir.

Confidant Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Calm Presence (Basic, 5 XP)	Once per scene, you may touch a creature suffering from Fear, Guilt, or Despair and remove that Condition.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 3
Sealed Lips (Basic, 4 XP)	You may use the Hedge Gift <i>Weight of the Unsaid</i> without spending XP (you know it instinctively).	Passive	Tier II
Burden Steady (Basic, 4 XP)	You may carry one additional psychological Condition without stacking penalties.	Passive	Spirit 3
Confessor Mercy (Standard, 8 XP)	When you use Rite of the Burden Bearer, the target's relief lasts for the entire scene (instead of just the social roll bonus).	+1 Obligation	Tier III
Sanctuary Keeper (Standard, 9 XP)	Once per session, you may declare a room you are in to be a <i>Sanctuary</i> for one scene. All within gain +1 die to resist fear and coercion.	1 Boon	Spirit 4, Tier III
Final Vow (Master, 12 XP)	Once per campaign, you may take a dying person's last secret and carry it permanently. You gain +1 permanent Corruption, but you may never reveal that secret — not even under magical compulsion.	Free	Epic

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *The Unburdened Confessor.* Once per session, you may absorb a single traumatic memory or secret from a willing creature, erasing it from their mind permanently. You gain the memory as your own (with all emotional weight), and the creature is freed from its effects. You gain 1 permanent Corruption and mark +2 Obligation to the Silent Choir. You cannot use this talent again until you have spent a downtime scene in meditation or confession.

Cantors & Cults of the Silent Choir

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Silent Choir sings in *breaths of omission* — melodies that are felt rather than heard, harmonies that resolve into silence. Their voice is used to quiet a room of gossip, to seal a confession with a hum that makes it sacred, or to place a gentle pressure on a tongue that would speak a harmful truth. The Choir's Cantors are often found in confessionals, in the rooms of the dying, and in the alcoves of great libraries, humming the songs that keep secrets safe.

The Cult of the Sealed Lip. The Silent Choir's cults meet in places where secrets are naturally kept: locked scriptoria, the back rooms of notaries, and the quiet corners of courthouses. The Sealed Lip is a fellowship of confessors, archivists, therapists, and spies who have learned that the most powerful word is the one left unspoken. A ritual of the Cult involves each member writing down a truth they wish they could tell, then sealing it in an envelope that is never opened. The envelopes are stored in a single locked chest — the *Coffer of Unspoken Things*. Once per season, they pour the ashes of a burned confession into a small copper bell; the bell never rings, but they claim it “remembers” every secret fed to it. Their creed is written on the inside of the lid: *"The word not spoken is a shield. The secret kept is a kindness."* Outsiders are welcome to bring a sealed envelope of their own, but they must never ask what is inside another's.

Witchcraft of the Silent Choir (Lay / Secrecy)

A witch who walks with the Silent Choir is a *seal-scribe* or *lock-keeper* — one who crafts the physical vessels of silence: a book whose pages refuse to reveal their contents to the wrong reader, a chest that cannot be opened without the keeper's whisper, or a letter that dissolves if read aloud. Their magic works through the materials of discretion: a quill that writes in ink that fades after one reading, a wax seal that screams if broken by an unauthorized hand, or a lock that only clicks shut when a secret is placed inside. Their tools are not hammers; they use candles, seals, and the soft pressure of a thumb on a clasp.

The Witch's Tool: The Candle of Unspoken Trust. A thick, beeswax candle, gray as ash, that burns with a silent, smokeless flame. Once per session, the witch may light the candle and hold a sealed envelope, a door, or a person's hand over the flame (not touching it). For the next hour, any secret placed in the envelope, spoken behind the door, or entrusted to the person cannot be revealed by magical means (compulsion, truth spells, divination). The candle gutters if the secret is about to be forced out, giving the keeper one minute to intervene. The candle melts entirely after nine uses.

A Hedge Gift: Weight of the Unsaid (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a person's lips and speak a single word (“hush”). For the next minute, that person cannot speak any word that would reveal a secret they have sworn to keep (including secrets they have overheard). If they try, they feel a mild pressure on their throat — enough to pause them, but not enough to cause harm. The effect ends if the witch speaks again.

The Silent Choir's Corruption Table

Tier	Blessing	Burden / Quirk
1	Discretion's Gift: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> when someone is about to speak what should be kept.	Silent Compulsion: Urge to still tongues; -1 die to ordinary conversation.
2	Confidence Keeper: Once/scene, shelter a secret from accidental spill.	Secret Burden: In places thick with confidences, suffer Fatigue 1 .
3	Merciful Blindness: Once/session, prevent discovery of a truth that would harm if revealed.	Truth Sensitivity: Lies grate; -1 die while surrounded by deception.
4	Sanctuary Sense: Once/scene, veil a brief zone from eavesdropping.	Communication Strain: Others balk at full candor; -1 die to personal disclosure.
5	Wisdom of Restraint: Once/session, see the full cost of airing any one truth.	Silent Isolation: -2 dice to form close bonds; you hold too much back.
6+	Choir's Voice: Once/session, speak with the gathered prudence of unspoken truths.	Truth Prison: Mark +3 Obligation; risk becoming a living vault unable to share without harm. You cannot speak any secret you have carried unless you first mark 1 Fatigue to "loosen" it.

Playstyle Notes

The Silent Choir favors guardians and confidants: those who stand between fragile lives and ruinous truth. Its rites fortify discretion, temper tempers, and build rooms where trust can breathe. The cost is weight: secrets you keep will keep you. Unlike the Witness (who would speak truth at any cost) or Ikasha (who hides for advantage), the Choir teaches that *mercy is sometimes silence*. Ideal for therapists, confessors, archivists, and anyone who has ever chosen to carry a burden so that another might walk free.

Emphasizes

- **Protective Restraint:** silence used as shield
- **Confidential Guardianship:** duty to those who trust you
- **Merciful Omission:** letting some truths sleep
- **Discretion Wisdom:** judging what, when, and how to speak
- **Burden Bearing:** carrying heat so others do not burn

Whisper Monk (Silent Choir)

The word not spoken is a shield. The secret kept is a kindness.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Presence 2+, Rite of the Gentle Seal or Cantor of Silent Choir.

Debt-Resistant Frame. What is not said cannot be owed. Whisper monks gain +1 die to resist any magical debt or obligation that would force them to speak a secret, reveal a truth, or betray a confidence. If they succeed, the creditor hears only silence — and silence has no signature.

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Silencing Palm (Basic, 5 XP)	On an unarmed hit, the target cannot speak any word that would reveal a secret they have sworn to keep for one scene (Resolve DV 3 to resist).	1 Fatigue	Spirit 3
Calm Presence (Basic, 5 XP)	Once per scene, remove a Condition (Fear, Guilt, Despair) from a willing creature by touch.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Gentle Seal (Basic, 4 XP)	Hush a space with respectful quiet. All present gain +1 die to actions of discretion, confidentiality, or de-escalation this scene.	1 Fatigue	Presence 2
Burden Bearer (Standard, 7 XP)	Take another's social or emotional weight for a time. Target gains +2 dice to social rolls while you suffer -1 die.	1 Boon	Spirit 2
Sanctuary Keeper (Standard, 9 XP)	Once per session, declare a room you are in to be a Sanctuary for one scene. All within gain +1 die to resist fear and coercion.	Free	Tier II

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *The Unburdened Confessor.* Once per session, absorb a single traumatic memory or secret from a willing creature, erasing it from their mind permanently. You gain the memory as your own (with all emotional weight), and the creature is freed from its effects. You may also ignore one debt or obligation that was based on that erased memory. Gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (a gray thread tied around your wrist that never loosens). The Hollow

will no longer pursue that debt — but the memory may one day haunt you.

6.8.38 Thrysos, King of Revels (Ecstasy, Excess & Salacious Delight)

Lore. Where torches flare and cups spill, where dancers stamp until dawn, there strides Thrysos crowned with ivy and horn. He is both host and beast, a patron of license who laughs at law. In his train follow the masked and the wild, the broken who dance to forget, the bold who revel to remember, and the lustful who seek the heat of bodies in the dark. His rites intoxicate, inflame, and unmask — yet each cup leaves a mark, each kiss a chain, each night of abandon a dawn of reckoning.

Thrysos rules the spectrum from the grinning drunkard who sings bawdy songs in taverns to the ecstatic cults whose rites strip away not only clothes but every pretense of civilization. He is the god of the Bacchanalia, the wild hunt of the senses, the moment when the watcher becomes the participant and the participant becomes the sacrifice. In his milder aspect, he blesses the fertility of the harvest and the laughter of lovers. In his darker aspect, he drives maenads to tear apart the hero who refused to join the dance.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Thrysos is called by many names. In Linn, his followers are the *Storm-Dancers*, who whirl through gales until exhaustion, their cries mistaken for ecstasy. In Aelinnel, he is the *Unbounded Guest*, whose arrival at a feast is marked by laughter, shattered glass, and at least one scandalous elopement. In Zakov, the *Revel-King* is invoked before every pirate carouse, with the understanding that a hungover crew is a vulnerable one — and that the captain's bed is never empty. In Vhasian hedge-courts, his name is whispered by those who seek a potion to lower inhibitions or a curse of unquenchable desire. His rituals are never secret — they are too loud, too wet, too fragrant with spilled wine and sweat — but they are always dangerous, for Thrysos demands that every excess be paid for, if not tonight then at the first hangover of spring, or in the unwanted child, or in the blood feud started by a jealous spouse.

*“Drink, and be unafraid. Kiss, and be unbound. Dance, and be devoured.
Every mask is true when worn long enough, and every truth is a mask for
hunger.”*

Signs. Wine that never sours; a mask that smiles without a wearer; goat-tracks circling thrice before vanishing; the sudden, inexplicable warmth of a stranger's hand on your arm; the sound of a zither played in an empty room; the scent of myrrh and sweat clinging to a garment that has never been worn.

Cantor's Temptation. Thrysos promises freedom without end: no oaths, no chains, only song and cup and flesh. Yet those who drink too deeply wake to find they serve not joy but appetite — and appetite is a master that never sleeps.

Domain Focus

- **Ecstatic Release:** dance, intoxication, the shedding of inhibition (and clothing)
- **Masked Freedom:** identity as performance, truth through disguise, the thrill of the anonymous encounter
- **Feast and Famine:** excess, appetite, lust, and the cost of indulgence
- **Ritual Frenzy:** communal ecstasy that transforms participants into something feral and beautiful
- **The Bacchic Dark:** the point where pleasure tips into violence, where the maenad tears apart the intruder

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Thrysos does not bind a familiar of quiet habits. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological being of primal appetites: a satyr-kid with too-bright eyes that nibbles at wine-soaked bread, a fox that dances on its hind legs when the moon is full, a ferret that steals silk ribbons from lovers' bedposts, a gecko that clings to wine jugs and changes color with desire, or a small bronze cymbal that claps of its own accord during moments of flirtation. This creature requires no ordinary food, but it must be present during an act of indulgence (drinking, dancing, lovemaking, or feasting) each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it shrieks at inappropriate moments, or its antics become grotesque, imposing -1 die on all social rolls involving subtlety or discretion for its bearer).

The **Codex** of Thrysos is never a sober book. It may be a wine-stained journal of erotic poetry, a set of ivory tablets carved with scenes of revelry, a leather folio containing pressed flowers from orgies, or a scroll that unravels further each time the reader laughs. Because Thrysos's truths are written in the body's language, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week adding a new verse, sketch, or memory of indulgence, or the Rites stored there become dull (treat as *Compromised* until reinvigorated with a night of celebration).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Thrysos may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or garment) and whisper a word of desire. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 die to *Performance* or *Sway* rolls involving seduction, charm, or intimidation, and the first time each scene the bearer would be affected by a Fear effect, they may laugh it off (ignore it). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the craving for another taste of freedom gnaws at them.

Rites of Thrysos

Rite of the Overflowing Cup (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [SOCIAL], [FEAR], [AREA]

Materials: A brimming vessel of wine (or a more intimate offering).

Effect: Allies who drink gain +1 die to social rolls this scene; enemies who drink suffer -1 die. Those who drink deeply may find their inhibitions loosened in other ways (GM's discretion for romantic or scandalous complications).

Push It: All in Near must test Resolve (DV 3) or be swept into revelry, possibly leading to unplanned liaisons or public confessions; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Horned Dance (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [BOOST], [FOCUS], [TRANSFORM]

Materials: A mask or antlers (carved from a stag that died in rut).

Effect: Enter an ecstatic frenzy: +2 dice to melee or performance; ignore 1 Fatigue per round. Your movements become both seductive and threatening; those watching may be captivated or disturbed.

Push It: The frenzy spreads: one ally joins you in the dance, but both mark **1 SB (Spades)** as the lines between combat and carnality blur.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Breaking Mask (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [DEBUFF], [FEAR]

Materials: A mask smashed in hand (or a lover's token torn in two).

Effect: Reveal the true face beneath the social mask: the target suffers **−2 dice** to disguise, deceit, or composure until scene end. They may also be compelled to admit a hidden desire (GM's discretion).

Push It: Truth is forced: the target must declare one hidden desire aloud, possibly to the wrong person; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Wild Procession (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [SUMMON], [WARD], [AREA]

Materials: A horn sounded thrice (or a kiss passed around a circle).

Effect: Summon spectral revelers — satyrs, dancers, horned riders, and a few figures whose embraces are more than friendly. For the scene, the zone is [WARD]ed: hostile entry forces **1 SB (Spades)**; allies gain **+1 die** to resist compulsion or fear. The revelers may also grant a boon of Vigor to one couple (restore 1 Fatigue to two allies who share a bond of intimacy).

Push It: The procession spills beyond the zone; outsiders in Near must test Resolve (DV 4) or join the dance — and perhaps the revel's other activities.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Endless Feast (High, 14 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [HEAL], [BOOST], [AREA], [BURDEN]

Materials: A feast laid for twelve, with wine, music, and comfortable cushions.

Effect: For one scene, the zone floods with plenty: allies restore Fatigue; all rolls tied to appetite or indulgence gain **+2 dice**. Leaving requires Resolve (DV 3) — the comforts are hard to abandon. The feast also grants a temporary *Heightened Desire* condition: the first seduction or intimidation roll each ally makes gains **+1 die**.

Push It: The feast persists as a hunger-haunt; start **Hedonist's Curse [6]**. Participants may find themselves unable to derive pleasure from mundane means, always craving the excess of that night.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Rite of the Reveler's Apotheosis (High, 15 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [FATE], [SACRIFICE]

Materials: A crown of twisted vines that bleed when touched, the first laugh of a newborn, a promise broken at a crossroads, and the willing touch of a lover.

Effect: Grant the ultimate reveler's gift — transformation into pure ecstatic essence. The target becomes immune to fear and despair, gains +**3 dice** to performance or frenzy, and can inspire allies within Near (+**1 die** to all rolls). Their aura also carries a scent of desire; anyone within Near who sees them must test Resolve (DV 3) or be mildly infatuated (disadvantage on hostile actions).

Push It: The transformation becomes contagious — nearby allies may also transform but risk losing their humanity (their sense of self blurs into the ecstatic mob); mark +**2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Drunken Master Monk (Thrysos)

The true disciple does not fight the wine — they let the wine fight for them. Every stagger is a feint, every spill a trip, every belch a battle cry, every wandering hand a distraction.

Prerequisites: Body 3+, Spirit 3+, Rite of the Horned Dance learned or Cantor of Thrysos.

Monastic Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Stagger Step (Basic, 4 XP)	When an enemy misses you with a melee attack, you may immediately move one band (Close → Near or vice versa) without provoking opportunity attacks.	1 Fatigue	Body 3
Spill the Cup (Basic, 5 XP)	As a reaction to being grappled or restrained, you may slip free and impose –1 die on the attacker’s next roll.	1 Boon	Dex 2
Drunken Fist (Basic, 5 XP)	Your unarmed strikes gain +1 die and ignore the first point of Armor when you are at Fatigue 2 or more (the wine “guides” you).	Passive	Body 3, Spirit 2
Hangover Resilience (Basic, 4 XP)	Once per scene, after suffering a complication or Story Beat from intoxication, you may clear 1 Fatigue (the headache fades, but the lesson remains).	Free	Spirit 3
Reveler’s Recovery (Standard, 8 XP)	When you use Rite of the Horned Dance, you may also heal 1 Harm (not Condition) as the ecstasy knits flesh.	+1 Obligation	Tier II, Rite of the Horned Dance
Satyr’s Sprawl (Standard, 8 XP)	You are immune to being knocked prone while moving, and when you fall prone intentionally you may immediately stand as a free action.	Passive	Body 4, Athletics 2
Bacchic Counter (Standard, 9 XP)	When you succeed on a defense roll while at Desperate Position, you may immediately make a free unarmed attack against the attacker.	Once per scene	Tier III, Drunken Fist

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *The Unbroken Bottle.* Once per session, you may ignore all penalties from Fatigue for one scene. While this is active, each time you would be hit by a melee attack, you may instead stagger out of the way and force the attacker to hit another adjacent creature of your choice (narrate the stumble). After the scene ends, you collapse with Harm 2 (Exhaustion) and cannot use this talent again until you have rested for a full night.

Cantors & Cults of Thrysos

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Thrysos sings in *off-key harmonies* — melodies that start wild and grow wilder, rhythms that mimic a galloping heart. Their voice is used to whip a crowd into a frenzy, to calm a hangover with a lullaby, or to make a mask cling to a face until the wearer is ready to take it off. Thrysos's Cantors are often found at festivals, in taverns at closing time, leading the procession of the horned dancers, or performing in private salons where the line between audience and participant is deliberately blurred.

The Cult of the Horned Circle. Thrysos's cults meet in clearings, barns, and the back rooms of inns after midnight. The Horned Circle is a fellowship of mask-carvers, vintners, musicians, courtesans, and those who have tasted the edge of ecstasy — sometimes all in the same person. Their most sacred vessel is a hollowed-out log that was struck by lightning; they ferment wine inside it, and the wine *whispers secrets* to those who drink it — forgotten grudges, hidden desires, the true names of those who will betray them, and the faces of those who are willing. A ritual of the Circle involves each member donning a mask (hand-carved, never bought) and dancing until the first dancer falls from exhaustion. The fallen is crowned with ivy and declared “guest of honor” — they lead the next circle, and sometimes the next bed. Their creed is carved into a single wine barrel that is never emptied: *"The cup that never empties is the cup you share."* Outsiders are welcome to dance, but they must leave their mask behind when they go — and if they drink from the lightning-log, they will hear the whispers for a year and a day, and they will return.

The Maenads of the Crimson Caves (Bacchic Dark). The darkest cult of Thrysos, the Maenads (or *Bassarids*) are almost exclusively female, though men may join at the risk of becoming their prey. They gather in hidden caves or moonlit groves to perform the *oreibasia* — the mountain dance — wearing fawnskins and carrying thyrsi tipped with bronze. Their rites begin with wine and music, escalate to ecstatic abandon, and sometimes end in *sparagmos* — the tearing apart of a living sacrifice (often a bull, but in the oldest stories, a human who refused to join the dance). This cult is banned in every civilized nation, but it persists in the wildest frontiers. A character who joins the Maenads gains access to darker rites, but also the risk of losing control entirely (the GM may treat this as a Corruption track that leads to a violent, permanent transformation).

Witchcraft of Thrysos (Lay / Revelry)

A witch who walks with Thrysos is a *mask-carver* or *wine-smith* — one who crafts the tools of ecstatic release: a mask that lets the wearer dance without tiring, a drum that beats in time with the drinker's pulse, a cup that never runs dry (but leaves a headache at dawn), or a perfume that makes the wearer irresistible for a single night. Their magic

works through the materials of celebration: a thyrsus that marks the boundary of a sacred dance, a press that squeezes wine that ferments in hours instead of weeks, a needle that sews a costume that makes the wearer faster, louder, bolder, or a small clay lamp that burns with a flame that kindles desire. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “revel keystone” into a feast hall, but a hedge-witch of Thrysos might instead drive a thyrsus into the floorboards to consecrate the space for an orgy.

The Witch’s Tool: The Thyrsus of the Unbound. A staff of fennel or oak, topped with a pine cone and bound with ivy, often with a ribbon from a lover’s garment. Once per session, the witch may strike the thyrsus against the ground three times. For the next scene, any creature within Near who is engaged in revelry (dancing, drinking, performing, or any act of intimacy) gains +1 **die** to social and physical actions, but any attempt to leave the zone requires a Resolve test (DV 3) — the revel holds them. The thyrsus can also be used to draw a circle on the ground; any mask placed within the circle becomes “true” for one night — the wearer cannot be recognized by anyone who was not present at the drawing, and their inhibitions are lowered (they may act on desires they would normally suppress).

A Hedge Gift: Dancer’s Cramp (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may snap their fingers and whisper a dancer’s rhythm. One target within Near range feels an irresistible urge to move — they must tap a foot, sway, or take a step. This cannot force them into danger, but it can ruin stealth, break a staredown, or distract a guard for one exchange. The target may resist with Resolve (DV 3) to ignore the urge. A more salacious version (*Lover’s Cramp*) might be used in seduction scenes, forcing an unintended compliment or touch.

Thrysos's Corruption Table

Tier	Gift	Corruption
1	Reveler's Grace: +1 die to social rolls in feasts or crowds.	Compulsive Toast: Must drink or mark 1 Fatigue when drink is offered.
2	Horned Vitality: Ignore the first 1 Fatigue each scene.	Restless Appetite: -1 die when abstaining from indulgence (food, drink, or touch).
3	Revel-Kin: Once/scene, summon a minor revel-spirit (advantage die) — a satyr, a maenad, or a muse of seduction.	Masked Self: Cannot act without a role or guise; -1 die to plain sincerity.
4	Bacchic Fury: Once/session, frenzy grants +2 dice to melee for one exchange. Also, once per scene, you may ignore the effects of a single social faux pas (the revel covers it).	Ecstatic Blindness: -1 die to perception outside the revel; you may not notice threats that require sobriety.
5	Feast Without End: Once/session, allies in Near clear all Fatigue.	Hungering Host: You consume twice as much; denial causes Harm 1 (Stress). You may also develop a reputation: every feast you attend ends in scandal.
6+	Satyr King's Mantle: For one scene, become an avatar of revels; all allies gain +2 dice, enemies suffer -2 dice. Your presence also inspires desire: once during the scene, you may compel one target to act on a hidden passion (Resolve DV 4).	Tyrant of Pleasure: Mark +3 Obligation; the revel grows monstrous, demanding a sacrifice (an oath, a relationship, or a life).
		Beast of Endless Revel: Permanent transformation — your mortal form becomes optional; must make Presence+Performance (DV 4) to appear civilized or risk terrifying (or entrancing) all who see you into joining your eternal celebration. You are always at least mildly intoxicated, and sobriety causes you physical pain (1 Fatigue per hour).

“Let the wine flow, let the masks fall, let the fire burn away all restraint. In the revel we find truth — raw, wild, and beautiful. And in the aftermath, we find the hunger for more.”

Playstyle Notes

Thrysos rewards those who embrace risk, abandon convention, and find power in letting go — both the laughter of the drunkard and the ecstasy of the maenad. His followers become masters of ecstatic ritual, social manipulation through celebration and seduction, and the dangerous art of losing control. The corruption progression leads toward a beast of endless revel — powerful, charismatic, but never truly sober, never truly at rest, and always hungry. Ideal for players who enjoy wild scenes, social chaos, characters who dance on the edge of self-destruction, and those who wish to explore the full spectrum of hedonism from playful flirtation to violent frenzy.

Emphasizes

- **Ecstatic Release:** music, dance, intoxication, the shedding of inhibition (and clothing)
- **Masked Freedom:** identity as performance, the thrill of the anonymous encounter
- **Feast and Famine:** excess, appetite, lust, and the cost of indulgence
- **Ritual Frenzy:** communal ecstasy that transforms participants into something feral and beautiful
- **The Bacchic Dark:** the point where pleasure tips into violence, where the revel demands blood
- **Seduction as Weapon:** using desire to manipulate, distract, or destroy

Drunken Master (Thrysos)

The true disciple does not fight the wine — they let the wine fight for them. Every stagger is a feint, every spill a trip, every belch a battle cry.

Prerequisites: Body 3+, Spirit 3+, Rite of the Horned Dance or Cantor of Thrysos.

Debt-Resistant Frame. Thrysos's monks owe nothing but the next glass. They gain +1 **die** to ignore or resist any magical debt, geas, or contract that would compel them to act against their revelry. This boon can be used once per scene, but each use leaves a faint scent of wine on the monk — the Hollow may find them easier to track (GM gains 1 SB).

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Stagger Step (Basic, 4 XP)	When an enemy misses you with a melee attack, move one band (Close↔Near) without provoking opportunity attacks.	1 Fatigue	Body 3
Spill the Cup (Basic, 5 XP)	As a reaction to being grappled, slip free and impose −1 die on the attacker's next roll.	1 Boon	Dex 2
Drunken Fist (Basic, 5 XP)	Unarmed strikes gain +1 die and ignore 1 Armor when you are at Fatigue 2+.	Passive	Body 3, Spirit 2
Hangover Resilience (Basic, 4 XP)	Once per scene, after a complication from intoxication, clear 1 Fatigue.	Free	Spirit 3
Satyr's Sprawl (Standard, 8 XP)	Immune to being knocked prone while moving; standing from prone is a free action.	Passive	Body 4, Athletics 2
Bacchic Counter (Standard, 9 XP)	When you succeed on a Desperate defense roll, make a free unarmed attack against the attacker.	Once per scene	Tier III, Drunken Fist

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *The Unbroken Bottle.* Once per session, ignore all Fatigue penalties for one scene. When you would be hit by a melee attack, you may force the attacker to hit another adjacent creature of your choice. After the scene, you suffer Harm 2 (Exhaustion). You gain a permanent **Debt Scar** — a purple bruise shaped like a grape cluster — but may ignore one forced Obligation or debt repayment that targets you (the patron's mark confuses the creditor).

6.8.39 The Traveler (Ways & Journeys)

Lore. The Traveler is the eternal guide of the road, guardian of those who walk the paths between what is and what might be. Among the Fhara caravans and Kuvani traders along the Way of Silk, the Traveler is invoked at every crossroads, honored with small offerings at each waypoint, and consulted before every major journey.

The Traveler is not merely one who shows the way — they *are* the way, existing in the pause between steps and in the choice of which path to take when roads fork. Every journey is both physical and spiritual; to move from one place to another is to transform, and the road itself becomes a teacher.

Across the known world, the Traveler wears many faces. In Kahfagia, the Traveler is the *Lantern-Bearer*, whose light guides ships through uncharted waters. In Ykrul, the Traveler is the *Hoof-Print*, the spirit of the steppe road that appears as a single arrowhead left at a crossroads. In Aeler, the Traveler is the *Ways-Stone*, carved into every mile marker by True-Masons to ensure the road remembers those who walk it. In the Mistlands, the Traveler is invoked with a single unknotted bell-rope — a sign that the fog may part for one who walks humbly. Wherever a traveler sets foot, the Traveler is already there, waiting to see which road they choose.

One foot in a promise, and the road will meet you halfway. But break your word to the way, and the way will break you.

Domain Focus

- **Wayfinding:** navigation, route-finding, safe passage
- **Journeys:** travel, pilgrimage, exploration
- **Thresholds of Movement:** doors, bridges, crossroads, borders
- **Road Covenants:** promises made on the road, hospitality to travelers

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Traveler binds a creature of the open road. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological being that embodies movement and guidance: a gray hare that never tires, a sparrow that knows every shortcut, a small fox that leaves no tracks, a dung beetle that rolls its ball unerringly toward the nearest water, or a tiny brass compass that hums when the bearer is on the true path. This creature requires no food, but it must walk at least a mile each day (or be allowed to roam freely in a new place). If confined for more than a day, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows lethargic and its guidance becomes unreliable, imposing –1 die on all Navigation and Survival rolls for its bearer until it is exercised).

The **Codex** of the Traveler is never a stationary book. It may be a leather strap knotted with directions, a set of scrolls kept in different saddlebags, a map that redraws itself after each journey, or a pilgrim's diary whose blank pages fill with route descriptions as the bearer walks. Because the road resists being captured in ink, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week walking a new path and annotating it, or the Rites stored there become faded (treat as *Compromised* until updated).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Traveler may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or cloak) and whisper a waymark. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Navigation* or *Survival* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be slowed by difficult terrain or a bureaucratic delay, they may ignore it (the road opens for them). After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the road's claim on them deepens.

Rites of the Traveler

Rite of Road-Sense (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [NAVIGATION], [AWARENESS]

Materials: A road-nail or waystone pebble.

Effect: Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near/Far. Gain +1 **die** to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment *Path Memory* timer to ignore difficult terrain once.

Push It: Spot one hidden bypass, but generate 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Traveler's Boon (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self/Ally; No.

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [BOND], [HASTE]

Materials: Thread tied at the wrist.

Effect: Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy; +1 **Effect** to travel or escape checks. If shared, create a 2-segment *Shared Journey* bond with an ally.

Push It: Extend to one more ally; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Waymark (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [MARK], [GUIDANCE], [PASSAGE]

Materials: A chalk mark or small cairn.

Effect: Declare a lane as permitted or easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment *Marked Path* timer.

Push It: The lane persists between scenes; the first enemy to exploit it forces 1 **SB (Spades)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Bridge Between (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [TRANSPORT], [PASSAGE], [BOND]

Materials: Two pinches of road-dust clapped.

Effect: Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible or named route. Unwilling targets may resist (Body+Resolve DV 3). Create a 4-segment *Pathway Established* timer.

Push It: Carry one extra ally or bundle; arrivals are off-balance.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Crown of Crossings (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [COMMAND], [MOVEMENT], [FEAR]

Materials: A brass compass missing its needle.

Effect: Call the Road: allies gain +1 **die** to move or evade; pursuers suffer –1 **die**. Once, declare “the long way is short” to finish a travel timer segment for free. Enemies must test (Wits+Command DV 4) or suffer –1 **die** to movement.

Push It: Seal a hostile route briefly; generate 2 **SB (Clubs/Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Wayfarer’s Covenant (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [COMMAND], [BOND], [FEAR]

Materials: Waystones from multiple regions.

Effect: Bind present parties to safe passage. While honored: +2 **Effect** on travel, reroll one failed travel roll per scene. Breaking the oath inflicts Harm 1 (Fatigue) and marks the breaker as *Oathbreaker of the Road* (–2 dice to travel rolls).

Push It: Breaking the covenant inflicts Harm 2 (Stress) and attracts hostile Wayward spirits.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Traveler

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of the Traveler sings in *verses of the open road* — melodies that rise and fall like hills, harmonies that echo the creak of wagon wheels. Their voice is used to mark a crossroads with a sung sign, to calm a spooked pack animal, or to call a lost wanderer back to the path. The Traveler’s Cantors are often found in caravan camps, at pilgrimage shrines, and walking the roads alone, humming to keep the miles company.

The Cult of the Unbroken Way. The Traveler’s cults gather at forks, at bridges, and at the crests of passes — never in buildings. The Unbroken Way is a fellowship of guides, couriers, scouts, and those who have walked so far that the road has become their home. A ritual of the Cult involves each member placing a small stone at a crossroads, then walking a different way home than they came — the road must be honored with new steps. Their creed is scratched into a single waystone that travels from meeting to meeting: *"The road does not end. It only turns."* Outsiders are welcome to walk a mile with the cult, but they must carry a stone from home and leave it at the next crossroads.

Witchcraft of the Traveler (Craft / Wayfinding)

A witch who walks with the Traveler is a *map-scribe* or *waystone-carver* — one who crafts the physical markers of the road: a compass that always points to a chosen destination, a map that shows routes that appear only when needed, or a staff that never causes the bearer to trip. Their magic works through the materials of travel: a quill that draws paths that become real by morning, a chisel that carves a symbol into a stone so that travelers who touch it feel rested, or a needle that sews a patch into a cloak that keeps the wind from shifting direction. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “way keystone” into a bridge so that the bridge remembers every traveler and wishes them well. In Vhasia, a cartographer might illuminate a map with a prayer; the map will never show the route to an ambush.

The Witch’s Tool: The Way Chisel. A chisel of iron, its head struck with a simple arrow. Once per session, the witch may carve a “way mark” into a stone, a tree, or a wooden post. For the next day, anyone who sees the way mark gains a perfect sense of direction to the nearest safe harbor, village, or crossroads — but only while walking. The chisel can also be used to “erase” a false trail, removing tracks from a path as if they had never been made (one exchange of effort per use).

A Hedge Gift: Road-Worn Token (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a small stone, a coin, or a button that has been carried on a long journey. For the next hour, the token glows faintly when the bearer is on the correct path to their goal (as long as the goal is a physical location). The token does not reveal the path — only that the bearer has not (or has) strayed from it.

The Traveler's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Pathfinding Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and movement rolls in familiar territory.	Restless Spirit: Suffer 1 Fatigue when forced to remain stationary or in confined spaces for extended periods.
2	Wayfarer's Luck: Once/scene, treat a failed travel or navigation roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Compulsive Wandering: Must take the less obvious path when choices present themselves; suffer –1 die when forced to follow direct routes.
3	Road Mastery: +2 dice to rolls involving travel, escape, or finding hidden paths.	Travel Dependency: –1 die to rolls requiring local knowledge or settlement-based skills.
4	Journey's Blessing: Once/session, grant all allies within Near range +1 die to travel-related rolls for one scene.	Nomad's Isolation: –1 die to social rolls involving long-term relationships or community ties.
5	Waypoint Sense: Once/session, instantly know the location and nature of all significant paths, routes, or crossroads within a day's travel.	Directional Obsession: –1 die to rolls not involving movement, travel, or pathfinding; always aware of cardinal directions.
6+	Master of All Ways: Once/session, become one with the road network. For one scene, teleport between any known waypoints and grant +2 dice to all travel-related actions.	Eternal Journey: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; risk permanent Harm (Stress) from the endless call of the road, making settlement impossible until the journey's end.

Playstyle Notes

The Traveler is the ideal patron for beginners and veterans alike — its rites are forgiving, its Obligation low, and its benefits immediately useful in almost any campaign. Followers become masters of navigation, escape, and the subtle art of being in the right place at the right time. The Traveler does not demand worship; it asks only that travelers respect the road and keep their bargains. Intrusions often take the form of a sudden fork in the path, a helpful stranger who knows too much, or a road that leads somewhere unexpected. Ideal for guides, couriers, scouts, pilgrims, and anyone who has ever felt the pull of the horizon.

Emphasizes

- **Wayfinding:** the art of never being lost
- **Road Covenants:** a promise made on the road is binding
- **Journey as Transformation:** the road changes the walker

- **Thresholds of Movement:** doors, bridges, borders, and the spaces between

- **Hospitality to Travelers:** the road gives, and the road expects

Way-Walker (The Traveler)

One foot in a promise, and the road will meet you halfway.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of Road-Sense or Cantor of The Traveler.

Debt-Resistant Frame. The road does not hold grudges; it simply turns. Way-Walker monks gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt or obligation that would bind them to a single place or force them to stay still. If they succeed, the creditor's chains find only empty air — the monk is already a mile down the road.

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Way-Step (Basic, 5 XP)	Teleport to any unoccupied space you can see within Near range. You must have line of sight and an unobstructed path (the road folds, not breaks).	1 Fatigue	Wits 3
Road-Sense (Basic, 4 XP)	Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near/Far. Gain +1 die to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment Path Memory timer.	1 Boon	Wits 2
Traveler's Boon (Basic, 5 XP)	Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucratic delay. +1 Effect to travel or escape checks.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 2
Waymark (Standard, 8 XP)	Declare a lane as permitted or easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment Marked Path timer.	1 Boon	Tier II
Bridge Between (Standard, 7 XP)	Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible or named route. Unwilling targets resist with Body+Resolve (DV 3).	1 Fatigue + 1 Boon	Wits 3, Spirit 2
Crown of Crossings (Standard, 9 XP)	For one scene, allies gain +1 die to move or evade; pursuers suffer -1 die. Once, declare "the long way is short" to finish a travel timer segment for free.	1 Fatigue	Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Master of All Ways.* Once per session, become one with the road network for one scene. Teleport between any two known waypoints (places you have visited and marked with a personal token — a pebble, a scratch on a door) within the same journey. You may also grant one ally the same teleport. After the scene, you gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your footprints face the wrong direction) but you may ignore one debt or obligation

that would force you to stay — the road simply does not remember you were ever there.

6.8.40 The Unbroken Way (Balance and Control)

Lore. The Unbroken Way does not speak. It listens. It is the pause between breaths, the space between thoughts, the stillness at the heart of motion. Those who walk this path learn that strength is not in the clenched fist but in the open hand — and that the greatest power is the power you do not use.

Followers of the Unbroken Way are mediators, guardians, and seekers of equilibrium. They serve not kings or gods but the *balance itself*. When a tyrant rises, they do not kill — they redirect. When a village starves, they do not feed — they teach. When a student falters, they do not punish — they guide.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, the Unbroken Way is known by many names. In Thepyrgos, it is the *Still Point*, studied by monks who seek to transcend the body. In Vhasia, it is the *Open Gorget*, a philosophy of mercy over force. In the Valewood, it is the *Root That Does Not Break*, a survival technique of the Lethai-al. Wherever warriors seek to master themselves rather than their enemies, the Unbroken Way waits.

The blade that is not drawn cannot be broken. The hand that is not clenched cannot be bound.

Domain Focus

- **Perfect Balance:** equilibrium in all things, neither too much nor too little
- **Disciplined Restraint:** power held in reserve, strength shown through mercy
- **Clear Perception:** seeing without judgment, acting without attachment
- **Protective Service:** guarding the innocent, teaching the willing, guiding the lost

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Unbroken Way does not bind a creature of claw and fang. Their **Thiasos** is a *focus crystal* — a translucent stone that hums faintly when they are at peace and grows cold when they are in danger. It requires no food, but they must meditate with it for one hour each day. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Clouded* (its hum becomes discordant, imposing –1 die on all Resolve rolls until they spend a scene in silent meditation).

The **Codex** of the Unbroken Way is never a book of spells. It is a *meditation manual* — a collection of koans, breathing exercises, and ethical precepts. It cannot be read in the usual way; the follower must *practice* each Rite before it becomes legible. Upkeep requires one hour of practice per week. If neglected, the Rites become faded (treat as *Compromised* until re-practiced).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Unbroken Way may touch a held weapon or focus. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 die to *Melee* and +1 die to *Insight*. The wielder feels a profound calm, as if the universe has paused to watch. After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** to the Unbroken Way.

Rites of the Unbroken Way

Rite of the Sensing Current (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [SENSE], [CLARITY]

Materials: A moment of stillness, eyes closed, breath held for one heartbeat.

Effect: For the next scene, gain +1 **die** to all Perception and Insight rolls. You feel the presence of living things within Near range and can sense strong emotions (fear, rage, joy) as faint temperature changes.

Push It: Extend the effect to the full session, but mark 1 Fatigue (the constant awareness wears on you).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Gentle Push (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Near; Yes (resist).

Tags: [FORCE], [PUSH]

Materials: An open palm, facing the target.

Effect: A wave of invisible pressure pushes one target within Near back one range band (Close → Near, or Near → Far). The target must test *Body + Athletics* vs. your *Spirit + Lore*. On a failure, they are shoved and lose their next Move action.

Push It: Push two targets instead of one. Mark 1 SB (Spades) as the force ripples visibly through the air.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Quiet Suggestion (Standard, 8 XP)

Instant; Near; Yes (resist).

Tags: [MIND], [COMMAND]

Materials: Eye contact with the target, sustained for a full heartbeat.

Effect: One willing or unsuspecting target within Near hears a short suggestion (eight words or fewer) that they believe is their own thought. The suggestion cannot be obviously self-destructive or impossible. Test *Spirit + Lore* vs. *Wits + Resolve*.

Push It: The suggestion lasts until the target completes it (instead of a single action). Mark 1 Obligation (the Way watches how you use this power).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Flowing Parry (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [WARD], [DEFEND]

Materials: A weapon in hand, or empty hands held in a defensive posture.

Effect: For the rest of the scene, you may *Defend* against ranged attacks as a reaction. On a success, the attack misses entirely. On a partial, reduce Harm by 1 (minimum 0). You cannot use this Rite while wearing heavy armor.

Push It: Extend the protection to one adjacent ally. Mark 1 Fatigue.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Still Mind (High, 12 XP)*Scene; Zone; No.***Tags:** [MIND], [AREA], [BOOST]**Materials:** A moment of silence, eyes closed, breath held at the still point.**Effect:** For the next scene, all allies within Near gain +1 **die** to all rolls, and all enemies within Near suffer -1 **die** to all rolls. You must concentrate (cannot take other actions) or the effect ends at the end of the current exchange.**Push It:** The effect lasts for the full scene even if you act, but you mark 2 Obligation (the Way demands you earn this power).*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended action; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Obligation:* 7 segments.**Rite of the Flowing Blade (Standard, 9 XP)***Instant; Self; No.***Tags:** [STRIKE], [ACCURATE]**Materials:** A light blade (one-handed sword, knife, or equivalent), held in a relaxed grip.**Effect:** Your next melee attack with a light blade gains +2 **dice**, ignores 1 Armor, and deals +1 **Harm** to any creature actively using dark or corrupting powers (GM discretion). The blade seems to move before you do.**Push It:** The attack also disarms the target (they drop one held item). Mark 1 Fatigue.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.**Cantors & Cults of the Unbroken Way**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Unbroken Way sings in *hummed koans* — melodic fragments that have no resolution, no cadence, no satisfying end. Their voice is used to calm a riot, to focus a meditation circle, or to signal an ally across a battlefield without drawing the enemy's attention. A Cantor may learn any Low Rite of the Unbroken Way as a Song (*Performance + Lore*, resolves next turn). Corruption accumulates when they use their voice for selfish ends, for violence, or to manipulate the innocent.

The Cult of the Watchers. The Unbroken Way's cults are not secret, but they are *invisible* — they meet in plain sight, in meditation halls, in public gardens, in the pauses between conversations. The Watchers are a fellowship of retired soldiers, reformed criminals, and those who have seen what unchecked power does to the soul. A ritual of the Cult involves each member sitting in silence for one hour, counting their breaths to eight — and only eight, never nine — then speaking aloud one thing they have forgiven themselves for. Their creed is written on a single slip of paper, folded eight times, passed from member to member: "*The way is not a destination. It is the walking.*" Outsiders are welcome to sit in silence with them. There is no pressure to speak. There is no pressure to stay.

Witchcraft of the Unbroken Way (Lay / Meditative)

A witch who walks with the Unbroken Way is a *breath-shaper* or *still-point-weaver* — one who crafts through the art of patient attention. Their magic works through the materials

of calm: a bell that rings only when rung with perfect intention, a candle that burns without smoke when lit by a steady hand, or a stone that does not roll when placed on a slope. In Thepyrgos, a True-Mason might carve a keystone that makes the arch above it stand for a thousand years, but a witch of the Unbroken Way would instead sit beneath the arch and breathe until the stone remembered how to hold itself.

The Witch's Tool: The Stillness Bell. A small bronze bell with no clapper — it cannot be rung by force. It rings only when the one who holds it achieves a moment of perfect stillness, and the ring is felt rather than heard. Once per session, the witch may ring the Stillness Bell to impose a single heartbeat of absolute calm in a Near zone — no violence, no action, no speech. Everyone (including allies) simply *pauses*. The witch may act during this pause, but only to observe, to move, or to speak a single word. The effect ends as soon as the witch acts beyond that word.

A Hedge Gift: The Unstruck Note (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may snap their fingers. For the next exchange, they may treat any failed *Resolve*, *Insight*, or *Perception* roll as a Partial Success instead of a Miss. The GM gains 1 SB (the world notices the stillness bending around you).

Corruption of the Unbroken Way

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Calm Presence: +1 die to resist fear, intimidation, or emotional manipulation.	Emotion Leak: -1 die to social rolls involving passion (love, rage, joy, grief).
2	Clarity of Purpose: Once/scene, reroll a failed Resolve test.	Detachment: -1 die to empathize with others' suffering or to share genuine emotional connection.
3	Flowing Defense: +2 dice to Defend actions when unarmored or in light armor.	Rigid Form: -1 die to improvise, adapt, or act on instinct rather than training.
4	Stillness of Mind: Immune to magical fear and charm effects.	Isolation: -1 die to all social rolls; others find your calm unsettling.
5	Current of Peace: Once/session, end all ongoing fear effects within Near.	Emotion Blind: Cannot recognize strong emotions in others without a successful Insight roll (DV 4).
6+	Empty Vessel: Once/session, become immune to all mind-affecting magic for one scene.	The Stillness Claims You: Mark +3 Obligation. You may no longer take any action that would cause direct harm to another living creature.

Playstyle Notes

The Unbroken Way is the ideal patron for players who want to play a disciplined martial artist, a diplomatic guardian, or a meditative warrior. Its Rites reward patience, perception, and restraint. The cost is emotional disconnection — the calm that protects you also isolates you. Intrusions often take the form of a challenge to your calm (a situation designed to provoke rage or fear), a student who needs teaching, or a conflict that cannot

be resolved without violence — forcing you to choose between your principles and your mission. Ideal for paladins (reflavored), monks, jedi analogues, and any character who believes that strength is not in what you can do, but in what you can choose *not* to do.

Emphasizes

- **Perfect Balance:** equilibrium in all things, neither too much nor too little
- **Disciplined Restraint:** power held in reserve, strength shown through mercy
- **Clear Perception:** seeing without judgment, acting without attachment
- **Protective Service:** guarding the innocent, teaching the willing, guiding the lost
- **The Stillness Within:** the calm at the center of every storm

Still-Point (The Unbroken Way)

The blade that is not drawn cannot be broken. The hand that is not clenched cannot be bound.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Sensing Current or Cantor of the Unbroken Way.

Debt-Resistant Frame. The Unbroken Way does not collect debts — it *rebalances*. Monks of the Still-Point gain +2 **dice** to resist any magical debt, geas, or contract that would compel them to act against their principles. If they succeed, the creditor finds only silence — but the Way marks a *Balance Debt* that will come due as a difficult choice later. The GM gains 1 SB (the scales tip).

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Sensing Current (Basic, 4 XP)	For one scene, gain +1 die to all Perception and Insight rolls. You sense living creatures and strong emotions within Near.	1 Fatigue	Wits 3
Gentle Push (Basic, 5 XP)	Push one target back one range band (Close→Near, Near→Far). Resist with Body+Athletics vs. Spirit+Lore. On failure, they lose their next Move action.	1 Boon	Spirit 2
Quiet Suggestion (Standard, 8 XP)	Target hears an 8-word suggestion they believe is their own thought. Not self-destructive. Resist Wits+Resolve vs. Spirit+Lore.	1 Boon	Wits 3, Spirit 2
Flowing Parry (Standard, 7 XP)	For one scene, Defend against ranged attacks as a reaction. On success, miss. On partial, reduce Harm by 1.	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Still Mind (High, 12 XP)	Allies within Near gain +1 die, enemies –1 die. You must concentrate or effect ends.	1 Boon + Concentration	Tier II

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Empty Vessel*. Once per session, become immune to all mind-affecting magic, fear, and charm for one scene. You may also end one ongoing emotional effect (rage, despair, terror) on a touched ally. After the scene, you gain a permanent **Stillness Scar** (your reflection is slightly delayed, as if the world is not sure you are there). You may ignore one Obligation call from the Unbroken Way — the Way simply waits. It is patient.

6.8.41 Varnek Karn, the Death's Negotiator (Bargains with the Departed)

Lore. Varnek Karn dwells in the gray between life and death, where the newly departed linger with unfinished business and elder shades guard secrets dearer than gold. He is the broker who speaks across the veil, the mediator of disputes between living and dead, and the archivist of every promise sworn beyond the grave. His servants practice post-mortem diplomacy: they negotiate, consult, and contract with spirits as equals — mindful that the dead are patient and rarely generous.

Yet Varnek Karn is also the patron of those who *raise* the dead, not through force but through bargain. The dead may be persuaded to walk again, to fight for a season, or to guard a threshold, but every such compact is a debt. The dead demand their due: a memory, a future, a name, or simply the promise that the living will remember them. Those who serve Varnek Karn learn that raising a spirit is never a command; it is a negotiation, and the spirit always has a price.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Varnek Karn is the patron of those who treat with the departed respectfully. In Aeler, he is the *Breath-Accountant*, who audits the spiritual ledgers of the Deep Vaults and ensures that the dead are not forgotten. In Ykrul, he is the *Bone-Speaker*, whose drum calls ancestors to council before any major migration. In Vhasia, he is the *Silent Notary*, who witnesses death-bed testaments and ensures their terms are honored. In the Mistlands, he is the *Bell-Shrouded*, whose unknotted rope holds the fog at bay. Wherever the living and the dead must negotiate, Varnek Karn's servants are there — not to command, but to listen.

“The dead have all the time in the world to consider their offers, and no need to rush to agreement. They know what the living forgot, and remember every slight with perfect clarity. In Varnek's halls, both parties pay a price — but the currency is never what you expect.”

Domain Focus

- **Post-Mortem Diplomacy:** parleys with ghosts and recent dead
- **Ancestral Wisdom:** counsel from forebears and keeping of funerary law
- **Unfinished Business:** resolving the concerns that bind spirits
- **Death-Bound Contracts:** obligations that outlive the flesh
- **The Unquiet Host:** raising temporary armies of the dead through pact

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Varnek Karn does not bind a living familiar. Their **Thiasos** is a *remnant of the honored dead*: a lead seal that has witnessed a funeral, a knucklebone from an ancestor who died content, or a small iron bell that rings only when a spirit is willing to speak. This object requires no food, but it must be placed on a grave or threshold at dusk each day. If neglected for a week, the Thiasos becomes *Compromised* (it emits a faint keening that imposes –1 die on all social rolls with the living).

The **Codex** of Varnek Karn is never a living book. It may be a slate carved with names that fade and reappear, a bundle of burial tablets, or the inside of a lead-lined casket. Because the dead are not bound by paper, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the

Runekeeper must spend an hour each week recording a new death or a settled dispute, or the Rites stored there become illegible (treat as Compromised until restored).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Varnek Karn may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or funerary token) and whisper a death-bargain. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Lore* or *Investigation* rolls involving death, ancestry, or inheritance, and the bearer may ask one question of a corpse less than a day dead (it answers with a single word or a gesture). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the weight of the grave lingers.

Rites of Varnek Karn

Rite of the Crossing Fee (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [SPIRIT], [TRUTH]

Materials: A coin for the tongue of the deceased, or a lock of hair from the bereaved.

Effect: Open speech with a specific dead individual. Gain **+1 die** to *Investigation* or *Lore* when seeking knowledge they once held.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Ancestral Consultation (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [SPIRIT], [TRUTH], [FATE]

Materials: A personal token of the departed, or their favored food or drink.

Effect: Ask one question of an ancestral spirit regarding family history, hidden legacies, or inherited debts.

Push It: The spirit grants detailed, prophetic guidance but exacts a small favor; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Mediated Pact (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [COMMAND], [SPIRIT]

Materials: Two copies of a written accord (one buried with the dead, one kept by the living), or a circle of salt mixed with grave-dust.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Death-Bound Pact:** Bind a compact between a living signatory and a willing spirit. Both gain **+1 die** when fulfilling the terms. Breach angers the spirit and Varnek both.
- **Spirit Medium:** Serve as a conduit for several spirits to speak. Gain **+2 dice** to mediate disputes between living and dead and to facilitate group negotiation.

Push It: If you chose *Pact*, the pact enforces itself: a breach triggers supernatural reprisal; mark **+1 Obligation**. If you chose *Medium*, a potent spirit rides your voice to speak directly; mark **Exposure +1**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unquiet Host (Standard, 10 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [SUMMON], [AREA], [BOND], [DEBT]

Materials: A battlefield relic (a broken sword, a skull, a scrap of uniform) and a handful of grave-earth.

Effect: You negotiate with the lingering dead of a place. Summon a **Temporary Host** – a spectral warband treated as a single **Cap 3 Follower** with the following traits:

- **Assist:** May grant **+3 dice** to a single combat or intimidation roll, or provide a free *Setup* action (e.g., “they distract the guards”).
- **Independent Action:** Once per scene, the Host may take one action from the Follower list (e.g., *Scout & Signal*, *Distract & Draw*) at the cost of marking **Exposure +1**.
- **Weakness:** The Host is vulnerable to salt, bells, and consecrated ground. Any attack using such materials ignores their spectral nature.

The Host lasts for the remainder of the current scene, or until dismissed. When it departs, the dead demand their due: you must either mark **+2 Obligation** or perform a *Memorial Rite* before the next dawn (a downtime action, no roll). If you fail to do so, the Host returns unbidden at the worst moment, acting as a hostile hazard (GM’s discretion).

Push It: Extend the Host’s duration to the entire session. The debt is doubled: mark **+4 Obligation** or perform a memorial rite *and* sacrifice a personal memory (erase a minor fact or a Bond for one session).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Final Testament (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [VOW], [FATE], [COMMAND], [DEATH]

Materials: A dying person’s last words recorded in their blood, witnessed by you.

Effect: Seal the last request with weight beyond life. Targets must pass *Resolve* (DV 4) to ignore it.

Push It: The testament becomes a geas: only fulfillment — or Varnek’s wrath — can break it; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Eternal Archive (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [TRUTH], [AREA], [FATE], [SANCTUARY]

Materials: A library mortared with tomb-stone, ink from cremation ash.

Effect: Found a repository where the dead deposit knowledge. Gain a permanent **+1 die** to *Lore* for historical or genealogical research made within. Spirits periodically contribute testimonies.

Push It: The archive awakens and begins to demand curatorship and payment; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Necromantic Summoning (Varnek Karn's Way)

For summoners (Pact-Whisperers) who follow Varnek Karn, the usual Leash mechanics gain an additional option. When you call a spirit (using the Pact-Whisperer rules), you may choose to bind it with a **Death-Bound Contract** instead of the standard Leash. Instead of ticking Leash on harm or disobedience, the spirit gains a **Promise Timer [4]** named "Debt Unpaid." Each time it acts against your interests, you may advance the timer by 1. When the timer fills, the spirit must either obey one final command (even against its nature) or immediately depart and become an enemy. However, while under contract, the spirit cannot be dismissed early — you are committed. This replaces the Boon Finesse option; you cannot spend Boons to clear ticks. This method is slower but more reliable for extended servitude, and it fits Varnek Karn's theme of negotiation over coercion.

Cantors & Cults of Varnek Karn

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Varnek Karn sings in *dirges of negotiation* — melodies that invite the dead to speak, harmonies that soothe restless shades. Their voice is used to call an ancestor to council, to lull a vengeful ghost into recounting its grievance, or to sing a funeral procession past a haunted crossroads. Varnek's Cantors are often found in graveyards, in the halls of the dying, and at the tables where inheritance disputes are settled, their songs bridging the silence between breath and decay.

The Cult of the Unforgotten Ledger. Varnek Karn's cults gather in crypts, ossuaries, and the quiet rooms above funeral parlors — but one cell, known as the *Ink-Flesh Communion*, tattoos the names of the dead onto their own skin, believing that each name grants a fragment of the ancestor's memory. Their ritual involves writing a death-record with a needle dipped in ash and wine; the tattoo whispers the dead person's last words when pressed. The Unforgotten Ledger itself is a single, ever-growing book bound in gray hide — it is said to *whisper* at night, adding names without a scribe. Outsiders are welcome to bring a name of someone they have lost; they may read the ledger but not write in it. Their creed: *"The dead are not gone. They have only changed their address. Be polite, pay your respects, and never make a promise you cannot keep."*

Witchcraft of Varnek Karn (Lay / Funeralary)

A witch who walks with Varnek Karn is a *funeral notary*, a *grave-warden*, or a *memory-keeper* — a lay practitioner who uses ink, seals, and small rites to witness the passage of the dead. Their magic is the art of recording and releasing: a leaden seal that certifies a death-bed promise, a quill that writes in invisible ink that appears only when a ghost

is near, or a carved wooden stamp that quiets a restless spirit for a night. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “memory niche” into a crypt wall, but a hedge-witch of Varnek Karn might press a wax seal onto the niche’s edge, binding the dead to speak truth when the seal is broken. In Zakov, a net-mender might weave a shroud with a single loose thread; pulling it releases the drowned sailor’s soul to the tide.

The Witch’s Tool: The Seal of the Silent Witness. A leaden seal on a leather thong, its face carved with a single closed eye. Once per session, the witch may press the seal into warm wax (or directly onto a stone threshold) while speaking the name of a dead person. For the next day, anyone who speaks that name near the seal hears a faint whisper — a single word or a sigh — from the deceased. The seal may also be used to “witness” a death-bed promise: pressing it onto a written testament makes the document unbearably heavy to anyone who would break the vow.

A Hedge Gift: Echo of the Honored Dead (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a physical remnant of the dead (a bone, a lock of hair, a piece of clothing) and whisper a question. For a moment, the remnant holds a memory — the GM answers one factual question about the dead person’s life or death, but the answer is always tinged with the emotion of the moment (e.g., “she was afraid,” “he was angry,” “they were at peace”).

Varnek Karn’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Death’s Whisper: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> when the dead seek to communicate.	Graveyard Pallor: –1 die to social rolls with the living; your presence unsettles.
2	Ancestral Insight: Once/scene, gain +2 dice for family history or inherited troubles.	Spectral Awareness: Ever-aware of nearby spirits; suffer Fatigue 1 in places of many deaths.
3	Medium’s Gift: Once/session, act as a flawless conduit for a spirit.	Death-Touched: Cold spots and small portents follow you; –1 die to ordinary social grace.
4	Final Authority: Once/scene, compel adherence to a true last request (Resolve DV 4).	Corpse-Pale: Visibly wan; –2 dice where warmth or vigor is required.
5	Archive Keeper: Once/session, access perfect recall of a historical event or family secret.	Unquiet Presence: The dead trail you; –1 die to stealth and to surprising the living.
6+	Death’s Confidant: Once/session, compel a willing spirit to answer three questions truthfully.	Halfway House: Mark +2 Obligation; risk becoming half-withdrawn from the living world. You must perform a funeral rite for a stranger before the next dawn, or mark an additional +2 Obligation.

Playstyle Notes

Varnek Karn favors investigators, arbiters, and heralds of funerary law. Power grows through cultural sensitivity, shrewd bargaining, and careful record-keeping; the price is a thinning tie to warmth and mortal ease. Expect mysteries of lineage, obligations that outlive their makers, and parleys where both sides of the veil demand their due. The *Rite of the Unquiet Host* allows a follower to temporarily command a small army of the dead, but the debt incurred ensures that such power is never free — and the dead always remember who called them.

Varnek Karn emphasizes

- **Diplomacy over Dominion:** bargaining with the dead rather than commanding them
- **Knowledge Brokerage:** trading for secrets and testimonies beyond the grave
- **Cultural Protocols:** rites, tokens, and proper doors for speaking with ancestors
- **Mediation:** resolving conflicts that bind the living to the dead
- **Historical Continuity:** showing how past vows shape the present
- **The Unquiet Host:** raising temporary armies through pact, not domination

Bone Monk (Varnek Karn)

The dead have all the time in the world to consider their offers.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Resolve 2+, Rite of the Crossing Fee or Cantor of Varnek Karn.

Debt-Resistant Frame. The dead do not collect — they witness. Bone monks gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt or obligation that would bind them beyond the grave. If they succeed, the creditor feels a cold hand on their shoulder — a reminder that death cancels all ledgers.

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Ancestor's Knuckle (Basic, 5 XP)	Reroll a missed unarmed attack. The ancestor who guides your fist demands a name or a memory after the scene.	Free (once/scene)	Spirit 3
Ancestral Consultation (Low, 5 XP)	Ask one question of an ancestral spirit regarding family history, hidden legacies, or inherited debts.	1 Fatigue	Lore 2
Grace of the Grave (Basic, 4 XP)	When you would take a Condition from fear or despair, you may ignore it — a dead relative steadies your hand.	1 Boon	Spirit 2
Death's Whisper (Basic, 4 XP)	+1 die to Notice when the dead seek to communicate. You may also speak with a corpse less than a day dead (one question).	Passive	Spirit 3
Final Testament (Standard, 9 XP)	Seal a dying person's last request with weight beyond life. Targets must pass Resolve (DV 4) to ignore it.	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Unquiet Host (Standard, 10 XP)	Negotiate with lingering dead of a place. Summon a spectral warband (Cap 3) for one scene. When it departs, you must mark 1 Fatigue or perform a Memorial Rite.	1 Boon	Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Death's Confidant*. Once per session, compel a willing spirit to answer three questions truthfully. You may also ignore one debt that would have been owed to a deceased creditor — the ledger entry becomes dust. Gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your fingertips are cold to the touch) and the Hollow notes your name, but you may call on one ancestor to resist a future obligation (the dead know how to wait).

6.8.42 Vorthak, the Hunger Unbound (Consumption & Metamorphic Hunger)

Lore. Vorthak is the principle of absolute consumption: an appetite that devours not only what is, but the very potential of what might be. Each feeding transforms both eater and eaten. His servants become conduits of metamorphosis through ingestion, learning to consume not only matter but also properties, identities, and even strands of fate. Power comes by taking in — and the cost is becoming more like the hunger you channel.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Vorthak is known by many fearful names. In Aeler, he is the *Deep Forge*, the hunger of the mountain that consumes ore and returns steel. In Zakov, he is the *Salt-Hunger*, the appetite that preserves by consuming the moisture from flesh. In Linn, he is the *Tide-That-Eats-The-Shore*, a slow, patient consumption that reshapes coastlines. His followers are rarely beloved, but they are essential — for without consumption, there is no transformation, and without transformation, there is only stagnation.

“To consume is to become. To devour is to transform. In Vorthak's embrace, the boundary between eater and eaten dissolves into something new — and something hungry.”

Domain Focus

- **Metamorphic Consumption:** transformation through ingestion of matter, energy, or concepts
- **Essence Absorption:** gaining properties by consuming them utterly
- **Hunger Propagation:** spreading consumption as a force of change
- **Identity Metabolism:** consuming and adopting aspects of others' natures

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Vorthak does not bind a familiar of flesh alone — their **Thiasos** is a small creature of endless appetite: a glossy black beetle that devours rot and grows more lustrous with each meal, a pale grub that pupates into a moth only after consuming something precious, a leech that clings to the shadow of the wounded, a small eel that lives in the bilge and grows an eye each time its master consumes an essence, or a rat with a second mouth that whispers the names of things recently devoured. This creature requires no food in the ordinary sense, but it must be allowed to consume something *significant* (a memory, a secret, a physical token) each week. If neglected, it becomes *Compromised* (it gnaws at its bearer's belongings, consumes a stray thought, and imposes –1 die on Concentration or memory rolls).

The **Codex** of Vorthak is never a static record. It may be a stomach-bound journal written on cured hide, its pages growing thicker each time a Rite is performed; a set of teeth strung on a leather cord, each tooth etched with a consumed spell; or a wooden bowl stained with the residue of a thousand meals, the grain of the wood shifting as new essences are added. Because hunger is never satisfied, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week feeding it — a drop of blood, a burnt letter, a morsel of rare meat — or the Rites stored there become faint (treat as *Compromised* until re-fed).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Vorthak may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or piece of armor) and whisper a word of consumption. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Survival* or *Craft* rolls involving organic or consumable materials, and the first time each scene the bearer would take a Condition from poison, disease, or starvation, they may ignore it (the hunger consumes the affliction). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the scent of turned earth and ash clings to them.

Rites of Vorthak**Rite of the Hungry Touch (Low, 5 XP)**

Scene; Touch/Self; Yes.

Tags: [CONSUME], [BOOST], [SENSE], [RISK]

Materials: A fragment of the thing to be consumed (food, substance, symbol); or an empty vessel or a place where something was devoured.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Metabolic Touch:** Absorb an essential trait of the target. Gain **+1 die** to actions aligned with the absorbed property for one scene.
- **Hunger's Whisper:** Sense what in the area may be consumed and the benefit it offers. Gain **+1 die** to *Investigation* when seeking consumable resources.

Push It: (Whisper only) The hunger turns contagious: nearby feel your appetite; mark **1 SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Essence Feast (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [CONSUME], [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [DEBT]

Materials: The complete consumption of a significant item (weapon, book, relic).

Effect: Permanently absorb the item's essential nature. Gain one minor property or **+1 die** to a closely related skill. The item is utterly destroyed.

Push It: Take a major property, but gain a permanent *Hunger Mark* (a visible sign of consumption).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Identity Meal (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [CONSUME], [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [RISK]

Materials: A personal token or a clear memory of the target.

Effect: Temporarily adopt one aspect of a specific person's nature (skill, talent, or defining trait). Gain **+2 dice** to actions matching that aspect.

Push It: The adoption deepens and clings; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Metamorphic Gluttony (High, 13 XP)*Scene; Zone; Yes.***Tags:** [CONSUME], [AREA], [TRANSFORM], [PRESSURE], [FATE]**Materials:** A site scarred by great consumption.**Effect:** Become a locus of transformative hunger. All present may consume aspects (skills, memories, properties), but each must pass *Spirit+Resolve* (DV 4) or suffer uncontrolled transformation effects.**Push It:** Some changes become permanent; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Obligation: 7 segments.***Rite of the Hunger's Ascension (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Self; Yes.***Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [SACRIFICE], [FATE], [DEBT]**Materials:** The deliberate offering-up of your current limits to Vorthak.**Effect:** Consume your own constraints and transform. Choose three: +1 Attribute; +2 dice to one skill; immunity to one Condition type; or one major supernatural capability.**Push It:** Take all chosen benefits, but lose one core aspect of your original identity; mark **Harm 2**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Obligation: 8 segments.***Hunger Ascetic (Metamorphic Monk)***To consume is to become. To devour is to transform. I am the stomach of the world.***Prerequisites:** Body 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Hungry Touch or Cantor of Vorthak.**Ascetic Techniques (purchased as Talents):**

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Gut of Iron (Basic, 4 XP)	You may consume anything organic (rotten food, raw meat, bitter herbs) without ill effect. +1 die to resist poison or disease from ingestion.	Passive	Body 3
Essence Glutton (Standard, 8 XP)	When you use Rite of the Essence Feast, you may gain one additional minor property (still destroying the item).	+1 Obligation	Tier II
Hunger's Patience (Basic, 4 XP)	You may go without food or water for twice as long as normal. When you finally consume, you heal 1 Fatigue.	Passive	Body 3, Spirit 2
Metabolic Shift (Standard, 8 XP)	Once per scene, as a reaction, you may convert 1 Harm you would take into 1 Fatigue (you metabolize the injury).	1 Boon	Body 4
Identity Digestion (Standard, 9 XP)	When you use Rite of the Identity Meal, the adopted aspect lasts for the entire session instead of one scene.	+1 Obligation	Tier III
All-Devouring Maw (Standard, 8 XP)	Once per session, you may consume a single mundane object (size no larger than a shield) as an action, gaining 1 Boon. The object is utterly destroyed.	Free	Body 4, Spirit 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): Apotheosis of Hunger. Once per session, you may enter a state of perfect consumption for one scene. You ignore all penalties from Fatigue, and any time you would take Harm from a physical attack, you may instead consume the attack's energy, converting the Harm into 1 Fatigue and gaining +1 die on your next action. When the scene ends, you suffer Harm 2 (Stress) as your body rejects the excess. You cannot use this talent again until you have consumed a significant meal (at least a full day's rations) in a ritual manner.

Cantors & Cults of Vorthak

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Vorthak sings in *hungry harmonies* — melodies that start with a single, clear note and then devour themselves, ending in a hungry silence. Their voice is used to urge a crowd to feast, to sing a blade sharper by absorbing the steel's flaws, or to make a meal last for hours by consuming the very passage of time. Vorthak's Cantors are often found in feasting halls, in butcheries, and around campfires where stories are consumed and retold.

The Cult of the Ravenous Circle. Vorthak's cults meet in places that embody consumption: abattoirs, forges, bakeries, and the kitchens of great manors. The Ravenous Circle is a fellowship of chefs, alchemists, tanners, and smelters — those who understand that to create something new, something old must be utterly consumed. A ritual of the Circle involves each member bringing a raw material (a cut of meat, a lump of ore, a written secret) and placing it in a central hearth. The hearth consumes it, and the circle speaks aloud what they hope to become by that consumption. Their creed is carved above the hearth: "*What is not consumed is wasted. What is wasted is an insult to hunger.*" Outsiders are welcome to bring an offering and a wish, but they must eat a portion of the ash.

Witchcraft of Vorthak (Lay / Consumption)

A witch who walks with Vorthak is a *hunger-smith* or *ash-weaver* — one who crafts through the act of consumption: a knife that sharpens itself by eating the metal of its victims, a forge that devours impurities and returns only the strongest steel, or a culinary knife that seasons meat by absorbing the memory of the animal's life. Their magic works through the materials of consumption: a quill that writes in ink made from burnt secrets, a needle that sews a garment by consuming thread and producing new cloth, or a smooth stone that absorbs properties by touch. Their tools are never hammers; they use stones, ashes, and the patient heat of a slow digestion.

The Witch's Tool: The Maw-Stone. A smooth, porous stone, warm to the touch, the size of a fist. It is said to have been regurgitated from the belly of a great beast. Once per session, the witch may press the stone against a material (stone, wood, metal, flesh) and speak a word of consumption. The stone "eats" a small portion of the material (a handful of stone dust, a sliver of wood, a thin curl of metal) and absorbs its essential property. For the next scene, the stone can be used to grant +1 die to any roll that benefits from that property (e.g., "sharpness" for a cutting tool, "hardness" for a shield). The stone can also be used to "consume" a single, small physical detail (a button, a lock, a hinge) as if it had never been there, but doing so empties the stone of its stored property.

A Hedge Gift: Ash of Old Forms (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may take a handful of ash from a fire that consumed something significant (a letter, a garment, a meal) and blow it into the air. For the next minute, the ash reveals the shape of what was consumed — a phantom image of the letter, the garment, or the meal. The image is ghostly and cannot be touched, but it can be read, examined, or used to identify an object that no longer exists.

Vorthak's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hunger's Sight: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> consumable properties in objects, beings, or ideas.	Metabolic Craving: Must consume something <i>significant</i> daily or suffer Fatigue 1 .
2	Essence Thief: Once/scene, temporarily gain a minor property by consuming it.	Identity Bleed: Absorbed aspects surface unbidden; –1 die to maintain your original persona.
3	Metamorphic Resilience: Once/session, consume a <i>Condition</i> or <i>Harm</i> to negate it.	Hunger Aura: Those Near feel urges to consume or hoard; they suffer –1 die to self-control rolls.
4	Transformation Feast: Once/scene, consume and permanently absorb one <i>minor</i> supernatural ability.	Essence Instability: Conflicting properties clash; –1 die when relying on multiple absorbed aspects.
5	Identity Cannibal: Once/session, consume a <i>significant</i> aspect of another (major skill or core trait).	Self-Consumption: Risk eating your own memories or abilities; mark 1 SB (Spades) when stressed.
6+	Hunger Incarnate: Once/session, become living consumption; absorb nearby properties, abilities, or aspects for one scene. You may consume one physical object as a free action.	Void Hunger: Mark +3 Obligation; risk dissolving into pure appetite that must feed every hour to keep form. Your eyes reflect no light.

Playstyle Notes

Vorthak favors those who hunt for change through taking in what the world offers: relish clever uses of absorbed traits, judge the *price* of every bite, and beware the slow surrender of the self. Expect scenes of metamorphosis, bargaining for what can be eaten, and hard choices where power tastes like you. Ideal for characters who embrace transformation at the cost of identity — alchemists, cannibal cultists, and those who believe that to improve, one must first consume.

Vorthak emphasizes

- **Transformation through Consumption:** becoming what you devour
- **Metamorphic Power:** fundamental, identity-shaping change
- **Essence Absorption:** discerning and using a thing's core nature
- **Identity Metabolism:** integrating (or failing to integrate) stolen aspects
- **Hunger Propagation:** letting appetite reshape people and places

6.8.43 The Witness (Truth & Revelation)

Lore. The Witness remembers what others bury. Every shadow cast and oath broken is a line in her unending ledger. She is the keeper of inconvenient truths, the patron of those who seek to expose lies or recover forgotten knowledge. Her followers learn that knowledge comes with a price — the weight of remembering what others would forget.

The Witness has no will, only a ledger; no mercy, only accuracy. She does not demand confessions, but she ensures that every lie leaves a stain, every secret a trace. Those who serve her become archivists of the uncomfortable, witnesses to the truths that others would kill to keep hidden. To walk her path is to accept that some truths are weapons, and that the truth-teller is never loved.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, the Witness is known by many names. In Ecktoria, she is the *Ink-Eye*, the Censor's clerk who copies every redacted line onto a private scroll. In Vhasia, she is the *Fractured Mirror*, prayed to by spies who seek to reveal a rival's true loyalty. In the Mistlands, she is the *Fog-Scribe*, whose name is whispered when a bell-line fails and the dead must be identified by their secrets. And in the shadows of every great city, there are those who follow the *Apocalyptic Witness* — a doomsaying cult that believes the world will end when the last hidden truth is finally spoken aloud, and who work to hasten that revelation by exposing every lie, no matter the cost.

I will show you what you would rather forget. But first, you must forget what you think you know.

Domain Focus

- **Truth Revelation:** exposing lies, uncovering secrets, forcing confessions
- **Memory Keeping:** preserving knowledge, recalling forgotten facts
- **Inconvenient Knowledge:** learning what others wish to hide
- **Prophetic Warning:** seeing the consequences of hidden truths
- **Burden of Witness:** the psychological weight of knowing too much

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to the Witness does not bind a familiar of flesh and comfort. Their **Thiasos** is a small creature that embodies memory and revelation: a raven that collects shiny objects and recites forgotten names, a silverfish that eats lies from parchment and leaves truth behind, a small brass beetle whose shell opens to reveal a perfect mirror, a white mouse that nests in archive drawers and remembers every page it has slept upon, or a cricket that chirps in the key of the last secret spoken nearby. This creature requires no food, but it must witness something *significant* (a lie told, a secret revealed, a confession made) each week. If neglected, it becomes *Compromised* (it grows silent and still, and its bearer loses +1 die on all Investigation rolls until it is shown a hidden truth).

The **Codex** of the Witness is never a book that can be closed. It may be a set of loose-leaf pages that reorganize themselves each dawn, a scroll that writes itself when no one is looking, a chalkboard that cannot be erased, or a stack of wax tablets that melt and reset each season. Because the Witness values accuracy over permanence, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week correcting a single error

in its records (a misspelled name, a misdated event) or the Rites stored there become garbled (treat as Compromised until restored).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of the Witness may touch a held item (weapon, tool, or writing implement) and whisper a word of truth. For the rest of the scene, the item grants +1 **die** to *Insight* or *Investigation* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be deceived by an illusion or a lie, they may roll twice and take the better result. After the scene, the user marks +1 **Obligation** as the weight of what they have seen presses upon their memory.

Rites of the Witness

Rite of the Lingering Trace (Low, 4 XP)

Instant; Near; Yes (Investigation/Notice only).

Tags: [INVESTIGATION], [TRUTH]

Materials: A trace of the thing to be remembered (hair, dust, a spoken name).

Effect: You follow a hidden thread. Gain +1 **die** to investigate or notice something directly related to the trace within the current scene. Additionally, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about whether the trace is connected to a specific person, event, or object.

Push It: Gain +2 **dice** instead, but mark 1 segment on a **Memory Strain Timer** [4]. If the timer fills, you gain Fatigue 1 and suffer –1 die on Investigation/Notice rolls until the end of the next scene (the Witness taxes your mind).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Uncomfortable Question (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [COMMAND], [FEAR], [TRUTH]

Materials: A circle drawn with chalk or string while focusing on a specific person.

Effect: You force a moment of raw honesty. Ask one question of a target within the zone. They may either answer truthfully (the GM must give a true answer, though it may be cryptic) or mark 1 **Fatigue** and gain a *Guilty Tell* Condition (–1 die to all social rolls until they confess the truth to someone).

Push It: The target must also reveal a surface emotion or a forgotten detail (GM's choice). Mark 1 **SB (Hearts)** as the Witness records the strain.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Echoing Truth (Standard, 8 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [READ], [TRUTH], [FEAR]

Materials: A reflective surface (mirror, still water, polished metal) used to focus on the target.

Effect: The target must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or suffer –1 die to rolls involving memory, deception, or resisting interrogation for the scene. If they fail, you may ask one

specific, factual question about something they know, and they must answer truthfully or suffer **1 SB (Hearts)** as the memory is forcibly drawn forth.

Push It: If the target fails their Resolve test, you may ask a second question, but the mental intrusion causes them **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Immutable Record (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [TRUTH]

Materials: A document signed by all parties within the zone, or a spoken pact witnessed by the caster.

Effect: Bind the agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers **1 SB (Hearts)** immediately and gains a persistent *Oathbreaker's Mark* Condition (–1 die on social rolls involving honor, trust, or oaths until amends are made or a significant act redeems them).

Push It: The bond becomes magically enforced for one specific, crucial clause: violation automatically inflicts **Harm 1 (Stress)** on the breaker in addition to the SB and Mark.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Shared Burden (Standard, 9 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [HEAL], [DEBT], [READ]

Materials: A written secret (yours or another's) and a candle.

Effect: You transfer the weight of a truth. Choose one: you may remove a *Guilty Tell*, *Haunted*, or similar psychological Condition from yourself and give it to a willing or unwilling target (they resist with Resolve DV 4). Alternatively, you may share a secret with an ally; both of you clear 1 Fatigue as the burden is halved.

Push It: Transfer a Condition without the target's consent (they automatically resist, but on failure they gain it). Mark **1 SB (Spades)** as the secret stains them.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unveiled Heart (High, 12 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [MANIPULATION], [FEAR], [TRUTH], [AREA]

Materials: A private setting where the target feels safe or is speaking freely.

Effect: The target suffers –2 dice to all attempts to conceal true emotions, intentions, or lies for the scene. Any successful social roll (Sway, Command, Deceit) made by the target generates **1 SB (Hearts)** as the effort to maintain falsehoods under the Witness's gaze creates internal discord.

Push It: You may designate one specific, complex question about the target's motivations, fears, or hidden loyalties. If you successfully use Sway or Insight against them this scene, you automatically learn the answer to that question. The intense scrutiny marks **1 SB (Spades)** for you as the Witness's attention lingers.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

Rite of the Final Reckoning (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [COMMAND], [TRUTH], [FEAR]

Materials: A formally called gathering (court, council, family meeting) within the consecrated zone.

Effect: All present must speak their greatest debt, wrongdoing, or hidden truth related to the gathering's purpose. Those who lie or withhold suffer **Harm 2 (Stress/Reputation)**. Truth-tellers gain **+2 dice** to social actions for the remainder of the scene within the zone.

Push It: The truth becomes inescapable – even indirect lies or evasions related to the core topic suffer the Harm 2 penalty. The absolute nature of the revelation creates **2 SB (Diamonds)** as the disruption to fates and secrets resonates.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (*Invoke:* **2 Boons**).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Witness

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Witness sings in *truth-tolling* – clear, piercing melodies that cut through evasion, harmonies that make the hidden surface. Their voice is used to compel a confession, to sound an alarm that a secret is about to be spoken, or to sing a historical record into being, each note a word in a ledger. The Witness's Cantors are often found in courtrooms, in archive vaults, and at the bedsides of the dying, singing the last truth.

The Congregation of the Unmasking (Apocalyptic Cult). The most feared of the Witness's cults, the Congregation of the Unmasking believes that the world will end when the last hidden truth is finally revealed – and that this ending is not a catastrophe but a liberation. They seek to expose every lie, every buried crime, every forgotten promise, no matter the cost. A ritual of the Congregation involves each member speaking aloud a truth they have kept secret, then burning a representation of the lie that concealed it. Their creed is painted on a scroll that is never fully unrolled: "*When all that is hidden is seen, the world will either break or be free. We will be there to witness which.*" Outsiders are not welcome; they are potential sources of truth – or obstacles to be unmasked. The Congregation has been known to destroy families, topple governments, and start wars in their pursuit of total revelation. They are loved by none and feared by all, but even their enemies cannot deny that they are right: some secrets truly are worth dying to expose.

Witchcraft of the Witness (Craft / Record)

A witch who walks with the Witness is a *ledger-scribe* or *seal-breaker* – one who crafts the tools of permanent record: a book that cannot be altered once written, a quill that writes in ink that fades only when the truth it records is fulfilled, or a press that stamps each page with a sigil of authenticity. Their magic works through the materials of documentation: a chisel that carves a truth into stone so that it cannot be erased, a needle that sews a confession into a garment so that the wearer cannot deny it, or a forge that tempers a door that can only be opened by someone who has never told a lie.

In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “witness stone” at a courthouse entrance, so that all testimony given within is remembered by the stone for a century. In Thepyrgos, a bookbinder might stitch a volume that screams if its pages are cut.

The Witch’s Tool: The Quill of Unwritten Truths. A quill carved from a raven’s feather, its nib dipped in ink made from lampblack and a drop of the witch’s blood. Once per session, the witch may write a single sentence on a piece of parchment, then seal it with a drop of wax. For the next day, anyone other than the witch who reads the sentence must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or forget it immediately after reading. The witch may also use the quill to “seal” a spoken secret, causing the speaker’s voice to catch if they try to repeat it for the rest of the scene.

A Hedge Gift: Record of a Breath (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may hold a blank piece of parchment up to a person’s lips as they speak. The parchment absorbs the spoken words, recording them exactly as they were said – including tone, hesitation, and any unconscious meaning. The parchment can be read by anyone (the words appear in the speaker’s own handwriting), but it crumbles to dust after being read aloud. The witch may also use this ability to record the final words of the dying, preserving them for one day.

The Witness's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Truth's Sight: +1 die to Insight when detecting deception or hidden motives.	Burden of Knowledge: –1 die to social rolls involving lies or deception; others become uncomfortable with your piercing gaze.
2	Memory's Keeper: Once/scene, recall one specific detail from a previous scene with perfect clarity.	Compulsive Honesty: Must correct obvious falsehoods witnessed, even when tactically disadvantageous.
3	Revelation's Power: +2 dice to rolls involving exposing secrets, uncovering lies, or forcing confessions.	Truth-Blind: Suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to comforting lies or willful ignorance.
4	Witness's Authority: Once/session, force one target to make a Resolve test (DV 4) or reveal a significant hidden truth.	Isolation: –1 die to rolls requiring trust or close relationships; others fear your ability to uncover their secrets.
5	Omniscient Gaze: Once/session, see through all deceptions and lies for one exchange, gaining +3 dice to related actions.	Paranoia: –1 die to rolls involving personal peace or rest; the weight of all truths witnessed creates constant mental strain.
6+	Absolute Witness: Once/session, become the living embodiment of truth. For one scene, all deceptions within Near range automatically fail.	Truth's Prison: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; become unable to tolerate any form of deception, making normal social interaction nearly impossible. The Unmasking Beckons: The apocalyptic urge grows – you may be called to expose a truth that will destroy a community, a nation, or yourself.

Playstyle Notes

The Witness rewards curiosity, patience, and a willingness to bear uncomfortable knowledge. Her followers are not merely investigators but *archivists of the real* – they record what others would erase. The Witness does not demand that you expose every secret; she simply ensures that you cannot forget the ones you learn. Intrusions often take the form of dreams showing a hidden crime, a sudden memory of a lie you told years ago, or the appearance of a scrap of parchment containing a truth you wish you had never read. High-Tier followers may find that secrets begin to *seek them out* – people confess unprompted, documents fall open to damning pages, and the world becomes a book that cannot be closed.

Emphasizes

- **Truth as Burden:** every secret known is a weight carried

- **Investigation as Ritual:** uncovering lies is a sacred act
- **Memory as Weapon:** forgetting can be as powerful as remembering
- **The Unmasking:** exposing a truth can be an act of mercy or destruction
- **Witness as Isolation:** those who know too much are seldom loved

Unmasked Fist (The Witness)

I will show you what you would rather forget.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Wits 2+, Rite of the Lingering Trace or Cantor of Witness.

Debt-Resistant Frame. The Witness records, but does not collect. Monks of the Witness gain +1 **die** to resist any magical debt or obligation that would force them to conceal the truth or perjure themselves. The creditor's ledger will show a blank where their name should be.

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Confession Blow (Basic, 5 XP)	On an unarmed hit, ask the GM one yes/no question about the target's hidden deed or recent lie. The GM must answer truthfully.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Lingering Trace (Basic, 4 XP)	Follow a hidden thread. Gain +1 die to investigate a specific trace within the current scene.	1 Fatigue	Wits 2
Uncomfortable Question (Low, 5 XP)	Force a target to answer one question truthfully (GM answer) or mark 1 Fatigue and gain a Guilty Tell (–1 die social rolls).	1 Boon	Presence 2
Immutable Record (Standard, 7 XP)	Bind an agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers 1 SB (Hearts) and gains an Oathbreaker's Mark (–1 die social rolls involving honor until amends).	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Shared Burden (Standard, 9 XP)	Transfer a psychological Condition (Guilty, Haunted) from yourself to a target (Resist DV 4) or share a secret with an ally to clear 1 Fatigue each.	1 Boon	Spirit 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Absolute Witness*. Once per session, become living truth for one scene: all deceptions within Near range automatically fail. You may demand a single truthful answer to one question from any creature, and they cannot refuse (no resistance roll). After the scene, you gain a permanent **Debt Scar** (your eyes reflect light like a brass mirror) and may ignore one debt or obligation that would require you to lie – the creditor sees only the truth of your refusal.

6.8.44 Xhak'Thul, the Thunder-Speaker (Storm, Shock & Awe)

Lore. Before words, there was thunder. Before scripture, lightning carved its commandments into the bones of the world. Xhak'Thul is the Voice That Splits Mountains, the Drum That Shakes Foundations, a power born from the first storm that ever raged across the primal earth. His faithful are whirlwinds of action — they do not study; they dance, they shout, they move with the sky's fury. His gifts are not gentle miracles but raw terror, awe, and vitality ripped from nature's heart.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Xhak'Thul is the patron of the pre-literate, the neolithic, those who have not yet built walls against the wild. In the deep Vhasian highlands, he is the *Storm-Father*, invoked by herders who watch lightning split the sky. In Ykrul, he is the *Thunder-Hoof*, the sound of a thousand horses stampeding. In Linn, he is the *Raging Tide*, the storm that comes without warning. His followers are not scholars; they are dancers, drummers, shamans, and warriors who feel the storm in their bones before they hear it in the sky. He favors those who act without hesitation, who embrace chaos, and who understand that the loudest voice is often the truest.

“Feel the drum in your bones before you hear it in the sky. When the storm speaks, you will already be dancing to its rhythm.”

Domain Focus

- **Primal Power:** storm, thunder, lightning, earthquake, wildfire
- **Shock and Awe:** overwhelming sensory impact, terror as a weapon
- **Fear-Eater:** absorbing panic to fuel strength
- **Immediate Magic:** no rituals, no books — only emotion, movement, and the moment

Thiasos and Codex (Runekeeper Options)

A Runekeeper sworn to Xhak'Thul does not bind a quiet familiar. Their **Thiasos** is a small beast or mythological creature that embodies the storm's wild heart: an electric blue salamander that crackles when touched, a tiny hawk whose feathers hum with static, a mouse that drums its tail in thunderstorms, or a small snake that vibrates like a plucked string before lightning strikes. This creature requires no food, but it must feel the open sky and hear thunder each week — a storm, a war drum, or even a slammed door. If neglected for a week, it becomes *Compromised* (it sparks uncontrollably, imposing –1 die on Stealth rolls for its bearer and occasionally setting small fires).

The **Codex** of Xhak'Thul is never a book of quiet study. It may be a drumhead painted with storm-runes, a set of carved bones that rattle like thunder when shaken, a stone tablet scored by a lightning strike, or a bundle of twigs tied with sinew that snaps like a whip crack when a Rite is invoked. Because the storm resists stillness, the Codex requires *upkeep*: the Runekeeper must spend an hour each week beating a rhythm into it (or exposing it to loud percussion), or the Rites stored there become sluggish (treat as *Compromised* until re-awakened).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement)

Once per scene as an action, a Runekeeper of Xhak'Thul may touch a held item (weapon, shield, or drum) and whisper a thunder-name. For the rest of the scene, the item grants **+1 die** to *Intimidation* or *Command* rolls, and the first time each scene the bearer would be surprised or lose initiative, they may act as if they were not surprised (the storm warns them). After the scene, the user marks **+1 Obligation** as the taste of ozone lingers on the item.

Rites of Xhak'Thul**Rite of the Thunderous Presence (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [FEAR], [COMMAND], [AREA], [PRESSURE]

Materials: A drum made from storm-felled wood or any suitable improvised percussion.

Effect: Your presence becomes overwhelming. All NPCs within Near range must test Resolve (DV 2) or suffer **−1 die** to social actions due to awe or terror for the scene. Allies gain **+1 die** to *Intimidation* or *Command* actions.

Push It: Extend the effect to Far range, but you mark 1 Fatigue and mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as your presence becomes difficult to control.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Storm's Step (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [SPEED], [FEAR], [BOOST]

Materials: Earth from a lightning strike site, worn boot leather.

Effect: You move with the storm's speed. Gain **+2 dice** to *Athletics* or *Stealth* rolls. The first attack you make this scene gains **+1 Effect**.

Push It: Gain **+3 dice** and move as a blur, becoming difficult to track or clearly remember; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Shattered Sky (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [FORCE], [FEAR], [WEATHER]

Materials: A shard of meteoric iron or metal touched by a severe storm.

Effect: You call a localized, supernatural storm in a Zone. Choose one effect:

- **Lightning Strike:** Single target, Harm 2.
- **Wind Blast:** Knockback, dispersing arrows or scattering foes.
- **Hail Barrage:** Harm 1 (AREA).

All enemies in the Zone suffer **−1 die** to actions from chaos and distraction.

Push It: Double the chosen effect's scale or potency (e.g., Harm 3, large knockback), but the effect also applies to allies in the Zone; mark **2 SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Rite of the Fear-Eater (Standard, 9 XP)*Scene; Self; No.***Tags:** [FEAR], [HEAL], [COMMAND], [BOOST]**Materials:** Soil or dust from a place of great terror (battlefield, prison, ruins).**Effect:** You feed on the fear around you. For each Frightened target in the scene, gain +1 die on your next action (max +3). If you successfully Intimidate a target during this scene, you heal 1 Fatigue.**Push It:** Absorb all palpable fear in the scene, gaining a flat +3 dice bonus to your next action, but mark 1 permanent Scar related to fear. Mark 1 SB (Hearts).*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +2 Obligation.**Rite of the World's Drum (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Zone; No.***Tags:** [AREA], [FEAR], [COMMAND], [TRANSFORM], [WEATHER]**Materials:** A drum fashioned from lightning-struck wood, with a hide from a beast killed by natural force.**Effect:** You become an incarnation of the storm for one scene:

- Gain +2 dice to rolls based on strength, speed, and intimidation.
- Your anger echoes as thunder; attacks against you may be answered by lightning (GM decides, usually 1 SB and Harm 1 to the attacker).
- Enemies must test Resolve at -2 dice to resist Fear effects you create.

Start a 6-segment *Natural Disasters* timer; when it fills, the storm's wrath manifests as a random environmental hazard (landslide, lightning strike, flash flood).**Push It:** The transformation lingers after the scene, and your emotional state causes minor environmental effects (windows rattle, small fires flicker). Mark 2 SB (Diamonds) and advance the timer by 2 segments.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended action; mark +3 Obligation.*Obligation:* 8 segments.**Thunder Speaker (Storm Shaman)***The storm does not ask. It speaks. You are its echo.***Prerequisites:** Body 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Thunderous Presence or Cantor of Xhak'Thul.**Shamanic Techniques (purchased as Talents):**

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Storm Caller (Standard, 8 XP)	Once per scene, as a free action, you may cause a peal of thunder to roll across the zone. All enemies must test Resolve (DV 3) or lose their next minor action.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Lightning Reflexes (Basic, 4 XP)	You gain +1 to defense DV against ranged attacks (arrows, bolts, thrown weapons).	Passive	Body 3, Athletics 2
Fear Eater (Basic, 5 XP)	When you successfully Intimidate a target, you gain 1 Boon (once per scene).	Passive	Spirit 3, Command 2
Pact Lightning (Synergy) (Standard, 8 XP)	If you are also a Pact-Whisperer (summoner), you may channel Xhak'Thul's power through a summoned spirit. The spirit gains the [LIGHTNING] tag for one scene (its attacks deal +1 Harm and ignore 1 Armor).	+1 Obligation	Tier II, Summoner
Storm Dance (Basic, 4 XP)	While you are moving (not standing still), you gain +1 die to all physical actions (melee, athletics, evasion).	Passive	Body 3, Performance 1
Thunder's Grasp (Standard, 9 XP)	Once per session, when you would be reduced to 0 Harm, you may instead unleash a concussive blast. All enemies in Close range are knocked back one band and must test Body+Resolve (DV 3) or fall prone. You survive, but mark Fatigue 2.	Free	Tier III, Rite of the Fear-Eater

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Eye of the Storm.* Once per session,

you may become the calm center of a supernatural storm for one scene. All allies within Near range ignore fear effects and weather penalties. You gain +2 dice to all physical and intimidation rolls, and any enemy that attacks you suffers a lightning counter (Harm 1, ignores armor). When the scene ends, you collapse with Fatigue 3 and cannot use this talent again until you have rested for a full night.

Cantors & Cults of Xhak'Thul

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Xhak'Thul does not sing melodies — they drum. Their voice is a percussive roar, a heartbeat rhythm that shakes the ground. Their “song” is the pattern of a storm: the slow build of pressure, the sudden crack of lightning, the fading rumble of retreating thunder. Xhak'Thul's Cantors are often found in places without writing, where memory is carried in dance and the beat of a skin drum.

The Cult of the First Drum. Xhak'Thul's cults gather in clearings, on hilltops, or in caves that echo with thunder. The First Drum is a fellowship of dancers, shamans, and warriors who believe that civilization is a cage and that the storm is the only honest law. A ritual of the Cult involves each member drumming on a skin drum (never bought, always made from an animal they killed themselves) until the first person collapses from exhaustion. The collapsed dancer is declared “storm-taken” and must lead the next ritual. Their creed is not written — it is beaten into the earth: *"The sky does not ask permission. Neither do we."* Outsiders are welcome to dance, but they must bring a drum they made with their own hands.

Witchcraft of Xhak'Thul (Shamanic / Storm)

A witch who walks with Xhak'Thul is a *storm-caller* or *drum-maker* — a shaman who crafts the tools of primal power: a drum that can be heard for a mile, a spear of lightning-struck wood that never misses its target, or a charm of meteoric iron that calls a storm when struck. Their magic is immediate, visceral, and never subtle. They do not use hammers or chisels; they use drums, rattles, and the raw energy of a thunderclap. In Ykrul, a bone-carver might shape a whistle that mimics the sound of a thunderclap, terrifying horses. In the deep Vhasian highlands, a shaman might paint their drum with the blood of a goat struck by lightning, binding the storm's spirit to the skin.

The Witch's Tool: The Storm-Drum. A hand-drum made from lightning-struck wood and the hide of an animal killed by a natural disaster (flood, fire, landslide). The drum's surface is painted with a spiral that represents the eye of the storm. Once per session, the witch may strike the drum with a single, thunderous beat. All creatures within Near range must test Resolve (DV 3) or be Shaken (–1 die to all actions) for one exchange. The drum can also be used to “call the storm” — beating a steady rhythm for a full minute (out of combat) grants +1 die to all weather-related rolls for the next hour.

A Hedge Gift: Drum of the First Beat (Basic, 4 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tap a rhythm on any surface (a table, a shield, a tree trunk). For the next minute, all allies within Near range who hear the rhythm gain +1 die to Athletics and combat rolls, as their heartbeat synchronizes with the storm. The rhythm cannot be sustained if the witch is silenced or takes a wound.

Shock & Awe Corruption Table

Level	Manifestation	Cost / Quirk
1–2	Static Cling: Your touch carries a static shock. Metal objects faintly hum in your presence.	You feel restless energy before a storm. Minor lies itch like a rash.
3–4	Storm-Touched: Your hair stirs without wind. Your voice occasionally cracks like thunder. Small flames flicker near you.	You become irritable in calm, silent places. You crave loud arguments and violent weather.
5–6	Lightning Rod: You are dangerously magnetic. Unshielded metal flies to your hands. Your eyes crackle with faint light.	You feel a compulsion to disrupt order and create chaos. Peace feels like a cage.
7–8	Walking Storm: A localized wind stirs around you. You smell of ozone and wet stone. You cannot whisper; your voice is a low rumble.	You lose patience with lengthy plans. You prefer direct, explosive action, regardless of the cost.
9–10	Heart of the Tempest: You are the eye of a personal storm. Rain sheets indoors; lightning threatens those who anger you.	You see the world only as a force to be broken or commanded. Gentler emotions are foreign memories.

Rivalries

- **The Penitent Lich (Remembrance & Restitution):** Orderly, structured memory versus Xhak'Thul's primal chaos.
- **The Traveler (Ways & Roads):** Carefully laid paths versus the sky's explosive, pathless nature.
- **Varnek Karn (Necromantic Archives):** The cold order of death versus the chaotic fury of life expressed through storm.

Obligation Triggers

- **8+ Segments:** Xhak'Thul demands a public spectacle of awe and fear, such as leveling a tower, parting a river, or terrifying a city district.
- **10+ Segments:** The storm begins speaking through you constantly. Refusal to act on its impulses ends your access to Rites until you perform a catastrophic display of power.

Signs of Favor

The scent of ozone, hair stirring from unseen static, a voice that carries perfectly over crowd noise, local storms that react to your emotional state.

Playstyle Notes

Khak'Thul is the patron of shamans, berserkers, and anyone who acts first and thinks never. His magic is immediate, loud, and unsubtle — the thunderclap, the lightning strike, the roar that silences a crowd. He rewards boldness, spontaneity, and the willingness to break things. His followers are not subtle, but they are terrifying. Ideal for players who enjoy direct solutions, primal power, and characters who would rather break a door than pick a lock.

Emphasizes

- **Primal Power:** storm, thunder, lightning, earthquake, wildfire
- **Shock and Awe:** overwhelming sensory impact, terror as a weapon
- **Fear-Eater:** absorbing panic to fuel strength
- **Immediate Magic:** no rituals, no books — only emotion, movement, and the moment
- **Pre-Literate Wisdom:** the oldest magic, written in bone and drum

Storm Fist (Xhak'Thul)

The storm does not ask. It speaks. You are its echo.

Prerequisites: Body 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Thunderous Presence or Cantor of Xhak'Thul.

Debt-Resistant Frame. Lightning leaves no ledger. Storm monks gain +1 die to resist any effect that would bind, contract, or obligate them (geas, oath, debt-enforcement). Each time they use this resistance, the air around them crackles audibly — pursuers gain +1 die to track them for the next hour.

Techniques (purchased as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Thunder Palm (Basic, 5 XP)	Unarmed strike deals +1 Harm and forces a Resolve test (DV 3) or the target loses their next minor action.	1 Fatigue	Body 3
Lightning Reflexes (Basic, 4 XP)	+1 to defense DV against ranged attacks.	Passive	Body 3, Athletics 2
Fear Eater (Basic, 5 XP)	When you successfully Intimidate a target, gain 1 Boon (once per scene).	Passive	Spirit 3, Command 2
Storm Step (Standard, 8 XP)	Move as a blur; you are difficult to track or remember. For one exchange, stealth rolls are at +2 dice.	1 Boon	Spirit 3, Tier II
Storm's Pace (Basic, 4 XP)	While moving (not standing still), gain +1 die to all physical actions.	Passive	Body 3, Performance 1
Thunder's Grasp (Standard, 9 XP)	When reduced to 0 Harm, instead unleash a concussive blast: all enemies in Close are knocked back one band and must test Body+Resolve (DV 3) or fall prone. You survive with Fatigue 2.	Once per session	Tier III, Fear Eater

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Eye of the Storm*. Once per session, become the calm center of a supernatural storm for one scene. Allies within Near ignore fear and weather penalties. You gain +2 dice to physical and intimidation rolls, and any enemy that attacks you suffers a lightning counter (Harm 1, ignores armor). After the scene, you collapse with Fatigue 3. Gain a permanent **Debt Scar** – a lightning-bolt pattern on your chest – but you may ignore one forced Obligation or debt call (the creditor sees only static).

No True Acolyte Interpreting a patron's will is often a dangerous prospect in and of itself. Many a Runekeeper has found themselves on the opposite end of machinations from others from the same patron.

Runebound Resilience (18 XP Epic Talent) *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Spirit 4+*

You have learned to transform the very essence of harm into deeper communion with your Patron.

- **Harm Conversion:** Once per round, you may convert up to 2 Harm levels to +2 Obligation instead of taking the damage
- **Obligation Endurance:** While at 6+ Obligation segments, gain +1 die to all Rite invocations
- **Patron's Shield:** When reduced to Harm 3, you may immediately Invoke any known Rite without marking additional Obligation
- **Debt Fortification:** At 8+ Obligation segments, ignore first Harm 1 each round
- **Once per scene**

Narrative Integration:

"Your flesh has become a ledger, and every wound is a prayer. The deeper your Patron's claim, the stronger your resistance to mortal frailty."

Patron's Favored (18 XP Prestige Talent) *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Familiar, 8+ total Obligation segments*

Your Patron has marked you as specially favored, granting you unprecedented access to their power with reduced cost.

- **Low Rite Discount:** Reduce Obligation cost for Low Rites by 1 (minimum 0)
- **Empower:** Once per scene, spend 1 Action + 1 Boons:
 - Target gains +1 Corruption level per round for 3 rounds. Corruption lasts until the end of the scene.
 - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
- **Empower Push:** Spend 1 Action + 1 Boon + 3 Obligation:
 - Target(s) gains +3 Corruption levels until end of scene
 - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
 - Target gains +Corruption fatigue at the end of the scene.
- **Enhanced Gift:** Your **Patron's Gift** now provides +2 dice instead of +1
- **Debt Bound:** Cannot Empower again until all Obligation is cleared

Narrative Integration: *The Patron's favor comes with a price—but for the truly devoted, that price is worth the power. You carry their blessing openly now, and their influence spreads like wildfire to those who would walk in your shadow.*

“Every Rune is a promise. Every line a covenant. Do not mistake the Runekeeper's silence for weakness; their memory is the foundation of our craft.”

6.8.45 The Invokers

Invokers are those who dare. Neither archivists nor worshippers, they are travelers on the knife-edge between story and ruin. An Invoker learns the Rites of a Patron, weaves them into their own Art, and bends fate for a moment. Yet invocation is not command: it is negotiation. The Patron always leaves its mark. The stronger the Rite, the deeper the scar.

Invokers are often wanderers, exiles, or seekers. To common folk they are feared—witches, oathbreakers, meddlers with things not meant for mortal hands. But when the village falls to plague, when the sea closes its roads, when the dead refuse their rest, it is an Invoker who is called upon.

6.8.46 Closing Words

The dance between Patron, Runekeeper, and Invoker is a triangle of peril and necessity. Without Patrons, there is no power. Without Runekeepers, no record. Without Invokers, no action. Together, they shape the crooked, perilous art we call Invocation.

6.9 Patrons & Rites

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Closing Thoughts

Every roleplaying game is, at its heart, a shared act of imagination. FATE'S EDGE offers rules and structures, but the real magic happens between players and game master, in the pauses between dice rolls and the sparks that leap across the table. The mechanics are not a cage—they are a scaffold, meant to support the story you want to tell.

You will not find every answer written in these pages, nor should you. The best sessions arise when the table embraces uncertainty: when a Story Beat pulls the tale in an unexpected direction, when a character's flaw drives the narrative forward, when laughter follows disaster. The system gives you tools; the table gives those tools meaning.

If you remember nothing else, carry these three principles into play:

- **Fiction First.** Let the world breathe, and let the rules bend to the needs of the story.
- **Every Choice Matters.** Risk, consequence, and reward shape characters as surely as dice.
- **Build Together.** Collaboration turns scenes into sagas and mechanics into myth.

The rules are here to help you weave drama, not to constrain it. Use them generously, ignore them when they slow the story, and trust your table to improvise with honesty and care. Above all, let the edges of fate guide you not toward certainty, but toward possibility.

May your journeys be bold, your dice fall true, and your stories echo long after the table is cleared.

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